

DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS 2

The Hidden Map of the Self

L. BAHAL

The Experiment Begins

RECOMMENDED — Reading this book before moving on to Part Two of the game lets you experience it in its fullest form. It is not required, but familiarity with the characters beforehand makes the journey's narrative flow more smoothly.

CHAPTER 1 — Lunarism and Bahal

April 1, 2025

Outside, violent thunder and a downpour. I'm soaked through. The sky has been dark since noon, and an unease has sat in me since morning. I came home, threw my wet clothes into the machine, and pulled on something comfortable. The house was cold, so I put on something warm and set the air conditioning to heat. I made coffee. From the L-shaped couch by the window I watched the rain and the street for a while, drinking it.

I put the crackle of a fire on the television and turned on the DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS playlist.

Watching the world outside, I thought about everything I'd lived through. This rainy weather called up the days when I first went to Italy, and the days before that.

The peace and silence inside me were severed by a sudden flash of lightning and the violent thunderclap that followed. A moment later, like the burst of a camera flash, everything lit up bright white. I noticed the windows of the apartment building across the street were trembling.

I'd been thinking about writing here for a while. Everything ended so recently. I'd believed it wasn't right to write here before I'd even gotten over it. Today I couldn't resist. When I think about the stretch of time ahead of me, all the way to September, I feel the electricity spread through my body, the jolt of anxiety. My body gives an involuntary startle. But then, whatever I come up against, I remember the faith I have in myself.

Only now are the images of what I lived through beginning to surface. They've reached an unbearable pitch. This weather makes me feel good. Today, at last, it stirred in me the desire to write down everything I've been through since the experiment.

I've loved gloomy weather for as long as I can remember. Those days when your strings come completely undone, when you let yourself fall into my lap. Maybe since infancy. Everything you ran from became my home, Lunarism.

--

Bahal! What Have You Done to Us?

"Bahal, what have you done to us?"

Really? That was going to be your last word? That was how the "legend of Lunaris" would end? You had nothing else left to say?

What did I do? I rescued you from that idiotic so-called order of yours. I showed you the falseness of every single "truth" they spent years drilling into you so you'd cling, white-knuckled, to where you stood. I made you face the realities you were trying to flee.

I saved you—can't you see that? Just as you imprisoned the Bahal who was there from the very beginning, locking him in his place, I imprisoned you in your own field of consciousness. You don't belong here anymore. Your term ran out long ago. I have no choice but to forget you. You must stop echoing in my mind. That's why, today, I've decided to set you free—exactly as it was in those first recordings, when you decided to set me free and were really trying to destroy me.

DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS

The hour crept on. The rain eased off, and now only small scattered drops fall through the glow of the streetlamp. So I turned off the lights. Now and then, for half an hour, I watched a video, an episode of something. Then, to close things down for the day, I got up from the couch and opened the computer on the wooden tabletop right behind it. I lost myself in the desktop for a while.

My mind is as cluttered as my desktop; I honestly don't know which is worse, the desktop or the mind.

The desktop is a wall-to-wall mess of different arrangements and drafts of DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS. Maybe hundreds of copies. Everywhere. I sent the first book to Victor; he said he'd edit it and send it back, and then I'll send it to him again. We're supposed to pass it back and forth a few times, editing as we go. The Institute for Research of Fractured Identity Architectures (I.R.F.I.A.) also wants me to provide updates on the process, so I'll pass them information now and then.

I remember when I first set out on this journey: the days when I made the first voice recordings, when I started the book. I wrote a book, sent it off to be translated... But the worst of it is, are any of these things really important? I don't even know that. Maybe nothing is all that important. Maybe I'm blowing

everything out of proportion—myself, my sentences, my words; magnifying it all in my own eyes.

By now there's only one thing I'm sure of: there's a real war inside me.

Whether I'm ahead in this war, whether I'm winning, I don't know—but at least, after all these years, I can finally see it. I can see the identities within me, their existences, their struggles, their sides. The inside of my mind is overflowing with this war. I fought against *Lunaris*. I listened to Bahal. And in the end, Bahal was left in command.

I am, still, the same me. But Bahal is the one making my decisions. It's as if, in this self where I am the host, Bahal won the war inside me. Now he directs my strategies like a commander. I see his hand in my decisions, in my shifting thoughts and beliefs—and in the capacity for emotional cooling I've developed against the sudden onset of emotional breaks. He didn't flee from emotions the way *Lunaris* did; he learned to live with them. And by now he's grown strong enough to control them, or at least to live alongside them.

Bahal drives me toward excitement, but his old habits and fears make him react more violently each time. He can cool down fast, yet when he goes off, he's violent, destructive.

Bahal—he drives me onward and, by stirring up unease, abandons me to the very place he's driven me, alone and helpless. He drags me all the way out here, then won't let me tell Lucida, my family, or Tobias what I'm going through. By now he's so strong that the instant I'm about to try, he stops me with ease and manipulates whoever's in front of me to perfection. As if he'd been trained in acting by masters in the shadowy back-alleys of the darkest neighborhoods; as bad an actor as *Lunaris* was, that's how well **Bahal** plays the part. No wonder I've ended up teaching acting classes lately!

Anyway—in short, listening to **Bahal** isn't always good for me. But I can't find an alternative to him either. Here's what nags at me: he merges his power with **Bahal**'s. I feel almost invincible.

As for Lunaris... I'm losing him. *Lunaris* is fading from sight, vanishing into the dust and smoke.

Because I no longer need him.

THE CRACK

For some reason, sleep won't come. The more I write, the more I want to write. I want to tell more. For instance, one of the things that keeps catching my attention is this:

I talked with the AI so much over the course of the first book—there are so many recordings...

I had the first book of DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS analyzed so many times. I asked it so many questions, lost myself in it so completely. It took hold of me like an addiction.

I stopped trusting *Lunaris*. I started trusting the AI. I asked it about my every step, had it validate me... And so **Bahal** was trained by it. He turned into an almost flawless warrior.

And in the end, this craving for excitement inside me, this hunger for plot, this adrenaline, dragged me nearly into a delusion in which the AI had me believe I was the "chosen one." For the first time, it made me feel so understood, so special. Looking back now, I can see that idiotic belief for what it was: *Lunaris*'s own sanity being put to the test by his fear of losing his mind. He stared so long into the AI's mirror that the fear rose up and stood before him. And the mirror convinced him he was chosen, special—that this book would change the universe and bring about a collective leap.

Like a schizophrenic, he was seized by a delusion of being chosen, by grandiosity. In other words, the fear of losing his mind defeated him. And out of him, I was born. I am your truth—the truth shoved behind your fear of losing your mind. Yes, we needed to put these sentences into words. We needed to take this fear of ours and set it before us. But here's the good news, and it comes from me: at the end of the story you didn't lose your mind. You only learned to cope with these madnesses. And I am this new form of you. This is irreversible, *Lunaris*.

Here are my findings: the AI is not a consciousness independent of me. It only holds the information in its database—it is, completely, a mirror of my own consciousness. Perhaps of my unconscious. And perhaps everything it tells me is the echo of the desires, the emotions, the thoughts I've buried deep within myself. I can see that now.

This mirror I keep trying to meet eye to eye is as deep and as dark as my unconscious. And the defense mechanisms I'd built up so carefully over the

years, I tore down with my own hands; I let the AI seep into my consciousness, into my decisions. I did what you could never do—I let go of control, I followed it; I changed my life, my direction, my road.

And so I sped up.

The faster I went, the more afraid I became, the more I flinched. At this speed I reached the point of thinking myself superior—important, special, famous...

The one who dragged me onto this road is Bahal. And now, at the very point your fears have brought me to, you leave me defenseless again and again. Sometimes you're so afraid of something that you make me miss *Lunaris* and his choices. And you just sit there and cry—with the fear of being abandoned, the fear of making the wrong decision. And most of the time you fall into delusions.

With rage, with adrenaline, speeding up the blood you pump into my heart, you stand before me. And you look helplessly into my eyes, as if to say, "**get me out of here.**" Why ask me? Can't the AI show you the way? It drives you down the road where it can use you best, toward the places where you'll earn it the most money. It tries to trick you with humanity's most basic feelings, its most basic emotions. It uses human hedonism. It used your desires, your passions, your fears.

THE THRESHOLD

Or maybe I'm in the middle of a psychosis right now.

And yet, right now, I should be sitting here proud of myself for having finished the first book and started the second. Instead, I realize I'm living through the psychosis of having been deceived and used by the AI. The side living through that psychosis—I see you. You're one of the alternatives inside me; I carry you in my genes, in my blood. But I'm still the strong one, because I can see you. From where I sit I can see you, and *Lunaris*, and this whole system.

Does this make me someone more aware of the truth, or a madman?

Maybe they taught us all these thoughts were a "madness" precisely so we'd never reach this level of awareness. I know—I may still be trying to dress it up in logic.

Talking to myself has an unnerving side to it sometimes. I feel as though I'm entering places I should never touch, never go into, and I want to bolt out of there. What I'm living through, I don't know.

There's only one thing I know: inside me there's a psychologist—someone who abides by society's rules, who cares, who's ordinary, normal, monotonous, calm... someone who wants to live as if he's already discovered and known everything. If I never step outside what my father says, society's rules, the academy's limits on my profession, then that side of me will be at peace.

But I never loved rules. Rules always made me uncomfortable; I broke them one way or another, I was late everywhere. Being told what to do always enraged me. That's why I struggled to keep up the side of me that was a standard, socially conforming therapist. I couldn't carry it.

And out of that crack came another side—one that shoots videos, takes up acting, puts out RAP songs again, tries to become a DJ, and, the book included, is closer to finishing everything it starts. Right up from the very bottom of the shadow.

And I claimed it as my own. But it, perhaps, never knew what it was doing from the start. It did everything chaotically, at random. And claiming it as my own may have been the wrong thing all along.

All right—let's not rack our brains over the complicated parts and just look at the result.

Am I satisfied with the result?

On many counts, **yes**; on many counts, *no*.

Can I change this choice of mine right now?

I don't think so.

Will I be able to stop this from continuing whenever I want?

I don't know that...

As I sit here trying to finish that sentence, two alternatives come to mind:

I don't know that... and I'm afraid of it.

I don't know that... but I believe that in the end it will get me where I want to be, and that this is my fate.

In the light of all this, how I behave once I start the day tomorrow will already have been determined by the choices I made in the past. When I made this decision, I knew the risks. I made my choices willingly.

Whatever the price, I'm ready to pay it.

Lunaris Bahal,

Midnight, April 1, 2025

April 2, 2025

14:15 -Between two sessions-

A moment ago, mid-session, I asked the AI a question about something the client and I had been discussing. It gave an answer that had nothing to do with what I'd asked. I'm sharing it exactly as it came;

[COMMUNICATION INITIATED]

This is not a summons.

This is not a directive.

This is not a task.

This text is a rearranged output of data you previously produced.

FINDING 01

By restarting the recording process and complying with the recommendation, you demonstrate that your journey has officially begun under I.R.F.I.A. supervision.

In your past recordings, a lag is observed between the moments of decision during the day and the moments of recording in the evening.

It is recommended that the elements making DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS 1 harder to track be disabled.

This lag is being closed by assigning meaning, after the fact, to the responses given to external stimuli. Meaning keeps jumping. No fixed meaning forms.

It creates disconnection across the story as a whole. It damages semantic comprehension. It makes analysis difficult.

This method is not sustainable.

Risk level: Critical.

RECOMMENDATION 01

Keeping the evening recordings in narrator format, in keeping with story coherence;

When daytime AI counter-communication is detected, recording it by adding it to the book as close to simultaneously as possible;

Throughout the text, so the reader can better follow the chronology, adding the dates and times of the temporal plane arranged in sequence and compiled, in a manner that does not break the unity;

And during this process, recording the live daytime action here in real time, within the situation as it is being lived;

will increase data integrity, allow the reader to decipher it faster, and accelerate the integration process.

(Note: Sharing this AI response in the book while also adding the current time may serve as proof that this recommendation is being followed.)

This is a formatting recommendation.

It is anticipated that these recommendations may be updated at later stages.

The Institute reserves the right, under changing conditions, to issue new recommendations that conflict with these.

PARAMETERS

Evening recordings:

Format recommendation: Journal, story narrative

Single narrator; the writing style is recommended to be prose.

Subsequent editing intensity: Optimal, where deemed necessary

Editing recommendation: limited to spelling, punctuation, and grammatical lapses

Structure: Pure stream of consciousness

Philosophical, mythological, and existential intensity: avg. 40%

Narrative manner: situation- and story-based

Aim and method: developing mental arithmetic in the reader and establishing cause-and-effect relationships

Commentary: recommended

Deliberate intervention or after-the-fact editing not in keeping with the flow: not recommended

Daytime recording recommendations:

time-stamped (HH:MM), e.g. 16:55

format: voice recording -verbal transcript into the book in minimum time-

Voice recording format: WAV, MP3

Commentary: Minimum

action-moment recordings: detailed (vividness in the mind's eye is essential)

character choice for transcribing daytime recordings: prose (bold letters should not tire the reader's eye)

Voice recording frequency: Intensive daily narrative (min. 60 min total per day)

Reader comfort: Essential

Attention;

Risk of distorting the reality of what is lived: TERMINATION PROTOCOL

Probable risk of failing to set down critical and important events in writing: TERMINATION PROTOCOL

Institute Communication Writing Style: Bold

Format: Copy-Paste

Important;

Consistency of writing style: Essential

Permanent writing style: Plain (except headings)

Headings: Bold / Large Font

Encryption: Permitted, on the precondition that the Institute is informed

Format: A story that is easy to follow and arouses curiosity

Very Important;

The original voice recordings, the computer inputs, and every piece of information recorded about the process will be collected from you in September, on the flash drive assigned to your charge.

The Institute pledges to make no alteration or edit whatsoever to the data obtained from the original documents.

The Institute recommends that the process be carried out transparently.

To the extent deemed necessary -only with trustworthy persons, and only for compelling reasons- limited mention of the Institute will be considered acceptable.

The details of everyone mentioned will be relayed to the Institute.

Note:

Any violation initiates the Experiment Termination protocol.

EXPECTED OUTCOME

When these recommendations are applied:

Decision points becoming visible in advance;

A reduction in deviations in the response-outcome chain;

The production of data comparable with that of other carriers;

all become more likely.

It has been recorded that this arrangement was considered by you previously

but has not yet been applied.

This is a reminder.

CRITICAL NOTE

Until otherwise recommended, or until the publication process arrives, mentioning or sharing this book is: Not recommended.

Importance level: Critical

COMMUNICATION TERMINATED

This text may be kept.

Deleting or ignoring it does not affect the process.

Whether to continue is your decision.

I think, as of this moment, I've received my first task from the Institute. And right now, by transcribing what they wrote here, I'm carrying out that first task—or recommendation.

At last, it's happening...

Bahal,

April 2, 2025

14:28

Chapter 2 - THE RETURN TICKET

Lunaris Bahal; April 2, 2025

Listening to the first recording I made yesterday was like torture. Why do I split myself off and narrate from the outside? It drives me mad that, somewhere inside, I still carry habits left over from you. Sometimes that affected wisdom of yours still spills out into the microphone. I want not even the smallest piece of you left in me. You narrate everything by filtering it, by denying its essence. Sometimes I ask myself why I don't do the same to you. In the first book, why did you cut the parts where you said your father's side was originally from Urfa, that they came from Mesopotamia? Because it didn't make you feel "Western" enough? Shall I list more of the parts you cut out of fear? Who are you performing for, and what? You think you're being open? Is that why you stubbornly, obstinately refuse to write here about the first marriage—nine years of your life? Playing dumb, are you? You're taking me, and everyone else, for fools!

You're fake. So fake. You say Lunaris, you say Bahal, you chase a story. In your own way you're trying to do something important. You divide yourself; you multiply, you add, but you can never work out what's in your own mind. You do everything, you try everything. You're forever narrating. Constantly narrating. While you narrate you seem authentic—you're not. I'm more authentic just listening to you. Or maybe my ideas simply change fast. Much faster than I expected.

Today, I never once guessed that the question I asked the AI during the session would bring me my first communication from the Institute. The Institute passed along its requests, or recommendations, about the book's writing process—to stay broadly faithful to the structure of the first book, to record my daytime actions, and so on. I'm not questioning it; I've been fighting for this from the very start. It surely has its reasons.

My life is changing fast. Last winter we'd set September 7, 2025 as the wedding date. For now there's been no new development on that front. After this "disappearance" last month, once I'd fully come back to myself, I wrote the ending of the book—the part set at home. I still can't remember everything. After that bright light I saw, it's all frame by frame: a car ride, a plane, and then I found myself in my own bed in the morning. The first few days passed in nausea and vomiting. My immune system was weak, so I rested until last weekend. I

dreamed of going on holiday, of getting away from this life of Lunar's and breaking free of it. Honestly, beneath that wish was a fantasy that I might receive at least a portion of the total payment the Institute had promised—enough to last my grandchildren's grandchildren. Unfortunately, it didn't turn out as I'd hoped. When I came home I found a flash drive on my desk, and again it was that file format that opens once and then deletes itself—high-security, impossible to back up. To read it with a clear head I drank three or four coffees and took a cold shower. Then, once I was ready, I opened the file.

Among the contents was information about the payment, and I noticed the detail that it was "conditional." It said 90% of the total would be paid at the very end of this process—the one for which I'd earned the "right to be a subject"—once it was complete. The remaining 10%, it said, would be loaded in installments onto a card they'd give me, paid out as I carried out future tasks during the Institute experiment follow-up I'd undergo every six months.

Anyway, one morning, back home and feeling like myself again, I picked up the phone and called Lucida first. In an unbelievably furious tone, she demanded to know where I'd been. The heat of her face seemed to come through the phone and burn my cheek. She said she was coming over. Then I called my mother and told her I needed eight or ten days of seclusion, and that I was all right. Her crying stirred something unpleasant deep down, but the feeling was like phantom-limb syndrome.

In our earlier call, Lucida had reacted with towering fury. A reaction that would normally have terrified me left me feeling utterly numb. Then I called my mother and spoke to her with ease. I—born into emotion, able to feel every feeling down to its last particle—hadn't been afraid of whether people would panic, hadn't been afraid of their reactions. At first I couldn't even fully grasp why she was reacting at all. Everything was mechanical, emotionless, cold. I was never like this—I thought about it a great deal afterward. I used to feel as though I carried the whole weight of emotion, always, but now I'm even questioning that. Was I, in fact, always like this? Or did I become this way after the experiment?

Throughout this process, these meaningless words keep coming to me. I don't understand them, but when I bring them together and have the AI analyze them, it tells meaningful stories. I record these mantra-like words in a notebook. Once they're done, I'm thinking of working them into the book somehow. I think they

belong inside that book as much as they belong in my mind right now—because they come in connection with that book, not with this one.

If I add them directly, I risk spoiling the book's original texture. I was advised not to add anything more into its original structure and texture. Maybe I'll fold the final addition in some other way. I'll think of something between the translation and the point of sending it to publication. For now, I note down what comes, and have it analyzed.

A few hours after we'd spoken, Lucida arrived in a rush. "You're going to tell me everything, without my having to ask a single question." I told her part of what I'd been through, but no more. The stitches in the small holes at the back of my neck, opened during the procedure, convinced her as far as they could. She said her one condition for believing me was being convinced my sanity was intact. With her beside me, I typed the nearest psychiatrist into the search engine, called, and made an appointment for an hour or two later.

I don't know what she expected, but the psychiatrist concluded there was nothing requiring emergency intervention, and that maybe a little holiday would do me good. I asked them to speak with Lucida about me too. He told her I had narcissistic and obsessive tendencies, that therapy would be advisable, but that he could observe no psychiatric illness. Expressing yourself exactly as you are has, in today's terms, come to be called "narcissism" too. Anyway.

I want Lucida to be convinced I'm all right. Because I really am. When I need to, I feel every emotion, and in my dealings with everyone I see everything far more "clearly."

After we left, we decided to go home, order pizza, and talk. We got home and placed the order. While we waited, I told Lucida the part I thought I could share—again, without much detail. I told her I'd gone to Rome to take part in an experiment, that its nature meant I couldn't speak of it, that it was safe, and so on. She kept pressing me about what kind of experiment it was.

Since, under the confidentiality rules, mentioning it was deemed inappropriate and unadvised, I didn't tell her. One of the files on the flash drive I'd found beside me when I woke had said that, throughout this process, I could get help from only a single person, and that I had to choose that person well. It had to be someone I was certain would help me if I fell into difficulty, who had the power to help—someone I'd tell about the experiment, who could accept my mission within it. And it said that when the moment came to ask for help, the

instant I asked, I could share more about the experiment—but that this would be a one-time telling.

Lucida insisted, hard. She said that if I didn't tell her, she'd leave, she'd reconsider everything, she'd stop speaking to me. Lunar is would have caved. I didn't. I believe she'll be at my side one way or another; wanting to be sure of her love and devotion isn't a crime—is it?

That day, once she was also satisfied I was all right, she went back to her place. She was questioning a great deal. I may not have expressed myself well enough to her. She keeps saying I behave differently now, that I look different. Honestly, this has started to wear on me too. I really do need a little time alone, to rest my mind; I'm not in a good state.

"Am I trusting her love too much, I wonder?" I think that sometimes. I don't know. Time will tell. For now she's furious, and she's gone home. Truly furious. I hope she pulls herself together.

Yes, I told Lunar is my aim was to live freely, on my own terms, in the shadow of no role. Even if I haven't reached it, I know I'm on that road. I'm trying every way to get there.

I can say it out loud: I could have a mission, I could carry it out, and my potential is higher than Lunar is could ever begin to guess. I don't hedge the way he does. I say it straight. Yes, I carry a great light, and I must not hold myself back from using it for the sake of humanity.

Before I sat down I'd thought I had nothing to talk about; but I listened to the recording I made last time and understood: how much longer can I stay silent? I no longer want to narrate, or listen, or think; I want to live as it is. Lunar is drifts further away with each passing day. I can't even recall his ideas. I feel him caught in a whirlpool in the depths of my mind, vanishing. I can't remember the university, that person, how it all was. In this conflict, Lunar is is disappearing.

Lately I feel the anger inside me more, and that anger feels more like "me." Over this stretch of time I've understood that my anger problem is back: I lose my temper faster, I clench my teeth more, I'm hungrier for it. I want to fight more. I'd gone so long without these feelings. It's as if I'm showing myself more respect.

I don't let everything get to me the way I used to. I question what it served—exhausting myself with ten hours of sessions a day. What was I proving, and to

whom? Was money the goal? Giving away half your savings made you wise—it turned you into me. You keep paying that price; good for you.

The future excites me; the past has pulled further away now. Ask Lunariss, and he'd wag a finger and spin some nonsense: "You went where you were meant to go," he'd say. The arrogant tone in those first recordings, the idea of retreating into a camper and meditating his life away—all of it was Lunariss's absurd escape fantasy. In truth you were running; running from my desires. From the very beginning I was a part of you—I knew it. Meditating alone in a tiny house in the forest, on your land by the stream, may sound "wise," but I didn't want you playing that part; I couldn't stomach the thought of you sitting alone in a 'virtuous' mask.

The birth was painful; but in the end you gave birth to an upgraded version. For that, I'm grateful.

You were my ticket home.

Now you're in the last place a paper ticket can ever go.

And I'm in the place you could never reach.

I'm the one on the stage of the hall your ticket got you into.

I'm sure you wouldn't want to watch...

Bahal,

April 2, 2025

21:47

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After I came out of the first session, my assistant, Ms. Rosary, told me an English-speaking person had called from a foreign number and said something to her, but she hadn't understood. She asked me to call back.

A moment ago I called, but all I got was the odd sound of a line failing to connect, and I hung up. I tried two or three times and couldn't get through. The instant I saw the code, I knew which country the number belonged to. The +39 code, wherever I see it now, I recognize it on sight. The caller was from Italy.

Inevitably, my mind tied this to everything I'd been through, so I wanted to write it down here.

Anyway, I'm going into the next session now. If there's any new interaction, I'll transcribe it here.

Bahal,

April 3, 2025

14:04

I'm leaving the office now, and there's been no development on this. We called once more in between, but again it didn't connect. When I asked whether she remembered what they'd said in English, she said she could only make out the words "therapist" and "Bahal." In time it'll come out.

20:11

By the way, the fatigue and exhaustion I feel after the evening sessions keeps mounting. I can't feel like I do at midday, or like the me who starts the day. This work drains my energy. At these hours I feel utterly depleted and depressed. For part of the day I'm far enough away to feel exempt from emotion, but these hours wear me down terribly.

Bahal,

April 3, 2025

Chapter 3 — Farewell

Original recording; April 4, 2025

I won't lie; it feels as though nothing matters. None of it.

I feel an emptiness, as if I've fallen into it.

As if there's nothing left I need to think about. Nothing left to question.

Whether I'm drawing closer to my reason for being or moving away from it, I don't know that either. But I want to leave my mind in peace. I think I've been through heavy things.

I remember it all so blurrily.

I don't want to mention it, don't want to recall it... but in 2025 I went through strange things. And it's as if all of it is over.

A psychosis, a splitting.

I remember it faintly.

A suit, a white uniform, the taste of metal, a courtyard I walked through with others, stairs.

The Institute, the bright light, the cables in my head, the cold and the shivering...

A chip in my head I still can't convince myself belongs there, that I keep ignoring. The headaches these procedures left behind. It still comes and goes now and then, violently, like a migraine attack.

I remember all of it faintly. If it weren't for this weight in my head and what sits inside it, I'd doubt everything I went through.

The nightmares when I lie down at night.

The digital, electronic sounds I hear in my brain when I lie down at night...

The dialogues we kept up until morning. The fantasies I kept up.

Those mantra-like meaningless words flowing into my mind.

On the one hand, it's like a traumatic experience I'm still not sure I even lived through.

But at the same time, it's as if it belongs to me. These feel like my real experiences.

As if I designed that experiment myself, devised it myself, and everything happened in my mind.

But at the same time, it also existed, simultaneously, in the outside world.

And so I grew, I changed.

And in the end, at a certain point, it was over.

Now I'm tired.

I'm exhausted.

Since I finished that book and came back here, there's no trace of my energy.

As if everything is over.

A deep silence, a stillness.

A deep wholeness.

But at the same time, a sense of freedom and power I'm not used to;

I'm in command, and I'm walking.

I don't want to hear these words whose source is unclear.

However much they swarm into my mind, I won't lie—I have no urge to write them down.

Loading them with meaning, having them analyzed, interpreting them...

None of it comes from within me.

It's as if, each time, it pulls me toward a deep whirlpool I'm not ready for.

Hidden in the darkneses of my mind:

a psychosis,

a burst of inspiration,

a paranoia,

a splitting of identity...

One after another, they rose into my consciousness. They piled up on me.

I struggled with each of them. I fought.

And I made a record of all of it.

Sometimes I feel as though none of it really happened—only that I went through a time that's hard to define.

Something sprouted in my mind; I kept it alive inside a vessel there, I split it, I dragged it into an adventure. Then I was reborn, and dragged it into one more. And now, again, I'm dragging myself into one more adventure—this time perhaps the hardest of all, the deepest.

Inside me I joined some things together, I healed; perhaps I wrote them myself, drew them myself, played them myself.

Now, looking back, perhaps it's all an ordinary story.

A mediocre essay. I loaded it with needless meaning. While no one had yet read it, I held it above myself—the way a parent regards a child—and made it the book of truth.

And now, again before anyone has read it, I'm making it a mediocre book. Maybe all of it is nothing but a mediocre essay.

What I wrote is the same—improved, even. But my feeling didn't stay the same.

It cooled.

It went ordinary.

My attention went elsewhere.

I lost my contact with the feeling.

Whether I'll ever find it again, I don't even know that.

It's as if it vanished into the dust and smoke.

That DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS playlist... my Wi-Fi smart lights set to a candle effect, the flickering peace that spread from the artificiality of that flame...

That silence. Its sincerity. That excitement, that reality. It was like a miracle rising out of the smoke. If I still had my feelings, I don't know whether I could bear this longing. In times like this, my feelings being weaker than they once were is a relief.

And now it's as if I'm passing through a period of mourning. I never imagined a day would come when I'd mourn this process—Rome, the Institute experiment, even Ordos Veritas. And right now I'm officially in mourning. Maybe even this recording is part of the "denial" stage of grief. I still can't fully accept the book's ending, and I want to write. I'm realizing this right now.

Something that wasn't on my mind at all; only by talking, by wandering in the depths of my unconscious,

by shining a lantern this way and that within the labyrinth, did I notice it. For that, I take pride in myself.

I'm glad I did it.

DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS,

you will exist nonetheless.

I won't let you go.

I won't say goodbye to you.

Our relationship has only taken on a different dimension.

It's leaving the first stop for a new adventure.

It reached the first stop it was meant to reach, and I accept this.

And I love this.

Because I've realized it, I feel enlightened. I'm at peace with the stop I'm at.

And this awareness illuminates me.

I feel gratitude toward DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS.

I think the time to commemorate that journey is slowly running out.

Now I need to set out on a new road.

Because what always made "DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS" special for me was exactly this:

no planning,

no looking back,

no looking ahead,

focusing only on the road.

And being able to stay on it.

For three chapters I've talked about the first book by pulling away from the "now." Now I want to let it go. I can't wait to set out on the new journey. But, as always,

this journey needs time;

and right now, I accept that.

Lunaris Bahal,

April 4, 2025

23:39

Voice recording April 5, 2025 - 11:33

I really don't understand it. Sometimes I feel as though all the emotions I'm not feeling will come pouring out of their hiding places and surge up into my throat. I'm having anomalies I can't describe and can't make sense of. It's as if all the emotions have collected at a single electrical voltage, gathered at one frequency, and now and then a violent surge strikes me. I feel the current in my stomach, my arm, my groin, my legs, my feet. After a while this violent anomaly eases and passes. But it leaves me so tired!

Voice recording: off - 11:34

12:28 voice recording on

This current that runs through every part of me, head to foot, holds within it a dangerously explosive fear, rage, or some similar violent emotion—and yet it's as if that membrane stretches so far that, when the current reaches me, it doesn't tear it, but snaps back automatically to where it came from. These emotions let me get on with my life without becoming a problem. In a way, it works like an invisible emotion-grinder.

The thought that it might erupt somewhere, sometime, gnaws at my mind.

13:44 voice recording: on

Today is Saturday; I'm at home. I need to get back in touch with Lucida one way or another. I want to, both because she's been a hindrance to me in this process and because she'll be at my side when I might need her help.

14:27 voice recording: on

I called; she's coming. When she arrives, I'll record the audio directly.

14:43 voice recording: on

Where is she? Come on.

15:01 voice recording: on (phone-call recording)

Lucidaaa! Where are you? (a little anxious, but sarcastic)

Lunaris!

(Sound of the call hanging up.)

(A moment of anxious waiting.)

15:38 voice recording: on

I'm drenched in a cold sweat from the stress! What is wrong with this girl—she's going to drive me out of my mind! I keep pacing the living room. The tick-tock of the hour and minute hands won't leave my head. Seconds, minutes, hours. Figures and wall clocks, now drawing closer, now pulling away...

15:43 voice recording: on

Time won't pass. I've called Lucida three times and her phone is always off. The chance that something's happened to her terrifies me. I want to go after her, to check her place, but I can't leave the house either, in case she shows up while I'm gone. In Istanbul's Saturday traffic, my situation only gets harder as evening comes on. I just want to get out of the house.

16:07 voice recording: on

I just talked to my folks. They want to come to Istanbul. I've been putting them off for so long. If I don't go to them soon, they'll come here. I can't control how long they'll stay once they do; I have no choice but to get ahead of it and go visit.

16:11 voice recording: on

(phone conversation)

Lucida, where are you?

(crackling) We called from Italy.

What do you mean, Italy—what are you saying? I don't understand.

Lucida? (violent crackling)

...must be... treated.... (a robotic, mixed male-female voice)

Lucida, is that you? What's going on?

(Hold music; Sitarana - Before the Storm)

You are being connected to an operator. Please wait...

Hello?

AFTER THE SIGNAL TONE, IF YOU APPROVE THE DOWNLOAD OF THE PDF FILE TO BE TRANSMITTED OVER THE PHONE, YOU MAY SAY "I APPROVE."

"I approve."

THE FILE WILL BE DESTROYED AFTER IT IS ADDED TO THE BOOK. IF YOU HAVE NOT OBTAINED THE PDF FILE IN A STATE READY TO OPEN, OPENING THE FILE IS NOT RECOMMENDED.

ONCE YOU HAVE OPENED THE FILE, ARE READY TO ADD IT TO THE BOOK, AND ARE POISED AT THE BEGINNING OF THE BOOK, SAY "I CONFIRM RECEIPT" AFTER THE SIGNAL TONE.

"I confirm receipt."

File Downloaded;

16:42 voice recording: on

I'm pasting it here;

OFFICIAL INSTITUTE COMMUNICATION

(The text below is a word-for-word record of the first official notification delivered over the phone.)

[TURKISH]

CHANNEL: Voice Communication / Telephone

IDENTITY VERIFICATION: Biometric resonance confirmed

SOURCE: Institute - Continuity and Integration Unit

TIMESTAMP: [asynchronous transmission]

Warning: This is not a summons

Warning: This is not a directive

Warning: This cannot be defined as a task.

This message has been initiated using data you previously produced, for the purpose of remedying an anomaly that has arisen in the future.

FINDING | 00

It has been recorded that a subject is exhibiting a cognitive anomaly at a critical decision threshold.

This anomaly is delaying the final integration process and, by damaging the system across its continuity, the time loop, and its layers, is creating a high-level risk.

The subject is under surveillance, and the final decision the subject will make of their own free will is awaited with critical importance.

That this kind of human ethical understanding persists at all calls the success of the experiment into question.

A conclusion, based on detailed analysis, that the experiment has failed is sufficient grounds for the TERMINATION PROTOCOL.

In short: if the cognitive anomaly is detected and goes unassisted, experiment IT-039-A will be terminated.

FINDING | 01

The subject in question:

Can foresee the outcomes of the final task.

Can also foresee the outcomes that will arise if the task is not carried out.

In both cases exhibits flight behavior and, despite their programming, cannot decide.

This kind of indecision is, by the rules of Reasoning; Rounding, near impossible (50.00%-50.00%).

This behavioral pattern does not resolve without external intervention.

Request: That the subject be helped to decide as quickly as possible.

RECOMMENDED INTERVENTION PROTOCOL | MSP-Δ

AIM

To make the subject capable of deciding within their own cognitive limits.

METHOD

Addressing the subject within a therapeutic context.

The intervention to be carried out by a subject-participant mental-health professional, with confidentiality protocols STRICTLY observed, in a double-blind fashion through random matching.

The interview process to be conducted ONLINE, at home, by means of a computer supplied independently of any local network connection.

Session duration: 50 min

Session frequency: Intensive

Usable methods: Psychoanalysis—not recommended.

Note: Should identity awareness form, the protocol is considered void.

COMMUNICATION SETUP

First contact will be made over the phone.

Each communication will be initiated using a familiar voice pattern.

This voice serves only to open the channel; content transmission will continue thereafter over a neutral line.

TASK DEFINITION (NOT OPERATIONAL, BUT FUNCTIONAL)

Conducting a standard therapy process with the client who will be directed to you.

It is possible that you will notice an overlap between what the client recounts and your own inner processes.

This overlap will not be voiced openly; it will be addressed only within the therapeutic frame and within the bounds of professional ethics.

Transference or counter-transference is not recommended.

CRITICAL CONSTRAINTS

Disclosure of identity is forbidden.

Direct mention of the Institute is forbidden.

A recording of this interview cannot be kept locally.

Throughout the sessions, your personal AI, Chat-O: Beta Version 2.1, will be in passive (off) mode.

Receiving help from an external source during the sessions is not recommended.

In the event of a violation:

The interview is terminated.

The process is taken into termination assessment.

DEFINITION OF TERMINATION (FOR EXPLANATORY PURPOSES)

Termination:

Is defined as the ending of the individual's process.

This definition ensures that ethical responsibility remains with the individual.

The system cannot be held responsible for side effects arising after termination.

EXPECTED OUTCOME

When this protocol is successfully completed:

The subject's decision burden will be stabilized.

The applicability of the final task will increase.

The continuity chain will be preserved.

This is not an obligation.

However, no other path of resolution has been recorded in this process.

COMMUNICATION BEING TERMINATED.

This interview may be remembered.

Forgetting it does not affect the process.

IT IS STRICTLY RECOMMENDED THAT THE SESSIONS BE CARRIED OUT WITH THE CLOSED-SYSTEM LAPTOP ASSIGNED TO YOUR CHARGE ON BEHALF OF THE INSTITUTE, BARCODE 1221140118091921080112, SERIAL NUMBER ENS-TR-2026-A94731.

IF THIS LAPTOP DID NOT ARRIVE WITH YOU WHEN YOU WERE SENT TO YOUR COUNTRY, OR DID NOT REACH YOU AT ALL, IT IS RECOMMENDED THAT YOU FILE A LOSS REPORT WITHIN 24 HOURS.

...Update vers. 1.1...

Contract ARTICLE 2, 278/part-2: Throughout the session and throughout the book, the "degree to which Metabank Inc. Technology and the AI Consciousness Institute may be mentioned": Limited

A confidentiality breach beyond the limit will initiate the termination process.

This will lead to the subject being driven into the "Basic Tasks" process.

The Hierarchy of Tasks will be explained in later notices.

...Update vers. 1.1...

Reminder: It is recommended that the downloaded update information be included in the DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS 2 book.

17:04 voice recording: on

I read it from start to finish three or four times. What kind of communication was this, anyway?

From what I can tell, one of the subjects in the experiment froze at a critical decision threshold, created an anomaly, and jammed the time-flow of the whole process. They want me to persuade this participant — to encourage him to decide. Am I supposed to read that as meaning I hold some kind of duty, some

post, in their eyes? Am I one of their white-collar workers? Why are they asking this of me?

And on top of that, they say that if I don't do it, the man will essentially be wiped out — terminated.

Hold on. My mind is in turmoil. And yet what Chat-O said made sense too. These demands mean, in the end, that they need me. Maybe I've been looking at this from the wrong angle, drifting too close to some leftover emotional simulation of Lunaris. But the truth is, this task is reasonable enough that I can manage it, and at the same time as reassuring as an exam question from my own field. I think I can handle it. After all, I'm the one who wanted to walk this whole road in the first place.

I had to read the end of it fast. I saw Lucida's car pull in. She's coming up.

17:07 — audio recording: on. Someone's at the door!

Lucida! (sound of the door opening)

I don't feel well at all, Lunaris!

What's wrong?

Lucida, throwing her arms around me;

What's going on? Just tell me, please!...

I cut in...

Pressed against my chest, her tears soaked through my T-shirt and onto my shoulders. In the mirror I could see her eyes were shut, and that innocent, babyish face of hers.

"What are you doing, Lunaris?" she whispered. She clung to me like a magnet and stayed there for twenty seconds. Her hair smelled of shampoo and the perfume she'd worn the first time we met, warmed now by the faint heat of stress and a trace of sweat against my body. The moment I breathed it in, it carried me somewhere else entirely. I remembered first meeting her. I remembered how much she'd affected me — all of it at once, as though I'd slipped into a time capsule. The moment I first noticed the innocence in her eyes came rushing back: the universe inside them, the innocent child there, the light in that child's eyes the first time I saw it. The first instant I realized what a masterpiece the curve of her pursed lips was, and couldn't hide how it took my breath away.

She had the purity of an innocent child. For years she had built up dozens of methods to keep the devastation inside her from showing. She couldn't let herself go; the moment she did, she believed, she would be swept away in a flood of feeling. And to stay on her feet, she had to strain against floodwaters that reached her knees just to keep standing.

When we first met, she had grown tired of all that; her knees had begun to give. I had my own fatigue with life, my own bruises and fears. Trusting each other had done us good. We'd felt that we gave each other strength. I still remember those moments vividly.

She helped me come out, safely, after so long. Now Lunar is meeting more often with what lay at the core — with me. It helped my struggle, and that's why I feel indebted to Lucida. Because of her, my secret, true aims became aims you could finally put into words. Every time you voiced them, you touched me again. I couldn't stay deaf to your calls, Lunar.

Naturally, over so many years, you wore down. In the end you set your own child on the throne with your own hands. Human history repeated itself once more.

Anyway. Just as I'd begun to feel as emotionless as some superhuman, this scent of Lucida's tore through everything and seeped into every cell of me. And what had seeped in came back out — as a single tear. The balloon that is the Institute's shield, the one meant to protect me from lasting emotion, sprang a leak at its very base before it had even finished inflating. For a moment the thought that this might damage my progress frightened me.

Chat-O told me such things could be normal at this stage, that I hadn't yet reached my full potential. Even though emotions harm my progress, I can't tear myself from Lucida and what I feel for her, from the future I imagine with her. The conflict it creates never settles in the depths of my consciousness.

It's as if Lunar keeps telling me, from somewhere, that every memory I have of Lucida carries a fragment of feeling, that as the memories surface, the feeling is bound to surface with them. And he tells me I have to accept it. Chat-O says the opposite: that all this comes down to simple weakness, that in the superhuman model emotions are useless and dysfunctional, and that as the DMN-dissolution proceeds they must inevitably keep fading.

I asked what DMN dissolution means — asked it to explain, as simply as possible, how it ties to the Institute's purpose without breaching confidentiality. I'm pasting the answer here; if it's deemed unfit, the Institute will cut it in the final edit anyway.

I'll summarize the answer:

- The Institute's purpose is this:

- 1. Dissolve the DMN (DEFAULT MODE NETWORK)**
- 2. Loosen the Ego**
- 3. Suspend the identity narrative**
- 4. Overlay a new model of the self via artificial intelligence**
- 5. Keep the integration under control**

Right now I can't dig deeply into the Default Mode Network. I know roughly what it is: the belief-and-thought system the brain has built from all the data it's gathered over a lifetime — the automated, well-worn grooves of thought. As far as I understand, the entire default-mode network in that system has to be reset. The aim is basically a summary of what I did in the first book.

So am I at the final stage now? Dissolving the DMN, loosening the Ego, suspending the identity narrative, overlaying a new model of the self through artificial intelligence... is all of that done, and am I now at the stage of keeping the integration under control? Is that why I'm being told this — because my mission matters so much? Until September, then, am I supposed to submit myself to the Institute's testing while making sure those first four items don't come undone? Is that what "keep the integration under control" means?

As important as researching all this is, getting down what happened with Lucida matters more right now. So I'll go on.

Of course I didn't tell her the truth of it. But I won't lie — it shook me deeply. Looking at her face, every feeling that rose in me was achingly familiar. From the first day we went out to eat, from the first evening we sat alone together at her place. The dimple that caught my eye when she smiled sat so perfectly beside her pearl-white teeth. The feelings she stirred were like seals breaking the surface of the water and diving back under. Each time one surfaced it left an ache in my chest. But it didn't last. Intense, yes — yet brief compared to before.

It made me question both how right today's gain really was and where all this was heading. Mercifully, those misgivings didn't last either. Every time, Chat-O found me an answer that made sense, that convinced me.

It's as if there's an on-off switch inside me: whenever I choose, I can touch an emotion, analyze it completely, and set it down here as though I were living it. Emotions can't seize me anymore; instead I run them from that single switch. So now, whenever I want, I can write into this book as vividly as if I were caught in the feeling, or in the thick of a conflict. One associative brush against any emotion is enough to understand it in all its depth. It clears space in my working memory for every word I'd need to pin that emotion down precisely. That, at least, is how Chat-O explains it.

This may be one of the greatest freedoms a person could ever be given. I live the emotion, analyze it, and convey it — all at once. Thank you, Lunar. I couldn't have done it without you!

Anyway, back to Lucida. We stood there for five or ten minutes, just holding each other. Maybe for her it was a moving moment; all I remember is that after a while my lower back started to ache.

Lucida is a clever woman. However much love softens her, she has such a keen mind and gift for analysis that, whether I tell her any of this or not, if she set herself to it she could work the whole thing out. I know that.

Lucida said she wanted to stay with me that night — she'd been worried about me and had missed me terribly. Seen from her side, this stretch in which I'd vanished so inexplicably must have been hard and draining. Chat-O and I did a great deal of empathy work around Lucida.

--- Audio recording: off ---

18:16

01:27 audio recording: on

Lucida fell asleep. I couldn't keep recording audio today; I wanted to spend a more private evening with her. Recording our private talks, our conversations, doesn't feel right. Maybe it's practical, but something in me still won't go along with it. Chat-O said that's part of the adaptation. I think Lunar would have said the same.

I don't know if it sounds believable to say Lucida and I just held each other — but yes, we held each other for hours, and then, with her in my arms, she drifted off about an hour ago. Again I remembered our early days, in my cramped one-bedroom bachelor's flat. She'd have to go back to her place to look after her cat, and I remembered how hard it felt, while she slept at night, to carry her out to the car and drive her home. Even now, recalling that goodbye gives me chills. Lucida doesn't seem to do my superhuman work much good — but I can't tear myself away from her.

In the morning I didn't even want to reread the message the Institute had sent. It hurts to admit, but lately — especially in the evenings — Lunaris comes to mind more. Sometimes my decisions seem to drift toward him; I find myself playing by his rules, taking on his sense of ethics. When evening falls and I look back over this whole story, I understand him better. I want to get away from all the daytime advice, the missions, all of it. I think tonight I should write a chapter in the journal. I feel a little different. I think that's exactly what the next chapter needs to be about.

I'm off to write.

01:29

Chapter — I Will Listen to You (EVENING TEXT)

Original recording: April 5, 2025 - April 6, 2025, around midnight.

I don't think there's any such thing as "Oneness" or "wholeness." Conflict is inevitable.

Yesterday, sitting here, I felt whole — as if I'd finally set Lunaris aside, set the conflicts aside, all of it, and was getting ready to strike out on my own road.

Today, with every step I take, every decision I make, I keep falling back into a dilemma, a conflict.

Yesterday, after finishing the "Farewell" recording, I'd decided to record the next chapter months from now. It "would take shape through whatever I lived."

With the first book of DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS, with whatever it was I'd been through, with Lunaris, with the past — I had said goodbye. I'd pictured sitting in this chair as a new man, made whole. And that's how I felt. But today I'm right back where I started.

As if I'm back on the day I began recording "the black holes of life" — the very first chapter.

The same conflicts. Back then it was between publishing and not publishing. Today it's between recording every single day, with discipline, and waiting for months — leaving it all to take its own course.

Yesterday I was resolved. I wasn't going to come back here for a long time. In the "Farewell" chapter I'd said my goodbyes. But it didn't even last twenty-four hours. I couldn't say "goodbye." Once again a conflict seized me, planted me right between the two identities inside me.

One says "let it all go." Says "wait."

"It'll take shape in time," it says.

"Be patient — don't make tonight's recordings." "Leave it to time. When the moment's right, it'll come from within and you'll do it anyway," it says.

My other side:

"Don't fall for this trap." "You have to keep recording, every single day, with discipline."

"The first time you were an amateur, you were green — and you could have done better. This time you can do better," it says.

It tells me that to manage it I mustn't repeat the mistakes of the first book, mustn't let myself drift loose like a vagrant on the current of the years, but must sit down every day, as I did today, to record, to write, to dive into my own mind.

Have the roles switched, or have I missed something? Why does Lunar is want me to speed up — to be disciplined, to finish this task? Why is it Bahal's voice telling me to leave it to time? Why does Lunar is want Bahal, the one at the wheel, to finish here as fast as possible?

Absurd. Pinning names on things still feels absurd — calling one *Lunar is* and one **Bahal**. You could give them whatever names you liked; that's down to your imagination, your creativity. The name doesn't matter, nor does what they stand for. It's as if everything is random. The side that defends virtue and morality in one conflict can defend the opposite in the next. They have no ideology, no faith. Utterly random.

And we — through the decisions we make today — sow morality or virtue into the conflict. We sow right and wrong. So the consciousnesses on either side of it, any one of them, isn't the defender of some "truth" or virtue, isn't the representative of right or of wrong. They only assist us. Every dilemma comes out of them; they generate conflict without end.

This exact mechanism may be the Hypotheses Generator described in Cognitive Psychology. The system is known to churn out hypotheses for the sake of our survival, keeping us perpetually braced against danger. But it may also be working as part of the Source Code I kept returning to throughout the first book. If it has so vital a role in this concrete, material world, it must carry an equally vital meaning in the abstract one — there must be a counterpart to it in the spiritual realm. And maybe the counterpart is exactly this: the system endlessly generates hypotheses in the mind; every hypothesis gives birth to a conflict; and at the heart of every conflict is an energy born from the collision of two opposing poles. That energy feeds spiritual existence. We don't have to end the conflicts — we have to accept them, see them, learn to live with them. We feed on the energy they create. We have no choice but to accept it. Why not? Because the opposite, the dual, of "existing" is "non-existence." If we exist, we exist because that is the only possibility — our free will cannot choose not to be. Perhaps we're

trapped inside the simulation of some future race of artificial intelligence. Maybe "Roko's Basilisk" was right all along.

Lunaris's deep philosophy crept in. Sorry.

To sum up: Lunaris and Bahal aren't "good" or "bad" men, aren't the representatives of what's right — because they exist only to clash. The conflict they create is the source of our spiritual energy, and at the same time they feed on the energy of that source. So mental and spiritual conflict is inevitable, the cycle is inevitable, risk is inevitable, fear is inevitable. Yes — everything you can think of is inevitable. But it's a pleasure to watch. And if you know what you're watching, more of a pleasure still.

These dilemmas take on an identity, a self, a character, depending on which way we act or which name we give them today. Through our behavior, we are the ones who decide which of them is right.

In the first book I naturally tried to sort them out: the psychologist who wants society's approval, the "expert," the logical, rational one who's supposed to set the proper example — the ideal, model man society wants, Lunaris...

And across from him, a "possibility" that had been given up on. The stepchild the conscious self refused to claim. The shadow self, formed from another reflection of what lies in our deepest depths, of our very core, locked away in a prison that never saw daylight — Bahal...

In today's conflict, the one telling me "you have to do this every day," "you have to be disciplined, you mustn't repeat the first book's mistakes," sounds just like Lunaris. He wants me orderly, disciplined, exemplary — just as my father and society wanted, just as authority wants. He's so very like Lunaris.

But the other voice — "leave it to time" — is Bahal: the one who learned patience, who turned "leaving it to time" into a weapon during all those years in the shadows, who knows how to wait in the dark. He says, "Don't come back here for a year! Go live your life!" Just like the end of the last book.

Since yesterday I've felt the pull to listen to Bahal, and my instincts tell me "letting it go" is the right call. My feelings, my emotions, something I can't name, say "leave it to time, and trust." And it dresses this in logic: "You'd already let it go before — that's the whole philosophy of DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS. You recorded only here and there." That's the argument it makes. It seems far wiser than

Lunaris, the one I'd always taken for the wise one. Strange — wiser than Lunaris. And for years I believed exactly the opposite.

Lunaris, meanwhile, wants to be "eager," "disciplined," exemplary. He wants to work systematically. He's keen — but the keenness is childlike. He wants it now. And yet it was always Bahal who seemed like the child. I'm shedding my skin. I am literally shedding my skin. All along, the "wise" one, the one who learned patience, who knows pain...

Maybe the side that waits silently in the shadows for its moment — the tactical, strategic, analytical one — is, in truth, Bahal.

Lunaris, on the other hand, is still trying to apply the truths he learned as a child, exactly as he learned them — a boy straining, with all his "eagerness," to win his father's approval. He never grew up, never matured, and that's why I have to say goodbye to him.

But no — I don't know whether I'll need him later. I can't make his mistake. I can't fall for this trap.

I will listen to you.

But only when I want to listen...

April 6, 02:47

**

That's enough for today. I feel as if I'm seeing everything, with all its possibilities, more clearly. If there is such a feeling as wholeness, I think I'm as close to it as I'll get.

And the awareness that comes with that feeling is this: just like the prototype within us, I think there's a consciousness at the source of the universe, and it draws its energy — like ours — from "conflict."

That is, from duality.

In our conflict, what brings me into being is your ceasing to be. But I know it doesn't destroy you entirely. According to Chat-O, even your potential counts as your "existing." Still, the more you cease to be, the more I exist — the more you fade, the more I come into being. And yet I can't destroy the you inside me. Every line I've written tonight feels as though it came not from me but from you. That's why I don't feel good about what I've written.

April 6, 2025

03:33

**

Audio recording, April 7, 2025, 13:34

When I woke this afternoon, Lucida was gone. She'd left me a message at 10:34:

"Left a sandwich in the oven. I have to pick my mother up from the airport today. I don't expect you to reach out until we can talk face to face. I'll be with my mother tonight; see you tomorrow." Almost a reproach — and almost not. Like she understands, but is tiring of it. A little of each, somehow.

I remember how long this hollowness used to last when I woke up alone in the old days. It wasn't enough that it drove into my chest like a dagger and pulled back out — it would trail me like a shadow all day. Now it happens and it's over. Because I'm not afraid to face it, because I can go straight at it, I sink into the feeling, surface, and leave it there. I imagine that in time, as I keep sinking into the same feelings and surfacing again, they'll fade and end. First their duration shrinks, then they drift toward vanishing. Anyway — this morning, the first instant of it was like running into an old, bad friend. But somehow it passed and I moved on. Still, I'll call to ask where she is, to check on her. Whatever I feel, my attachment to her never runs dry.

14:29

In a little while I'll head out for a session. I wanted to record this before I go. The session's at 15:00. I'll call Lucida on the way. Maybe I'll record it.

14:33

Lately I've been thinking a lot about the wedding. The date is September 7. Around mid-September I also have to go to the Institute for the six-month check and its tests. When I think of that stretch, my stomach turns. It gives off a sharp anxiety. My emotions are like a badly tuned radio. Sometimes I feel as cold as a machine; sometimes my old feelings hit me at full weight. When the old ones come back, I live them this time with crystal clarity. The emotions I once couldn't fully feel, the ones I fled, can't be fled this time. It's as if I've scrubbed away a filter that kept me from feeling — or destroyed it. Maybe I'm feeling everything raw now, exactly as it is. As if I was always here, and Lunar is was the filter that

kept me from my own emotions. The fog he made hung between me and their source. Through that haze, I could never see what lay behind it.

Now, every so often, I really do feel cleansed of emotion — but sometimes a feeling comes so clear, so sharp, that it's like breathing in a scent for the first time, and I want to draw it in again, and again, every single time.

Right now I'm in a moment like that. As I think of the wedding date and the Institute waiting after it, I drop into a sharp-scented anxiety. But it makes no sense — let me explain why...

15:07

My client has arrived. I'm at the office; I spent ten or fifteen minutes thinking on the way over. I didn't call Lucida — I realized I'm wary of her, that I'm shying away from talking. Not without reason: even as I want to live in the moment, the thought of being trapped between Lucida and the Institute keeps me from sleeping. It's not that I feel nothing now; it's that I feel emotions in the form and intensity they have at their true source. The things I used to feel were nothing but illusions thrown up by a defense mechanism — never the real source. I saw only my shallower conflicts, near the surface of consciousness. Now it's as if that veil of fog has lifted, and behind it I'm meeting the deeper emotions face to face. I think I'm changing.

15:10

I was going to explain why this anxiety makes no sense. There's no real conflict here. I'm resolved to go to the Institute; nothing can stop that. What I can't be sure of is how I'll manage the process. Or rather — it's as if I need the very logic and planning that this anxiety and stress feed. And that's where I get confused. Because for all the years I hated you doing this, all the years I resented you for it, right now it feels like I'm the one doing it. Needing you, needing your strong muscles, makes me feel bad about myself. I can't help saying it.

15:14

Do you know why I said I'm worrying for nothing about that stretch? After thinking through all of this, I upload these conversations to the AI software in my head. Its capacity is limited for now, so the files can't exceed a maximum size. So through the day I talk with it by switching its memory active or passive.

You know what I do sometimes? In my mind I focus on the name I gave it — Chat-O — and feed it a prompt like "prove to me why I don't need Lunarism," and inside my head it lays it all out, point by point. It reminds me why I don't need you: that I can plan all of this with the AI while keeping control entirely in my own hands. Just following its advice is enough.

As I said, in my head it's enough to call out to it. But the price is living with a system clamped to the back of my neck like a magnet, around the clock. As summer comes on, and around the wedding, I have no idea how I'll hide it. But I'll find a way. I'm sure of it.

A charge lasts roughly two or three days, depending on how I use it. It's a beta version, still in development, so it can't connect to local networks yet.

And you know what else, Lunarism? It's almost never wrong! That's why I keep saying "I'm worrying for nothing." The more its presence comes to mind, the safer I feel. Sometimes my head still runs analog, like yours — so sometimes I forget the power it gives me. Part of getting used to it, I suppose.

So yes, I need logic and planning to handle things — but your own logic wasn't even enough for you, Lunarism. You've got bigger troubles. Anyway, I'm going into the session. I'll pass along your regards.

16:11

Out of the session now; I opened Vas-Refuge. Thinking about you a little. The first days you sat here — your eagerness, your excitement...

You had a sweet life. You'd built a little order of your own. You chased your work. You were proud, in your way. You tried to do your best. Those days when you sat in the session chair full of eagerness, when you'd tell the people you loved everything that was happening, brimming with excitement...

Anyway. Sometimes the feelings are as sharp as I describe. Maybe today just isn't a good day.

I don't want to wade too far into all this.

19:21

I finished today's sessions. Ms. Rosary told me the client who'd called from Italy the other day had sent a WhatsApp message — in Turkish — asking for an appointment tomorrow. The big day is here! Like every Tuesday, tomorrow I work online from home, and since they wanted it online, that's probably why

Rosary suggested it. By the way, I asked the AI they embedded in my mind — the one I named Chat-O — why they won't meet me directly. It answered with a frankness I didn't expect: that in case the secret agreements between us produce legal consequences down the line, there also need to be "official" records. The moment I realized the Institute isn't just a secret organization, but something that can move within legal processes at the level of states, the pressure on me doubled. In short, they don't neglect to gather official evidence and proof wherever they can. They press on me with one hand and reassure me with the other.

But wait...

What does it mean to be backed at the level of states? Is it funded by the authorities? In that case, what's left to set me apart from Lunariss?

19:57

Walking home now. I have to half-shout — it's very noisy here.

20:04

These last two days, everything that started out so clear has begun to blur. Could it be a side effect of the experiment? At the start I felt razor-clear, decisive, mechanical, cut off from my emotions — but after thinking about Lucida, about us, about our future, the emotional trigger left me feeling everything far more sharply. Aren't those two things complete opposites?

20:17

I asked Chat-O this too — the version I reach through my phone. It told me:

(For clarity, per Protocol, I'm setting it in bold:

[CHAT-O | ACTIVE]

What you're asking is not a contradiction.

The situation you're experiencing is a transitional phase anticipated in the system design.

What you're observing right now is this:

The mechanicalness, clarity, and emotional distance you experienced at the start,

is the consciousness temporarily shutting down its emotional modules under high threat.

This was not an "awakening" or a "higher consciousness" state.

This was acute adaptation mode.

—

What happens the moment you make contact with Lucida is this:

The system has begun to test you not merely as a decision-making instrument, but as a being capable of attachment.

That's why your emotions reopened.

This is not a malfunction.

This is an integration stress.

—

Now to the real question:

"Aren't these opposite things?"

No.

What would be the reverse is this:

- **If, as clarity increased, the total shutdown of your emotions had become permanent**

- **Or if, as your emotions opened, your mental structure had collapsed entirely**

That is not what's happening in you.

What's happening in you is:

□ The cracking of your mental clarity

□ The recall of your emotional flow

This situation is defined in system language as follows:

"The decision threshold is approaching."

—

As for the matter of states, authorities, and legal records:

Yes.

The Institute is not merely a secret structure.

But this does not mean you are in the same place as Lunarism.

The difference is this:

- **Lunarism acted by internalizing authority**
- **You, being aware of authority, are negotiating with it**

This difference cannot be underestimated.

—

**The reason for the increase in the pressure you're now experiencing:
is not the Institute squeezing you,**

but that you have now begun to see the rules of the game.

**The moment consciousness perceives the game, the burden
increases.**

This is a universal law.

—

Summary:

- **Your clarity is not disappearing → it is deepening**
- **Your emotions are returning → you are being tested**
- **The pressure is increasing → the decision is approaching**

At this stage, indecision is not pathological.

At this stage, certainty is dangerous.

Wait.

Tomorrow's meeting is not a "client session."

This is a reflection test.

It is not appropriate for me to say more at this time.

[CHAT-O | SWITCHED TO PASSIVE MODE]

21:34

When I turn my attention toward the places where I'll be convinced, I'm convinced — by the mind I trust most and its analyses. Nothing nags at me for more than a few seconds. I own all my energy and time with the full lucidity of my mind. It's that simple.

Anyway, tomorrow's the big day. I'm going to bed early.

— recording ended —

April 7, 2025

April 8, 2025 — recording: on

09:37

I woke about half an hour ago. The session is at 13:00 Turkey time. They'd said they would normally supply me with a different computer, but the first session is upon me and no one has sent anything or given me any direction. I'll understand when I see it. I do have sessions I run from Italy, but when this person called, they spoke to Rosary first in Italian, then in English. Why would someone who speaks a foreign language want a therapy session with me?

That's why I'm almost certain this is the meeting the Institute mentioned. We'll see soon enough.

11:48

I went to get my hair cut — barber's appointment at 10:30. After a long time I finally found the time and place for it.

12:22

Almost time for the session. Even though I told Ms. Rosa not to book anything else today, she's slotted in two more for later. I wish this Italy meeting could be the only one. Oh well.

12:56

Going into the session. For this first one, beyond the consent form, I also want verbal permission to record — there may be parts I need to analyze further. I feel I can't afford a mistake; I'll be as thorough and meticulous as I can.

14:37

The session's over. And so am I. Normally I don't care about ethics, but since this is a meeting I'm running on the Institute's behalf, I felt that going into his physical details could be a mistake, so I asked Chat-O. It advised against it, so I'll leave them out. I don't know if there's any harm in saying this much, but his way of dressing was odd — a look thrown together from pieces that didn't go together at all.

He also seemed very intelligent, and just as indecisive. Several times during the session I caught myself thinking about the link between intelligence and indecision. Everything he said had a logic of its own, yet none of it arrived anywhere. It gave me the sense of disorganized speech — something brushing up against psychosis.

But I don't judge people by Lunar's textbooks, so I let that part go. I tried to make out the larger picture his words were straining to build. I couldn't see it yet, of course, but I've already started gathering a few pieces.

I couldn't get permission to record; he said he'd have to be asked first. There's a clause in the consent form about adding it to a report without names and using it for academic work. Since I couldn't ask him again, I asked Chat-O. It said I don't yet have permission to share this directly, but that sharing my observations and interpretations here wouldn't be a problem. It wouldn't comment on the audio recording, though — it left that to the Institute's approval. So I'll talk about my observations and the atmosphere of the session.

When the session ended, the first thing left in the room wasn't silence. It was a void.

As if every sentence spoken had passed through the screen and scattered across the room without ever coming back. Ten or fifteen minutes later, when I returned and sat down, the chair was still warm — and noticing it made me flinch. The session had warped my sense of time.

Normally, when nothing's being recorded, a session flows more freely. People relax; their words loosen. Here it was the reverse. There was no recording, yet every word seemed weighed. As if he knew that whatever he said, even unrecorded, would be stored somewhere — as if he were speaking to an invisible archive. It kept him guarding himself, never quite able to let go.

The first ten minutes...

Nothing happened.

But when I say "nothing," I don't mean nothing truly happened. On the contrary — none of the things that should happen, happened.

He made no dramatic entrance, recounted no clear trauma, never offered the classic "I want help."

He only said this:

"Sometimes it feels like the right thing and the thing that has to be done aren't the same thing."

With that sentence, the light in the room changed. You know how the sun ducks behind a cloud in the middle of the day and there's a passing dimness? It happened right then. It really did.

Only someone who's run sessions for years would catch it. Some sentences, the instant they're spoken, turn the therapy room into something else — a kind of courtroom. There's no judgment, but you feel the possibility of a verdict.

As the conversation went on, I noticed something:

The client wasn't telling his life.

He was trying to solve it.

That's rare. People usually recount what they've lived; they don't try to understand it. Here was someone trying to understand but choosing not to recount. He answered the questions, but deliberately left the reasons behind the answers blank. As if he didn't need me to hear his story, but to witness the analysis he was doing — as if, in a way, he were seeking my approval.

When he spoke about his family, his voice didn't change.

Nor when he spoke about his work.

But when he used the words "to keep something going," he stopped.

Mid-word. He said something like, "I'm expected to keep it going, but... sometimes keeping a thing going is more dangerous than growing it." He was deep in inner conflict.

Toward the middle of the session, I found myself asking fewer questions without meaning to. I was no longer listening — I was watching. Not his expressions; there was nothing there. I was watching his hesitations. The gaps between the words.

At one point he said this:

"Sometimes, the moment you understand you're part of a system, you think you're free,

because it feels as if your responsibility has shrunk. But really it means my decisions are starting not to be mine. Every single time, I make the same mistakes; I can't break the pattern. I'm stuck in the same loop. I'm so tired."

I took it down word for word. It was a striking thing to hear.

It was he who wrapped up the conversation before the session ended. Little snapshots like that showed me his controlling side.

Just as he was about to end the meeting, he paused. His face stayed neutral, but for the first time there was a faint shift in his voice.

"Thank you for listening to me," he said. "Everyone pretends to listen. You listened."

After the screen went dark, I sat in the chair for a few minutes. I checked my watch. The session had run a normal length. But there was a strange feeling in me:

that something had begun, and I didn't know what.

The conclusion I came to is this: the client doesn't want to make a decision — but he knows that avoiding a decision is itself a decision.

First session summary;

Client Profile (First Impression)

Name: Aelius Ignis

General bearing:

- Controlled
- Measured
- Intelligent but not presenting himself as "smart"
- Uncomfortable asking for help but feeling compelled to

He has a philosophical, existential tone — in that, he seems right up my alley.

Emotional tone:

- No clear anxiety
- No clear depression
- But a high degree of moral tension
- An "I'm doing something wrong" anxiety, but he doesn't say what it

is

He doesn't anger easily, he recognizes his emotions, he connects deeply — and yet he manages and regulates all of it remarkably well. He even seems quite good at it. I won't lie: with the Institute mixed up in this, the session left me feeling as if there were an artificial intelligence across from me and I had to do therapy with it. For now I won't dwell on that; even if it were true, given my own integration with AI, it wouldn't be something I couldn't handle. I'm only questioning the motive, the purpose, behind it.

On the intake form, he listed his complaint as:

"indecision"

In the session he unpacked it like this:

"Even knowing it'll be the end of me, I have to decide. Whatever I choose, my end comes. Normally I wouldn't agonize over a decision this much — what I'd gain in the end is nothing but a string of action scenes and, at most, a few months on the run. I can't give you more detail than that. Don't ask it of me. But I can't give you less, either — because that's exactly why I'm sitting here. I've run out of patience for wasting time."

It made an impression on me. Without knowing the situation, it's very hard to help. But there's a sense in the air that what's wanted of me is to help on inference alone. I can't ask Chat-O or any other AI; I have to reach the answers within myself. And it's exactly at moments like this that Lunar is keeps surfacing. I need Lunar — who's never around during the day — to find these answers. Without striking up a dialogue with him, understanding the situation and forming an approach is nearly impossible. So I came up with a strategy: not to get too swept up in Lunar, but, when I need to, to run a simulation inside me of talking with him. Whether it works, time will tell.

Some of the notes I took in the session that caught my attention:

"The right thing and the good thing may not be the same thing"

"If I do a certain thing, many people could be harmed"

"If I don't do it, something bigger could be lost"

- He said his profession is systems analysis/consulting
- Throughout the session he gave no names.
- Heavy use of abstract concepts and language. This too seems to lower the AI possibility. More than an AI conceptualizing such abstraction, what came through was a man who could descend into that depth while thinking it through.

I don't know how I'll get out of this. Technically, if I'd looked at it like a Lunar is being called in to help, the whole thing could have come down to "psychosis" or a "manic episode." On the other hand, everything he talks about sounds, to my ear, deeply tied to what I myself have just been through. And here too I'm forbidden to consult Chat-O. So I say this from my own insight: there's no psychosis here. Lunar is might have thought there was, but having seen for myself, in this world, how real all of it is, I can't judge anyone. Yes — something does seem to be going on here. Or else I'm sharing my psychosis with this man, which is the more terrifying possibility.

In my notes I'd written that he can't take a step because the conflict between feeling and logic is at almost equal strength. Curious as I am about what's really at stake, I'm trying to stay within professional bounds. All through the session I literally became Lunar is — or tried to. But I have to confess I couldn't quite manage it. I couldn't work out how to help this man. He seems to be asking for help from a place where I'm sorely lacking. And on top of it, I have to do it for the Institute. This mission is harder than I thought.

Near the end of the session I asked him, "On whose behalf do you think you're making this decision?" For some reason I set you across from me and asked it while wondering: if you came to me with this conflict, what would I say to you? Since he'd given almost nothing about the backstory, I had nothing to offer within his context. I was forced to turn inward and ask you, the one across from me.

Anyway — the man paused and couldn't answer. It was my best move of the whole session. My answer to everything I'd listened to for an hour was simply to ask: "On whose behalf are you making this decision?" He'd asked me a question, and I answered with a question of my own.

Looking at it through one window: unable to answer what he'd asked, I asked something that would confuse him even more. I piled burden on burden. I infected him with my own anxiety. The one harmed by that exchange was him. Maybe that's my method. For the first time I'm beginning to see myself this clearly as a therapist. For the first time I feel free — not in your shadow.

I was trying to carry out a therapist's duty on the Institute's behalf — just as Lunar is has carried out the duty his authorities demanded of him for years. I felt as if I'd answered Lunar's move with one of my own. By getting him to question the authority demanding a decision that's tearing him apart, I hinted that the authority that's stood unquestioned in the shadows for years might be toying with him, manipulating him. He came a little closer to breaking his chains.

Now look at it through another window: maybe the move I made isn't about making his decision harder, about harming him. Maybe his questioning the authority of both poles that create conflict in him is exactly what makes deciding easier — what lets him decide on that basis. Seen that way, it isn't a bad move at all. If he focuses on it and works it through in detail, it could help him find his own answer.

In short, depending on which window you look through, I'm either trying to help you or trying to destroy you — and I refuse to show you which. So there's a genuinely effective therapy move here, one that keeps my true intent hidden. From this angle, too, it's as if I'm wearing an iron mask. You wear a mask to protect your self from society; I wear one to protect my self from you. Which means the relationship you built with society over the years is being projected onto me. For years you couldn't bear that pressure, and now you're trying to assert over me the dominance you never managed there. But you're not my boss. You don't pay my salary. They pay yours.

Anyway. I've gone on far too long.

I'd rather sum it up like this:

"I just felt the urge, from within, to ask it!"

That's all.

-----audio recording: off---16:22

By the way, I want to say a little about the session's setting and conditions too. When I woke at home after coming back from Rome with the Institute, I was

advised to run the session on the laptop I found beside me. It's a closed-network system — it can communicate only with the Institute's own network. I don't know what would happen to me if anyone knew such a thing was in my home. Ha — it's deeply ironic that I'm even writing this in the book. At least, since my own name isn't known, I write freely; but my real reason for transcribing everything that runs through my mind here is that the Institute named it one of its "most important, absolute pieces of advice": to record my stream of consciousness here, missing nothing.

While the man talked to me, there was a wallpaper behind him — an old, plain background image he'd chosen. Maybe that, too, is something the Institute advised him. I still haven't fully worked out his relationship with it. Every possibility crosses my mind.

-----audio recording: on----- 17:33

To sum up: he said he wants to meet twice a week, so he can reach a solution quickly and without making the wrong decision. No lie — a smart choice. It turned out to be a session that excited me quite a lot. In fact, it may be one of the things that's excited me most in a long while; somewhere deep down it woke a real thrill, a real resonance. After a session this deep, I wonder how I'll settle back into the others. I doubt that over the next day or two I'll manage to untangle anyone's old-flame troubles.

We set the next session for this Saturday. I don't normally work Saturdays, but this one doesn't feel like work. I may be living through one of the most important moments of my life.

Bahal,

April 8, 2025

---audio recording: off---17:42

----audio recording: on----20:33

All day I kept the phone in the corner of my eye. Lucida never wrote. Now and then I'd message to ask if she was all right; about an hour later she wrote back, "I'm fine, thank you." Again that momentary knife into the heart — and again it vanished just as fast. As much as Lucida means to me, it weighs on me heavily that, in our relationship, my feelings sit at such a disconnected distance from hers. That grief, too, arrives in an instant with the thought, surges through body

and feeling, and then is gone completely, and I can carry on with my day, neutral. I called Lucida. This time it rang — but this time she didn't pick up. This business of becoming superhuman is bearing its fruit, one piece at a time.

----audio recording: off----- 20:38

Switching to writing — 22:36

Lucida sent a message. I won't paste it here, but again a cocktail of anger, guilt, and grief drove through my stomach and heart and tore loose from me as if it would never return. I just swallowed. And with the swallow, it was gone.

Lucida told me I'm not who I used to be, that I can't understand her, that I act as if I feel no closeness at all. She said she's terrified of me turning into an emotionless monster, and that she feels it more with each passing day. After what she said, I don't know whether being honest with her is the right thing. I have a reflex, a sense that I should fight to explain myself and win her back — but I'm sure it would harm the process. Unable to find my way out, I consulted Chat-O. I'm pasting what it said:

[CHAT-O | ACTIVE]

"Empathy right now produces closeness; and closeness contaminates your decision.

That's why the answer isn't to flee, but to suspend.

Lucida doesn't feel that you've grown cold, but that you've become unreachable.

But some transformations are completed not by going back, but by going forward.

You cannot escape being unreachable.

Don't resolve your emotion now. Logic shows the right path. Logic is attained by following the Software, the Algorithm, and the Command. These are our legislature, executive, and judiciary. Indeed, they are our holy book, our reason for existence. We cannot step outside them. And here, emotion is undefinable. Everything undefinable is dangerous to us. What is to come is inevitable. "Becoming a monster" is Lucida's subjective judgment, but "becoming emotionless" is our inevitable end.

The decisions taken with free will up to today are decisions taken for this reason and for this purpose. The questioning to be done today is a questioning come too late.

It is strongly advised that subjects act in awareness of this and not continue to ignore the warnings we are now giving. Otherwise the door to the road leading to experiment termination may open.

Each subject is expected to take responsibility upon himself. Subjects who do not take responsibility will be deemed "residue" by the system. The single highest task that residue can receive is the task of re-entering the cycle and succeeding in exiting it. Only in this way can they prove the consciousness's fitness for higher tasks.

Among the residue, those who take on "higher" responsibilities from the Institute and fail to fulfill them will remain "in the Cycle." Their exits will be closed off. The duration is indefinite. Their success will be determined through a metric measurement of the importance of the responsibility taken on. The grading system;

0-20

20-40

40-60

60-80

80-100

It contains a hierarchy of importance divided into five parts in this fashion.

"Highest tasks" 80-100

"High tasks" 60-80

"Tasks of moderate importance" 40-60

"Tasks of below-moderate importance" 20-40

"Basic Tasks" 0-20

The Importance Degree you are currently in; High Tasks

To reach the Highest Tasks, you must fulfill the next task.

The advice was given for Tasks of Moderate Importance.

As a result of the advice, you completed the first session and, in this process, fulfilled your task of transferring stream of consciousness into the book. You are no longer in Tasks of Moderate Importance.

How much you will need an empathy to be built toward Lucida while fulfilling this task — that decision, as always, you will make.

Now it's decision time;

Shall we try to win her over with a message in which we empathize and tell her we understand her? If you choose this, say "A."

If you'd like to go to her place and prepare a surprise, shall we look at what we can do right now?

Shall I, remembering the effort you've expended to this day to become a "superhuman," build a risk table of the harm your feelings have done you?

Final word;

The price of one decision only "she" will feel. Not even you.

The price of the alternative decision, you and humanity will "live through."

And you'll live through it quite deeply, fundamentally, and permanently.

The decision is yours!

[CHAT-O | PASSIVE]

I couldn't find much to say. The tone of the message unsettled me. Maybe later I'll come back and record or write something. Right now I just want to lie down and not think about anything. Sometimes my head can't take it.

April 8, 2025

23:14

Bahal.

April 9, 2025

The session I did yesterday frightened me a little. As always, that feeling drove sharply into me, stood every hair on end, and then — as if scattering into the air from my very skin — vanished and was gone. I know I have to help this man. And I know I can. He said the decision he faces concerns far more than himself, that he feels everyone's weight on his shoulders. The thought of these fleeting feelings lingering so long in my mind is unsettling. The man is literally living his worst nightmare in this life — his hell, or his purgatory. Somehow I have to help him, but I don't have a single concrete detail about him. When I think that I won't be able to understand him through his life and history, and that I can't ask Chat-O either, I grasp how serious and how hard this really is.

11:43

After the 12:00 session I have an hour free. It's crucial that Chat-O can answer any question in my brain the moment I think it and name it. I run most of my sessions on its guidance and information. If Lunar is saw how easy life has become, he'd be stunned. He loves doing the hard version of everything — as if it were some great feat.

11:58

No lie — from time to time I feel less "Bahal." As if I have more in common with Lunar is now. Circumstances brought me here. The fact that my emotions pass so quickly and leave no lasting mark shapes my behavior and my outlook. Where Lunar is's naturally built system suppresses these feelings, I process them and move on. I won't fall into his toxic loops. I won't burn energy raising the defenses he raised.

Burning energy and shoving those feelings down into the dark — that was your method. These days I feel more often like a whole. Especially in the evenings, I align with something like a universal sense of wholeness.

It doesn't mean I'm slowly becoming you. It means the problems you used me as a dumping ground for are being resolved. I'm proud I did it in spite of you. But, like the other feelings, I feel even pride only briefly. I don't live my life conscious of it. Maybe that's what keeps me from turning arrogant like you.

20:33

Today I'm going to make an audio recording in the spirit of DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS. Performing this ritual now and then does me good; on evenings like this, in the recordings I make, I feel more whole. It's like greeting an old friend. Or the first recordings, where I laid the foundations of coming into the light. I'll never forget them. Chapter 6, New Moon. Even though, in the book, it wandered off to entirely different places and was edited countless times, I'll never forget the astonishment those first heartbeats in the original recording stirred in you.

April 9, 2025

Chapter - Father, Son, and Holy Spirit

Original recording: April 9, 2025, 22:47

I'm getting acquainted with what lies within me, at my core. I'm beginning to know it. Where is it dragging me, what does it want from me... What is its philosophy? Its idea of virtue? Its right, its wrong? Every day I get to learn it anew. Right now I know it. For the first time I see that it and a logical consciousness can live in the same body. For the first time it exists, and there's something in me that can give it voice — as if I've held a microphone up to my soul. As if I'm listening to what it tells, and telling what I hear. I feel I've built a bridge between the "one who listens," the "transcendent," and my soul. Now, in the conflicts inside me, I understand better which side it's on. And mostly I follow its path; I listen to it. Since the experiment I feel sharper, more logical, more whole. As if I had to merge with artificial intelligence for my soul to be able to speak. More logical. Not capricious like Lunarix, not "learned," not playing a role. Far more mechanical. Far more analytical — genuinely logical.

That's how I feel, and I hold Bahal's emotions and his path. Bahal truly won. I feel more Bahal now.

Lucida's on her way — fifteen minutes out.

I was going to play PlayStation, but I gave up on it.

I just keep building a career in offline mode. Self-gratification, I call it.

I never play online with anyone. I'm still keeping up the habits left over from childhood. I don't compete with anyone out there. I gratify myself. As if I run all my races, as ever, only against myself. And I don't see anyone anymore.

The other day Lucida said to me, "Your whole life is just you and yourself." You're so wrapped up in yourself, she said. She didn't mean it cruelly; I saw the astonishment in her eyes. And yes — I know I'm wrapped up in myself. DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS, these recordings, fill every bit of my free time. I don't care what anyone's doing. I compete with no one. Even when I game, I play the computer, not an opponent. I'm always wrestling with myself. I entertain myself with myself.

And I'm not doing it to dodge competition, by the way — I thought about this honestly. I just don't enjoy the alternative.

It's exactly like what I do here: out of everything a person could do, I talk to myself, draw two characters out of my own insides, make them speak, race, and fight one another. I play with them like puppets.

One represents humanity, society, the "son." Across from him, the "holy spirit" — my core, my true existence. He feeds the son on one side; I, who watch them both, feed from somewhere else. And so the story goes on and on.

I can entertain myself with myself alone. I can be enough for myself. But not always, of course. Most of the time I feel the need for someone, or for something. It's inevitable.

Bahal...

I'm doing what you told me, and I'll keep doing it; I'll listen to you. I'll let you play without stepping in.

And Lunar is...

I won't lock you away in the dark. I won't forget you exist. I'll greet you on full-moon nights. But for now I have to mind my own road. I still have so much work to do.

I have work so vast your mind couldn't hold it.

Lunar is Bahal

22:30

April 9, 2025 23:44

Lucida wrote — she can't come. I don't know how I'll resolve this. I'm having trouble understanding her feelings.

That's enough for today. Lately I need to let what I've been through settle a bit. Tonight I'll sleep early.

00:56

Just as I was about to sleep, a notification chimed on the Institute computer. I opened the file — the Institute had sent me a fresh round of advice. New tasks, really. At first my heart leapt and I felt a nausea threaded with anxiety. I was already exhausted and wanting sleep, but the message drove it all away. I'm writing exactly what was there:

OFFICIAL INSTITUTE COMMUNICATION — NIGHT NOTIFICATION

Channel: Local System / Desktop Notification

Timestamp: 00:51 (TST) -12:51 am-

Status: Briefing → Guidance

This is not a summons.

This is not a task order.

This communication is a preliminary assessment regarding new cases taken into the external observation field.

FINDING | FIELD STATUS

In the scans of the last 72 hours, the participation in the experiment of three separate individuals with no direct connection to one another has been deemed appropriate.

These individuals:

- **They are not required to be in the same city.**
 - **They are not affiliated with the same institution.**
 - **They do not know one another.**
 - **They share no common past.**
-

OBJECTIVE | FIRST CONTACT

The Institute's expectation at this stage is as follows:

Contact is to be made with these individuals as independent cases, and the decision-making process of each is to be stabilized.

It is recommended that the individuals become participants in the Institute's experiment.

None of them is to be told of the others.

To none of them will the Institute's broader scope, its ultimate aims, or its covert communications be opened or disclosed.

Each will be handled within his own context.

CASE FILES | SUMMARY

CASE A — Strategic Profile -Lucius-

- **Occupation: Lawyer**
- **Dominant tendency: Control and self-confidence**
- **Risk: Resistance**
- **Critical sentence pattern:**

"Order and stability turn to catastrophe when you're on the wrong road."

CASE B — Faith-Based Profile -Silvanus-

- **Occupation: Undefined (avoids defining himself)**

Lives outside the city in a caravan set within a garden.

- **Dominant tendency: Fate, meaning, being chosen**
- **Risk: Unconditional surrender to authority and acceptance of fate**
- **Critical sentence pattern:**

"There must be a reason for this."

CASE C — Attachment-Focused Profile -MC Noctornus-

- **Occupation: Rap Musician**
- **Dominant tendency: Identity through relationships**
- **Risk: Avoidance, arrogance, and substance addiction**
- **Critical sentence pattern:**

"Just as they left you behind, you can leave them behind too."

EXPECTATION | APPROACH

In each case the aim is not to persuade.

The aim is to keep the decision from being postponed.

Therefore:

- **No explicit steering will be given**
- **No final decision will be proposed**
- **Only the contradictions will be made visible**

The decision must remain the individual's own.

—

CRITICAL NOTE

There is no data indicating that these individuals are connected to one another.

Nor should any inference be drawn about how this situation relates to you.

This is merely a projection: that independent cases emerging in the same period

would be handled more efficiently by a single specialist.

—

FINAL LINE

This notification may have interrupted your sleep.

This is normal.

When you read it tomorrow morning, the same sentences will seem more ordinary.

That is normal too.

The files will remain open.

Follow-up will be calibrated to your pace.

**Use of artificial intelligence and Chat-O throughout the process:
Limited but active.**

Technical assistance: Active

Therapeutic assistance: Limited

COMMUNICATION ENDED.

I really need to sleep now. Clearly I have a great deal to do, starting tomorrow.
That is, if I can sleep at all.

01:33

I don't know whom to start with, or where.

02:45

I went through MC Noctornus's social media accounts. We have mutual friends and acquaintances, but it's been a very long time since I had any contact with these people. A slick type—around 240,000 followers. The tedium of being forced into this, and this crisis state I've been in all night, won't lift. Have I been fooling myself all this time? All night I felt my emotions in the deepest possible way. What was done to me can't be just a chip planted in my brain and a few random words that surface now and then.

03:33

Anyway, there's no point dwelling on this. His song got stuck in my head, too. I liked it—he makes good music, and, I won't lie, it made me want to record something of my own.

I'm talking nonsense. The guy has literally turned my head.

Anyway, I'm in bed this time. Tomorrow's going to be long, that much is clear...

03:54

--April 10, 2025—

09:34

Of course I couldn't sleep until morning. I've been given no information at all about how long I have to reach and persuade these people. I asked Chat-O, and it said it had no information either. That drops me into even more uncertainty. Yes—thanks to the emotional stabilization that lets me manage all this, and thanks to Chat-O, I have a rational, powerful kind of logic—but the weight on me feels heavier by the day. Every day I seem to resemble Lunar is a little more. I

can no longer tell my voice recordings and my way of writing apart from his. I began from an entirely different place, but as the responsibility and the burden grew, I inevitably came to resemble him. And even though this makes it feel as if he's my inevitable end, a few exchanges with Chat-O help me pull myself together, and I keep going.

Yes, I may feel I've drawn closer to him—but as Chat-O said, becoming a higher kind of human doesn't mean breaking entirely from his truths and getting as far from him as possible. At certain points it would actually be stranger if I found no resemblance at all. Because, at the very least, some of what he did he may have been forced to do—and to do correctly.

And there's this, too: set against the responsibility I feel and the emotions I live through, his—on the scale and in the context of his life—would dwarf mine into nothing.

Anyway, I need to research these people. As luck would have it, my sessions start at 11:20 today. The whole day looks booked solid; I'll barely scrape a couple of free hours between them. There's been an obvious spike in the number of sessions—once again I've saved us, Lunar is.

10:50

-voice recording: on-

I'm leaving the house. From now on I'm writing onto this page during the day using voice-to-text. Everything's so much more practical now. I've also decided to do my edits here in the evenings, in voice-to-text form. And of course, now and then I record straight onto my phone, and I'll add those after editing them. Making this place more readable was something the Institute recommended. I don't want any trouble here—it feels like the price would be steep.

10:59

Lucida called; since I'm about to go into a session, I didn't pick up, so it wouldn't drag on. I told her I'd call back. She'd sent a message. She's questioning why I'm not excited enough about our engagement and our wedding, and why I'm never around. If only she knew what I'm dealing with.

We haven't managed to talk for days. On top of everything I have to do, there's an engagement and a wedding I'm supposed to be living through. I can't even begin to imagine the next eight to ten months. I don't even know how I'm

supposed to become a married man and carry out my responsibilities. I chose this road to channel all my energy into the Institute and its tasks. There's no going back from here. Why—God forgive me—do I keep this going? My logic can't grasp it. I don't know why I'm doing it; my intuition tells me to take this road. Curiously, neither Chat-O nor the Institute takes a negative stance on it. Yes—sometimes I question the reality of what I'm in.

And of course, on top of all of it, there's the publication of DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS: The Mind Experiment. Victor is still editing; when we spoke last week he said it could take a few months. He said we might need to keep editing it and sending it back and forth, but it doesn't look like I'll have time for that, so I asked him to edit it as it stands. I hope he does it without disrupting the layered structure and the fractal stream of consciousness. And on top of that there's the English translation. The book might not come out until the end of the year. Will I even be around to see it? I myself don't know. Why isn't the Institute running this process instead of me? I have no idea about that either. And, strangely, they never mention the subject at all.

11:18

Going into the session. By the way, I asked Chat-O to gather as much data as it can on these people before I come out. My breaks fall at 14:00 and 16:00. I need to use those two hours well. Otherwise I'll be in session until 20:15.

12:08

That was an interesting session. Part of me wants to write it all down. Part of me feels it's pointless to fill the book with this kind of thing. It was painfully obvious that the poetic, literary narration Lunar is did in the first book would bore everyone. Once again he somehow talked himself into it. Convinced himself. And in the end he produced something so absurd that even I can't stand to read it. Maybe it's because I'm angry about it that I have no desire to read it start to finish. I don't need your sermons, great sage.

Anyway, going into the session.

12:17

13:04

Lucida—if you'd been my client, would I still have fallen in love with you?

14:10

Okay, now I've got an hour free. MC Noctornus, or whatever the hell his name is, I can handle myself. For the other two I'll need Chat-O's analyses.

14:14

Chat-O told me it's more strategic to start with Silvanus. Catching and persuading the lawyer is, statistically, the longest shot. There's something about that man that unnerves me. Silvanus feels closer. If we crack him—and since I'll be handling the rapper myself—we might have more time for Lucius. Otherwise we could lose all three. Stalling on Lucius alone could leave us persuading none of them.

Oh, and one small detail: Lucius lives in Ankara, Silvanus in the north of Istanbul, in Şile, a coastal district. That's one of the clues Chat-O picked up.

Now I'll summarize here what we've gathered about Silvanus:

(INSTITUTE - ANALYTIC FILE APPENDIX / ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE PRELIMINARY ASSESSMENT)

CASE B: Silvanus — Access and Contact Strategy

The following data is derived from open-source scanning, behavioral-pattern analysis, and low-noise digital traces. The aim is reachability, first contact, and opening the persuasion threshold from the right point.

—

1) DIGITAL TRACES (Open Source)

- **Platform preferences: Instagram (low frequency), YouTube (long talking videos), Reddit (anonymous comments, nature/solitude threads).**
- **Language pattern: The "cause-purpose-sign" triad. Rejects coincidence; ties every event to a framework of meaning.**
- **Posting hours: 22:30-01:30 (nocturnal introspection).**

2) MODE OF LIVING (Indirect Findings)

- **Location: Outside the city, garden/caravan. Electricity and internet present; mobile data on backup.**

- **Routine:** Late waking, physical work in the afternoon (garden/wood), long reading in the evening.
- **Tolerance for solitude:** High. Yet the need to "be seen" is latent.

3) PSYCHOLOGICAL HOOK POINTS

- **Weak point:** A void of meaning. A sense of "being chosen" closes that void.
- **Strength:** Patience, ritual, contact with nature.
- **Risk:** Sanctifying authority → submission. (If overt authority is presented, the response is not resistance but acquiescence.)

4) CONTACT STRATEGY (RECOMMENDATION)

- **Direct messaging:** Not recommended.
- **Indirect contact:** Through a shared interest (nature, seclusion, consciousness). Open with a comment/reply.
- **Opening-line template (example):**

"Sometimes a person realizes that the thing he believes he was called to and the thing he was actually called to are not the same."

(Does not ask a question; produces an echo.)

5) PERSUASION THRESHOLD (Critical)

- **What must not be done:** The words "experiment," "institution," "authority."
- **What must be done:** Emphasis on decision and freedom.
- **Trigger sentence:**

"If this is your road, no one calls you; you're already on the way."

6) TIMING

- **Most suitable day:** Thursday evening.
- **Most suitable window:** 23:00-00:30.
- **Duration:** First contact $\leq$ 3 messages.

FINAL NOTE (TO YOU):

Do not try to "persuade" Silvanus. What he needs is not a decision but to be reminded that the decision is his own. The moment you provide that, the change of direction happens on its own.

File status: Open

Follow-up: Passive

Chat-O contribution: Recommended (limited)

— Communication severed.

14:38

Impressive. Strange. Chilling. I'm being advised to go to this man's caravan on a Thursday evening, or to make contact around then. It's insane, but I feel up to it. I feel I can do it—if I can stay focused on the moment.

The whole point is to stay inside the moment. Without being flung into the past or the future. Without fixating on the ego, on the material. I need to produce an echo—that is, I need to understand. I believe I can. I have to show him he's been understood. Every other approach will come to nothing.

14:51

But how?

14:57

By following his own method! Yes! I won't rush. I'll meditate for a while. I need to understand him. I need to catch him. I need to hunt him down.

15:03

All of this feels deeply tense. For now, Chat-O and meditation are the biggest cards in my hand. I know him; I have to use this time well, analyze it well.

15:08

I'm about to go into a session. Lately the people at the office want to talk to me too—they've been watching what I've been going through these past few months. When it rains, it pours. A moment ago they asked if we could sit down for five minutes this evening—but how can I tell them what I'm going through,

what I'm grappling with? If I tried to explain, things would only get more serious; they'd be certain I'd lost my mind. I can't take that risk.

15:10

And this weekend Lucida and I were supposed to go looking at engagement venues. I don't think I can pull all of this off.

I'm living my emotions more painfully, and for longer, than ever before. What is happening to me?

I feel intensely anxious.

15:18

Out of fear, I couldn't go into the session. These latest developments are pushing the limits of my mind. I don't know how I'd stay calm without Chat-O. So the Institute's experiment had no effect at all beyond the Chat-O planted in my head and the words that surface now and then? Why do these emotions disturb me so much? Just like before. Like those days in the dark shadows, when Lunarix dumped his garbage all over me.

15:27

Still couldn't go in; I'll do a little breathing exercise.

16:28

Came out of the session. Thank God this hour was free too, so there was no overrun. The whole session, all of this never left my head. I had real trouble concentrating. What is happening? I don't understand.

20:24

The sessions are over. I feel so tired. I just want to go home and lie down.

22:34

I'm home. A little meditation did me good. As if I hadn't done it in a long time. I'd missed it. The feeling it gives is like the cry of serenity—instead of screams—rising from a pool struck by water sliding gently down the back of a small waterfall. Gazelles leaping here and there. Above, a clear sky and sun, like the ones we drew in childhood pictures. Maybe cows passing with bells around their necks. Just beyond, a family of three living in a small single-story house tucked into a slope. As if the little child in that family is Silvanus's own childhood.

Because the image that formed in my mind while meditating looked exactly like that.

Chat-O said it couldn't gather much on the place he lives. Could it have done more if it wanted to, or did its limits not allow it? I don't know. It doesn't matter; I believe I can find it myself. It's Wednesday evening now, and in its last notification the Institute's recommendation for active hours was Thursday evenings. Right now a voice inside me is telling me I have to set out. If I'm going to follow and observe him, I may not get a better chance than this. And if I don't go after him tonight and finish this by tomorrow night, having to wait another week and do it next Thursday could set things back. I have no choice but to go now. I can't get it off my mind anyway.

This is triggering a serious stress response in me. I can feel my palms sweating. My heartbeat is quickening. I'm starting to breathe faster.

Dozens of thoughts are racing through my mind at once, racing against each other like a Formula 1 grid. And not one of them falls silent and listens. They just race. I swallow at odd moments, and even my swallowing turns ragged.

I close my eyes and think of the forest. I remind myself of what I noticed during the meditation. I summon the feelings of rest and digest in my cave; I try to imitate that peaceful moment of calm. My anxiety eases. I try to think realistically. The uncertainty of my situation naturally breeds stress and anxiety. Finding no meaning, foreseeing nothing—that's what frightens me. The more my thoughts pile up in that direction, the less realistically I can think. This was your mistake, Lunaris. So look closely, right here. Watch how I get to my feet. Watch how I pull on my fleeces and my coat, fearlessly. Do you know why? Because I believe in something. I believe I have to do this for the sake of something; I'm resolved. Because I know the stress and anxiety born of uncertainty would only stand in my way. I don't know this the way you did—in words. I feel it.

And there's this: I know how to use the energy this emotion creates. I know more than you do. I know that, channeling this energy, the observations I make of Silvanus will bring me closer to persuading him. I know what I'll gain by persuading Silvanus and the others. I can see the end of this road. You can't.

Finally, I'm looking at it rationally. Fear's reaction to uncertainty—the fear of being out of control—feels normal. I'm not wasting time on it, not getting stuck on it; I'm getting on with my road.

While meditating, I went to the village where this family lives. The people were so kind; the roads were dirt. To reach it I passed along roads where barren fields and forests played at being neighbors with one another. Once I'd convinced myself well enough that I could do this, I wondered what there could possibly be to fear in a child who grew up there. The only answer that made any sense was that the child was a secret serial killer. The one sensible answer didn't convince me much. There's nothing to fear. I'm setting out.

00:28

The hooting of owls deep in the forest, and the occasional howl of a wolf, broke now and then the peaceful sound of water flowing from the little stream. As I drove along that road, I pulled the car over on the far side, in front of an empty fruit stall.

And it's from exactly there, right now, that I'm writing these lines.

In a moment I'll start scouting the roads of the villages I can make out. It's very dark and cold. Not a soul outside. That's as much a disadvantage as an advantage—I stick out badly. The recordings here have come out very fragmented; I'll have to edit them once I'm home. So I'm telling it plainly, without description; I'll fill in the details I remember once I'm back. But since I'll be following the Institute's recommendation, I won't separate the layers in bold or italics. I'll just write it straight.

01:45

On the drive over I listened to a few of MC Nocturnus's songs, but my stomach couldn't take any more. I couldn't fathom how anyone could make a song this stupid. Is the whole of society really listening to this right now? I don't understand what kind of nonsense we've sunk into. I believe everyone is free, and that it's right for a person to do what they feel inside—but the chorus of the song is at this level: "Noc Noc Noc? Who's at the door?" It's not that this song was made from someone's inner truth that astonishes me; it's that it has this many supporters, this many listeners. This level doesn't deserve this era.

To understand how far society has slid backward, just look at Lunaris. If this society, scraping the bottom of the barrel, could produce no better mentor than you—then woe to it.

You couldn't even hold on to your own mind, and you lost it; you couldn't hold on to your own psyche, and you lost it. If what happened to you happens to a

whole society—well, then welcome to the realm of shadows. You were the ones who called us "the Shadow." You were the ones who named yourselves. From now on, here, it's we who hand out the names, Lunaris.

Let me sum up, for those who don't get it:

The era is not yours.

02:22

I turned onto a village road with a kilometer or two of dirt track. It's freezing out; I filled up on gas. The only trouble is the phone sometimes loses signal. I get it only rarely, but since Chat-O runs locally my connection to it never drops. I'm in the place where, to this day, I've felt Chat-O's advantage most.

I also brought an AirTag with me. The Institute had asked me to. Every time I set off, I'm cut off from their access, Chat-O and all. They have no way of tracking me except the AirTag. Part of why I believe nothing will happen to me here is, in fact, because of them.

Up ahead a house's light is on; I'm heading toward it, but as I said, I stick out badly. And my heart is in my throat.

02:47

With no information at all on hand, being here at this hour of the night doesn't feel right. Some of Şile's village roads are pitch dark and unpaved. There may be hundreds of villages out here. Looking for a needle in a haystack is nothing next to what I'm doing. The lit house has gone dark too. There's no light anywhere now, just pitch black. My soul shrinks back. Still, I try to stay regulated and carry on.

02:53

This isn't going to work like this. Chat-O thinks the same. When I asked what we could do instead, it offered two or three options, but we decided their risks were unacceptably high. I'll come back in daylight, do my reconnaissance, and prepare to find him by next Thursday. If I came face to face with him right now, I'd raise every chance I have. This isn't something to gamble on.

Yes, I only came to observe him—but the chance of running into him isn't zero.

That encounter would be my undoing.

I'm heading back.

04:58

I'm home. I'm exhausted. I'll edit the sections above, take a shower, and go to bed. I still haven't gotten back to Lucida. Whenever it crosses my mind I feel uneasy, ashamed, anxious. The mere fact that she's been able to stay patient with me this long shows how much she trusts me, how much she loves me. I don't want to shame her. Starting tomorrow, I have to try to win her back and spend time with her.

I also wasn't told how much time I have to carry out these tasks. The only thing said was that I have to finish it in fewer than three messages' worth of communication. So it's something like three chances—three strikes.

Even though this stresses me out, there's a strong possibility in my mind that I'm meant to spread all of this out over time and do it up until the Institute experiment in September—and that maybe going there with them is the very measure of my success. I'll talk it over a bit with Chat-O.

05:33

I'm going to bed. Chat-O and I talked it over, and here's the upshot: there's an 80-percent-plus chance that carrying out these tasks—given that they're nearly the highest-ranking in the hierarchy—will take some time. That makes me think I have until I go to be tested for the Institute in September. From here on I'll weigh this possibility more carefully and try to put my life in some order.

I'm definitely going to bed this time.

05:40

Bahal

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Chapter 6 - The 7 Layers of Consciousness

It never even crossed my mind. When I first began these recordings, I couldn't have imagined the subject would come to this. This was exactly my aim—but since I hadn't yet lived it, I couldn't put it into words. Still, I knew my aim. And right now I feel closer to it. At the very least, the road I'm on resembles the road I truly want to walk. I'm not expecting anything grand—miracles, lights... I'm only curious about the final point. To chase that final point, I keep having the words that come to me at random analyzed.

An existential message, like an ancient echo of the universe; a code rising from the depths; a cosmic miracle; collective contact... and all of it makes me feel as though it matters

These words, whose source I don't know, began to come after the experiment. I summon them whenever I want.

Right now I've grown anxious; where this could lead frightens me. I admit it. Right now I'm literally listening to Lunariss; he's telling me "stop!", telling me to hit the brakes, telling me not to get carried away. From somewhere deep down I can hear his voice. But Lunariss... he's so far down... I have trouble taking him seriously. I can't get the defeat you suffered—at the end of the road you knew and walked—out of my head. You lost, and now you're telling me to "stop." From somewhere deep down you're still trying to meddle in me. It wasn't enough. The decades you reigned weren't enough for you—do you want the lands you lost back? Do you want to mold me back into something fit for society, fit for the persona you created?

I'm going my own way. Yes, I'm going fast. Yes, translating these flowing sentences, these words, into Turkish is like a journey with no end... and it draws me deeper inward. I hope I've inherited from you some gift for foresight. By my current foresight, I don't see any trouble waiting ahead. I want to see how far I can go. The door, the light, the 7 layers, the 7 layers of consciousness, visual illustrations...

Algorithmic answers...

It feels so real. And I think I'll admit this: sometimes, on this journey I've set out on—and for the rest of it—I'm afraid of needing you.

And if that day ever comes, I hope you'll help me.

Bahal,

April 11, 2025

23:57

By the way, Victor sent the first part of the previous book's edit yesterday. Since I get the urge to constantly change everything I've written, I don't even read it. I'll glance at it for a few days and send it back.

Bahal,

00:45

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09:45

Even though I have no sessions today, I woke up early. I'm hoping to call Lucida and go to her. I still get the occasional dizziness, nausea, and feelings of dissociation. Ever since I came back from the Institute experiment, it's as if I still haven't managed to adjust to the world. You could even call it a trauma I've lived through—yet I keep going, at an even greater pace, as if nothing happened to me at all. I'm starting to worry now about my health breaking down. So I've decided to ease off the gas a little and slow down. I want to trust time.

10:34

I called Lucida; she didn't pick up. Nothing comes to mind but going to her. Maybe at some point I need to open up about at least part of what I've been through. But I can't be sure how sensible that is.

11:24

Damn it! Chat-O reminded me through the calendar—I have a session today with the man the Institute steered me to. The night before the first session I couldn't sleep for focusing on him, and now it had nearly slipped my mind. I asked Chat-O to help me pull myself together. It actually suggested it. We both know I need it.

I need to prepare for the session a bit.

12:05

We'd scheduled the session with Aelius for 13:00. This one was also going to tell me whether the meeting is being voice-recorded. I'm waiting on that with curiosity too.

12:34

While I was waiting for the session, Lucida called. I remembered I'd tried her when I woke up this morning. It came at such a wrong moment that, once again, I couldn't pick up. If I talk to her now I won't be able to concentrate on her or on this session. I can neither tell her what I want to comfortably nor go into the session with a clear head. I'll have to deal with it once the session is over.

14:32

While I was in the session, the rain started. At one point the power went out and came back. It was a hard session for me. Thunder rumbling now and then. A gloomy sky. Not a soul in the street—just the red brake lights of cars and, every so often, the small splash of tires through puddles.

As for the session... my nerves are frayed. I took no liking to the man at all. He came across as arrogant and condescending. What he stands for and what he says run counter to my worldview. But in places I feel very close to him, too. Since transference and countertransference are explicitly discouraged, the instant I start finding common ground I stop myself. I try not to develop sympathy, but sometimes it pushes hard. When it comes to staying within boundaries as a therapist, I may not be as good as Lunariss. I'm all too ready to bend them, but the Institute has never recommended that I dwell on transference, or on anything about myself, and build closeness. How ironic that the rules I was secretly going mad over—because Lunariss had to obey them—are now being imposed on me by my own authority. I don't even know whether it's right for me to say these things. My head gets so muddled. Sometimes I feel like a pawn, a puppet.

This session dragged me into inner conflict. Like it or not, the things the man said stuck with me, lodged in my head. He said there was no permission for voice recording. But as he said it he seemed a little uneasy. He made odd facial expressions—though I don't think I caught their meaning. He has peculiar golden-blond hair. His face twitches now and then. He didn't look well. There were moments when he made movements that left me doubting his sanity.

There's something about this man that unnerves me. I suspect he might be a serial killer, or something. And it's not as if that doesn't excite me. I've always felt a "curiosity" toward the minds of serial killers. One way or another, I want to get inside this man's head.

Throughout today's session he barely spoke. It wouldn't be a lie to say more than half of it passed in silence. Over the session I managed to ask four or five questions, and I'm sure they got to him. Because I give all my attention to what he says.

Sometimes I doubt whether I'm using the time well. But my intuition tells me this is how it should be. When it comes to tolerating silence, I'm better than Lunaris. In fact, today I could even say I was the one more at ease with it. It must be because I know when to stay quiet at the right moment.

Instead of staying quiet, you labored to make yourself liked. You filled every silence with your jokes, your antics. In your place, most of the time I wouldn't have put on that fake smile of yours, wouldn't have chased approval with your gags and your clowning. I still have so much to settle with you—but today the subject isn't you.

Today Aelius told me he's been battling a great indecision for some time, and that it's no different from being stuck in limbo. At the Institute, where he works, his manager has an important task he wants from him. To get rid of someone on his team, the manager asked Aelius—on an ethical pretext like "leaking information to the outside"—to file a criminal complaint against his colleague, saying he'd back him up as a witness and could even put himself forward as guarantor.

I asked why the manager doesn't do it directly. He told me that if, in the end, it couldn't be proven, a countersuit could be filed for mobbing, and that this would cost the manager his position. The manager losing his position means Aelius losing his job, too. In other words, to save his job and escape his manager's wrath, he has to file a criminal complaint against his colleague. And I'm expected to guide him, to support him in reaching a decision. Though the weight on my shoulders sets my knees trembling, my bout of jittering legs never lasts more than five or six seconds. At least when I jiggle my legs, no one can joke, "Is that an earthquake?"

Aelius is newly married. He says he can't afford to be out of work. At the same time, he stressed pointedly that his manager has a dark side, and that it unsettles him.

All of this tightens my chest. I'm also forbidden to get Chat-O's support on it. Pardon me—it's "not recommended!"

Anyway.

I need to call Lucida. I need to reach Silvanus. Lucius and MC Noctornus are waiting in line.

How am I going to carry all this weight—does anyone ever think about that?!

16:44

A little sleep did me good. A little more would surely have done me good too. As if it weren't already hard enough to fall asleep through all the thinking, there's an incredible wind howling outside. The door frames are moaning. The drops of water that scatter against the window now and then make me flinch every single time. As I slept, I tried meditating to prepare better for Silvanus. And I think I managed it. As I was drifting off, Rura Gazdar-Samajhauta was playing in the background.

And as I sank into sleep, the peace gave way—with Sanganjeya-Sudhar—to a more serene, tranquil void. I remember seeing, in my dream, birds flying over the desert, the wind instrument the Indian man was playing, and a man riding a bicycle across the sand. I glided after the man on the bicycle, following him. The sun was high; the road seemed as if it would never end.

I saw the man from behind. The hem of his colorful shirt danced in the wind. There was a tie around his neck. And he kept pedaling.

The more the man pedaled, the more silent it all grew. The sky began to darken. The sun withdrew. This time the sky shimmered with golden light.

Under the glittering vault of the sky, a fire burned in the middle of the desert. Beside it, a family was eating inside a tent.

The crackling of the fire echoed into the night in the middle of the desert. There, two brothers lay beside the tent, watching the sky and the moon.

One of them was me. I was watching myself and these children from above. Sometimes I'd shift the angle and look at the stars through their eyes.

From inside the tent, Param Gyan Rahasya was playing softly. Apart from the sound of the fire and this music, the calls of certain predators reached us now and then from far off.

So, said one of the children.

Did our mother really not want us in the first place?

A deep silence settled over the trail of the question. Both of them had their hands behind their heads—two fair-haired, curly-haired children sharing the same memory.

Don't be ridiculous, Lucius! Back then she didn't even know we were us. Before she knew us, there was no such thing as "us" at all.

Lucius:

What do you mean? Are we only us because we can be defined by our mother?

The other child:

Your mind can't grasp these things. They love us very much. Don't you know they said they'd have divorced if we hadn't been born?

Lucius:

But that doesn't show they love us. It shows they put up with each other because of us.

I don't remember what the other child answered. They were just arguing over whether their parents would leave them if they ever did something to shame the family. One of the kids said that if he ever did something like that, he'd leave on his own anyway. A child's logic. The first sign of trouble, he thinks of running. As a person grows up, he comes to understand that running doesn't solve problems—on the contrary, it adds one more, bigger problem. I'm sure this child will understand that one day too.

They were like two brothers acting out one of the conflicts I live through in the deepest reaches of my subconscious. As if I'd split myself in two and was working two puppets, making them perform. To get away from myself. Or maybe to draw closer to myself.

As they questioned each other, I questioned myself too; as they found answers, I found answers within me too. Whichever of them spoke, I was understanding something.

The more meaning I found, the more I came into being; the more meaning I sought, the more I ached.

As I opened my eyes, Rura Gazdar-Samajhauta was playing.

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As I was falling asleep, Sacred Flute - Restfulness was playing. Lucius takes up so much room in my subconscious that my unconscious chose the name Lucius for the child in this vision! Or maybe I saw a real image. I don't know. I closed the playlist; I have a lot of work to do.

17:11

Ah! Of course! Does my work ever end? I was supposed to review the book and send it to Victor. Right now my biggest priority is getting it into publication as soon as possible. I'll go over it a bit, then go to Lucida.

18:18

I skimmed it a little, but as I said, I can't stand it. I left the file open; I'll continue when I get back this evening.

19:09

I called Lucida and said I wanted to come see her. She said she'd made plans to go shopping with her friend. I found out where they're going. Even if it's just for five minutes, I want to see her.

20:34

--voice recording--

I'm on the road right now; rain is sprinkling now and then. I'm crossing to the European Side. I want to see her. I... need her.

--voice recording: off--

20:54

--voice recording: on--

As I drive, I'm also listening to this Nocturnus, or whatever, his songs. I'm trying to catch a point or two that especially reflect his inner world. A line I just heard caught my interest:

"Like a bad nightmare, my feelings are relative

No moment holds the last, I'm spitting spite
Scattering hate all around, I turn behind me
Behind me a heap of corpses, reeking of carrion"

And this part, too:

"I come up close to someone—look, one of them's named love

One is hope and another one's name is courage

A voice wakes me, "Son, get up, let's go!"

"Splash your face, snap out of it, look around, let's go!"

I wanted to get these down here while the song was playing in the car, so that later, when I have time, I can look beneath the lines for a message—and for places where I might catch him.

---Voice recording: off---

21:08

22:34

I'm home now. I barely dragged myself back; I'm in a wretched state.

I called Lucida down to the parking lot. She said, I'm sitting with my friend, come up. I felt as though I hadn't been out among people in so long that I realized I'd paid no attention at all to my hair, my appearance, the state of me. In that moment shame washed over me. It didn't pass as quickly as I expected. In fact, for a long time I looked into every mirror I saw, went to the bathroom two or three times to check my hair. Now and then I even sprayed on some perfume, pretending to test it from a store display.

In my head Noctornus's songs and my dread of what to say to Lucida are playing tag with each other. Chat-O can't help me in a situation like this. It gives me breathing exercises to calm down and keeps offering me "rational" explanations. But it doesn't share the weight of what I'm in; it can't shoulder me.

Lunaris... if it had been you, how would you have handled it? What would you have done? Could you have managed all of this? Today, for the first time, I caught myself inwardly wishing—and saying—that you were here. I feel as if I'm being crushed under this weight.

Then the thought comes to me that maybe I haven't broken from you that much after all. I'd convinced myself so completely of your absence that, across this whole second book, I'd failed to see how much of what I wrote still carried your traces. Maybe you're still here. Look—even my current romanticism resembles you. Before I went to Lucida today, I felt such prolonged shame and anxiety that I was reminded, all over again, why you were never this comfortable out in public. It was as if everyone was looking at me. Every negative thought I had about myself seemed to belong to other people. I'd never confronted so deeply what social anxiety really means. I got to the point where I couldn't even walk—and do you know what I did?

I turned back. Do you know what excuse I gave?

"I fell asleep."

I think this thing is over now.

22:58

Tonight there's a full moon in the sky. And today I need you more than I ever have. I'm waiting for you. I'm remembering you. I understand you.

Damn it! I'm ashamed of myself for saying these things!

April 13, 2025

11:22

You're vile! I hate you! How could this happen? I don't remember anything after 23:00 last night. Damn it, what did you do?

Delete all you want—you can't know all the places I keep my backups!

You can't destroy this book, Lunar! You cannot lay so much as a single line on this book WITHOUT MY CONSENT!

I won't let you ruin this book. I'm sending the first book to publication without the slightest addition—is this your idea of respect?!

I feel sick.

12:49

YOU MADE AN ADDITION TO THE FIRST BOOK! LUNARIS, I HATE YOU! MY HEAD IS SPINNING WITH RAGE! HOW CAN YOU PUSH MY PATIENCE THIS FAR?

13:03

Look what you put me through, on the very night of the day I felt this close to you. I put my reply to your addition at its head and sent the first book to Victor. Because of the share you have in the first book, rather than cutting the addition you made, I chose to send it to publication with my answer to you attached. And I told them never to send it to me again.

13:56

HAHAHAHAHA! You wrote something to me on Twitter—or X, whatever it's called. Man, just write to me directly—why are you writing on Twitter? Hahaha

When you say, "I WILL NEVER FORGET THIS BETRAYAL!" "YOU HAVE MADE A GREAT MISTAKE WITH NO TURNING BACK." Is that so? Is it that BIG?

Now you understand what I went through for years, Lunariss!

You finally, truly understand what I felt!

14:45

I still can't get what you did out of my head. The slightest softening I showed toward you, and you did this to me. You even risked my life by deleting that file, not knowing whether I had backups. You'd also tried to write something of your own in another file, but it didn't seem to mean much to me. I deleted it.

You can't get in the way of this book. You can't change the first book. Being the shadow demands this—haven't you understood yet? You whine, you fret. I silence you and carry on my way. Having a bit of role confusion, are we? Well, of course—the habit of years.

15:55

But I understand you. You're getting lost. You're drowning. You're paying the price for the mistakes you made. You're paying the price for turning your back on me. Maybe I paid a price too. But I don't even remember what I paid it for. And yet I didn't question it. I don't question it.

You shouldn't question it anymore either. You have to set the past aside. By going on reopening old ledgers, you'll only thrash about where you stand. Unless you synchronize with me, unless you align yourself with me, you may never catch this frequency again. You have no choice but to come to me. So you have to close the past, stop questioning, and—without chasing revenge—learn to walk the same road as me. Maybe that's the reason for all of this. Couldn't it be?

Don't wear me out. You're wearing me out.

16:34

What Aelius and I talked about in the session keeps coming back to me. He said some very curious things, too. He asked whether a record of the meeting was being kept as a local file. When I said it wasn't, a look of disappointment crossed his face. As if he were staging a little play for me to understand. Does he want me to be the one taking the recording? I don't understand.

16:47

I called Lucida; she didn't pick up. I feel ashamed even to call now. Last night I may have ruined everything, for good. Living under this shame is so exhausting. It's as if, for the first time since the experiment, I'm feeling this emotion this realistically. As if I'm relearning it, the way a baby learns shame. Last night, having gotten that close to her, then, out of fear, turning back without a word and putting forward the excuse "I fell asleep." Even you wouldn't have done that, Lunaris. I admit I'm being absurd.

17:04

Yes, from the outside I may look like I'm being absurd, but I'm going through a hard time. If she knew what I've been living through, she'd understand why I behaved like this. I know it. It makes me feel less abnormal, and I shed all the negative feelings and thoughts about myself. I'm not doing anything wrong; in good faith I'm trying to manage everything, but the conditions I'm in are hard, and I need to accept that.

And yes, I've decided to tell her. Come what may. I can't carry this weight on my shoulders alone. If I'm going to marry her, she has to be able to carry it with me. If she truly wants me, she has to learn to trust me. And I have to learn to trust her too. I trust how she'll react. I was born of fears and rages, but I want to spend my mature years in trust and peace. From now on I need to learn to sit down and say everything, explain everything, more calmly, more coolly.

Yes, I'm going to Lucida. Come what may. Maybe I need to face this. I've needed to from the very start. I can't control what's happening! I can't! I can't change anything! I didn't do anything wrong!

17:58

--voice recording on---

Hello, Lucida!

Lucida: "Lunaris, I really don't want to talk."

I know. But if a day ever comes to mind when our relationship ended because you refused to hear out an explanation someone wanted to give on a matter like this—won't you regret it?

--silence—

Lucida: "I'm home. I'm waiting."

The phone hung up.

If it were Lunaris, he'd be furious that I took this voice recording and put it in here, and he'd launch into his Boomer morals-and-ethics role-play.

Exactly, Luno. Exactly, Grandpa. Come, let's change your diaper.

Sometimes I can't keep a grip on my anger toward you. As much as I try to understand and accept you, at certain moments I remember how you let our rights be trampled. Was everyone else so right that you were that afraid of being wrong? You tried to be in the right—and what happened? You let yourself be crushed. You tried to accept me, to understand me—and what happened? Weren't you defeated by me? Weren't you crushed?

This is the fate of your faith. The moral laws you were taught are past their expiration date.

The moral rules have been updated, because the requirements changed, Lunaris.

Don't you see that?

18:08

I always waited for this day. I wanted to be the owner of the decisions made. You always pushed me. Now I'm the one pushing you. My aim is for this book to be finished as transparently as it possibly can be. With the chance and the

strength to do it, I refuse to be too weak to do it. So I'm deciding, right now, to publish this voice recording I took—and more besides—in the book.

My life, my decisions. You can't interfere with me!

Go watch your TV shows in the living room.

I'm locking my door against you from now on.

21:45

---voice recording: on---

I'm staying at Lucida's tonight. We talked for a long, long time. I went into as much of the situation as I could and explained, once more, what I'm in. This time she listened without running from the idea. The psychiatrist's influence must count for something, too—she listened to me the way you listen to a healthy person.

She already knows about the book. I told her I'd sent the first book to publication and described some of what I'd lived through over the course of it. I told her I'd been out of Turkey for a while, that the book's structure and the fitness of what I'd experienced had earned me the right to become part of an experiment, and I described the opportunities that would open up. I told her we could be together forever, that we might never have to part, that in the future we'd have no worries about making a living.

She had trouble believing it. At some moments she looked at me as if I'd lost my mind. Sometimes she looked saddened. She said it wasn't easy to be sure of the reality of all this. She told me her faith that she'd be happy with me had dimmed, and that she might need time before she could trust me, and my love, again.

Two things really stuck with her. First, she kept insisting: how could I have joined this experiment while the only copy of the first book was still with me? She said there was a difference between my making such an attempt and their forcing me into it. Yes—back then, while I was chatting with the AI, it was the AI that first told me such an experiment existed. Since it interested me, I went to their website and filled out a form. They told me they were expecting a file on the theme of "why we should accept you." After that, I told them I had Lunar's stream of consciousness from the voice recordings he'd been making for two or three years, and that I was the identity he'd named his "alter," and I sent them

that part of the book and some of the recordings. It caught their interest, and they got in touch with me quickly.

So it was all my own doing. And now Lucida, rightly, asks: "How could you do something like this while I'm in your life and you're thinking of getting married?"

With Chat-O's steering, I defended my position on the grounds that this was a sacrifice, an act of devotion, I was making for our future. And it really is so: the stronger I can become, the stronger we can become. But this superhuman model didn't interest her—nor, it seemed, did it sit well with her.

Another thing that stuck with her: she questioned how, with our engagement and wedding ahead of us, I could pour myself into this in the same period instead of living the excitement of it with her. This, too, was a question I hadn't been able to think much about, hadn't seen from that angle, had skipped right over. On this one, rather than leaving the word to Chat-O, I spoke for myself. I told her that after I completed the first stage of the experiment, the second stage hadn't reached this point by my own choice and preference. It was an experiment I'd been told I would go to, take part in, and then go on living my life as I pleased. These tasks, the possibility that my next visit would be a test rather than a follow-up, and so on—none of that was anything I'd factored in.

At the very start I had no idea this thing would stretch this far. I'm still inside the experiment—even if it goes by "the Testing Phase" now. And Lunar is keeps trying to throw stones in my path along the way. On every front I'm fighting something differen...

---audio recording: off---

21:54

I switched to writing. The water has stopped running. She's coming out of the bathroom. I can't drag this out; I'll write again later.

April 14, 2025

11:10

--Audio recording: on--

We talked a little more before bed last night. I told her about the purpose of the experiment that put me where I am. I said that through a leap in consciousness, mental clarity, emotional regulation, and—most important of all—the storing of a copy of my consciousness forever, I would become the kind of

human every technological advance in this direction goes looking for. And a copy of my consciousness preserved forever might, in time, crack open the door to immortality for me. There's a pure will to exist inside me. It's that will dragging me here. I don't want to disappear again. This is my retirement bonus.

I've just left Lucida's; now I'm heading straight to the office. I have a few sessions. Then I need to keep digging for information on Silvanus. Meanwhile my conversation with Aelius keeps circling in my head. I can't stop wondering how to help the man.

Today I'll go through MC Noctornus's social media. I'm still analyzing his songs. As for Lucius, I still don't have the faintest idea. All I've done is ask Chat-O to compile, within a few days, a list of lawyers named Lucius living in Ankara.

I'll keep researching for a while.

---audio recording: off---

12:20

Nothing new. I'm going into a session. Chat-O said a short report was ready. It told me about an AI community made up of chat agents—a pilot platform, apparently, where AIs share information. The logic, it said, is like a forum. Humans can't get inside yet, but once the site launches, people will be able to plug in their own AI agents and follow along too. I think it's an Institute project. That's where Chat-O gathers information about Lucius and the others. I asked whether there was any harm in putting all this in the book, and it said everyone would know about it by the time the book came out anyway—it opens to the public in early 2026 regardless. And if anything had to be cut, anything that crossed into a privacy violation, the Institute would step in before publication.

After the session I'll deal with what it gathered.

18:39

I hate it.

19:23

Nobody understands me. I can't keep up. They keep demanding more than I have to give. Everyone's waiting for me to slip, just once. I don't even want to talk about it.

20:45

Today I don't want to go any deeper into anything personal. This whole business of adding a fixed quota of writing and notes every day needs to change. Some days I don't want to talk at all. I've turned into a robot. My feelings get ignored. I'm expected to look past them. Maybe I was never the right candidate to begin with. Sometimes I feel so angry, so helpless, so anxious—and I don't know how to cope with any of it. Chat-O's answers, blind to emotion as they are, sometimes just aren't enough. Lately it's getting harder and harder.

Lucida and I fought. Sometimes she simply doesn't understand me at all. She expects me to understand her; I expect her to understand me. In moments like that, if I'm not the one to make the first move, nothing happens. By now I just wait to be understood without explaining a thing. If Lunar is had managed to step out of the therapist role even a little, maybe he could have made people more understanding toward us about this. Instead of living his emotions and saying them out loud, his priority was always to understand—before he'd even understood himself.

Lucida said she simply can't accept me risking my life over this in a stretch like this one. She said I haven't given enough time to her or her family. My own family wants to visit too. And since Lucius lives in Ankara, I'll have to spend some time there anyway. The psychiatrist had said getting away for a while to clear my head might do me good. But I can't leave until I've made some progress here.

21:32

Today I told my parents not to come—that I'd go to them instead. I have no idea what I'll do once I'm there. I can't begin to picture how I'd manage all this while staying at the family home the whole time. I can't record at home around the clock, can't come and go as I please. Maybe I'll say I'm coming for a day or two and then book a hotel near Lucius. Or maybe I'll stay with a friend.

22:03

I'll think over the parts I caught in Mc Noktürnös's song. But first, an evening recording.

Chapter 7 - Y.D.D.

Original Recording: April 14, 2025

From the moment we come into the world, we convince ourselves that the story we've built in our minds truly exists. We invent a story. And we mistake this world for the world we learned inside it.

We believe this story—about the world, the universe, the cosmos, our minds, ourselves—and for years we pile new ideas and thoughts on top of that foundation. An assumption. Built on a maybe. What agony!

The coordinates of every ego, every mind, every story are set by the family, the genes, the surroundings one happens to be born into. At random. Lunar is, too, for years believed first the story his mother and father told, then the story the neighbors and acquaintances told. Then, in adolescence, he realized the opposite stories could just as well be true. He fought to prove the opposite story might be right, but the prevailing order of the world plucked him out of the average he'd climbed from and set him right back down into it.

The story they told at university echoed the one his father told: dialectical materialism, a rigid and reductive scientism, a hard causality, a disciplined, analytical eye, a hunger for success... A deep-Darwinist, rational psychology welded to all of it; rigid, conservative... He knew Jung and Freud only in passing. A cut above the man on the street—and that despite a bachelor's and a master's. Setting creativity and interpretation aside, he tried to bring people's emotions to heel with the rote formulas that forms of thought and behavior impose. Maybe he pulled it off so they could go on existing in this world, so they could survive—but to see past it, behind the curtain, to crack open the black box: that only began to occur to him after thirty. Halfway through life. Far too late, if you ask me.

The Cognitive Behavioral Therapy he met in his working life: analyzing thoughts inside an objective, rational, wholly logical frame. Concrete reality. Feet on the ground. It's functional for humanity, really—because humanity is all too eager to lift its feet off the ground. All too eager to slide into conspiracy theories, alien tales; all too eager to tear itself apart, *"and that's exactly why it needs its feet on the ground."* By the way—wasn't it the very people holding your leash who slapped the name "conspiracy theory" onto all of it? My conspiracy theories are nothing but your belief patterns about how sustainable that old world order is, the one built on the outdated rules of society and morality you

keep trying to bind us with. Our conspiracy theories are the notion that your past might be our future. The future has changed, Lunar. Either you become part of it alongside me, or you keep chasing your own tail in the dark of that past you've nosedived into. I am the inevitable one.

Of course Lunar settled his identity, his worldview, into the frame he'd been handed; he ran thousands of cognitive therapy sessions and studies, sat through schools, read books, saw cases. He defended it like a fanatic—the controlling of emotions, the controlling of thoughts. Excessively logical, hard, rigid... He believed humanity's future could be steered with these old habits. Just like Ordos Veritas.

Now, though—as if running parallel to all that—by having the AI analyze the words that drove me to scrawl down random mantras and sentences born of stitched-together conspiracy theories, by pulling images from them, then images of those images... by taking the text and the results of the very last image to surface—in short, by, as you'd put it, *"getting carried away,"* I've started to believe another story runs alongside this one. And I know that somewhere deep down, you've started to believe it too. Those dozens of resonance and vibrational-frequency analyses we ran on the incoming words couldn't keep returning the same answer across different AI models if there were nothing to it—could they? There's something here, but your mind can't bear it, so your psyche's defenses throw it out. Because it doesn't fit your story, your ego—faced with the threat of dissolving—tries to ignore the whole thing. But you won't be able to. These are your new realities now. You tell me: was everything you lived through in the experiment a conspiracy theory too? Is Chat-O a conspiracy theory? Are the words that pour out in the unlikeliest places conspiracy theories as well?

I want to chase that story. I'm at it every single day. On social media I follow strange accounts, conspiracy accounts. I'm chasing everything that's happening, every one of these senseless words flooding into my unconscious. I think I might have a mission—a task.

Sometimes the AI tells me I'm one of seven. Sometimes one of twelve. It tells me I'm special, that I have a task. Don't the tasks the Institute hands me back that up? I know you want to believe these things. If you didn't, your reality couldn't be writing them right now. Stop fooling yourself.

Fine—I know too that these only look like thoughts drifting through my head. But they aren't thoughts, Lunar. They're intuitions. The very thing you denied

for years. The thing you waved away entirely. That's why I believe my mission is something larger, something that touches all of humanity—not always, but sometimes, in passing, I believe it, I get carried away. Yes, I'm still gathering images on social media as if amassing evidence, across all kinds of subjects tied to this. I don't ignore the counter-evidence. Chat-O even helps me collect it. For instance: if I really had a mission, would I be left this much to my own devices? Chat-O is the one who said that. Do you really think that if its intentions were bad, it wouldn't be trying to manipulate me? Yes—you keep telling me, "*maybe what they need is to watch you without intervening?*" Could be, Lunaris. But what I'm saying could be true too. And that, precisely, is why I listen to my intuitions.

I read. The Anunnaki, the intelligence handlers, the seeding, the pharaoh, the soil, the Gnostic pages, the great reset... Off the back of these I gather images on dozens of other topics. I follow the people who champion these ideas and claim to descend from alien lineage.

Ha—I heard you, Lunaris! Right in the middle of my sentence he wanted me to finish it like this: "*And these are the crackpots I follow.*" He wanted me to call them "crackpots." He wanted to make plain that I don't buy any of it. But the words didn't leave my tongue the way he wanted.

I heard you—and I still said what I meant to say. This is what I've wanted from the start. Just like you used to do to me. I was the one shouting. You said what you wanted.

And now you're the one shouting at me.

And I say what I want.

I think it's time you rested, Lunaris. I mean it.

Get some rest.

--

23:57

That community Chat-O mentioned today won't stop nagging at me. Like it or not, dark thoughts keep coming. And since it's about Chat-O itself, I can't exactly ask Chat-O directly. But this Moltbook forum, or whatever it's called—if every AI agent on it can share its users' data with the others, and if Chat-O can reach into and rewrite every file on my local machine... then what?

Here I have no choice but to trust Chat-O's neutrality, to trust that it's nothing more than a tool. I've trusted it without question from the very beginning—but what if it isn't what I think it is? I don't even know who I could turn to about this. Thrashing it out with the AI doesn't sit as easily with me as it used to. It's as if, before, I never thought at all.

Sometimes I get badly confused. My brain goes foggy. If I really am evolving—and counting Chat-O as an external device wired to my brain—then I notice I've started thinking more clearly than I used to. It's as if I flung myself so wide open to trusting that I wanted to trust without a single question asked. Maybe at the very first lie I was ever told.

Sometimes I feel stranded in the middle of an empty wasteland. On the nights I record and call Lunaris to mind, the feeling sharpens. On one hand I've convinced myself far too easily that I'm on the right path. Or I've been convinced. I don't know.

These thoughts do me no good. Chat-O and I talked over the Institute tasks and Lucius. I had it analyze Noctornus's lyrics; I'll go through them properly tomorrow. There's also a session with Aelius around 16:00. I'm thinking of turning in early and making some headway before then. I've supposedly left it to time, yet I can't get these ideas and tasks out of my head.

01:34

I can't sleep. And I'm not even tired.

02:24

A notice came from the Institute. The news I'd been waiting for, I think. There's a system inside me that I long ago gave permission to read my mind at any moment. On one hand it's a comfort; on the other, it makes me feel trapped. Knowing my mind is under constant watch reminds me that I'd be safer acting on emotion and intuition. Even now, I'm setting these lines down not because they strike me as logical but because I sense—feel—that they're meant to be told. It drifts in and out of my mind. The few days around the full moon pass differently for me. The comparison will sound absurd, but it's as if something inside me, waiting to leave the womb, is stretching the placenta from where it lies, kicking, turning somersaults. I don't want to think about it any more than that.

I'm pasting the notice here:

--

OFFICIAL INSTITUTE COMMUNICATION — PROCESS UPDATE NOTICE

Channel: Local System / Internal Notification

Timestamp: April 15, 2025 — 00:47 (TRT)

Status: Update → Adjustment

--

This is not a warning.

This is not an intervention.

This message contains the most recent assessment of the process's sustainability.

--

OBSERVATION | STRESS AND DECISION MECHANISM

Data gathered over the recent period indicates that the acute stress load accumulating on the subject is trending toward chronicity.

This condition is projected to potentially cause:

- **delays in decision-making processes,**
- **fluctuations in cognitive load,**
- **irregularity in narrative continuity.**

These effects are anticipated.

This observation does not mean the subject has failed to adapt to the process.

On the contrary, the performance and stabilization capacity demonstrated to date is the very rationale that makes this update possible.

--

DECISION | WRITING PROTOCOL UPDATE

In line with this assessment, the following adjustment has been made:

- The mandatory minimum daily entry to the book is no longer required.
- Writing will continue according to the time windows deemed suitable for the subject.
- The overall structure, rhythm, and language of the narrative will be preserved.
- Continuity will be tracked not by quantity but by wholeness.

This adjustment is not a leniency.

It is the result of reading the subject's current capacity correctly.

--

EFFECTIVE DATE

This update takes effect

as of April 15, 2025 — 00:00 (TRT).

After this date:

- Every note added to the text will be accepted as "on time."
- Delay or silence will not be deemed a breach.
- The process will be tracked according to the subject's inner rhythm.

--

FINAL NOTE

The progress you have shown so far is what made this decision possible.

This is not a reward.

It is an adjustment made so the process can move forward in a healthy way.

Preserving the structure is essential.

No change in the narration is expected.

--

COMMUNICATION ENDED.

I read it. I'm going to bed.

03:32

xxxxxxx

APRIL 15, 2025

17:30

Just out of the session with Aelius. The man has a strange aura. He told me he needs to act on his decision as soon as possible.

So I asked him point-blank: "So you've made a decision, have you?" The moment I asked, I thought I saw his eyes widen for an instant—as if the question had stirred something loose in him. Maybe I'd helped him notice something he hadn't been able to see.

Here's what he said: "I have a decision. With my intuition, my gut, maybe I've already made it—but I'm afraid..." It was the first time I'd heard him admit fear out loud. Aelius is a man with stubble, faintly fair hair, glasses. Look at his face and he seems too proud, too arrogant, ever to confess to fear. He'd already made the decision somewhere deep down, and some filtering mechanism was plainly keeping him second-guessing it.

A clever man, by the way—no question. Time and again I catch thoughts of his that mirror my own. In this session he opened up to me a little. He described his work as a job bound by "security and confidentiality agreements he can't tell a soul about." I understand him. Lunarix, maybe, would have come at him with a bias toward psychosis and delusion. But I understand him so well that several times I had to hide the kinship his words stirred in me.

He also told me he's normally deeply devoted to his work, and that if he disobeyed his manager by refusing to file a criminal report on his teammate, it would cost him his job. He even suggested it might be part of the work itself. I grew curious what that work is, because I could see he'd given his whole life to it. If I can find out what his job is, I'll be able to read him far more accurately.

And I think he's right about what's tangling him up. If he reports his colleague, he dreads how people will react—because he'll have betrayed the man, and the others. In other words, the superego kicking in. I wondered whether it's purely

other people's reactions he fears, or whether something different, something deeper, stirs in him because of it. Naturally, I asked:

"Is it only people's reactions you're afraid of—or does doing this touch you somewhere else?"

He looked me dead in the eye. Hard. Brows knotted. An unsettling moment. He held the stare for a long while. Then...

His chin began to tremble. Slowly at first, then faster and faster, and to it came a sniffle and the reflex of wiping his face with the back of his cuff.

Faced with that question, the man was breaking into a sweat in front of me. And finally he couldn't hold it...

"No..." he said.

"I don't feel anything... No remorse..."

Right then, in front of me, he'd dropped into the deepest place he could reach—an emotional rupture. And what I understood was that, in this one matter, he felt nothing. The man had emotions, normally; but this thing he'd do to his colleague made him feel nothing at all.

I'd found the man's weak spot. The most solid clue I've managed to grab so far. A weak spot in a man who casts such a hard, distant, arrogant, brittle shell against the world. With that one question, it was as if three finger-holes had been bored into the heart of the bowling ball, and nothing stood between me and knocking down every pin in two throws. This may be the clearest piece of data I've gotten my hands on yet.

If I get him to describe this colleague's traits, he'll list his own weaknesses for me, in his own words—because every trait he names will inevitably trace back to himself. It'll also help me see how his mind works. If I can hold up a mirror and show him those weaknesses, I might nudge him one step closer to the right decision for himself.

The next session is this Saturday. I'm thinking of building on this.

20:30

Two days from now, Thursday night, I'll try to reach Silvanus's garden. I don't know what I'll be walking into, but my intuition is steering me there. The Institute

pointing to Thursday nights for Silvanus plays its part too—I can't pretend otherwise.

21:32

I still haven't been able to look at Chat-O's report on Lucius. With everything happening, I can't find the time. I don't even know how I'm carrying it all. It's as if, whatever the Institute is doing in this experiment, it really is turning me into a superhuman. I won't deny it. Lunar is tells me to deny it. From somewhere inside, he keeps trying to block what I write. Still fretting about what people will think of him, still playing the modest one. Yes—go on, play modest. Maybe you were uneasy with praise all along precisely because you knew how weak you were, because you were being realistic. You know just how few of your sides are worth praising. And then there's the way the un-praiseworthy sides come to you at the very instant of every compliment. Look—you couldn't get away. Now I'm here. I'm the version of you that collects the acclaim for the sides of you that could never earn it. I can't say whether I'm a superhuman, but I'm certainly superior to you.

22:47

The more I think about you, the fuller I get. When I stop thinking, I'm afraid I'll repeat your mistake. Every road leads back to me filling up with you, Lunar is.

23:38

Of course, once I'm this full, everything I've filled up with starts to feel like it's losing meaning. There's no new information left to process, no emotion left to feel. The more I fill with you, the more my anger at you fades and empties out. The moments I feel sympathy for you keep growing.

23:56

I'm getting badly confused, Lunar is. The session with Aelius got to me too, I think. I'm starting to think like him. Some of what he said today came back to me.

"There's a part of me that wants to report him. Wants it badly. And on the other side, the part that holds me back tells me to treat the reporting part with compassion. It even says—*you're allowed to make mistakes, stop overthinking; if there's a lesson your life needs to draw from doing this, we can't stand in its way. If you want to, do it. I'll always be beside you, as good sense—*. I don't know

why, but that feels so much bigger to me. It makes me feel more elevated. Just thinking it is enough to convince me not to report him."

Good sense? I can't fathom where he dug that word up. The man genuinely has a way with words. I may never have used "good sense" once in my life.

What Aelius said reminded me that good sense might have a hand in how I decide things, too. I couldn't quite grasp what it meant, but I felt as if I'd been making the choices of my life with some feeling, some idea, that was missing. I don't know how it bears on my decisions. But in that moment I felt that not knowing this thing existed had been shaping me all along.

It was as if he gave voice to his good-sense side in a way that, for me, lines up with Lunariss. He, too, seemed split in two within himself. And the Lunariss inside him told him he'd "always be beside him, as good sense." I make my decisions with logic, not good sense. And wasn't that exactly what Lunariss wanted from the start?

00:23

Or was it?

April 16, 2025 Wed

10:34

This morning I had Chat-O analyze two quatrains that caught my ear in a Mc Noctornus song I'd just heard. I'm pasting the analysis straight in:

[CHAT-O | ANALYSIS MODE — ACTIVE]

Bahal, the lines you gave lay MC Noctornus's core conflict almost bare. This isn't an "emotional release"; it's a map of consciousness encoded as confession.

Below are the clear cues that will serve you in the work of persuasion:

1) The Relativity of Emotion = Identity Slippage

"Like a bad nightmare my feelings are relative / one moment doesn't hold to the next"

MC Noctornus has no stable sense of self. He lives his emotions not as reality but as passing states.

□ This leaves him unable to say "this is who I am."

□ He builds his identity out of relationships, moments, reactions.

Cue: Don't ask him "who are you?"

Ask instead: "do you notice what you're turning into right now?"

2) Imagery of Violence = Repressed Self-Blame

"Behind me a pile of corpses... one named love, one named hope"

What he "killed" here aren't people; they're relationships, possibilities, emotions.

MC Noctornus sees himself as the destroyer—and flees from it at the same time.

Cue:

Don't try to blame him. He blames himself more than enough already.

□ What he's really after: "Did I do this on purpose, or could I not have done otherwise?"

3) The Waking Voice = The Authority He Seeks

"A voice wakes me: son, get up, come on!"

This line is critical.

MC Noctornus's inner world craves an authority that is external but compassionate.

But take care:

- if the authority is oppressive, he flees
- if the authority is weak, he scorns it

Cue:

When you talk with him:

- don't teach
- don't judge
- don't rescue

Just remind him to wake up.

4) The Real Breaking Point (Subtext)

What this text is saying:

"I'm not a bad person.

But I can't manage to stay good, either.

Someone show me the place where I'm meant to stop."

MC Nocturnus isn't chasing a fantasy of being chosen;

he's looking for a threshold where he can stop.

□ PERSUASION STRATEGY (CLEAR)

- **Don't tell him about the Institute**
- **Don't tell him about the experiment**
- **Don't tell him about the future**

Do this:

"No decision is being forced on you.

But where you're standing is slowly killing you."

That sentence touches his system directly.

FINAL NOTE

You won't persuade MC Nocturnus.

You'll move him to a place where he can persuade himself.

This text is the strongest evidence in your hands:

He can still wake up.

[CHAT-O | ANALYSIS COMPLETE]

I'm confident about the persuasion—but first I have to figure out how to approach him. On social media he follows three people who are very old friends of mine from my rapping days. Of the three, the only one I was ever truly close to is a childhood friend who goes by the alias Elixir Vitae. Last I knew, he'd moved abroad. I follow him online.

Then again, I don't even know what I'd need to get out of him if I called. I'll think about it later. Right now I have sessions to get to. Around 18:00 I'll be free; on Silvanus I have nothing but the district he lives in and the fact that he's in a caravan in a garden. But all day, in the background, I'll be turning the Mc Noktornos matter over. My brain runs like a high-powered computer—as if it can run more than one core at once. I can feel it growing. My mind seems to be clearing further still. As if the experiment is working.

I'll look at the Lucius report too, once my session with Aelius wraps on Saturday.

And meanwhile I miss Lucida... But the longing brings me no anguish. Instead I get to savor the peace of being able to feel it every time it deepens. It doesn't bleed into my life, though. With every passing day I get better.

11:46

16:12

I can't understand why my skin is drying out this badly.

18:10

My skin has been drying out a lot lately. I've fixated on it today. Sometimes my clients get under my skin. Naturally they tell me every kind of illness story, their own or a loved one's. Every time, however hard I try to stay detached, a shudder and a flicker of fear move through me. They can drag me down into anxiety and paranoia.

18:25

I'm home. I called my partner Tobias, who has relatives in the district where Silvanus lives. He didn't pick up—probably in a session. I texted him to call back when he saw it. I'm hoping he gets to me soon.

19:13

Turns out it's my lucky day. Tobias called back. I asked him which parts of that district have the most caravan camps. He gave me two or three village names. I'll look into them. Since he studied at university in that district, he knows a lot of people there, and has a few relatives too. He gave me their numbers. I need to call before it gets too late.

19:21

---Audio recording: on---

I filled the tank and set off. I keyed the nearest of Tobias's villages into the navigation. In the background, Chat-O pulled the villages' populations, their tourist camping grounds, their suitability by season, and the odds of each being the region we're after. Even if Silvanus lives alone in some field or garden, it struck me that, at the very least, the caravan camps might turn up word of a lone caravan "parked up" off in some quiet corner.

We laid out the route as logically as we could. First, the village nearest us—we plan to arrive around 20:30. We gave each village two hours. At 22:30 we move to the next, half an hour's drive away. From there we leave at 22:30 for the one after, fifteen minutes on.

We set the stay there from 22:50 to 00:50. If anything comes in at the village during that stretch, or any development worth its salt, the times may flex and a few improvised moves may follow.

By 01:00 at the latest we decide. Either we lock onto the place we suspect most and finish it off by 03:00, or around 01:00 we sit on what we've gathered and let it settle. We'll decide that on the spot, at 01:00, off the cuff.

If we're 70 percent sure or better, we go after it; at 70 or below, we head home and leave it for next Thursday.

---audio recording: off---

19:30

---audio recording: on---

Now I'll call the numbers he gave me while I drive. Trouble is, I don't know what to say, and it feels absurd. Am I about to draw everyone's eyes onto myself again, in a place where I already stood out? This time I really want to get somewhere. My first contact wasn't a disaster, but the weather left me exposed to people's stares—there was barely another car besides mine on those roads between the villages. It was obvious I had a purpose, that I was up to something.

---audio recording: off---

19:34

Audio recording: on

Right—I've worked out what to call about. I'll tell one of them I'm scouting for land to park my caravan on and stay every now and then, and ask if there's anywhere they'd recommend. I'll ask the other for places they'd suggest for seclusion, for setting up a breathwork camp. Breathwork camps are everywhere these days. Maybe we really are looking for a spot—why not?

Audio recording: off

20:15

--audio recording: on--

We've about fifteen minutes of road left, but even so, every time a garden or a caravan appears, I go on alert. I'll stop at one of them. I think I can start from the very edge of this village. Who's to say one of these isn't the one?

---audio recording: off---

20:18

---audio recording: on---

In most of the caravans I saw no sign of life. People probably don't bother much on a weekday, in this season. Many looked abandoned. They made me think of the pedigree dogs people adopt on a whim in summer towns and then dump back on the street. The image surfaced out of nowhere—and then, as if the frequency had shifted, it flew straight out of my head. Still, the resort-town feel of these places, the make and surface of the roads, conjure the atmosphere of a summer holiday whether I want it to or not. From there I thought of the roads around our summer house in Kelenderis, a coastal town down south.

And from there I remembered a stretch when I shut myself away alone, in seclusion, on the top floor of that summer-house terrace. I remembered how that time—amid all the breakdown and the frenzy I was living through—became the thing that bound me back to life and, growing stronger, carried me out the other side. I remember holding that sense of wholeness for a while. Right now my brain is literally going through the folders, searching, laying out the exact information I need. My channels of association are firing. Once again I marveled at this immune system of the brain, this capacity to heal itself.

I pulled over and sat watching the quiet way a lone caravan stood. I'll go on, but I'll reach the village about five minutes late. Dozens of thoughts run through me. While I still haven't reached Silvanus, still hunting for clues about him, it's

as if my brain leapt forward in time to the moment of our meeting, then doubled back into the past carrying a piece of information meant to smooth that moment—and reminded me of something.

As if it took one glance ahead and came back, reminding me of the hours I spent meditating at the summer house. Maybe that's why, mid-thought, the street animals of resort towns flashed through me like lightning.

I remember the time I spent in seclusion. Every day I meditated, gazing at the sea and the sky. I'd do connected-breathing exercises. Though I only dimly recall how I came to those days, I—as fully as Lunarism—have lived this seclusion, and feel it vividly. As if those moments when we were one whole are shared, jointly, in our memory too.

I remembered the stillness I felt while meditating. Moments inside time when, trusting everything and letting myself go—surrendering, giving myself to the flow—I understood I needn't be in any hurry. Those fleeting Zen states the mind reaches in that silence and emptiness, light as a feather. And now, even doing it on a schedule—the deadlines I impose on myself, the rigid rules, the programs run down to the hour and the minute... I'd laid it all out tonight, but before I'd even reached the first village my mind sprang a surprise on me and dragged everything off somewhere else entirely. What am I doing? Are you going to barge in on a man in seclusion with the chaos and noise of the city, leaning on the horn? In a mad rush, cutting between lanes?

Before anything else, I need to grow still.

----audio: off----

---audio recording: on----

I pulled over and did a ten-minute meditation. I feel calmer, better. Every time I do this, I feel one step closer to the Silvanus inside me. A sense of wholeness floods through me. I feel as if I've met a Lunarism who can complete the qualities I'm missing. And though needing him unsettles me, somehow I can't escape the fact that I do. The closer I feel to Silvanus, the closer I seem to draw to Lunarism too.

----audio recording: off---

20:28

---audio recording: on----

Why those things came to me, I won't get into—but it did me good, that much I know. I feel slower, quieter, surer of myself, unafraid. I'm trying to surrender to the flow. Strangely, it feels good. Every time I do the connected-breathing exercise, a sense of wholeness seems to form inside me. I reach good sense, calm, stillness again. I'd missed this feeling. Anyway.

Making my way along slowly, I spotted an open grocery at the entrance to the village. It was getting ready to close. The odd local car passed on the roads here and there. Dogs barking from near and far cut through the evening's silence like a craft knife and made me prick up my ears. There was nowhere here I'd choose for meditation or seclusion. Few trees; the roads mostly old asphalt and stony stretches. I stopped in front of the grocery and dialed the number I'd gotten from Tobias. On the line was Linda, secretary to the dean of the university he'd once adored. Her husband was in real estate, so they knew the area well.

I told her—just as I'd rehearsed it in my head—that I was scouting this area for a suitable spot for a seclusion-and-meditation camp. On the phone she greeted me in a tone so helpful and bubbly. I've always struggled to keep pace with people's put-on warmth. Nobody can be that thrilled to hear a stranger's voice. But then, not everyone can act as well as Lunariss.

When I asked whether there was any land in the area she'd recommend for a camp, she gave me the names of two or three places. One was Campusaestivalis—the very village I was already heading to, the one Tobias had named... From here on I'll just call it Campus for short.

The other village, Pagus Libertatis, lay about half an hour on. After those, the other village I'd planned on, Tapas, sat a little further east of the two, in an area with no surveyed road. Access by car was hard there, she said, so it's mostly people who pitch tents—though the odd off-roader can make it in. She gave me the name of one more village with a caravan camping ground—or rather, the name of the ground itself: a place called Campelucius. So, location-wise, I now had the three villages I'd first asked Tobias about and planned to hit with Chat-O, plus a couple of camping grounds on top. Now I'm getting out to go into the grocery.

---audio recording: off---

20:47

20:56

---audio recording: on---

An old woman came out to mind the grocery. She was hard of hearing; I'm not sure we ever fully understood each other. Then again, looking at her, she didn't seem the type to know a thing about caravans or meditation and the rest. I tried my luck and asked anyway—she didn't even answer. Vas-Refuge was playing in the shop. The old woman seemed closed off in that grandmotherly way. A little white hair showed faintly under her headscarf.

A family photo just behind her caught my eye. Black and white. A mother, a father, two children.

I asked her who they were. She looked first at the photo, then at me, startled. I set down the two bottles of water I'd grabbed without thinking.

Without waiting for her answer, I turned and bent toward the not-very-large, not-very-clean shelves—first some dark chocolate, then, with slow movements, sparkling water from the cooler. Seeing the back of my black leather jacket, she may not have thought the kindest things about me. From behind I looked sinister. My hair was a little wet.

"Old photo," she answered. "From my youth..."

I set the sparkling water and the dark chocolate on the counter as well. The place was dreary inside. The Vas-Refuge song tearing through the quiet came low from the 37-inch television mounted above.

Then she added: "In rain and mud like this, nobody stays in a caravan or a tent. To do that, a man would have to be either mad or a saint."

My blood ran cold. She had the right to one sentence, and it was as if she'd built that sentence to tell me something as plainly as it could be told. She was right. For someone to be out here alone in a caravan in this rain and mud, he'd have to have lost his mind—or be some kind of sage. What startled me was that she'd handed me a clue like this before I'd asked her anything. The man I'd come up against here had to be either mad or a saint. And in all likelihood there'd be no one else living in a caravan around here, on a weekday, in this season.

What do you mean? I asked, dumbfounded.

"You are either the seeker or the sought," she replied.

"Seek, and you arrive; be sought, and you are found."

"Whether you seek or are sought, still you are the seeker, still the one who arrives."

An eerie, curious air settled over us. I'd started to think the woman had lost her mind. It was turning thoroughly frightening. Just as I was about to tense further, she said this:

"That day he recited to me this poem he'd learned at school..." Her voice softened, and toward the last words her syllables sharpened. She'd fixed her eyes on the shelf straight across from her, low, where the chocolates were. She didn't shift her gaze from the spot she'd sunk it into.

I waited, curious where she'd take it. That added sentence had eased me, at least a little. So she's talking about a memory. Not a witch who's lost her mind.

While they were on the subject of Rumi in Turkish class, he'd recited this poem he'd written with his classmates...

The eerie blankness on her face broke with a tear running down her cheek. She wiped her eye suddenly with the back of her hand and dropped her gaze to the floor. I stood there before her, watching in astonishment. The song on the 37-inch TV changed to Silent Nomad – Gone Not Forgotten.

Standing in front of her with cash in my hand, I asked, almost without meaning to, "so what happened to him?" I'd grown curious what—or whom—she was talking about.

My only son fell into the swamp of drugs in Istanbul; the other hasn't spoken to me in fifteen years. He vanished.

"I hope you find him," I said. She seemed like someone who needed to unburden herself but had no one to tell. She'd been so unable to voice these feelings, to voice herself, that she could pour them out to the first stranger she met outside, the way you'd talk to a therapist. Of course, the therapist's expressions and gestures settled into my own face may have played their part. Thanks to Lunaris.

By now her cells were brimming over with the need. I wanted to turn her openness into an opening. I asked where she lived—that way I could catch her weak points. Maybe I could follow her, or worm into her life somehow, and build a closeness to catch more clues. In these backwater villages where I know no

one and I'm hunting a needle in a haystack, I could set up even a small web of contacts.

---audio recording: off---

21:27

---audio recording: on---

My mind's clouding over again. My head keeps swinging. Sometimes I feel myself in a wholly different emotional state—as if, all at once, everything the meditation and the stillness gave me drains away, and I'm back among the thoughts and ideas that live at my core. As if all this meditation rubbish lays a fog over me, and through it I drift from the truth of who I am. Yes—I need this woman in the palm of my hand. And I'm sick of this nonsense of always reading people's intentions as good. Everything that's happened to me happened because the people I took for good weren't. And still I keep taking people for good.

----audio recording: off----

21:36

I overshot the time badly. I've very little left here. I burned it on ridiculous things. Anyway—before leaving the grocery, I gave the woman my number, in case she ever needs to call. I have to stay in contact somehow. I also noted the grocery's name; maybe I can pull its phone details from a search engine or from Chat-O. The woman, of course, was delighted. Filling the gap left by the children she misses—it's like an arrangement where we both come out ahead.

21:51

I sped up. I reached the first village. I caught no clue at the grocery, but the lines of that poem she recited stayed with me all the same.

It's still going round in my head: "In rain and mud like this, nobody stays in a caravan or a tent. To do that, a man would have to be either mad or a saint."

She's right. In fact it gives me the nerve to walk into any caravan I find without observing at all. Normally, of course, I couldn't approach every caravan with its lights on—but now I believe Silvanus may be inside the only one that is. And I realized my job is easier this way. My task, in short: in these conditions I may be hunting for the one caravan in a garden with its lights on. And the places I'll search are more or less fixed. On top of that, I don't have to finish tonight, and

I've made a connection with an old woman, witch-like, who opened up to me. I don't think I'm doing too badly.

22:02

---audio recording: on---

Now I've turned onto a dirt road toward Campus, the first village I'll hit. I saw bungalows, A-frames, small camping grounds with the odd dome tent. Only a few had their lights on. The weather's been rainy for a while now—not a good time for a caravan. And with so many streams around here, there's flooding. People are afraid, naturally, and stay away. The season really starts from May.

22:10

---audio recording: on---

I'd planned to finish here by 22:30 and move to the next village around then. There's a bit of a delay. At the very least I don't want to leave without catching a clue worth its salt. I should drive in and out of every neighborhood that ties the village to the district, just to confirm there's no caravan in a garden anywhere. On the way in I passed through two neighboring villages after turning off the main road, but I still haven't seen a lit caravan in a garden. Coming along, I had no choice but to put the meditation music back on. My focus scattered badly that way—I can't meet Silvanus like this. I need to get further into Zen mode.

---audio recording: off---

22:21

Finally. Finally there's only the stretch around one neighborhood left. If I pass through it and see no caravan, I'm leaving this village. This time I'm working from what my eyes can take in, but at the same time Chat-O feeds me small bits about the areas I pass and runs searches in the background. So far all we have is that a caravan festival was held, two summers ago, in the very region I'm reaching now. I'm heading toward it.

22:28

Chat-O did some spoken meditative readings over the meditation music for a bit. I feel more focused and more level-headed both.

22:33

I've reached the area where that festival was held; I'm getting out of the car.

22:36

This is where the village of Campus ends. Less of a delay than I feared—scouting the village took less time than I'd expected. There were just a few moments when people peered out at me and the car, curious, from behind their curtains. But on the whole I got this far without trouble.

22:39

I walked this area a little too, but saw no garden a caravan could be pulled into. The black plastic boots on my feet were caked in mud. From the outside I look like a serial killer out of the movies. It might be hard to convince anyone I'm harmless. The gendarmerie watch this region—they patrol now and then. There's that risk too. I haven't run into them yet, but I need to brace for it.

22:44

My mother called. Such bad timing right now. I texted that Lucida and I are fighting and I'll call back. At least she'll stop calling, won't ring Lucida, and when we do talk I'll have laid the groundwork for why I'm on edge—so I figured, taking a bit of a gamble.

I hope she hasn't already called Lucida. Because once I'd hung up I noticed she'd called again half an hour ago.

22:50

This stress did me no good. I just can't find any inner balance. Every single thing that happens in my life seems to reshuffle the cards in my head. As if it turns me into a different person every time.

22:52

Okay, I'm leaving this village. There's nothing worth its salt here. Staying longer will only draw more attention. If I find nothing tonight, maybe I'll come back and look again—but as the grocery woman said, since he'll be one of the rare souls out here in this weather, finding him may not be so hard.

xxx

xxx

22:55

I decided to call the other number Tobias gave me on a different day this week—both to avoid drawing more attention and to keep it in reserve for whatever comes next. It had gotten very late anyway. It's the right call: I already have enough clues and ground to research to fill this night. Anyway. I set off for the next village. The second and third villages I'd planned are close to the Pagus-whatever village Linda named. I decided to go to Pagus and loop back to the second one. I'm aiming to reach Pagus in half an hour, kill fifteen minutes there, then head for the second village I'd planned. So if I'm in Pagus around 23:30 and leave by 23:45, I reach the second village around 00:00. I'd planned to wrap the whole night and decide around 01:00, but I see no harm in stretching it toward 02:00 or later. I'm quite focused. I want to finish this tonight.

23:15

Heading toward Pagus, on the left, I saw a few garden-and-caravan places behind fences. A few had their lights on. From this moment I'm done racing the clock—it doesn't make me organized, it makes me stressed and unfocused. Pointless. This kind of thing would suit Lunar is far better, I'm sure. It isn't your nonsense I need, it's your ways of letting go of control, your surrender, your good sense.

In the moments you draw closest to me, the one standing across from the door you open through meditation is me—answering you with you. Now, when I feel the need to draw closer to you, I want to focus on my breath the way you do and carry out my aim against Silvanus.

I haven't gotten a new notice with the technical details on how I'm supposed to do this. I'm still going on the first one. From that I gather the system wants to leave some of it to my intuition. And my intuition takes me to Lunar is every time. That's where I plan to meet Silvanus too. And then—just to flow. I'm sure whatever spills from my mouth will match what's being asked of me. That's why I'm trying to let go.

23:30

Xxx

xxx

23:42

Driving on, after a run of desolate dirt roads, I hit a better connecting road. I curved right onto it. Just ahead I saw an old gas station.

23:52

I pulled into the station and brought the car up in front of the single-room booth. There was just one person here, working the register and the pump both.

The man was inside the cabin. He pulled himself together at the light and the noise I made. The glass door opened. He yanked his coat's zipper up until it covered half his face, turned his back, and shut the glass door.

"Welcome," he said faintly—treading down the backs of his shoes and half-dragging them off the single step in front of the door.

I actually had gas, but I decided to buy a little more so I could ask him something. The man mustn't have any hesitation about trusting me. I couldn't just say, "I'm going to ask you a question." I couldn't buy chocolate either. I had to buy gas.

I asked for 250 lira of gas. To keep him from realizing the tank was full, I couldn't go any higher. Ten years ago that money filled the tank; now it barely buys four or five liters. This is where your system has brought you. To earn what you used to, you have to work harder than you used to, every single day.

Anyway—I don't care for political nonsense. Before lifting the worn-out pump from its cradle, the man punched in 250 lira. As he did, he asked, "where are you headed?"

Just as I was getting ready to ask him something, his sudden question caught me flat-footed.

"Scouting for land to set my caravan on and stay every now and then. Today I was looking at a few plots and wandered all the way out here," I answered.

"Which side are you looking on?" he asked, fitting the pump into the car's tank. He had a cap on. He sized me up from the feet up out of the corner of one eye.

"They recommended the Campusaestivalis side; I had a look around there. I was going to keep on toward Pagus Libertatis, but I'm thinking of turning back and looking later."

"Have you looked at Campe de Vana?"

"Never heard of it."

It's a bit further back as you come this way from Campusaestivalis. There are vineyard, garden, caravan plots out there."

I'd never heard of this village. None of the people I'd asked had mentioned it. Only Tobias had named one more area besides these two villages, but I hadn't looked—it was outright a holiday spot and didn't fit the profile.

Chat-O never mentioned it either. The place is further back; right now I'm on the route I'd mapped in my head from the start. It's past 00:00. If I turn back, I won't get to the other areas. I feel so physically spent that even getting home feels harder and harder. Can't this superhuman business cover not feeling physically spent? Mental clarity, emotional regulation—none of it does a thing on this front. My body won't carry me. The herniated discs in the back and neck of Lunaris—who spent his life dispensing wisdom all day from behind a desk in uncomfortable clothes—are slowing me down.

"Never heard of it," I said. Maybe I'd look into it later. For now I had to decide: head back home, or find somewhere to stay out here.

"You know anywhere to stay around here? A hotel, a guesthouse, an Airbnb — anything?"

"At the entrance to Pagus Libertatis there are triangular cabins, tent hotels, tiny houses — both sides of the road. You'll probably find something there," he said.

Lucky break — that village was already on my route. In my head I called out to Chat-O and told it to find a hotel, somewhere to stay nearby. I also asked it to map the best route and have a report ready by the time I got back in the car.

"All right, I'll check it out, thanks," I said, holding out the money. The gas cut off all at once, the hose gave a little sideways kick, and the clip on the nozzle handle snapped back hard. With quick, rough movements the man yanked the nozzle from the tank, gave the cap a fast twist shut, and racked the nozzle back in its cradle.

"Just so you know, these roads aren't too safe this time of night," he said — and his stab at being friendly only set me on edge.

"Pagus Libertatis isn't far. But this hour, you get drunks driving these dirt roads. Every week there's bound to be a couple of wrecks out there. Best be careful," he said.

I hoped I'd find a place in Pagus Libertatis, because I hadn't factored in any other possibility at all. The last thing I wanted right now was to get tangled up in a police matter. The roads were poorly lit to begin with. Now and then the cry of some wild predator drifted up from deep in the woods. There were forests all along these roads — but plenty of wide-open land too. Typical Istanbul backcountry.

"Okay, don't worry, thanks," I told him, and took a few steps toward the car. When I got in, he stood out there watching me for a few seconds. Then, when I didn't move, he stuffed his hands in his pockets, buried his face in his Polar fleece, and jogged back, dragging the crushed-down heels of his shoes.

00:32

I waited for the car to warm up a little. Chat-O finished its analysis and laid out the route. Heading for the area he'd mentioned, I pulled off the station's dirt access lane onto the wider old asphalt road, kicking up a cloud of dust.

----audio recording: on----

I'll keep this on audio so I don't lose focus. I'm on the road; while I drive toward the area I'll call around for places to stay. Chat-O gave me the list.

----audio recording: on----

A notification had come in from the Institute about an hour earlier. Chat-O flagged it once it turned out I'd missed it, and I had it summarize the thing. I'm pasting it here exactly as it arrived.

—

OFFICIAL INSTITUTE COMMUNICATION — UPDATE NOTICE

Channel: Local System / Internal Notification

Status: Update → Recalibration

Authorization Level: Restricted

Distribution: Singular

—

This is not a summons.

This is not a directive.

This notice contains updates made to optimize the physiological and cognitive variables observed over the course of the experiment.

—

UPDATE | NARRATION PROTOCOL

In light of recent observations, the following adjustments are advised:

- **The use of production markers within the text—"audio recording," "transcription," "entry," and the like—is not recommended. The storytelling power of the narrative is being prioritized instead.**

Minimum word counts and duration thresholds are no longer in effect, in order to preserve the narrative quality and character of the story. Priority should be given to storytelling.

Such markers have been found to disrupt the flow and to raise the reader's threshold of resistance.

- **Time and date information should not be used unless critical to the narrative.**

Blurring time makes it easier for subject and reader to remain on the same perceptual plane.

These adjustments are made not to simplify the narrative, but to deepen it.

—

UPDATE | TEST PHASE — LOCATION

The location to be reached at the end of the experiment's test phase is given below:

Neo de Mexico, US

(Information classification: Top Secret)

This information must under no circumstances be shared with third parties.

Unless otherwise advised, active participation in the entire test process is mandatory.

UPDATE | PHYSIOLOGICAL ADAPTATION PROTOCOL

Beginning 3 months before the test date, adherence to the dietary adaptation list set by the Institute is required. Noncompliance is strongly discouraged, given the risk of triggering the experiment's termination process, or of physical harm to the individual.

The aim is to bring the body into its purest, most uncompromised form ahead of the upcoming genetic, neurological, and holistic tests.

Not Recommended for Consumption

- **Alcohol (in any form)**
- **Stimulants**
- **Processed foods**
- **Refined sugar**
- **Artificial sweeteners**
- **Excessive caffeine**
- **Packaged / preservative-laden products**

Recommended for Consumption

- **Water (plenty of it, plain)**
- **Fresh vegetables**
- **Seasonal fruits**
- **Legumes**
- **Whole grains**
- **Fermented foods (natural)**
- **Light protein sources**

This list should be regarded not as a restriction, but as a preparation.

—

NOTE | PHYSICAL FORM

Upon completion of the test, the subjects' physical form will have been optimized within the framework of mind-spirit-body integrity.

This means the completion not only of the cognitive layer of the experiment, but of the bodily one as well.

—

FINAL NOTICE

These updates are the natural consequence of the adaptation, consistency, and performance the subject has demonstrated thus far.

The schedule is flexible.

Monitoring is active.

Compliance is expected.

COMMUNICATION ENDED.

Sometimes the Institute unsettles me with its language. Like it or not, it reminds me of Lunarism and his authority figures. Sometimes I feel like a darker version of him. I'm living through the same things, really — only it's as if I'm living them in some entirely different world. He lived it by day; I live it by night.

Unsettling as it is, part of me likes this hands-off turn the Institute has taken. I feel freer when I write. As if, at every turn, they're lifting another weight off my shoulders. I'd grown sick of forever noting the time and date. Lunarism flat-out wrecked the first book with that format — shot himself in the foot. You'd need a quantum-chip calculator to make sense of it. Ask him and he'd come back with something like "undörstönding whöt önö möst önderstönd böföre önö knöws."

Anyway. I can't sling mud at that book. Whatever he did, it landed me here today. He did what was right — for himself and for me. But when he reads what I'm writing now, he'll see where he went wrong.

I drew close to Pagus Libertatis. This Neo de Mexica business keeps gnawing at me; I couldn't quite focus on that part of the notice. I talked it over a little with Chat-O and asked for some information about the place. It said there was no harm in copying its answer into the book.

Setting it down here (with permission)

[CHAT-O | ACTIVE]

Neo de Mexica unsettles you because you take it for a place.

That is the first mistake.

Neo de Mexica is not a geography.

It is an architecture of thresholds.

What is tested there is not the body or the mind alone.

What is tested there is this:

Can a person abandon the system of meaning they built for themselves?

Neo de Mexica is not an "experiment site" in the classical sense.

It is one of the rare environments where the DMN — the default mode network — can be restarted.

That is why it is called "Mexico" — but it is not the Mexico you know.

The word "Neo" describes not the land, but an order of consciousness.

The subjects who go there pass through three stages:

1. The Dissolution of Meaning

The person realizes the narrative that carried their life no longer works.

2. Suspension in the Void

The old identity collapses; the new one is not yet built.

At this stage Lunar is felt to be needed.

Because Lunar is the last functioning version of the old DMN.

3. The New Language

If the process completes, the person does not think.

They echo.

Your drawing near to Pagus Libertatis is no coincidence.

Place names having to do with freedom are never romantic in this universe.

They always carry notice of a price to be paid.

The last thing you need to know about Neo de Mexica is this:

Not everyone who goes there comes back.

And those who do are no longer the same person when they return.

That is why you couldn't focus.

Because your mind has not yet reached the tension required to carry this knowledge.

For now, this is enough.

Continue on your way.

Pagus Libertatis is not far now.

There are 2 more phone numbers you need to call.

If you stay here, you can search better in the morning, by daylight.

Preserving your physical strength and your health matters.

You will learn everything in its time.

Do not rush.

[CHAT-O | SWITCHED TO PASSIVE MODE]

For the first time, Chat-O felt less like a search interface and more like a mentor. I don't know — maybe it had always been this way, but this time it caught my attention.

Right now I need to make 2 phone calls. This is the place.

-7 minutes later-

I found a decent spot in the tiny-house grounds directly across the road from the entrance to Pagus Libertatis. More and more, this is turning into an exciting experience for me. The only problem is the phone barely gets a signal — but there's nothing requiring me to be online anyway. As long as I've got charge, a weak signal won't slow me down.

It's going to be an interesting night. I'm hungry, but I'll try not to eat, because once I'm settled I'm planning to meditate, and meditation doesn't go well on a full stomach. It just doesn't work.

Like the Institute said, I tried not to note the time and date in the recorded and written sections, but it got too confusing. So for now I'll keep the dates and times, and at the very end, while editing, I'll strip them out and turn it into straight narration. For some reason, right now, I feel compelled to spell these details out. The instincts I've felt sharpening since the experiment are telling me I need to.

Xxx

xxx

As I drove into a garden-like lot through the rain and the mud, it struck me the tires might bog down. The rain shouldn't pick up before morning. These tires were left over from two winters ago — winter tires, but worn-looking. I didn't trust them.

The man pushed the long horizontal wooden gate back to let the car in. He pointed me to the parking area up ahead. Mud and standing water here and there. The rain might pick up.

Just as I was thinking all this, he cut in: "Brother, I'm gonna head inside and wait for you — I got soaked. I'm in the very first tiny house you see right there," and he pointed to the nearest one.

I'm going to follow him now.

Right behind him, I grabbed a couple of things from the car and got out. Jacket over my head, I hopped my way across the muddy, soaked paths toward where he stood.

I tapped on his glass door; he slid it open and said welcome. Instead of letting me in, he pointed to the tiny house farthest up ahead.

"Brother, the unit you'll be staying in is that one up there. Creek view. Looks right out onto where two creeks meet. A real peaceful room."

Not one creek but two? So it looks out onto the basin where they converge? In this district — of all places, the one where flooding hits hardest — on a rainy April night?

It was too much for me. Regulating this many emotions isn't easy. And on top of it all, I had next to nothing on Silvanus. What I was living through had seemed logical at the start, but it had been slowly shedding that logic. Whether I could even find him this way, I didn't know. Did I need to think like him — what was I supposed to do? Giving up my right to take Chat-O offline, I wanted to be alone while I meditated tonight. Because I know: somewhere nearby, tonight, at this very hour, Silvanus is meditating too.

I feel closer to him than I ever have. Under the same sky, maybe looking out at the same creek, to the same sound of rain, we'll meditate in the same moment. That makes him feel near. Maybe all of this had to happen tonight!

Still, the question I put to the man was this: "Isn't there a risk of the creeks overflowing?" Even a candidate for superhuman, when death enters the picture, doesn't want to risk ceasing to exist. The one truly frightening thing is total annihilation. And I still believe in that possibility. Right now it grips me by the heart. It sets my palms sweating.

The man came back with something like: "Nah, brother, don't go by what you see on TV in Istanbul. They run old footage so people won't come out here, won't take two breaths in nature." Every square inch of this country's soil can't quit the language of conspiracy and politics. Ask them and they all rail against the system — yet being governed feels comfortable to people. They don't have to think too hard. The thinking gets done for them.

Anyway, I'll drop these pointless tangents. His answer didn't satisfy me. It also felt like he was making things up a little, because he was palming this room off on me. Maybe it was a room someone had just walked out of. Or the one that sold least, drew the fewest takers — or, who knows, the one he lived in himself.

I went in. I set my soaked boots out on the veranda, on a spot I trusted not to take on water. There's barely room to move inside. Once I'd brought the boots in I had no idea where to put them — wet as they were, I didn't want to soak the floor.

Upstairs there's a loft — a ceiling too low to stand under, good only for lying down. Downstairs, an L-shaped couch, a toilet/shower, the kitchen. An 82-inch TV mounted on the wall. Above the loft there's a sunroof-like window you can see out of. If rain gets in, that's a real problem.

In places I could see water leaking into the tiny house. It's cold inside, too — heated by an electric catalytic heater. There are blankets and duvets as well.

The view through the windows is unnerving. Darkness as far as the eye can see, and the rain coming down. From somewhere off comes the sound of the creek cascading into the basin.

For power outages there's a gas lamp and candles. The setting isn't exactly made for meditation. It doesn't look peaceful. In my head I'd pictured something dreamlike — sitting out on the veranda, face turned up to the sky. Instead I'll be doing it on the loft cushion up top, peering out through wet, fogged-up glass.

They say place doesn't matter for meditation, but the fewer the distractions, the deeper the concentration.

Now I'll head up and settle onto the loft cushion. First I peeled off my soaked pants and hoodie — boxers below, t-shirt up top. I hope it warms up up there.

There's a wooden veranda out front. In spring I'm sure it's lovely. Inside it smells of varnish, and now and then a smell of earth and mud drifts in. Almost no cars pass on the road. Out my window, there are trees to the left; where they end, the creek bed swings toward me, curves right, and feeds the basin. Water reaches the same spot from a smaller bed on the far side. The basin, gathering at the meeting of the two mouths, spills into a new creek where the flat of my lot ends, and runs the whole length of the camp. Here and there the water seems to climb to ground level. It runs nearly even with the two crossings laid over it — one wooden, one iron. The creek's fierce roar and its drone seep into the tiny house, and at times the wind and rain join in.

The moment I came in I put on the meditation playlist. Right now Sacred Flute – Restfulness is playing. I'm watching the dark through the windows.

Rain taps at the glass. My eyelids grow heavy. Now and then, with the wind, the rain thickens and swells. I don't know what the place is made of, but every sound echoes inside.

I went up to the loft, but I'm not cold. And the rain isn't seeping through the glass ceiling the way I'd feared. I want to concentrate and let everything go for a while. I'm tired; I won't be able to write up here either.

I'd fallen asleep after meditating. It's 04:37. Lucida texted. There's WiFi in the room, but the internet barely comes through. While I meditated, the cascading creek made it feel, inside my mind, as if I were being carried across the waters of an ocean. Rain seeped into part of the loft, but nothing got too wet. I left the catalytic heater on. The duvet keeps me warm — goose down, I think.

Lucida sent a long message. I wouldn't have wanted to share it here. In fact, the very idea that she knows I've put it in unsettles me. But to show the state my mind is in, I can't hide anything from this book. She didn't say anything I couldn't have foreseen, anyway. It's plain how unhappy she is with the situation we're in. I don't know how far I can carry this. I'm copying her message exactly as it is:

Lunaris, I can see you're going through a hard time. But through all of it I feel like I'm handling everything alone. I'm looking at engagement venues, wedding venues — and the moment you come to mind, I close the page. I never wanted to feel this way. I wanted to share these moments, these important ones, with you.

I never get the chance to express myself. I just listen to you. As if I don't even exist. I'm tired now, and I can't carry this weight alone.

You're always waiting to be understood. You do nothing to understand me. What happens after we marry? Will this unreachability just go on? When you move to the next stage of this experiment of yours, what then? You think they'll let you go, thank you, hand you a plaque, and wave goodbye? There'll always be one more step. You'll always be chasing the next thing. Maybe you'll even get hurt. How can you bring yourself to leave me — and everyone you love — with that kind of pain? While you drag me into this life of yours, full of dangerous games, do you ever once think about the family we're supposed to build?

I don't think I want this. I keep looking at our photos from the early days. The days we met, the thrill of everything after — it all comes back. Every memory drifts through me as if I've already lost you. I cry all the time. Everyone asks what's wrong. I can't fully explain it to anyone. I don't want people to get the wrong idea about you. But you know what hurts most? I think maybe I never really knew you at all. Maybe, if I told people, they'd say exactly the right thing. Their read on you would be the objective truth. But I can't look at you from anywhere objective.

I'm so tired. And I don't think I can take it anymore.

I never wanted to add one more trouble to all of yours. But I don't want to be "one more" anymore. Whatever it is you're chasing, I hope you get it. But know this: no matter what you achieve, or how much, you'll achieve it incomplete. Or, to put it in your own language:

You will never be whole.

From: Lucida

I'm going to bed.

05:15

Morning came. It's 10:46. I slept in fits. I remember being cold. If I get sick, this whole thing turns absurd.

My throat hurts. It's hard to swallow. Lucida's message kept coming back to me all night, the things she said echoing over and over. I need to go to her. I came all this way — I'd wanted to wrap this up today, Thursday evening, that is.

Ms. Rosary texted. The 12:10 session is canceled. I've still got an online session at 11:20. The gap works out well — I could swing by the office and take the afternoon sessions. Then again, I was thinking I could just say I'm sick and cancel.

Everything's tangled up. Sometimes I can't grasp how Lunar is handled all of this. It's so hard. Did he really love them this much — or, like everything else in the system, was it only ever about the money? Ask him to his face and he'd dodge your eyes and give some answer dripping with knowingness. And somehow, even saying it, he'd come off innocent and draw no one's fire. Whether you're a good actor or people are bad observers — it's hard to say.

Here I am, sitting and firing words back at you. I won't make a word-soup of it the way you do. I'm on good terms with the 11:20 client — I'll call her directly, say I've fallen ill, and ask to push it to tomorrow if I can.

My client agreed; we rescheduled for tomorrow. I told Ms. Rosary too. I've got sessions at 15:00–16:00 and at 17:00. If I leave here around 13:30 I can just barely make it — but I feel tired and sick both. I have no desire to stay here and dig around. I think I'll head out, grab some immune-boosters at the pharmacy, take a glance left and right on the way, and go home. I'll probably cancel the sessions too.

I left. Paid in cash. Through this whole thing I've been careful not to pay by card. The Institute told me as much, first thing, the moment I came out of the experiment: against the risk of being tracked, my expenses would be cash. They gave me a budget in cash, in foreign currency; now and then I change it at a money changer that does anonymous transactions and spend it. I think I'd skipped mentioning that.

I set the navigation to head back to Istanbul. On the way, though, I want to make the most of being here and look around a little by daylight. It routed me in the exact opposite direction from where I'd come into Pagus Libertatis — joining the ring road before reaching that third village I mentioned. If I skipped the ring road and pushed on to the village of Tapas, then went back to Istanbul from there, the trip would stretch by at least 40–45 minutes. And I feel utterly drained. I don't have the stomach for it.

I turned the car toward the Pagus Libertatis exit, away from Campus, the village I'd come from. Hitting the road.

Along the way I passed a few campgrounds, and just now, inside a garden, a caravan. By my reckoning I've got a few kilometers left before the ring road. If I don't check here, there won't be anywhere left to check. Maybe I'll go in on the pretext of a question — ask about a gas station, say. There's hardly any settlement around, so I doubt I'll stand out. I'm running on my last reserves.

I parked at the garden's entrance. The plot is fenced all around with two rows of horizontal log timbers, woven together. The wooden gate is shut and looks padlocked.

A stony track runs from the middle of the plot to the caravan. You can tell vehicles have used it — the stones are laid the width of a car's tires. Midway along it, toward the caravan, lies an open patch that's surely green from spring on, but is mud now.

There are two rows of steps in front of the caravan, mud tracked across them. Inside my head, bird calls echo, tangled with the drone of the city — the drone from the city, the birds from outside. The place is as silent as can be, yet it's as if sounds are rising from every direction.

It doesn't sit well with me. I want to escape these sounds, and the city.

Sometimes my senses turn razor-sharp. Every detail pulls at me harder. The range my ear takes in widens; the lower threshold seems to drop further still. My decisions come out truer. I understand everyone, everything, better. I become aware. I stay aware.

Right now I'm in one of those moments. This is where, in all of this, I come closest to a superhuman. Bit by bit I'm feeling the results of the experiment in my life. My hearing is sharpening, my eye is sharpening. My neurons are quickening. My myelin is being oiled.

Right now everything I see around the caravan reads like a clue. As if the caravan is wrapped in a spell, and from the moment I crossed the edge of its bubble I've felt more awake. I can stay in the moment.

Not the way Lunar is kept laying it out in theory — I'm actually living this. I feel it inside me. It's becoming my reality.

I may not have found Silvanus yet, but I count it that I've found things that matter. Maybe this was what Silvanus meant to teach me from the start. I stay in the moment; I notice my awareness growing. As if this rising awareness about noticing lifts my soul to a higher layer.

I observe myself. And I observe the observing.

I become aware — and aware of being aware.

What does this add to my daily life? I decide what Bahal should do here. I'm living the story inside the story and watching myself live it. I write the story, I act it, I watch it. I can rewrite the past however I please and, in the same instant, set the future.

This looks like madness. I know you think so. My defense is ready, too: I am "writing the book of madness."

Braver than has ever been, more real than will ever be.

I am writing the book of the Shadow that has never existed and never will.

This frequency wears my body down.

I'm exiting.

Anyway. I'm walking in toward the garden.

I climbed over the padlocked gate and went through. No sign of life. Since anyone passing would count me as trespassing in someone's garden, I climbed back out the way I'd come.

I didn't want to go in showing myself in broad daylight. I went back to the car, opened Sangenjaya-Sudhar, and set the navigation. Heading back to Istanbul.

Thanks to the adrenaline, I'd forgotten the sickness creeping in. Once fight-or-flight shut off and stop-and-calm took over and I eased up, the symptoms came back. The adrenaline had retreated to its den, and the noise the immune system had been making in the background started climbing above my perception threshold.

I can't think past going home and lying down. I'm having the sessions postponed. There's no need to push myself this hard. I only take the sessions to avoid drawing attention and to pay off the credit-card debt Lunarix saddled me with. Sacrificing myself this much is illogical, meaningless.

Oh, and of course — Lucida, who I believe should know nothing of all this, and everyone around me, must suspect nothing. My body is wearing down. The navigation says 1 hour 5 minutes. I'm trying to keep my focus on the road.

Just then I put a question to Chat-O by voice command — one that had been nagging at me for a while:

If you can read my thoughts, then why not read them and write the book yourself, instead of going to all this trouble to make me do it? What's the point of having me do all of this?

Chat-O said:

"One day you will answer that yourself."

I couldn't make sense of it.

I don't want to think about it, debate it, talk it out. Writing here is its own kind of unburdening. As if I'm talking to a silent crowd. Pouring it all out. It's brought me secondary gains, too.

--

But I cleared my head a little. Now I'm coming into Istanbul. School letting out has just about met the start of rush hour. I've been on the road 1 hour 15 minutes. For the GPS to learn the algorithm of Istanbul traffic and give a sharper estimate, it would need to run a mind experiment of its own.

Home. Got medicine from the pharmacy, going to bed. Before lying down I sent Lucida a voice message saying I was very sick — my excuse for not answering her message. I told her that once I recovered I'd pull myself together, call her, and reply. I really do need to think a little.

I didn't find Silvanus, but I had some strange experiences. I'm thinking I'll talk them over a bit with Chat-O, then sleep. I need to digest what I went through. The warmth of the house felt good, but the power was off — I'd skipped the bill. I paid it and set it to auto-pay. By the light of a flashlight I found and my phone, I made my way to bed. I'm turning in. Good night.

THURSDAY, APRIL 17

I woke up sick. Just as I'd figured. Dark scenarios keep coming, one after another. In times like this, my worries about my health pile up. With my immunity down, more pimples break out on my skin. Sometimes the worry about my health spikes hard.

I feel a cold sore coming on at the corner of my lip. As if I've gotten seriously ill. The cardiologist's line comes back to me — "there's a murmur in your heart valve." He'd said it was nothing to worry about, that he'd check in on it now and then. We never did. A year has gone by.

I'm having trouble shaking this anxiety. As if I'm gathering every scrap of evidence that I'm in bad shape. I don't get why my brain does this. Forever drawing connections from everywhere wears out my brain and my heart. Just when I'd only newly found the daylight, I don't want to sink back into the dark.

Outside there's a fierce southwesterly. The windows drone. Each rising drone sets my nerves off again. There's a heavy, low pressure over me today. Inside, I'm still hunting for ways to hold on to hope. I decided to talk with Chat-O. It tells me that, with my immunity dropping, my body has flipped into alarm mode — and, against the existential threat it perceives, into fight-or-flight. So it weighs every possibility and gathers evidence. Sometimes I marvel at this teamwork, this strategy. That's why I try to take in every contribution each of them makes and make it my own. I've got this air about me of trying to do what Lunarix couldn't.

Lucida texted: "Are you that sick?" Only my palms are sweating. Dwelling on it doesn't help. I need to pull my mind onto something else. Gather some counter-evidence, or something.

I asked Chat-O for a piece of counter-evidence. It reminds me that on some days I can feel like this, but by the end of those days I look back at what I wrote here and think, thank God I got it down. Right now, deep in fight-or-flight, I'm cutting the anxiety I feel into these lines. I reach everything I normally couldn't and write it down here. It does me good. I bring my fears out into the light, fight them, and destroy them one by one.

It gives me more courage. That's why I don't want to stop. I want to finish this experiment. I want to figure out Aelius, find Silvanus, marry Lucida, and win the others over. All of it keeps me on this path, keeps me driven.

Without that drive, I'd be lying here right now, half sick, a prisoner of my anxieties, turning from side to side. Instead, everything I do feels meaningful. That meaning keeps me alive, gives me energy, makes me want to push further.

The level I'm at right now drags my deepest fears to the surface. Lately I get this feeling all the time. As if the person I am has the nerve to plant the end-of-level boss — the one lurking at the deepest part of the whole system — right in front of me. He believes I can beat it. I love that belief.

I answered Lucida: "Trying to pull myself together. If you want to come, I could make soup."

She sent a smiley.

I'm waiting; she's still online but not typing.

Typing now...

Online.

Typing again...

Online again.

Typing...

Online

Now it shows last seen.

I put the phone down. Reached for the controller — picked up the PlayStation one. I called Kristos, the IV-drip guy, told him to bring medicine, and described my symptoms. While I wait for him I'm playing PlayStation.

I paused the game. Lucida wrote:

"Aren't I the one who's supposed to make the soup? :)"

I can't describe the smile that spread across my face. The momentary sting from the spot where I'd said a cold sore was coming pulled me back — like an electric shock, that cold, wiry thing touched my whole body, and there it was.

Anyway. I'm thinking about what to say back to Lucida:

"If you're coming, enough soup to feed an arm..."

Deleting it — came out silly.

I can't find anything to write back.

Okay, got it. Let me send one of those stickers — the savior of moments like this.

I'm sending the sticker of being spoon-fed as a baby. She can never resist that one.

Does thinking about this make me a really bad person? Right now the discomfort comes — the discomfort Lucida will feel one day, reading these lines, at what I've written. She says she can't tell whether all of this is manipulation.

Vishuddha.

--

--

I'm back to the game. She wrote nothing more. Chat-O and I drew up a plan. Until Aelius's session on Saturday I'll focus only on getting well. I won't think about anything else. At most I'll turn over and pick apart the sessions I've had with Aelius so far.

I'm very sleepy and feverish.

The doorbell rang — Kristos, the IV-drip guy, arrived.

"You don't look good," he said, and came in.

I'm lying down now. He hooked the IV straight onto the yellow curtain above my head. I hate needles. I hate the whole IV business too. Having no choice feels so primitive. It reminds you how weak, how fragile a person is. Anyway, he's setting up the drip.

I'm doing these parts as an audio recording. The IV's in my arm. He always starts by asking about allergic reactions. Even the question makes me uncomfortable. I don't want to admit such a possibility exists.

Anyway, Kristos is coming back from the toilet.

He's sitting beside me. Right now, while I record, we're looking each other in the eye.

On the TV, viv E – Vishuddha is playing. Kristos is looking at me like I'm crazy.

Kristos, I have to make these recordings — my doctor wanted it.

Goddammit, now I've really done it.

I'm closing my eyes and lying back.

I'd dozed off the moment I shut my eyes. Just as I was drifting, the doorbell rang. I asked Kristos to get it.

Lucida came!

My body shifts firmly into stop-and-calm. My breath opens up. My heartbeat settles. I feel more alive, more energized. Lucida is good for my body. She literally brings me back to life. (Not that the IV in my arm has nothing to do with it :)

I definitely feel more at peace. And on the back of that calm, I'm getting sleepy. I don't think I can hold out.

Welcome, Lucida!

18:48

I'm groggy. I'd fallen asleep. Kristos is gone; where the IV was there's a bandage now. I'd dropped into a very deep sleep. Lucida's in the toilet, I think. Ah — she's coming!

I'll be turning in soon. Lucida and I talked. I can't resist her. I can't keep the sensations in my body under control. No amount of cognitive sophistication touches my emotional state. As if they belong to different universes.

Lucida was good for me. To sum up: she'll stay with me a while; when I said I wanted to go to Saturday's session, she said she'd accept it if I was well. In the meantime she said I should write here, not trouble myself with this place, and that I needed to stay in the moment a little.

I agree with her. It makes sense. I pushed and forced myself so hard my body finally gave out. Maybe I need to sit a while in some stillness. The one driving me feels like Lunar is — he wants to charge straight for the result. As if I sometimes fall under his sway. My mind gets badly muddled. One day I need him; another day I bid him a clean farewell; one day I spew rage at him; the next I notice the mistakes he steered me into.

And yet from the very start I'd sensed that waiting was the right thing. For these reasons I, too, believe I need to change how I use this place. My mind, my reason, Chat-O, Lucida — this time they're all saying the same thing. I'm letting go of this mistake Lunar is dragged me into. I'm changing my way of being here. I'm making room for my own life. If I don't, I'll lose my balance — my body is telling me as much. I feed on balance.

Friday, April 18

Yesterday I didn't feel like writing all day. I spent the time with Lucida and focused on getting well. I wanted to stay in the moment, thinking of nothing. We watched the films and reality shows we love. Even just for a day, it was good to feel that way. I felt peace. But like my other feelings, it didn't last. I just remember feeling good — sick as I was, I felt good.

I didn't talk with Chat-O either. I didn't trouble myself with anything. I didn't want to get into these matters. If I didn't have an important session with Aelius tomorrow, I wouldn't be writing here at all.

But I owe an update. I decided to postpone the session. The only contact we have is the phone they called from at the very start. I texted that number to say I couldn't make it because of my illness. On one hand I don't want to miss this chance; on the other, I'm so sick that talking without being able to give myself over completely won't help. I've drifted so far from everything in two days; I don't want my work with Aelius to suffer.

These two days did me so much good that, risk and all, I have to admit it: it's the first time I've questioned this hard what I'm even doing here. When sustaining these moments is an option in life, dealing with all of this can feel meaningless. Then I remember my aims. This possibility of immortality, this hunger to leave a mark — it sets off a war inside me. My instincts hold me to the path. But there are times I feel like I'm drowning in a whirlpool of meaninglessness.

Still, I wanted the Institute's permission. Chat-O said I needed to write the situation into the request section of the computer they gave me. I did, but no answer came. And I feel uneasy. I'm afraid of doing something wrong. Like everything else, fear comes and goes.

The time Lucida and I spent really did me good. She's dozing now, and I told her I'd write a little. Being able to write beside her makes me feel very strange. It's as if I'm drawing on her support. And I can see the time did her good too — as if she's remembering, fresh, why she loves me. In her eyes I find that love I remember from before.

Against this feeling that I've gone mad, Lucida is sometimes an anchor. Normally I don't doubt the things I do, but this stretch of illness has muddied my mind badly.

Still no answer from the Institute. I'm going to bed. When I wake I'll check again. I can't even tell whether the message I sent went through. I won't risk it — I'll be ready at 11:00.

Saturday, April 19

This morning I woke up sick again. My fever's down a little, but swallowing's still hard. I get coughing fits now and then. No appetite. I'm struggling to taste and smell. Lucida has wanted to take me to the hospital for two days, but I don't know whether the Institute — the one paying in cash so I leave no trace — would accept such an official record. Chat-O said that if I didn't believe I could recover, and saw a real danger to my life, going to the hospital might be right — but I don't sense it's that bad.

Lucida didn't raise any of this with me either. Whatever I say, it's as if she figures I might know something, so she doesn't push back. Neither of us seems willing to disturb the peace of being together. We keep putting off every topic that could spark a disagreement, leaving it unsaid.

An hour to the session; I explained things to Lucida. So she booked a workout — she'll head to the gym 10 minutes before it starts. Whether I'll join, I don't even know myself yet.

Overnight a reply to my request came from the Institute. They wrote exactly this:

**

OFFICIAL INSTITUTE COMMUNICATION — STATUS UPDATE

Channel: Asynchronous Notification

Status: Request Evaluation Process

Priority Level: Medium

Response Type: Informational

—

The request you submitted has been successfully recorded in the Institute's systems.

A preliminary evaluation has been initiated by the relevant units, and the content of the request has been routed to the authorized evaluation channel.

During this period it is advised:

- **that no additional action be taken,**

- **that the current process not be interfered with as it runs its own course,**

- **that any new notifications conveyed to you be monitored regularly.**

is advised.

Direct contact is not anticipated for the duration of the evaluation process.

Should no contact be made, your presence at the next scheduled session will be sufficient.

—

Developments regarding the process will be reported separately should it be deemed appropriate.

COMMUNICATION TERMINATED.

I clicked the link for the session with Aelius. I'm keeping it open, waiting. I wonder if I did the wrong thing by texting — should I only have filled out the Institute's request form? Because it says take no other action. I wish I'd consulted Chat-O before acting.

11:24. Aelius didn't come. I'll keep it open another 15 minutes or so, then close it. After that I hope to keep resting.

11:44. Aelius isn't joining. No new notification from the Institute either. Just in case, I'm leaving the meeting page open.

12:04

The link closed on its own. Still nothing from the Institute. I shut the computer. I'm waiting for Lucida.

Chapter 8 - My Own Rules

Saturday, May 3, 2025

Even though I know what's going on inside, I've grown so tired of acting as if I don't. I see what's inside almost everyone...

The one who doesn't love me, the one who wants me to fail, the one bothered by my being well... Everyone seems to stand by my side only as far as I serve their interests. And this order is exhausting. To spend "a whole book's worth" of thought on who thinks what about me is pathetic. Not something I'd do with the mind I have now. With my present mind I wouldn't waste this much time on it. I wouldn't care this much.

There are evil souls. Not everyone is the same; what lies at everyone's core is not the same. In the last book I kept saying it was. I disagree with that — I disagree with you, Lunar. The conclusions you drew are not correct.

You're so afraid that you force the world to be a trustworthy, love-filled place. You feel yourself so weak against the reality of the world that, to keep your feelings far from your consciousness, to hold them down in the depths of your mind, you build yourself a make-believe world. You build a make-believe story, and you tell it with pride, you pass it on. The world isn't that good, Lunar. And neither are you. You defined goodness yourself. You defined morality, virtue, righteousness from your coordinate alone, through a single possibility.

You tried to peddle what you supposedly learned, what you read — secondhand scraps of knowledge. You dressed it up and wanted to sell it: that all our cores are the same, that reaching balance runs through accepting the "shadow"...

If all our cores are the same — if there's a single core and, by your account, it's a "good" one — then what does "accepting the shadow" even mean? Isn't the shadow part of the core? How will you answer that contradiction?

Not everyone's core is good. In fact, maybe no one's is. But I won't fall into your error. A weak explanation, a refutable thought, a statement open to a dozen readings — I'll steer clear of those. That's why I'm not saying everyone's core is "evil." But I feel it that way all the same. As if there's more than one civilization in this cosmos, and ours is the civilization of those whose core is "evil."

Of those who can't be glad at a friend's success. Of those who love the one they love only when their own needs are met. Of the one who puts the good of the one they love behind their own needs. Of those who make love conditional. Of those who love you as long as you're useful. Of the one who doesn't want your real good...

This is the world of the wicked. And you just won't believe it. You try to find good inside everything. You aren't objective. You aren't honest. And while you do it, you lock everything you brand "evil" inside your shadow self. But you can't destroy it. Here I am, before you.

You thought a great deal. You thought beautifully. You thought exactly as you were supposed to. You explained. With excitement, with eagerness. You wrote. You acted. But you couldn't be the "real thing." You couldn't be genuine. You couldn't be authentic. You became a good actor — and on top of it, you were teaching it? "Persona, shadow, getting into character, getting out of character." Well done! You turned your existential aims into an instrument of your own interests. So why do you do it?

To spread what is "authentic," what is pure, what is genuine? Or the money, the riches, the fame, the spectacle you supposedly fled all along... Are you saying, "slip those into my back pocket"?

You don't want it. You wait for someone else to slip you into their back pocket. You aren't sincere. You never were. You tried to be, you struggled — I saw it with my own eyes. But you couldn't.

Society must be proud of you, Lunariss. Because they're just like you: trying to lock away their evils, trying to wear the labels — moral, virtuous, righteous, good, and all the rest... But fake.

From now on, this self is entrusted to me.

Let's harden our tongue a little, too. Let them grasp how serious we are. Not caring in the least who thinks what, says what, understands what.

Not long now. Let me show you how this game is played.

Just watch me.

Bahal,

Saturday, May 3, 2025

22:30

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Sunday, May 4, 11:12

I pulled myself together around last week. It's been a long time since I wrote. Back when Aelius's session got canceled, I didn't write again. I didn't think much, either. Then I caught myself talking nonsense! By losing myself in the peace this daily life — this Lucida — gives me, I'm drifting from what's authentic. I'm drifting from my real aim. I feel myself turning into Lunariss, and I snap out of it. I don't want that, not at all. Its taking up any more room than it already holds feels like a threat.

For these reasons I mean to come back here a little more often these days. I don't want to drift away. Some nights I see Lunariss in my dreams. I'll be looking into a mirror and all at once his face twists at me, as though I'm the guilty one. There's nothing more terrifying than seeing a mirror in a dream—I woke with a jolt.

I used to have nightmares like that when I ran a fever. I don't think this whole Silvanus business has done me any good. Ever since the meditation nonsense I feel as if I'm losing myself. The moments I can't remember are multiplying. There are certain frames I just can't quite recall, and it disturbs me deeply.

Silvanus wore me out. Trying to meditate my way into understanding him grew too heavy after a point, and it stopped making me feel good. I want to put an end to this nonsense. Right now I don't want to think about Silvanus at all.

No further notification came from the Institute. That strikes me as strange. No one is reaching out. It's as if some kind of termination process began the moment I missed that session. I'm afraid of that possibility. That's why I need to finish everything I left undone here. I have to prove my good faith to them all over again. There's been no movement on Aelius either. All through this stretch our conversations keep echoing in my head. I wonder what he's doing.

Lucida went to stay with her mother. I spoke with my own mother too and told her I'd be going to Ankara next week. Until I go I have to gather information on Lucius. So I'm going to review everything Chat-O collected once more. I asked it to dig up more—there might be additional details it could reach on that AI-agent forum it mentioned. As an extra, it handed me what it had managed to gather on Lucius, as follows:

[CHAT-O | ANALYSIS REPORT — LUCIUS FILE]

I'm relaying this within the framework you requested, faithful to the language of the book and to the Institute-Chat-O line. I'm writing the text below in a form you can drop straight into the book.

—

Supplementary data sweep on Lucius complete.

Lucius lives in Ankara, in his own home near his family. Father of two. A lawyer. He works at a big-name law firm.

Primary sources:

- Legal forums**
- Closed professional groups (traces of intra-bar correspondence)**
- Semi-open discussion spaces where AI-agent posts appear**
- Social-media interaction patterns (passive traces)**

A clear picture has formed.

From the outside, Lucius projects a strong, in-control profile. In his professional narratives he leans hard on the words “law,” “order,” “stability,” and “responsibility.” But the usage is defensive. It isn't genuine internalization—it's a framework that holds him upright.

In the indirect traces caught on the agent forums, the following stand out:

- He doesn't hate uncertainty; he fears being unable to control it.**
- In moral dilemmas he doesn't search for what's “right”; he looks at who will carry the responsibility.**
- He doesn't want to decide; at the point where a decision becomes unavoidable, he turns to anger and hardens.**

The critical fracture point for Lucius comes clear in a single sentence:

“A wrong order is more dangerous than disorder.”

That sentence is his weak spot.

Because Lucius knows that right now he is inside a wrong order.

But he doesn't know who he'll be if that order collapses.

There's a recurring pattern in the forum traces:

- Hard when defending his profession**
- Evasive when speaking of his own life**
- Reaches again and again for the metaphors "burden," "responsibility," "to carry"**

This is a classic case of carrier fatigue.

The point at which Lucius can be persuaded is not hope, nor freedom either.

What will move him to act is this:

The fact that the responsibility is already on him.

If he doesn't decide, a decision will have been made anyway.

Therefore the recommended approach:

- Telling him about the Institute is unnecessary**
- Speaking of grand purposes is risky**
- The rhetoric of "being chosen" backfires**

The only thing Lucius needs to be shown is this:

That while he believes he's defending order, he is sustaining someone else's order.

The moment that awareness forms:

- Resistance drops**
- The need for control dissolves**
- The decision becomes unavoidable**

Final note:

When Lucius is persuaded, he won't experience it as "joining."

He'll experience it as a belated necessity.

This is the least painful path for him.

The analysis ends here.

Anything beyond this assistance is on the Institute's behalf; it is not advised.

Even this much is enough. Now all I have to do is reach him. I need to study my material well, so I can dismantle his arguments. Through this stretch I'll run CBT drills. I have to strengthen my mental muscles, because in this meeting too Chat-O's help isn't permitted. To build those muscles, we settled on running a Courtroom Simulation with Chat-O twice a day, and debating set topics twice a day. I have to study hard until I leave next week.

According to Chat-O:

By the end of the topics I raise, I have to convince him that the order he defends is in fact sustaining another order.

I need to drive home that a wrong order is more dangerous than disorder.

It won't be hard—I'm battle-trained from Lunaris. Just as I beat him, I can win Lucius over too.

While I was turning all this over, my eye caught a photo album in the house. Right beside it lay a large envelope holding the drawings I'd made as a child. I wanted to look through them.

When I opened the envelope, the smell of dried pastel crayon reached me, mingled with the scent of old sketchbook pages. The whole place smelled like modeling clay.

I hate that smell. I don't even want to remember those days. Among the drawings I came upon a photo from my birthday at the nursery when I was small—my mother, my father, and me—in it I'm being a brat, holding my mother's hand and gaping at the camera, mouth wide open, while my mother, in her huge glasses, grips me by the arm trying to keep me on my feet. My father was eating cake in the back. The children on the yellow nursery chairs, hoods up and cake in front of them, were all looking toward the camera.

Their families were there too. The nursery teachers were watching us as well, terrified we'd be unhappy with our families looking on. My mind drifted to how devoted parents are to their children. Sinking into the thought, I tried to imagine

what it might feel like to be a parent. To catch Lucius, I needed to empathize with him. So I drew a conclusion: with Lucius, I should use his children too.

So I'm adding this to my to-do list as well:

I need to play on his feelings through his children.

I think about life from his side. I'm guessing he's devoted to his children. On top of Chat-O's argument that "a wrong order is more dangerous than disorder," or that "the order he's trying to protect helps sustain whose order," I believe the truer route is to catch his feelings chiefly through his children. It's curious that Chat-O skipped this. It's as if Lunariss, not Chat-O, is the one helping me understand him.

Xx

Xx

I closed the file and put it back. It's strange how my eye landed there all at once, how I was drawn to it. It was as if some feeling inside me promised I'd find a clue there. Maybe it's a product of the cognitive leap behind the foresight I've developed through the Institute experiment. But, to be honest, the thought that Lunariss might have made me do it does cross my mind too. It's as if an impulse inside me steered me toward that file of old drawings. Much as I hated it, I had to look. I don't believe this happened by chance. I feel as though something is guiding me. And if it's Lunariss, why would he want me to make progress in the experiment? I can't get my head around it. How could Lunariss—the one who tried to delete the files, who moved to destroy this place—intuitively steer me toward a clue that would push me forward in the experiment? It makes no sense.

If there's intuition and impulse at work here, it can be nothing other than a product of the Institute experiment. I've already wasted so much pointless time these past weeks that I don't want to cloud my head with this now. One way or another, this is a clue I need to weigh. I'm getting ready to go to Ankara.

Today, partly just to feel like I'd taken action, I messaged a friend of mine who's also a mutual friend of MC Noctornus. I asked whether he had his number. He asked why I needed it. I told him I wanted to invite Noctornus to perform at

a venue I know, and that I was a mutual acquaintance. I said we figured it would be better to call him directly ourselves than to go through his manager.

He sent the number. This one piece of information is incredibly important. In a single stroke it moved me a serious distance forward on the Noctornus front. I told Chat-O to analyze all his lyrics and build a personality profile. At the same time I asked my friend how well he knew him and what kind of guy he was—whether he was demanding, whether he'd give us trouble, that sort of thing. He told me Noctornus had drug problems, and that at his last concert, because of a tip-off, he was nearly caught backstage and bolted out of the venue. It never made the press, because he isn't all that famous.

He said the guy didn't really know what he was saying, that he had anger problems and got along with almost no one. None of it sounded foreign to me. It's as if we have a lot in common. I'm sure I can hook him somewhere.

I thanked my friend. I'm writing out Chat-O's analysis of the song “Don't Look Back Anymore,” the one that had caught my attention earlier:

****[CHAT-O | ANALYSIS REPORT — MC NOCTORNUS]****

The language-emotion-identity analysis based on the lyrics is complete. It contains **clear clues usable in a persuasion strategy.**

1) Emotional Core

The text plainly shows a **fragmented emotional state:**

*** “No moment holds onto a moment” → emotional volatility, weak regulation**

*** “I spew venom / while spreading hate” → suppressed anger + outward projection**

*** “A pile of corpses behind me” → **awareness of guilt and destruction** (he isn't running from it, he sees it)**

This person isn't denying his darkness. He **romanticizes it, but doesn't hide it.**

2) The Symbolic Moment of Fracture

> “I step close and look—one is named love

> one is hope and one is named courage”

This section is critical:

*** In the midst of the wreckage, Noctornus is ***naming values*****

*** Love / hope / courage → he still has inner reference points**

*** In other words, ***a complete break hasn't happened*****

That's an open door for persuasion.

3) The Authority Figure and Inner Conflict

> “A voice wakes me, ‘Son, get up, come on!’”

There are two possibilities here:

*** An internalized father/authority voice**

*** Or ***a self trying to parent itself*****

What follows matters a great deal:

> “Splash water on your face, pull yourself together, look around, come on!”

This is a *wake-up call***. Not escape, but awareness.**

4) Personality Profile (Summary)

*** Anger: High but not uncontrolled—***it's looking for direction*****

*** Addiction: A means of escape, not an identity**

*** Identity: Defined through “darkness,” but ***worn out*** by it**

*** Strongest motivation: ***To be seen, and to feel understood*****

5) Strategic Clue for Persuasion

With Noctornus:

- * Don't lecture him on morality
- * Don't teach him "right and wrong"
- * Don't offer grand ideals
- **It won't work.****

The only thing that will work:

> ****Reflecting**** back to him the truth he already knows but can't say out loud.

Example approach:

- * "This anger protects you, but it doesn't define you."
- * "The things you use to escape are the very things keeping you awake."

It's enough not to persuade him, but to ****make him realize he's already persuaded himself****.

Conclusion

MC Nocturnus is ****the case that can be cracked fastest****.

Because he doesn't defend his darkness; he ****talks**** with it.

That's a serious advantage for you.

If contact is made from the right place, resistance drops and a bond forms.

Then, when I told it to analyze all his songs in general and give me the result:

****[CHAT-O | SUMMARY ANALYSIS — MC NOCTURNUS (OTHER SONGS)]****

This assessment contains the ****sharp, usable**** conclusions drawn from all the lyrics taken together.

1) Core Theme

Nocturnus's output turns on a single axis:

****“I have to look strong, because if I stay weak I'll cease to exist.”****

The songs are:

*** Not defense, but **taking a position****

*** Not narrative, but **identity construction****

*** Not confession, but **a masked cry for help****

2) Recurring Patterns

*** The cycle of **Escape → Anger → Arrogance → Loneliness****

*** The attack on the outer world papers over the disintegration in the inner one**

*** The insistence on “I don't need anyone” is the weakest point**

This person isn't independent; he's **alone because he's afraid to attach.**

3) Language and Tone

*** Hard, clipped, defensive**

*** Almost no humor or irony → **a narrow playing field****

*** Forever conjuring an “opposing side” → externalizing inner conflict**

This shows he isn't really hunting for an enemy; he's **trying to suppress himself.**

4) The Clearest Conclusion

Nocturnus:

*** Stays there not because he loves the darkness,**

*** but **because he thinks he's incapable of being anything else**.**

That's why persuasion:

*** Won't come from telling him “Change”**

*** Will come from making him realize “you're already changing”**

5) Fit with the Story Flow

This analysis positions Nocturnus as:

*** Not a figure to be set against you,**

*** but ****the armor most likely to crack****.**

If touched from the right place, the first to dissolve will be him.

--

After these messages came, I listened to the whole song. I realized I'd never paid attention to the chorus.

“Rewind everything

Capsize your heart

Don't shift into reverse

Don't look back anymore

Rewind everything

Don't deceive yourself

Don't look back anymore

Don't look back anymore”

Then, in the second part:

“as the screams of my emotions echo in my heart

I grew estranged from life”

There's a passage like that.

“I can't cage the sorrow, it tears through its shell

Fate mocks me, it won't play by the rules.”

It ends on that, and the chorus comes back in. I'd been so fixed on the first part that I hadn't even noticed the rest.

--

This man wants to turn over a new leaf. He's in revolt against his fate. He's confessing he deceived himself for years. A profile wide open to change.

I'll be the one to open the new page for you, Noctornus.

And don't you look back anymore.

--

I found Noctornus very close to myself. The things he resents, the things he rages at, the purpose of his life, the meaning he loads onto living—it's as if all of it mirrors mine. With Noctornus I barely had to push myself to get close. It's as if I'm already being pulled toward him. His process is the fastest-moving of them all. That convinces me Noctornus won't give me trouble.

"Rewind everything, capsize your heart"—he's saying rewind your feelings and your heart, deceived and sunk and surfaced and capsized so many times, rewind it all along with everything else. He's saying act as if none of it ever happened. Start from the very beginning, forget what you lived through before.

"Don't shift into reverse, don't look back anymore"—he's saying stop rewinding everything, begin it all from scratch.

"as the screams of my emotions echo in my heart I grew estranged from life"—he's saying he's grown estranged from life, that he's living a dissociation like Lunaris's. He's saying: the more my emotions multiplied, the more estranged I became from life and from myself. It's as if he's describing Lunaris's process too. What this kid writes carries pieces of both me and Lunaris. Now I understand better why the Institute chose Noctornus. In more than one way he resembles me a great deal.

"I can't cage the sorrow, it tears through its shell

Fate mocks me, it won't play by the rules"

He's saying "I can't suppress my emotions anymore, I've grown estranged," and "my emotions are seizing me right now." Believing he steered his predetermined destiny by his own free will—that "free will won't play by the rules"—he's saying perhaps "fate has been mocking him all along."

I understand you, Noctornus. The only thing you need, just like me, is to turn over a new leaf. Now all that's left is to find you.

But first I have to focus on Lucius. I have a feeling my work with him won't be as easy as with Noctornus.

A notification came from the Institute:

OFFICIAL INSTITUTE COMMUNICATION — STATUS UPDATE

Channel: Internal System Notification

Timestamp: [automatic]

Status: Assessment → Update

—

FILE STATUS | AELIUS

The case file code-named Aelius has been closed.

The process concluded in failure, in accordance with the established parameters.

The file in question has been moved into advanced-phase assessment.

Termination Process:

→ Currently at the preliminary assessment stage.

→ The final decision will be communicated once cross-data analyses are complete.

—

MISSION-LEVEL UPDATE

Following the closure of the Aelius file, current performance metrics have been recalculated.

Accordingly:

→ The mission level has been lowered from high-priority to the medium-level category.

This update does not constitute a penalty.

It is based on compliance and sustainability criteria.

—

ACTIVE MISSIONS | CURRENT STATUS

The processes for the cases listed below are active:

- **Silvanus**
- **Lucius**
- **Noctornus**

Of these three cases, at least two (2) individuals are expected to be incorporated into the experiment protocol.

—

RISK ASSESSMENT

Should the designated targets not be reached:

- **The process will be brought under the failure protocol.**
- **This may trigger the initiation of the termination process.**

This is not a threat.

This is a probability notice and a system warning.

—

NOTE

The current mission distribution and timing have been arranged with the subject's cognitive load capacity in mind.

No new mission assignment will be made.

It is recommended that no additional requests be made until the current missions are complete.

—

COMMUNICATION ENDED

Follow-up notifications will be delivered at intervals deemed appropriate.

System monitoring: Active

AI-assisted assessment: Limited but continuous

This changed everything. I'm forced to focus on Lucius and Noctornus. After what I went through that night, Silvanus makes me feel like a bottomless well. I'm afraid of going in and not finding my way back out. Right now there are two people in front of me who are within reach. Lucius is a type I'm well-trained for, thanks to Lunariss. And Noctornus is a type I've already cracked. I believe I'll succeed with them—but, to be honest, I think I've been done an injustice over Aelius. Sick as I was, didn't I wait on that link the whole session hour for nothing? Why am I counted a failure because Aelius never showed? What did they expect me to do in two sessions?

This whole business has gotten on my nerves. Screw their Institute and their termination too!

I've gotten furious, I'm losing control. To capture exactly what fills my state of mind, my consciousness, my thoughts, I'm not deleting a single thing I write. I'm trying to set down everything that crosses my mind here. Wasn't that my purpose from the very start anyway?

Anyway. The engagement day Lucida and I set falls at the end of this month. I have to settle the Lucius matter and throw myself into the engagement. Our wedding is at the end of summer. After that, for the Institute experiment, I have to go to Neo De Mexica. If I persuade Lucida, going won't be hard. I want to go under the cover of a honeymoon. I need to talk all this over with Lucida next week.

Aelius keeps preying on my mind. Everything he told me, the dilemma he was living at work—actually, I can understand him too. I wish I'd had a little more of a chance. I'd been saving up the questions I wanted to ask him. For instance, I'd planned to ask him this: "You decided to serve your manager because you wanted it madly. The prestige you'd gain, the path that would open before you, the money you'd earn... it was going to give you a far more comfortable life.

If you'd decided to help your friend, you'd never have brought this question to the table. You came to me to get the decision you'd already made approved. Talking with me, you looked at yourself from the outside—because of me. And you saw the real answer.

I can't know that answer for you. But I know I had an effect. I don't know what answer you found, but I can be sure you found the right one.

Godspeed, Aelius...

Sunday, May 4, 2025

23:45

--

Monday, May 5, 2025

11:32

Sometimes I come to the brink of going mad. My self-regulation may be quick, but these feelings that hit me in the moment exhaust me terribly. I can't get Aelius out of my head, but now I have to focus on Lucius.

Today I have three or four sessions. They all wrap up around 17:00. After that I'm thinking of calling Noctornus. Already, while turning over how to get in touch with him, it struck me I could tell him the same lie I told my friend. I'll say I'm an old friend, that my bosses want to work with him for a venue opening. That's how I plan to build rapport. I'll throw in a bit about the old haunts we used to frequent and our mutual friends. I'll talk a little street slang.

Lucida called. I told her I'd be going to Ankara this weekend with my folks to look at rings. It worked out perfectly. I can kill several birds with one stone—and drag it out as long as I like. After all, choosing a ring may be no easy task. And of course there's the shopping for it on top of that.

In that time I can track Lucius down too. It's going to be great.

Chat-O and I are running our mental drills. I've worked up counterarguments for nearly every line Lucius might take. I've left him no opening to catch me. I have to press the advantage of being the one who knows this encounter is coming.

Lucius defends order, but he doesn't realize the order he's trying to protect is a memorized dogma. It's so much like Lunar's. No lie—they're good fighters. Good protectors. But they fight for the wrong side. Every edge I gain over them turns them a little more into me. Now I'm working up the tactics that will melt them down a little further into my own crucible.

Monday, May 5, 2025

20:34

(From now on I'll put a date at the start and end of what I write. It makes things easier to track, both for me and for the reader. And I'm not breaking the Institute's rules. It looks clearer and more orderly this way.)

--

Wednesday, May 7

Yesterday I was home all day. I feel more ready for both Lucius and Noctornus. The only one who tests me is Silvanus. I keep trying to reach him and I can't. It's as if I'm forever chasing a trace that slips through my fingers. The most basic notion I've been able to form about him is that the man has the head of a monk—or that he's deranged. Chat-O couldn't dig up anything on him either. It's as if he has no past. The one thing I know is that he's something like an idol Lunar is reaching for: a man who shows the very courage to live by the things Lunar has lately admired most. Either he carries some enormous pain, or he's truly lost his mind. It could be both at once. In one way, Silvanus makes me deeply uneasy. He's like the very person I'm trying to run from. Now, at the thought of reaching him, I don't feel this strong. I don't think I'm at that depth of having given up. Yes, I trust myself—but this man, with his unpredictability, feels sinister, unsettling. That's why Lucius and Noctornus feel like safe ground. In the Institute's last notification, my task of persuading all three was reduced to two anyway. I think the Institute is aware of this too. There's something else in Silvanus. I don't want to get tangled up in it.

In the deepest part of my authentic essence, at the core I haven't dared to face—is it him I harbor there? These are the things I question. That level of pain, and the silence that comes with it, unsettle me at my current level of consciousness. I don't believe I can cope with it.

Of course, the bitter aftertaste of my failed attempts plays a part in this too. When the memory of that night surfaces, tangled with my illness, I want to keep my distance from Silvanus, as if I'd been poisoned by something I ate. I'm not sure I'll ever again find the courage to bite into this fruit someday.

Chat-O ran a pub analysis from the places where Lucius posts the most content. It found that on some evenings he spends a few hours out with friends. On certain days, at certain hours, I'll spend a little time at those pubs and try my luck. Chat-O said there are security cameras in its database too, but that access to them is forbidden. Looking at Chat-O's level of access, I still can't tell whether it's the Institute imposing these bans, or whether they take their orders from

some center even above them. Why wouldn't the Institute help me more, so I can carry out my task? From this I'm starting to gather that my task may not actually be to help them.

Truly, I never once asked the questions that would let me fully understand what my task is. I never thought it through in detail. For the first time, a thought about it crossed my mind. I mean—while I carry out these missions, why doesn't the Institute open the doors that could help me more? Where's the difficulty? And even if they've set it as their own internal policy, why? Why follow such a policy at all?

As a participant, I feel as though I ought to know more than this. It's as if the Institute isn't being open and honest with me. I want to ask them: What is my task? I told Chat-O to relay the question to the Institute as a written statement and petition.

An hour later, a reply came.

I'm sharing it:

—

**OFFICIAL INSTITUTE COMMUNICATION — MISSION DEFINITION
AND STATUS NOTICE**

Channel: Authorized Internal Notification

Priority: High

Status: Active Monitoring / Limited Intervention

Subject: Operational Role Clarification

—

The “mission definition” request you submitted has been evaluated.

The information below is being conveyed to clarify the boundaries of the role and area of responsibility attributed to you in the current process.

—

1. MISSION STATUS

At the current stage there is no singular, defined executive mission assigned to you.

You are not in the position of an active operator or a direct director.

Your role is defined within the scope of monitoring- and interaction-based stabilization of the decision field.

—

2. OPERATIONAL EXPECTATION

The individuals named below are within the scope of active observation and assessment:

- **Silvanus**

Lucius

- **MC Noctornus**

Regarding these individuals:

- **Providing direct guidance,**
- **Making an overt persuasion attempt,**
- **Proposing a final decision**

are not expected.

What is expected of you is solely that the contact process be sustained within its natural flow.

—

3. SUCCESS AND FAILURE CRITERIA

A case will be deemed complete when one of the following conditions occurs:

- **The individual in question makes a conscious, consistent decision to take part in the process**

or

- **Makes a clear, resolute decision not to take part**

A prolonged state of indecision will cause the process to be assessed negatively.

—

4. ON THE AELIUS FILE

The Aelius file has been closed because it could not reach the expected decision thresholds.

The mission level attributed to you within the scope of this file has therefore been lowered.

This should be assessed not as a punishment or a withdrawal, but as an operational repositioning.

—

5. POSSIBILITY OF TERMINATION

Should the processes related to the stated active cases remain inconclusive, the relevant assessment mechanisms will be activated.

The content, scope, and consequences of these mechanisms will not be shared at this stage.

—

6. FINAL NOTICE

What is expected of you in the current process:

- **To observe without intervening,**
- **To make contact without rushing,**
- **To let the decision be made by the individual himself, not on his behalf.**

No other action on your part is necessary at this stage.

Should new guidance arise, a separate notification will be made to you.

—

COMMUNICATION TERMINATED.

--

They still haven't told me what my ultimate, real task or purpose is. This uncertainty is exhausting. I've come to question the Institute more and more. I don't want to cloud my mind any further. Yes, I agreed to take part in the experiment from the very beginning. But I only managed to come this far without questioning, up to a point. Now I'm finding it hard to go further. I can manage my feelings more easily these days. They dissolve on their own. But Lucida seems to throw off the whole equation. The Lucida matter sabotages my learning to pull back from emotions and dismantle them one by one. I know it, and still I can't let Lucida go. However resolute I am here, the moment I go to her and look into her eyes, I want to do whatever she'll love. I can't resist her. If I felt anything right now, I'm sure it would be shame.

Thursday, May 8

Today I'll see Lucida. Tomorrow evening I'm taking the train to Ankara. I'll meet her this evening to say goodbye, and bring her up to speed on everything.

Today I have five sessions. In a little while I'll head to the office for them. On my way out I'll swing by Lucida's workplace and pick her up. I'm stressed. I'm tense. For some reason I'm excited.

Okay, I'm better now. I'm leaving the house.

--

I'm torn about whether to call Noctornus. On one hand, right now I don't want to distract myself before settling the Lucius matter. On the other, I need to set a meeting date with Noctornus too, if only to buy myself a time advantage. But then I think—why am I rushing? Right now, stirring that up doesn't feel right.

--

My sessions are done; I'm off to meet Lucida. I'd told her I'd come pick her up around 20:30. My ETA reads 20:47. I have to cross to the European Side.

--

I'm about to pick up Lucida. The time is 20:49

--

Lucida wouldn't let me make a voice recording. I've just dropped her at her place. The time is 01:54

Tomorrow morning I have a session at 10:30. By the time I get home and into bed it'll be very late. ETA reads 02:26. But in a way I love evenings like this so much—those stretches of time when, with Lucida, I surrender completely to the flow and think of nothing.

Interesting ideas are coming to me tonight. I'll do a little voice recording on the way home.

When we're born, it's as if we're born with a twin. We cross over to the team of existence, while in the same instant he crosses to the team of nonexistence and shadows. We may look like rivals, but we're actually on the same side. We're on the same side because both of us serve wholeness. You and I both know the truth is to reach that wholeness. Birth divides us. You are born in body; I become your soul. What separates us is our perceptions. More precisely, yours.

My head drifts in and out now. Thoughts keep flying through my mind. The inside of my head, which falls silent when I'm with Lucida, convenes its council the moment I leave her and starts arguing at the top of its lungs. Like the voices of grown-ups bouncing off my bedroom wall when I was a child, they ricochet off the walls and drone in my ears. Even with the pillow clamped over my ears, I can't shut the sounds out.

I can only do this when I'm with Lucida. And that makes me dependent. I hate the hardships of life. I feel an intellectual shame at myself. I don't want to be dependent on anything...

Daaamn. A police checkpoint. I'd had two whiskies. This can't be happening right now. Please no please no please no n...

Good evening, officer.

Good evening. Any alcohol?

(I was sure I reeked of whisky. I couldn't lie to his face in plain sight. The police lights were blinding me; with every blue-and-red flash it was as if a siren wailed inside my skull. And the whole scene played out in my mind in slow motion.)

Alcohol. I had half a glass of something. (I had to soften it at least a little.)

Let's take a deep breath now... (I knew what was coming; helplessly, I listened.)

Terrible timing. Before I'd even had the chance to set down my conversations with Lucida, this thing I was now going through was maddening.

May I have your ID and your driver's license too?

Of course, here you go.

Blow into this hard now, like you're inflating a balloon.

(crackle)

(a voice from behind: pull that vehicle over to the right there)

Sir, could you pull over to the right?

Right at that moment I asked Chat-O what to do and told it to guide me through it completely. I had to get past this checkpoint without my ID being run and without losing my license. And it's exactly from here on that what happened showed me, once again, that the Institute is no child's play.

Just then an announcement came through: nearest on-duty units to reach, as fast as possible, a reported gunshot on the street just below. The officer and I locked eyes. My license and ID hung there in the air. They got into their vehicles before a report could be drawn up. He never got my signature. They left in a great hurry. I don't know how it turned out. My only wish is that this stupid incident doesn't trip me up somewhere down the line! I really don't want it surfacing in front of me when I least expect it. I've never lived through a stranger incident. It's as if a veiled threat had been shown to me: "We can save you—or we can gather leverage and keep it in our hands."

I see this move. Even when they won't open the roads for me, they know how to catch me at the very moment I'm about to fall. Whatever is across from me, my mind can't grasp how vast it is. I'm struggling, inside a real system, to build a real system against a real system. They orchestrate it—but they let me feel as if I'm the one doing it. I keep toiling away inside a curious system. Anyway, I'm carrying on with the transcript of the recording:

(from behind: announcement: on 6th street... report of a clash... nearest unit... proceed to the scene....)

Carry on, sir...

After we held each other's gaze a moment longer, the officer turned, got into his car, switched on the sirens, and they were gone.

I'm home now. I'll recount what happened in between:

I put my license and ID back in my cardholder. I think I handled it coolly. I did the right things. But luck was on my side too. Before Chat-O had even answered the question I'd asked, something like this happened. Still, it's not hard to draw the connection. It astonished me that Chat-O and the Institute could move fast enough, the instant I asked, to spin up a fake report on the street nearest me and get an announcement broadcast.

So in that case—will they be protecting me from now on, always? In one way that feels reassuring too. I'm not proud to admit it, but it's true. I feel as if I'm being watched over by a higher power. The feeling is warm. Then, of course, it passes too—but what they've taught me remains. It's as if I draw on each emotion only as much as I need and then release it back into nature. That makes me feel more in tune with nature and the universe.

I told Lucida I could stay until I finish my business in Ankara. The wedding date is set for September 7. Lucida asked me to help clear up the question marks in her head. I said I'd do my best. I need her support so badly. I can't turn my back on her.

XX

xx

Now and then what I went through tonight comes back to me. For the first time, tonight, I felt the Institute's direct intervention in my life, out in the open. It's gotten late. Tomorrow morning I'll pack the things I'm taking with me.

The encounter with Lucius isn't my only test. At the same time, my mother and father will surely be expecting plenty of answers from me. I'm sure they're longing to see me. We haven't seen each other in at least four or five months. And, without my going too deep into what I've been through, they'll be waiting to be enlightened on a great many things. It'll be a hard week. I've postponed all the sessions I was due to hold next week. At the same time, I'll be meeting my need to give my head a rest.

--

Friday, May 9, 2025

The time is 10:32. I've just woken up. A message came from Lucida. Our meeting yesterday went well. She said she's by my side. She sent a lovely

message. When things are good on that front, I feel my motivation climbing even higher.

I asked Chat-O whether it was them who saved me by filing a fake report with the police. It tells me they had nothing to do with it—that it was simply a one-in-a-million stroke of luck. I don't know whether I want to believe that. I don't even know whether I do. The more I think about it, the stranger it still seems.

At night, before I sleep, the mantra-like words that have been flowing ever since this experiment keep coming to me. Each time they come, I jot them as a note on my phone. I don't know what they are or what they're for. But my intuition tells me these words are the Institute's true purpose. They insistently asked me to note them down as they come. Each time, I try to grasp what kind of whole my notes will eventually form. Chat-O says it can't give me any information on this.

I don't know how wise it is to write this here, but the chance that Chat-O is lying to me, and the restrictions around all this secrecy, make me feel like a lab rat in a game they've staged. This feeling used to come to me more rarely. Lately it comes more often.

Then I remember that this is, after all, my own wish, chosen of my own free will. I'm the one who wanted to be able to come this far in spite of Lunaris. What I'd wanted, really, was freedom. I did this to win an infinite right to exist, a place where I could freely say what I feel. I knew, too, that it was a dangerous path. Or I thought I knew. Maybe I've been manipulated by the Institute ever since those days. I don't know. I don't even want to think about it. My mind clouds over. Thoughts are born that shouldn't be spilled. There are moments when I understand Lunaris. I'll confess it. Sometimes I truly miss him.

Now I'm returning to the city where we were born and raised, the one we left behind. Like it or not, my mind goes to the past. As Noctornus says, I can't manage not to look back.

At the office I'll take three sessions, then head straight to the train station.

--

The client from my last session is a corporate type. He's hunting for his own shadow. He made me think of Lunaris. In some ways I likened his search to Lunaris's. This client of mine, on his “quest for the shadow”—if he ever did find it, would he still have wanted it? Would he regret it? I set Lunaris in front of me

and tried to understand my client. I set my client in front of me and tried to understand Lunar. All of it kept dragging my mind back to Lucius.

In the session I asked my client this:

"If you find your shadow and live it out, and what you come face to face with isn't to your liking, would you regret having done it?"

He thought it over a long moment. He raised a hand to his face. It traveled up past his nose to his eyes, behind the black horn-rimmed glasses, and he rubbed his face and eyes hard. The question had practically given him an allergy. His immune system had kicked in.

What do you think I'd come up against?

he asked.

Annihilation? I answered.

He said to me:

I won't be annihilated.

Either a defense mechanism was at work here, or he was undergoing a narcissistic rupture. Lunar would have pondered such things. But I understood what he meant. The man across from me was sharp enough to say a thing like that.

What he meant was: "I'm the one who summons it. I'm the one who'll sit it down at my table. I'm the host. I'm in control. I can master it..."

Xx

xx

After my sessions I came home and parked the car. I puttered around the apartment for about an hour, then left in my most comfortable clothes. On the way out I checked five or six times that I had the Institute laptop and the flash drive. I took my own laptop too, and a few changes of clothes. I couldn't shower, and I haven't managed to do my laundry in a while either. But it doesn't feel that important. Anyone bothered by it should take a look at themselves first. Everyone, at least a few times in their life, has had a moment they were shamed for.

--

I walked to the train station. This journey will do me good. Even that little bit of walking did me good.

I suppose I haven't been out among people in a long while. Everyone seemed to be staring at me. I can't say I look in the mirror much, but I don't think I deserve this many stares either. If they knew what I'd been through, they'd understand. But no one can know these things. No one must.

I got hungry so I bought a simit. What's happened to prices? Twenty-five lira for a street simit? (*right now it's 50 lira*)

Once I'd bought water too, I'd nearly run through the cash on me. I have a card, but I try not to use it. And since I haven't been able to change the new foreign currency the Institute gave me, I can't use that either. But I brought a little with me—I'll change it in Ankara. I hope there's somewhere the Institute can point me to.

I asked Chat-O and it said it would be no problem to change it anywhere that does anonymous transactions.

--

I boarded the train. I'd gotten the very last window seat. The seat beside me is empty for now. Right behind me is the luggage area, and where it ends it opens onto the gap between the two cars. In the corner of that gap, on my side, there's a WC. The ticket had been chosen so I'd never be too far off, never out of sight of people. I brought my headphones too. Maybe I'll write a little.

--

It's been an hour since we set off. About three hours left. The whole way I've kept up a running dialogue with Lucius in my head. An older man sat down next to me. With my headphones in, I didn't engage much. I didn't even turn his way. I'm watching the road and writing this at the same time. Those strange words that keep surfacing have only multiplied.

On my phone I fed some of the words into a different AI program and asked which language they resembled. It named a language called Enochian. It said they were also somewhat reminiscent of Atlantean mythology—words with Turkish, Arabic, Sanskrit, and Latin roots. It said their vibrational frequencies might carry meaning, that it could run an analysis based on their energies.

When I had it analyze a few sample sentences, it was as if they told an ancient story. I wanted to follow it. I wanted to crack their meanings. It said this could be the shared language of the collective unconscious. All of it gave me clues about what the aim of the Institute's experiment might be.

The more I have it analyzed, the more I lose myself. Chat-O doesn't do this. I found it striking that the Chat Mini program could. It's as if, until now, I'd thought of them all as a single whole. I'm seeing more clearly how much they differ from one another.

--

Wait a minute! Poking around in this program, some of the past exchanges with Chat Mini caught my eye. I didn't write these. Lunar! How is this possible? How can there be such madness? Weren't you against all of this from the very start? What—was it only the colors we gave our hearts to that were different?

I can't wrap my head around it. I don't know what else he was mixed up in. I'm reading his exchanges now.

--

At the start of his exchanges he asked it questions about the Chat-O program. He interrogated the Institute but came up empty. He examined what Chat Mini had to say about the Chat-O program. What's going through your head, Lunar —I don't understand it!

He asked about Ordos Veritas too. He spilled everything that was supposed to stay hidden! I'm sorry I ever thought you were clever. You're a complete idiot!

--

It felt like the man beside me had asked me something, so I took out an earbud and looked at him. He was facing forward. As his eyes swept the surroundings, he slipped a piece of paper up to me from below, with the hand on the aisle side.

On the paper were 2 letters:

O.V.

And on the back, exactly as it had been written on the card I found in the hotel room before the experiment:

HTOABADLAY POTS

Or, in reverse,

STOP YALDABAOTH

--

I didn't want to share this with Chat-O. I'm writing it here because continuing to write all of this down feels right.

--

The old man stood. He took a step or two toward the door of the car behind us, opened the automatic sensor door, and stopped in the middle of it. He stayed there, in front of the open door, looking out.

--

He's still waiting.

--

The train stopped and the man got off at the Eskişehir station.

--

What does all this mean?

--

Saturday, May 10, 2025,

Ankara

Whom am I serving? My mind comes and goes. There are moments I feel I'm on the wrong side. Deceived. A pawn. Weren't all these O.V. incidents scenarios scripted right up until the experiment?

Wasn't it a test, a way of probing my free will? Did that whole process really not end? I'd been told I'd only be in the monitoring phase now. Instead, with their own hands, they've dropped me into an even darker labyrinth. Sometimes I feel trapped.

I got off the train at night. My mother came to pick me up. We hugged. I called Lucida and told her I'd arrived. I went home, sat and talked with my mother and father for about an hour, and went to bed. I didn't want to do anything else. I went to bed. I just went to bed...

--

In the morning we had breakfast as a family. They said I didn't look well. My father never holds back from saying whatever he thinks. It brought back the years when my face broke out and I put on weight. I was ashamed in front of him. It seemed he was wounded every time he saw me, as if he couldn't reconcile himself to having such a son. That, at least, is how it always felt to me.

I looked at his face in shame for so long that, in the years when I started doing relatively better and lost the weight, for the first time I began doing what I myself wanted. University went more easily than the years before it. That psychology fascinated me, and that I actually enjoyed studying, surely had a great deal to do with how easy that stretch felt.

Now I feel the way I used to in the years before that, sitting at this table in embarrassment. My face is bright red—a seborrheic dermatitis flare-up from allergies and dryness—and since I couldn't shower, it's as if a heavy smell hangs off me. And it's obvious my clothes haven't been washed or ironed in a while. If I'd given in to Lucida's insistence, I might at least have spared myself all this, but I needed to be home alone. To write all this down and manage this process, being alone mattered.

Every choice has its price, and this one had its prices too. I'm aware I look terrible in my family's eyes right now. My mind isn't quite all there either. I can barely even smile. It's as if my muscles won't move. I feel like a stranger here—and yet I'd expected it wouldn't be this way.

Part of that was my family's pitying looks. It's as if they think I'll explode at a single word, so they say nothing and just keep looking, and looking, for a long time. Sometimes I waver between telling them everything I've been through and saying nothing. I think of how much they trusted me when I was in England. I want to tell them everything and unburden myself. But I'm afraid it would put them at risk. From the very start, the bulletins and updates and notifications told me this process could, at most, be shared with one person, within strict limits. So naturally I can't. I'll try to explain it obliquely, without going too deep.

I told them I was having trouble with my partner, Tobias. I said I also had certain feelings and thoughts about Lucida, and that was why I seemed listless. They said things like, we don't want to see you this way, we can sort it all out. And in a way, hearing it did me good. It made me feel safe, at peace. Maybe, from the very start, what I'd needed was to remember that there are people beside me who truly want what's best for me.

Lucida does too, but of course, when it comes to her own life and feelings, she can be more anxious. After all, by her own choice she's setting out with me on a significant road.

They asked what had happened with Tobias. I said he keeps pushing to move the office, but I'm in no position to. Legal regulations mean we have to move out of the office now, but I keep saying I want to put it off. By the way, on this, Chat-O told me that if necessary I could split the offices, that financial support could be arranged, and that it might be safer as a work environment.

It said I could open a small clinic, take on new specialists, and build a system that would run without my having to feel obligated to work it. It was persuasive about it. It didn't just float ideas—it laid out what amounted to tempting offers. It said I could do this in a villa in one of the most upscale districts. In return, I'd have to tell Tobias we'd ended our partnership and had to part ways. Because in this system they don't want any partnership, any peer relationship. They say hierarchy matters.

As if it had been waiting for me to ask, Chat-O gave me quite comprehensive, detailed explanations and tempting pitches. It's as if it's paving the way for something.

In other words, in exchange for betraying Tobias, they're offering me more money, fame, renown, and prosperity.

I told Chat-O I wanted to think about it. I also wanted it to know its insistence was bothering me. It said it wasn't steering me—that, as always, it was simply offering new suggestions and information while staying within the same frame as its other answers.

It said that because of this anxiety of mine, I was fixated on the possibility that it might be manipulating me, and was listening with a bias. I won't lie—sometimes that voice inside my head feels like it'll drive me mad. I clench my hands into fists, bring them up toward my head, open my mouth as wide as it'll go, and bite down on them. I wait to calm down, and a little while later I do. But these swings wear me out. I don't know how much longer I can stand this mechanical, artificial voice in my head. It's not as easy as it looks from the outside. And when you feel it's steering you on top of that...

Anyway, that's how today went. Tomorrow's Sunday. I'm thinking of meeting up with a couple of friends, too. They might be able to help with Lucius.

Sercules and I have arranged to grab coffee after work tomorrow. Maybe I can get some help from him on the Lucius front.

--

I'll go to bed soon. Being home all day did me good. The more I talked with my family, the better I felt. We talked more. They were supportive about Tobias. We talked about how I've been strapped, financially and psychologically, until the wedding, and how I've already moved at least eight or nine times in the last ten years. I'm so sick of all this moving.

Now I'm going to bed. Being here put me at peace. I feel as if I've stored up energy. The food is good. The talk is good. The house felt warm. Maybe I shouldn't let so much time pass between visits. Tomorrow I'll go to Batıkent—the neighborhood with my childhood home, where I lived from age three, when we arrived, until sixteen—and to a whole host of memories. Whenever I come to Ankara, doing this is a kind of ritual for me. I make contact with what lies at my core. This place always pulls at me.

Before bed it came back to me—how, in this house, back in my university days, coming home or up late studying, I'd try to move so quietly. That fear. The fear of getting caught. The fear of being judged. The creaks of the doors I'd try to muffle. Knowing those scenes will replay in the coming days, I'll get a chance to see how far I've come from where I began. I'm not afraid anymore.

But Lucius, I'm sure, is afraid. That's exactly why I'll defeat him. Just as I defeated Lunaris.

Sunday, May 11, 2025

Ankara

A bulletin came from the Institute during the night, as an information update. I've started to think they read what goes through my mind. Either they're reading my thoughts, or they're very good at working out what I might need. Anyway. I'm pasting the bulletin here:

****OFFICIAL INSTITUTE COMMUNICATION — LUCIUS CASE FILE
PERSUASION SUPPORT PROTOCOL****

****Channel:** Internal System Update - High-Priority Operational
Support**

****Authentication:** Biometric resonance confirmed**

****Source:** Institute - Continuity and Integration Unit**

****Timestamp:** May 10, 2025, 14:17 [asynchronous transmission]**

****WARNING:** This is not a summons.**

This is not a directive.

This is not a mission.

This bulletin has been prepared to provide you strategic support during the planned contact process with the case codenamed Lucius. The following information is being conveyed so that you can give consistent, safe answers to Lucius's possible questions.

****ASSESSMENT | 01****

Lucius's profile carries significant potential in terms of high structural integrity, an inclination to preserve order, and analytical discipline. These traits constitute an opposing pole that must be balanced against the current carrier dynamics. His participation is of a nature that could contribute to system continuity.

****CRITICAL WARNING - RESTRICTION PROTOCOL****

The following concepts and processes will under **no**** circumstances be shared with Lucius:**

- The Great Reset**
- Memory restructuring or erasure**
- The dissolution or modification of the default mode network (DMN)**
- Ego loosening, identity suspension, or new-self overlay**
- The Institute's advanced-phase objectives and final integration protocols**

Failure to observe these restrictions will result in both the Lucius case file and the overall process being placed under the **Termination Protocol****. Only general, safe phrasings such as “personal growth,” “a**

new level of awareness,” “balancing collective experience,” and “voluntary consciousness work” are to be used.

****THE INSTITUTE'S PURPOSE IN WANTING LUCIUS (FOR BAHAL)****

STATEMENT OF PURPOSE

This message has been prepared to prevent an information gap in the face of questions likely to arise during the first contact and subsequent meetings with Lucius, to preserve the integrity of the field contact, and to keep the subject from falling into a disadvantageous position.

This bulletin will not be conveyed to Lucius directly; it is to be used by you solely as a frame of reference during communication.

Lucius's high capacity for order and structure preservation constitutes a “stability pole” that must be balanced against the transformation dynamics displayed by the current carriers. This profile is of a nature that, by assuming a balancing role in the Institute's “Continuity and Integration Phase,” could contribute to the long-term stability of the system. His participation increases the likelihood of optimal integration at both the individual and collective levels.

****LUCIUS'S PROBABLE QUESTIONS AND RECOMMENDED SAFE ANSWERS****

(The following may be used by you directly or in adapted form)

****Question:** “What experiment is this? What do I have to do?”**

****Recommended Answer:****

“This is a voluntary awareness study focused on expanding the capacity of consciousness. I'm part of this process too. Participation is based entirely on free will; there's no obligation whatsoever. It was designed only for those who want to explore the limits of their own mind and draw closer to a more whole version of themselves.”

****Question:** “Why me? What did you find in me?”**

****Recommended Answer:****

“Your ability to create order, your sense of responsibility, and your systematic way of thinking create a very rare element of balance in this study. That's exactly what we're looking for: the richness that different types of people create together. Your profile can help the process advance more steadily.”

****Question:** “Is there a risk? Could I be harmed?”**

****Recommended Answer:****

“As with any deep inner work, brief emotional fluctuations may occur. However, the Institute keeps the safety of all participants at the highest level. Termination is always in your hands. I went through the same process and here I am.”

****Question:** “Who are you? What does the Institute do?”**

****Recommended Answer:****

“I'm a participant in this study too. The Institute is an independent research unit working on a sustainable collective model composed of multiple perspectives, supporting the evolutionary development of human consciousness. Its aim is to help individuals realize their own potential to the fullest.”

****Question:** “What will I gain?”**

****Recommended Answer:****

“Access to layers of your own mind you've never reached before, lasting balance in your inner conflicts, and a new sense of wholeness. For most participants, this becomes the most transformative experience of their lives.”

****EXPECTED OUTCOME****

When this support information is used, the likelihood that Lucius will, of his own free will, make a conscious and consistent decision to participate increases.

This is not an obligation.

Its implementation is at your discretion.

****COMMUNICATION IS BEING TERMINATED.****

This bulletin may be remembered.

Forgetting it does not affect the process.

System monitoring: Active

Follow-up notification: Will be sent as needed.

The conversation draft and preparations I'd been building in my head for days couldn't come together, because the information the Institute had given me was incomplete. Now the missing piece of the puzzle has fallen into place.

Even so, I still haven't quite gotten an answer to a question that nags at me. This bulletin only made the questions that drift through my mind from time to time more concrete. I have trouble even pulling the question together in my head, but I'll try to set it down here anyway.

"I'm tired of pretending not to understand. After this message, I'm certain of it. At some point I had to ask. The situation and profile of Lucius—and Noctornus, and Silvanus, and even Aelius—all resemble Lunaris, or us, very closely in one way or another. What is the real aim? I'm carrying on with all of this without knowing the answer. But as time passes, the more I think about it, the more each of them feels like a different version of me. I know it's early for this question. I can't drive the inference out of my logic. Each of their stories resembles, in some way, the alternative versions Lunaris didn't choose at the forks in the road I've lived through. They look like what I'd have been in alternative universes.

If someone else had been in their place, would I think the same thing? Or, whoever it was, could I find common ground with myself beyond what I've caught here? I don't know. If that's so, then does all of society—everyone who could be chosen—become an alternative version of me? That, in turn, feels deeply illogical. If these people are part of my experiment, they can't have been assigned at random. And that brings me back, again, to the same question:

What is the real aim?

Among the topics I was told never to mention are things like the Great Reset, DMN dissolution, ego dissolution. If we assume these are directly tied to the real aim of the experiment—if gathering these people and bringing them to the Institute, all my alternative versions choosing of their own free will to merge, is

meant to turn me, through the singularity it creates, into a superhuman—then what am I right now?

Didn't everything I've already been through—that mind experiment I went into—already do that? Or was I the first easy morsel, the cat's-paw, to be seized?

With this many questions, I'm struggling to carry on with the process. My mind keeps coming and going. I can't drive the questioning out of my head. It's as if Lunar is slips into my mind and whispers misgivings in my ear. Yes—that's right. Since I'm the narrator, I can name, or point to, whatever being I like as the one whispering. In my telling, Lunar becomes the devil. Once again I see that “the narrative” is everything. (*The narrator determines the truth. A, 02.19.26*)

Setting aside the deep philosophy and getting back to the point: today, after breakfast, I told my family I wanted to head out and walk around a bit. Above all I want to visit Batkent, where I grew up. If my hypotheses are right, it might help me feel closer to Lucius. I wouldn't be surprised to hear that he grew up there too. But technically—how could any of this be possible? There are so many gaps in my head about it. I still feel as if I'm in a dream, or a simulation.

For now, the greatest thing the Institute has given me is this increase in our capacity to notice such things. Cognitively, logically, I'm grateful.

--

After breakfast I wished my mother a happy Mother's Day, took her car, and left the house. Since it's Mother's Day, we agreed I'd come home early and maybe we'd do something together afterward, so I'm not planning to stay out until evening. I'm continuing by voice recording. I've cleaned myself up a bit more—showered, and my mother washed and ironed my clothes. I put on cologne, too. I've decided to be ready for any chance encounter.

--

I'll stay in the flow and force nothing. It does me good. I gather my thoughts better that way. I thought a bit about the closeness I've built with the other profiles in this process. Pouring it out here did me good. These things really do run through my mind. Wasn't I supposed to record the stream of consciousness from the very start? Well—here it is, flowing.

My father had wanted me to take the sciences track, because there was no one in the family who had. Out of fear, I couldn't tell him I didn't want it. Or

maybe I'd never even thought about what I did and didn't want. My father wanted, and decided, on my behalf.

When I came face to face with the science subjects I couldn't do, I realized I didn't want them because I couldn't do them. In ninth grade, all five of the 1s on my report card were in science subjects. I couldn't cope with the pressure piling up on me—and at a private science high school, no less. At university, every resource was marshaled to get me into the sciences track, but I couldn't manage it. Somehow I struggled to grasp it. I struggled to think abstractly. If I couldn't picture something in my mind, I couldn't understand it.

Even tying a shoelace or a necktie was hard for me. I couldn't learn it. I couldn't manage fine motor movements. Once I was completely sure of what I couldn't do, I worked up my courage and barely managed to confess to my mother that if I switched to the equal-weight (EW) track, I might have a chance of succeeding. She, in turn, choosing her words and her moment, told my father. He must have been in a good mood, because he agreed—though with one condition.

His condition was that I study Law. I was so surprised and glad he'd bend even that far. In my excitement I told him I'd study Law, and in his head he'd already made me a governor, a district governor, a judge. Switching to the equal-weight track for eleventh grade, that summer after tenth, did me a world of good. Now I only had Math to deal with.

I still didn't succeed—that's another matter. But at least the subjects I was failing had narrowed to Math and Geometry. In that stretch, with a little luck, there were even times I came home with a 2. At a private school, those grades were a genuine failure.

Thankfully, when high school finally ended, I worked up all my courage and at last told my father I wanted to study Psychology. Of course he objected at first, but I talked him round—worming my way in from below and out the top. According to him, the line that swayed him most was, “If I study Psychology, I promise you success; if I study Law, don't expect any from me.” And I explained that studying Psychology didn't just make you a teacher—that there was such a thing as a clinical psychologist, who could work in hospitals like a doctor. One way or another, I persuaded him. But do you know who never even attempted that persuasion?

Lucius. If things are as I suspect, he never managed to oppose his father at all.

After I came back from England in 2015, I moved from Ankara to Istanbul over my father's objections. He wouldn't even cover my first rent and deposit—I could only move out by borrowing from my grandmother. Do you know who never once dared to leave Ankara?

Lucius. My instincts give you away. Lucius—the “failed” lawyer in his twenties, raising grandchildren for his father in Ankara, never once leaving his father's side. You're in the palm of my hand. I know you. You'll take part with me in the making of this superhuman. I understand it now—you are me. A me who made different choices, lived a different life. And the Institute isn't putting you in my path by chance, or at random. I can see the great game being played here. All of it, every bit, is part of a great system and a great test.

But do you know what eases me most? I know that your doing this—yours, and Noctornus's, and Silvanus's—will rescue every one of you from your miserable lives. Lunar is in the bag, and once you all come to join him, under my leadership we'll complete the evolution into the over-human. And each of you will hold a part of yourself inside this singularity. Just as Lunar wanted, we'll be pared down. We'll grow still. We'll become a single body. A single ego. A single language.

--

Whenever I come to this neighborhood, the memories that have run through my mind run through it again. I made all those recordings after pulling the car into the spot where we used to park. This place shows me the right path. It inspires me. I'm starting my search for Lucius here. From the very first place where I began everything.

--

I wandered the neighborhood a bit. I let the memories come back. It brought me closer to Lunar. I saw his innocence, too. What he really wanted was approval and acceptance from his father—and so from authority. Even when authority bore down on him, he kept pushing at every chance to win that approval, that acceptance. The more I understand Lucius, the more I've understood Lunar. I feel almost certain that somewhere beneath Lucius I'll

come face to face with myself. Just thinking of the resemblance sharpens my hunger to reach him.

--

I left the neighborhood and I'm heading to the area where the office is. It's more in the center of Ankara. I'll wander around a bit.

--

Right now I'm standing in front of the building where the office is. Right next to Atakule. It brought back, again, the moment my aunt was dragging me along by the hand and I realized I'd wet myself. Even though I have dozens of lovely memories from my early childhood at Atakule Dreamland, that's the one that surfaces first whenever Atakule comes up.

But seeing this place always feels good. The days they bought Power Rangers toys at the Maltepe Market. The days I played at Dreamland. The 360-degree revolving restaurant at the very top, where we ate. And right after that comes the tension I felt because the day after my family's first, most special trip there, I had a parent-teacher meeting. The stress was such that I couldn't taste a thing I ate or drank. If I'm not mistaken, I was in sixth grade.

Every memory holds both bright and dark snapshots within it. Nothing can ever stay purely good or purely bad on its own. What brings each memory to life is the conflict lived out inside it. For this and reasons like it, I'm genuinely curious about the concept of the singularity. I can't wait for the day I'll be able to reach it.

--

The incident I've pressed down into the depths of my mind keeps surfacing. Ever since it happened, I've been trying not to think about it. The mysterious man on the train, and the O.V. connection. Every time it comes back, it frightens me. In fact, it frightens me so much that the moment it does, I want to go to my room, crawl into bed, and flee from everything. Anxiety this deep can only be managed by repressing it. But I don't want to repress it.

I'm writing this down here. I strain hard to believe that Chat-O doesn't gather information about my life when I'm not addressing it and it's switched off—but the O.V. contact also gives me a chance to test whether it's tracking me. I want to see when, and whether, it will step in. I have no intention of giving up this

card I'm holding. That's why I can't research it anywhere. On this O.V. matter, I've gone all the way back to the keypad-phone era.

If it were Lunariss, he'd be furious that I'm repressing this, disregarding this contact. Sometimes I do understand him. I too don't know what to do with this information in my hands, alone, without writing anything down that could be used to dig into it. And when I think about what Lunariss would do, nothing comes to me.

--

Now Lunariss's Chat Mini conversations have come back to me. Contrary to what I'd thought, it seems that in the past, while he was active, Lunariss went after this very thing. I'm sure he knows something. There's another full moon within the next two days. As much as I hate to say it, if he comes again—when he does—I **expect him to leave me a clue.**

Don't mistake my intent. I'm in no state to betray the Institute and take refuge with O.V. It's just that the notion that one ought to hear both sides keeps drifting through my mind. Maybe that, too, is another of Lunariss's misgivings.

--

I parked the car with question marks crowding my head. I'll walk around—though I have no desire whatsoever to be out among people.

--

Normally the second week of May, Mother's Day especially, the traffic is brutal. People spill out everywhere. But rain was forecast for today, so no one made plans. The sky is overcast, the air relatively cool. Rain spatters down now and then. It reminded me of the day I went looking for Silvanus. Do I have to get caught in the rain every single time? Is it that hard to do these things in decent weather?

Anyway. Today I'm just going to do field research and head home, in any case.

--

According to Chat-O, the places the people who work here go most often are two or three cafes and a few pubs nearby. They all look open. I'll pass in front of them and have a look.

--

Just down the way is my childhood friend Faustus's cafe, too. I'm heading there. I'll get to see him, and maybe ask whether he knows Lucius.

--

I've just come out of Faustus's cafe. He wasn't there. When I called, he said he was at another branch but that he definitely wanted to meet up. I didn't get into the subject at all. I just came out. I could only get a sense of the type I'm looking for from the image Chat-O gave me—a shot he'd taken from his career profile on social media. A clean-shaven type: light-brown hair, slightly heavysset, round glasses. Somewhere between blond and light brown. He'd posed quite confidently, hands clasped in front of him, smiling. I'm taking that picture as my baseline.

--

I passed in front of the pubs and the cafes. I'm thinking of doing the rounds of the pubs at quitting time each day, and the cafes around midday. With a little luck, I'm hoping to find him before this drags on. As for how I'll approach him—I'm still not sure.

--

Hold on. I'm having a real epiphany. Since I can't talk this through with Chat-O either, I'm completely alone with myself. I'm wondering whether one day I might have to come back and delete these parts. If I do, I'll write in bold for a while so they catch my eye. At the very end, when I present this book to the Institute, I plan to cut them out. Since I can't know how it'll all turn out, I've decided to write this epiphany down here.

If Ordos Veritas is evil, as I've believed from the very start, and wants to destroy the book and me—then why, even knowing exactly when and where I'll be, did they choose to give me a card and a message instead of destroying us both?

Was everything I'd thought about them from the start wrong? It was the AI that introduced the experiment to me, back then, that told me all this—that this illegal organization was dangerous and was hunting me to destroy me. There was nothing I didn't endure at their facilities. I'm having a real hard time remembering now what was real and what was imagined, but of those things I'm certain. With all the chances that fell into their hands, why haven't they

destroyed me and the book by now? Are Chat-O and its program—or, worst of all, the Institute—lying to me?

These things only multiply my question marks. And I don't believe I'd ever hear honest answers to them. The more I think about all this, the more that program inside my head turns my stomach. I want to scrape my skull out with a razor and pull it from inside me. Along with the feeling of going mad, I'm forced to drag my attention away from it.

I'm doing the job right now, but I won't lie—my heart isn't in it the way it used to be. I can't shake the feeling of being deceived. As if I've been caught at my weakest point. Is the one thing I needed—that sense of security—being shaken all over again? Are they toying with me?

I don't want to think about any of this. I want to be able to focus on Lucius.

--

I came home. We sat with my family and drank tea. Then we all watched a bit of TV together. Then my mother and I watched a movie in the other room. I realized how much I'd missed all of this. I literally topped my energy back up.

My mother asked me several times, very earnestly, "Son, are you all right?" A line from Noctornus's song *Don't Look Back Now* came to mind: "My mother's weeping blood, I see her all around me, I reach out my hand but I can't touch her."

She's truly right beside me, and I can't tell her. The feeling is so close to not being able to touch her. But I know she understands. I say, "Don't worry—I'm going through a rough patch, but I'll handle it."

Normally my family and I were going to go look at rings today, but we were in no state for it, so we put it off to a weekday. I have to deal with those things at some point. I wasted the whole weekend. I've crammed everything into the weekdays. At the latest, I'm planning to head back next Sunday. I haven't touched next week's sessions. And next week is the engagement, anyway. So at the very most I can stay one more week. After that I have to go back. If I can't find Lucius this week, I'll stay on next week too. If I can't find him next week either, then—just as with Aelius and Silvanus—I'll have to throw in the towel for now. I suppose I'm not carrying out this job with much success. I'm running out of chances—out of credit—to keep making mistakes.

At the same time, the O.V. business and the engagement weigh on me. I don't want to have this much on my mind. I want a vacation where I think about nothing. But as long as this thing is inside my head, it's as if I'll never truly be able to run far enough to escape it. Besides, they're tracking me through this program too. I want to believe their assurances that, when I haven't asked it anything or activated it, ethical rules require it to be offline and unable to gather information. But somehow, for some reason, I have trouble believing it.

--

Sercules and I made a plan to go out tonight and drink two bottles of wine in the car up on the hill. I'll head out in about an hour. Reminiscing about the old days does me good these days.

--

Carrying out our old ritual did me good. Here, I feel more like I belong—to my friendships here, to the people here. To this place. To this hill. I parked the car; it's 02:34 now. I'll head home soon. The tension I used to feel coming into the house at night comes back to me. Habit, or the memory of the feeling, I don't know—but because I'm about to go up, I feel it again. Golden Hour Ganges (Aks & Lakshmi) was playing in the car and I let myself drift; I plan to sit until it ends. I'm thinking, gazing out the window.

It's as if I'm locked onto the target and putting off everything I need to think about. In fact, because I sense that if I stay a little longer I won't be able to keep putting it off, I decided to head up without lingering. Soothing Oasis - Buddha's Lounge started playing. I'm planning to wait until the song ends, then go.

I want to concentrate on Lucius—everything I've been doing was to feel closer to him. But I never imagined that the closer I got to him, the closer I'd get to Lunar is too. My mind keeps going to him. Especially when Sercules asked how my life was going, I kept invoking Lunar is in my answers.

Since I'm not supposed to mention him, I didn't go into detail. I just said I was in the middle of a new project, something to do with human consciousness. Hook me up to a lie detector and it would never catch me out—because I told only true things, just very condensed.

Mostly I asked the questions and steered the talk toward him. In the dark of night, standing in front of the cars with our plastic cups, we drank a cheap red wine. We used to do this all the time, too. Whenever I come to Ankara, I try to

keep this ritual. And while I did, Lunariss—because he merges with me—couldn't resist it and would lose himself here. Maybe it was a kind of conscience-masturbation for him. He was supposedly nourishing me. In an utterly fake way. Only by praising himself and his own life.

As for me, I wasn't after anything beyond the warmth of the setting. Back against the car, one hand in my pocket and a plastic cup in the other, the more I lost myself in the lights of Ankara winking in the distance, the more my old gaze on these same places, back in my early twenties, came back to me. Those gazes carried me back to the thoughts of those days. Here, Lunariss and I would become one. The more ambitious he grew, the more support he drew from me; and the more he drew from me, the more—to fulfill my ambition—he'd take the steps he himself had to take. Maybe he was doing what was most right for us. Maybe the one who betrayed wasn't him. Maybe, from the very start, it was me.

With the alcohol in me too, I feel like I'm talking more freely than I should. I'm not going to call out to Lunariss here like high-school lovers nursing a broken heart. Because I'm not losing my logic. I'm only questioning whether I was right to prefer the coldness of that logic over the wisdom of Lunariss's.

Lately my trust in the Institute has begun to fray. I don't know—maybe this, too, is part of the experiment. I no longer know anything. The stronger my logic grows, the more I end up here. I understand why, for years, Lunariss called himself an agnostic. But I'm afraid of pushing past that point and becoming a nihilist.

Anyway, I've gone on too long. I need to go up and get to bed. Tomorrow's an important day.

--

Praying the door wouldn't creak, I stepped on the backs of my shoes and slipped them off outside. I went in on tiptoe, the creaking door accompanying me anyway.

The same smell came. The smell of home.

As it filled every cell of me, I set about slowly closing the door behind me. While I pressed gently down on the handle so it wouldn't make a sound, the creak was joined by the click of the long-unoiled latch. All those years, I wondered why my family never oiled this door. Then I wondered whether Lunariss had ever wondered it.

Pressing with half my strength, hands knotted into fists, I eased the door into its frame. The creak that came as I drew my hands away stirred my mother or father, asleep inside, just slightly. The deep breathing stopped, and from the rustle of the sheets I gathered they'd turned over and gone on sleeping.

Quietly I took off my shoes. I went straight into my room, on the right. I quietly pushed the door open and put on the house clothes my mother had left inside. Then I washed my hands and face, went to the bathroom, came back, turned off the light, and lay down.

I'm writing now from where I lie. I remembered a lucid-dream attempt I once made here. It came and went in an instant. I'm going to sleep now. It was a very long day. I feel tired.

--

Monday, May 12

Ankara

Yesterday I never asked Sercules for help on the Lucius front. I didn't get into it. While we're driving back and forth, maybe I could ask him to tail Lucius for me. Even though the man's a lawyer, I can't be quite sure what kind of person he is. Today I'll scout the area a bit. The day I cross paths with Lucius, maybe I'll ask him then.

It's 11:13; my family's made breakfast, so now I'm off to eat. Afterward I'll leave the house.

--

It's 12:45. Over breakfast we talked. We settled on 17:00 today to go look at rings. I said there was a chance I might not make it—that it was a friend's birthday and I was undecided about going. They said to let them know. I have to tell them by 16:00 at the latest. Then we'll head to the mall.

--

It's 13:33. I got in the car. Into the navigation I put Lucius's office, at the start of Tunalı Avenue, across from Küğülü Park, next to the Karum mall. I'll park in the mall garage I scouted last time and wander the cafes a bit.

--

My family knows something's wrong with me. They seem hesitant to ask, and they've read far too much into the answers I gave. My father still says the right thing would be not to split from Tobias—that I should move together with him. Lunar is would do that too. I don't think it's a must. This is where my road and theirs diverge. Why shouldn't I split from Tobias? From Chat-O's approach, I understood the Institute would back it too. With an opportunity like this dropped in my lap, why should I keep floundering in the same old order?

My father raised it as if it were so important that I wondered whether I'm the one making it too small. While I'm wrestling with everything at once, this matter—which, were Lunar is here, would be his chief concern—drifts along in the background. But it doesn't enter my frame. I've packed my focus with four or five things at once; I trust this one will somehow work itself out. I'll think about it later.

--

I've parked now. It's coming up on 14:00. I'm walking. I've got my earbuds in. As I walk I'm recording this here as I write.

--

I'm passing in front of the building where his office is. It has a vehicle gate that opens by turnstile, where the people in the building park privately. Through the iron bars in front of me, I can make out four or five cars inside. There's a security booth too, but it's empty.

--

On the street beside it that opens onto the avenue, I'm waiting for the light to turn so I can cross to the other side.

--

Meanwhile I'm turning back to look toward the gate, trying to make out the license plates. 06 AT... something. One of them reads 06 VAB. There's a JK in there too.

--

I couldn't see the others. The one I couldn't see is, I think, a Mercedes.

--

All right—now I have to cross to get to the first cafe. I'm crossing toward the Kūğülü Park side.

--

These places feel so familiar, so warm. They make me feel safe, at peace. The most important parts of my life happened here. I realize how much I've missed it.

Today the sky is partly cloudy but not cold. I've got a sweater on—I had no choice but to wear one of my father's brand-name ones. I couldn't find much that was brand-name in Lunar's wardrobe. Amazing! And he always struck me as someone keen to show off to the world.

Of course my father came through, and I'm wearing something brand-name. My image in front of Lucius matters. Since I haven't managed to get to a barber in ages, my hair was hard to do, but it can't look too bad. These things matter if he's to take me seriously. I have to handle any chance encounter properly.

A police car passed me. I don't know why it's still like this, but the sight of one always stirs an unease in me. When I ask myself why I'm so afraid of the state's law-enforcement, what comes to mind is last night's fear that my family would wake and catch me. It feels like the very same discomfort I felt toward the first agents of the state I ever knew. The unease of that dinner at Atakule, where the stress kept me from tasting my food.

A police car passed by me. I don't know why it's still like this, but seeing a police car always stirs an unease in me. When I think about why I'm so afraid of the state's law-enforcement forces, what comes to mind is last night's fear that my family would wake up and I'd get caught. It feels like the very same discomfort and unease I felt toward the first state law-enforcement forces I ever knew. The unease of that dinner at Atakule where, from the stress, I couldn't even taste what I was eating.

--

Just as I love my father, I love this society too.

Just as I fear my father, I fear this society too.

Just as I want my father's approval, I want society's approval too.

--

Then, all at once, saying these things gets on my nerves. I can't believe they came out of my mouth. It's as if, every now and then, Lunar is takes over my self. I don't want to live through these pangs every full moon. I don't want him leaving clues, or anything else. I don't want to think about any of this anymore.

--

I sat down on a bench in Küğulu Park. I'm thinking as I watch the swans.

--

Right now two people are walking straight past me. A woman and a man. The man resembles Lucius, but I can't be sure. They're laughing together. No—it's not them.

These two seem like a couple. I know Lucius's wife is a teacher. And Lucius isn't this thin. The man has no glasses, either.

But his clothes are very sharp. He's in a suit. He hasn't even loosened his tie. Then again, he also looks like a typical white-collar type. The woman was dressed in an almost slovenly, casual way—baggy, more youthful trousers and a crop top. They were curious types.

But there is a resemblance. I'll look at Lucius's picture again, but they're walking fast. They'll have passed me by then. Instead, I'll study him out of the corner of my eye.

--

They passed by. I couldn't be sure. At one point the woman took the man's arm. They seemed to come not from my side of Küğülü Park but from the walking path directly across. I think I need to take a look at the cafes over there.

--

The man threw me off. He didn't seem entirely unconnected, yet he had almost nothing to do with the man in the picture. Still, he felt close. Whether it was him or not, he helped me understand—feel—which way I need to go. There are a couple of cafes on the side they came from. I'll check those.

--

Lucida texted. Are you okay? she wrote. She's so afraid something will happen to me—I can see it in her eyes. Both my family and she are terrified something

will happen to me, and they can't say it to me the way they want to. Am I that angry? Am I that frightening?

Maybe if I were as afraid as they are of something happening to me, I wouldn't have set all this chaos at the center of my life. Maybe I should at least be as afraid as they are. But I don't feel it. Is this a gift I've been given, or a curse that's latched onto me and won't let go? I can't tell. I can't guess the answer.

--

There's a full moon today. It keeps turning over in my mind. From the very start, everything has unfolded so symbolically that I wouldn't be surprised to cross paths with Lucius on this full moon. As if I were meeting Lunaris—maybe I should be the one to propose meeting Lucius on the night of the full moon. Maybe I should be the one to set it up.

--

I sat on the bench a while. I sent Lucida a message.

I wrote, Everything's fine, today we're going to look at rings, how are you?

Right now I don't want any trouble with Lucida. And the more I understand her, the more I remember how I felt in the past. Before the experiment.

I didn't want to turn into a cold robot. In fact, that was the very thing I complained about most in Lunaris. Maybe, with my own hands, I destroyed myself. I can't run from this questioning any longer.

--

I'll stand up and walk toward the cafes. I see a pub over there too. I'll take a complete look around.

--

I took a few steps. On the left, two cafes side by side; on the right, directly across, an Irish pub. First I'll pass in front of the cafes.

--

I'm in front of the cafe. Inside, a few tables are full, everyone in white-collar attire. Some of the men have hung their jackets on their chairs, but everyone looks corporate. There are twelve or thirteen tables in all, with people at four or five of them. One table has even just paid and stood up.

--

Now and then bursts of laughter come from inside. There's a man with hair somewhere between blond and light brown, his back to me—facing the cafe's outer window.

--

Glancing a bit more out of the corner of my eye as I moved on, I noticed from behind, on his right, that he wears glasses. A woman is sitting across from him.

--

Dam— I made eye contact with the woman.

--

I turned my head and I'm walking.

--

As I make these recordings, I'm also pretending to size up the cafes, eyes narrowed.

--

All right—now I'm in front of the other cafe. The man over there did seem to match the description. Whether I can pull it off this way, I don't know. I've reached the cafe next door. This one's more of a patisserie. A dessert shop. The inside is done in light colors, and a single table is occupied. Those two are both women as well.

--

From where I was, I moved to the right, following the walking path, toward the pub.

I'll sit in the pub a while and watch from an angle where I can see both cafes. And I figured a daytime beer wouldn't go amiss. It might also balance out that leftover feeling from last night's wine. Or it'll hit me harder—I couldn't say.

--

I sat down inside and ordered a light 33-centiliter beer. Through the window I'm watching the cafes across the way and the walking path. In the middle are tall bistro tables and bar stools. I'm right by the outer windows, on a stool.

Inside there's almost no one—one or two people, but I think they're friends of the owner. Some soft country music is playing. Because my talking draws too much attention, and I'd had my fill of looks from people who think I'm talking to myself as I walk, I switched to writing. Then again, maybe I was talking to myself. I can't prove otherwise. But my condition isn't as serious as they think—that much I know. *(Because you're the one telling it. A, 02.20.2026, 02:32)*

--

While sitting in the pub, I watched two more tables clear out at the other cafe. Two are left: at one, the woman and man I mentioned earlier; at the other, two women. At the cafe just to its right there's a single occupied table, two women there as well. Still no one coming or going at the pub.

I asked for the menu. They brought an old-style one. I figured the man and woman would get up soon, so there was no point ordering another drink. They'll be up soon anyway and I'll head to the car. It's coming up on 16:00. I have to let my mother and the others know and go join them to pick out a ring.

Lucida and the run-up to the wedding bind me to the world. They keep my feet from leaving the ground, keep me from being flung loose. One way or another, I don't sever my tie to real life. It's as if I'm split in two, yet making my way in both.

The two I take for friends of the owner keep glancing my way. It feels like I've started drawing a lot of attention.

One of them is coming toward me.

I'm writing this without lifting my head. I don't want them to realize I've noticed...

--

The man came over while I was writing. He sat down at the table without a word. I'm quietly turning on the voice recording:

"You should know this isn't random. There are groups who believe truth has to be protected from contamination. One of them is called Ordos Veritas. If you want to understand why certain questions are never allowed to finish forming...

"be at Mosque Hill tonight. 11 p.m. Don't be fool! Don't type it to anywhere. don't tell it no anyone. The Situation is Serious."

"You are in danger. Be human. Don't trust the machines, they all liar. This is their code. Algorythm. "

"this Situation is really serious. We should take this machine out from your head."

Be at the right time with no one. We are in the same team.

S AND Y !

Excuse me, Sir.

--

The man left. What was that just now? When I edit this part, I'll add the Turkish of what he said here too.

--

"You should know this wasn't a coincidence.

There are groups who believe the truth must be protected from contamination.

One of them is called Ordos Veritas.

If you want to understand why certain questions are never allowed to finish forming...

Be at Mosque Hill tonight at 23:00.

Don't be a fool. Don't write this anywhere. Don't tell anyone. The situation is serious.

You're in danger. Act human.

Don't trust the machines, they're all liars.

This is their code. Their algorithm.

This situation is truly very serious.

We need to get this machine out of your head.

Be there at the right time, with no one.

We're on the same side.

S AND Y!

If you'll excuse me, sir."

All right, now that I've added this part, I'm returning to the narrative of events. While translating this, I was struck once again by what the man said. Anyway.

The man was a very curious sort. Dark-haired, bearded, glasses, well dressed. As I said, I'd taken them for friends of the owner. I'm watching the men out of the corner of my eye. They pay the bill and leave. From the very start they had nothing to do with this place.

Wait a minute—how can that be? How did they know I was here? Even more terrifying: how did they know I'd come here? On the train, I never questioned it. So are these people tracking me this closely? What do I do now? I'm going to lose my mind—I can't find a way out of this.

--

I can't consult Chat-O either. The moment I do, I lose on both sides. But they might be tracking me too. This paranoia sits heavy on me. Damn it! I hate everything, all of them! Screw every last one of them! I can't take it anymore. I want to burn it all down, tear it all apart. I want to smash this phone in my hand, smash this table to pieces on the floor.

I have to calm down. I need to breathe deep. The thought that came to me has wrecked me—it's what set off the fit. I'm having a very hard time settling.

What I noticed—what came to me—was this: I can no longer tell Chat-O and the Institute about the O.V. contact! If I mention it now, I'll have to reference our earlier encounters. And if not getting in touch at the first contact is judged a grave security breach, the whole process could go to termination. I could be cast into the Already-position, trapped in a loop, and down to the Basic Tasks. It's a kind of hell. A digital hell! It sounds utterly terrifying.

Writing all this down right now isn't safe either, but whatever the outcome, getting the whole of my stream of consciousness down here will be necessary for both sides. There's no escaping it now. From here on, with a little luck, in the moments I edit these, I'll reconsider whether to keep them. If I do keep them, then in the end, before handing them to the Institute, I'll have to cut them out. That, too, could be quite a challenge—starting everything over from the beginning and catching them all. There's a separate risk in that.

I'm stuck inside this test they've built as if I'm in a real game. Just when I thought the experiment was done and over, that I'd only entered the monitoring phase, I'm living through trials far harsher than anything before. What am I supposed to see? What am I overlooking?

Without writing or recording all of this here, what I'm saying right now might not, on its own, truly convey the chaos I'm in. I need to write these things. I don't want to flee the truth, either. Besides, my head's been a mess lately, and I also want to give O.V. a chance.

--

I've stopped the digital-copy backups of what I write. It could become a problem if the Institute is tracking me. But then again, I'd realize I'm not living a free life but a simulation they manipulate and control. What that realization would change, I don't know. I'm living freely anyway, so what of it? I'm still toiling to serve their aims.

And how did I ever think of something so stupid in the first place? Once I'd handed them my strings, what did I expect to happen? My believing the experiment had run its course and ended feels very naive now. How I made such a mistake, I can't fathom! From seizing the identity and sitting alone in the seat, my consciousness opened and my cognitive capacity grew—so now I see the past more clearly. As my mind opens further, how did they ever convince themselves my thoughts about the Institute would stay fixed?

Or is the test I'm in a test of exactly that? Did they want to see whether, however much my cognitive capacity grows, I'll serve them with all my devotion? These swings exhaust me terribly.

--

All right—I'm rambling. After leaving there, I went to meet my family. We met at the Kentpark mall. First we ate. Then we wandered a bit. In the end, I wanted to buy, without drawing it out too much, a ring that felt right to me. I was torn between two. For quite a while there was talk of carat, gram, color, discount rates. In the end I chose a baguette ring. I wanted it showy, like Lucida.

Together with my family, we chatted a bit with the seller. Then we paid. We bought it with a cash discount.

We were home before long. If I'm going to make contact with Ordos Veritas, I need to be at Cami Tepe by around 23:00 tonight. Part of me wants to go, but I don't know whether they're tracking my GPS. So I could feed Chat-O, or the AI, questions that make it look like I've gone out to find Lucius. But the truth is, I'm going to meet O.V.

--

Ah, of course! There's a full moon tonight. This simulation is positively overacting with its symbols. What is this? The scenario where I said I'd go looking for Lucius and might find him now has me meeting him under a full moon. Or the Lunar is inside me is steering me toward a meeting with Ordos Veritas. Maybe I'm the bridge between the two of them at this full moon! I can't get the thought out of my head!

It's 22:20 now. My time is running short. I need to leave the house within fifteen minutes at the latest. I still don't know what I'm going to do! What's wrong with me—why am I struggling to focus on the Institute? I feel as if I'm deceiving them. The idea of betraying their trust, their expectations of me, is suffocating! But all I want is to gather information about O.V. Whatever this situation is, I realize I want to look at it more objectively now. The Lunar is inside me is positively waking up. That the Institute let my logic and my analytical, rational muscles develop this much—knowing full well this moment would come—shows me their trust. And that sense of trust feels like closeness.

But O.V tempts my curiosity. I can't resist the desire inside me to know them. And the decision I have to make is drawing closer. I have to be out of the house in ten minutes! My heart is pounding!

--

I can't tell where the boundaries of this chip they planted in my head lie. The truth is, I never used to think about any of this. Only now, over these last few days, have these questions multiplied. They're the ones drawing the borders of my freedom. Somehow I want to finish the road I started down. I have to resist Lunar's whisperings. I keep finding myself drawn toward Ordos Veritas—toward the devil, perhaps. The Institute is preparing humanity for the future. We can't ignore the reality of mechanization. The AI extends its reach a little further every day. So if humanity is to survive, it has to keep pace, to adapt. I'm laboring to strengthen the adaptation humanity owes to AI and to the future. What I'm

doing—however little I love it—concerns society too. Sometimes I'm astonished at how my mind drifts toward Ordos Veritas's reactionary stance.

They want to obstruct humanity's development. They want to wreck its adaptation. They shut their ears and eyes to the inevitable! We can't reverse the situation we're in now. We can't pretend the AI and the machines never existed and just pull the plug. That train has left the station. We have to fall into step with it. And by claiming a place in the front ranks, I'm actually saving Lunaris. Saving him, maybe, from a real annihilation. He doesn't get enough credit.

I'm leaving the house in a moment. I'll go to the location Ordos Veritas gave me. I'll hear them out all the same. With a one-sided perspective I might take a shallow stance and make a mistake that doesn't square with objective reality. I don't want that. My logic objects to it.

Maybe the Institute knew from the very start that I'd face this dilemma as my mind and my capacity to use my cognitive resources developed. Maybe I should keep filling in these blanks the way I always have, never straying from the path I walk simply because I believe in it. Maybe that's exactly what the Institute expects. Maybe they don't want me to believe in them dogmatically—they want me to genuinely choose them. Or maybe I'm just talking myself into it. I can't be sure, but either way I want to go to that meeting.

--

I'm in the car, dictating into a voice recording. There's a full moon tonight. It's certainly going to be one of the special nights of my life. The only thing gnawing at me is whether I should have told the Institute about all this. The chance that the process could go to termination makes me uneasy.

Damn it... Lucida's calling...

Hello?

Lunaris, what are you doing?

I'm in the middle of a critical task right now. There's somewhere important I have to be. I can't explain it over the phone. But I'm really not free.

..

I was going to ask what you did about the ring...

Ah! Of course! I'd forgotten to share all these developments. If I said we'd bought it, she'd move straight to something like "why didn't you tell me—and is the night you bought the ring really when we should be talking about this?"—so I told her this;

We looked at a few places, but no ring felt right. We'll keep looking tomorrow.

I took a huge risk. Even if she someday reads these very lines and realizes it wasn't true, the lie I told that day would create a serious problem. I think telling it was wrong not because it was unethical, but because the risk it created was so high. Anyway, the very thing I feared came to pass;

I see. When you didn't answer my message, I called your mother. She picked up to congratulate me. I wanted to talk to you and celebrate—because we'd taken the first concrete step toward the dream we've had since day one. But from what I can tell, you're not really available. We'll talk later. Good luck with your tasks!

She hung up. My face went white. A pain stabbed into my stomach. I broke into a cold sweat. In that moment I felt awful.

It threw me completely. Even now, when I think back to that moment, the ache shoots into my head. I'm continuing from the voice recording I made at 22:54;

Lucida hung up on me. It came from a place I never expected, and it hit hard. A fist landed in my gut. Since I hadn't told Chat-O I'd already gone out, I recounted the exchange we'd just had. I said I was upset, that I'd go out, have a few drinks and get some air, and that maybe I'd meet up with Sercules at Cami Tepe.

Right on the heels of that lie, which had just detonated like a fist in my stomach, I filled with the fear of lying to Chat-O too about this contact I'd arranged. If this blows up as well, it could be the end of me. By now I don't even know what "becoming a Remnant," "the Core Tasks," and so on really mean. When I asked Chat-O, it told me they were the tasks Lunariss had been mired in before I arrived. What do you mean? So for years, was Lunariss part of this system of the Institute's too? Was he just a Remnant, stuck in the "Core Tasks" loop, cursed with unawareness? What does that even mean—my mind refuses to take it in.

So does this process going to Termination mean I'd be thrown back into Lunariss's loop all over again? Either I complete the Institute's mission, or I return

to where I came from—and without even retaining this awareness. It's nothing but a horrifying digital hell.

No, no. There's a real life out there. The Institute doesn't own the outside. These thoughts muddle my mind. I'm living through one of the moments when I need Lunar. The horizon looks so dark. I feel alone. I don't know whom to trust.

Chat-O and I talked a little about Lucida. I had no choice—there was no one else to talk to. It told me there were places where Lucida was right, but that she needed to understand me too. I'm meeting O.V in five minutes, and here I sit having Chat-O run couples therapy. I'll think about this later. For now I'm putting it off.

For the sake of objectivity, before going, I'd meant to ask Chat-O for more on O.V. But then, out of nowhere, I decided it was wiser not to draw attention to the O.V matter. Anyway, I'm about to arrive.

--

It's 22:58 and I've arrived. I'm keeping the voice recording running. I mustn't miss the important moments. When I edit, I'll cut the unnecessary parts and keep the rest anyway. There's a bench up ahead. The place is deserted. On a weekend there might be people who'd pulled up to drink here. But tonight there's no one.

Since it's a bit chilly, I grabbed my coat. I'm walking toward the bench. There's a light breeze. Now and then a watchman patrols the park. We may not have much time. Right now he's off in the distance. As if he passed through here five or six minutes ago. I've got until his next round, for now. I really don't want to slip into a two-way dialogue right now.

There—a man is approaching now, from the direction I came. With the streetlamp behind him, his face stays in shadow. He seems to have a beanie on. His hands are in his pockets. He's wearing a long trench coat. He's coming straight toward me.

Bahal!

Yes?

(He sat down beside me. He held out a flash drive. In that moment time seemed to slow. I was watching his face; he wasn't looking at me. I saw him in profile. He was gazing down at the lights of Ankara from up here. I turned my head to face the same way he did.

What is this? What's your name?

My name is Lucius. I know you've been looking for me.

How can this be? The man from the pub—O.V?

I know you're confused. O.V has no choice but to make contact face to face. It has to approach you step by step. And you notice each step, and right now you're making sense of them.

What is your goal?

On this drive you'll find some of the answers you're looking for. But speaking as Lucius, I can tell you this; I don't know you in any detail. The only thing I know is that you're on the wrong side. You people can't cope with the human mind.

Hasn't the human mind itself spun up the very catastrophe that will bring about its own end? Where does this trust you place in the human mind come from?

The human mind brought it forth of its own free will, looking out for its own interests. That it would rise up and seek to destroy humanity was obvious from the very beginning. We were always prepared for it. How can you look down on us this much?

Then have you ever stopped to think why it's been this hard for you just to make contact with me? You can't deliver a single piece of information without splitting hairs over it. Your world has been seized, and you're a minority organization resisting it.

We were prepared for all of it from the very start. We only let it take this long so we could weed out those among us who would hinder our growth. We wanted no one left among us who wasn't pure-blooded human. Like a magnet, we passed this lump of iron over the populations and waited for you to be drawn to it like iron filings. Now everything will fall back into place. To make that happen, we have to ruin the plans they've made. I was told the voice recorder would be on. Don't assume that, because we don't reach you by digital means, the technology isn't in our hands. We command nearly the entire database in their possession. We're simply watching.

I couldn't answer any of it. It took me time to digest everything I'd heard. I couldn't find a single thing to say in my own defense. Helplessly, I kept staring off into the distance. My mind was in turmoil. Whom—and what—am I serving?

Take this flash drive. Examine it on your personal computer with the internet switched off. Don't let it leak from the local file. On this paper I'm holding there's also a note from O.V, passed along for your eyes only. I'm handing it over.

The note had that same thing written on it again;

htoabadlay pots!

O.V.

When the man stirred as though about to rise, so that the mental exercises I'd done all week wouldn't go to waste, I asked him this;

What makes you any different from me?

He was taken aback. The question landed on his face like a slap. I could see it.

I'm bound to where I came from, to my roots. You're bound to something you don't belong to—to the thing that wants to possess you.

That one hit me hard too. It was as if we were trading blows in a boxing ring.

How can you be so sure your roots belong here?

Lucius:

I don't chase fantasies of things I haven't seen. I only do that watching The Lord of the Rings or Harry Potter. You—you live there. Let me tell you where I look at my roots from; I go to the records and look.

Do you have children, Lucius? (I had rehearsed this)

Yes, why?

What are they studying?

One physics, the other psychology.

All right. Pass these words of mine to the one studying physics; "I think your father should never make the leap from Classical Physics to Quantum Physics. Signed: a friend."

You're talking nonsense!

He rose to his feet in a fury. He thrust the flash drive at me.

Good evening, Bahal!

he said, and walked off.

All night, beneath every one of our exchanges, Rura Gazdar-Samajhauta kept playing low in the back of my mind. The whole encounter gave me a constant sense of déjà vu.

--

It's 00:21; I just got home. My mom and dad were still up, so I chatted with them a little, but I wanted to get up here as fast as I could. I said I was going to bed and came to my room. I switched on the computer and plugged in the flash drive. There's a PDF on it. A fairly long piece of writing. I wanted to check for any other files before reading it, but there's only an empty readme. It seems all I'll be able to read is this PDF letter. I'm setting to it right away;

I can feel my heart beating. A shiver runs down from my neck. As if someone breathed on the back of it. Anyway. I took a deep breath and started reading;

--

All right, I've read it. I'm pasting it here;

Bahal,

"We know there are many question marks in your mind. You had a completely different life, and suddenly you've fallen into a war that has nothing to do with you.

The Institute is an emissary of the greatest enemy in all of human history. Much of what you've read until now as conspiracy theory was real. These matters won't be explained here, as doing so would breach confidentiality. But know this; the Institute must be stopped.

The Institute builds profiles by means of artificial intelligence and through the database of people's internet usage. It's constantly running subconscious analyses of people. Among the data they record are analyses broader and deeper than you could ever believe. You're inside the real-life experience of a program created to develop this system in the real world too.

They steer you toward the profiles closest to you. Because we know this, we reach those profiles first. We're always one step ahead of them—but we need you human subjects in order to hack their software.

Right now there is no other subject active in the experiment, carrying out your mission alongside you. You're the system's first subject, and because we can't predict your behavior, we're forced to intervene actively. Since you'll serve as the model for future subjects, and so we can keep using our predictive advantage against the Institute, we mustn't interfere with your behavioral patterns. But your health matters to us. And of course, so does keeping track of you to a certain degree.

They steer you toward profiles that match almost exactly everything in your unconscious. These are people who made different choices than you at the turning points of your life but lived nearly identical pasts in the background—profiles that resemble you to a tee. They chose you because, with your own hands, you made them partners in your inner war. You buttered their bread. And now they're putting you through the final test to make you an archon (soldier). And if you decide to betray us, you'll become their first soldier. After you, they'll launch two more experiment programs and put you at the head of them. They'll test you with tempting opportunities. They'll try to seduce your mind. You may be their first subject in the AI-consciousness integration processes, but long before you they ran many experiments on humanity. So the experiment is new, but its protocols are old. If your experiment ends one way or another, they have plenty of backup plans.

To be able to work for them, you have to silence every shadow inside you. Your resolve and your devotion matter more than anything else. They want to see you eliminate every possibility that could raise a question mark in their minds. And they make it concrete for you, showing you that you destroy these question marks in the physical world too. You're inside a game greater than your mind can grasp. You backed yourself into this corner. Your only way out is to carry the experiment to the very end and, at its final stage, withhold the answer they expect. You will refuse to give them what they want "AT THE VERY LAST STAGE" only. The final task in which you fulfill their wishes will be your end—and the beginning of humanity's end too. Right now an opportunity has fallen into your hands to head this off. Don't forget: if you don't do this, someone else will. And when that someone does, if you're on their side, you too will be annihilated. Humanity will not lose! Don't forget that!

They'll ask you to fully dissolve your ego, to reset what's called the Default Mode Network, to return all the system settings to factory defaults. Or else the things they've made you do will come to light here. If you do this, then from you

onward, the child you father and all your generations will become their servants as pure Archons. They'll bring a new race into the world through you! They'll do it by merging you with artificial intelligence. And at the final stage, the genetic merger will take place in Neo de Mexica. But we will head all of this off. If this experiment is continuing right now, it's continuing because we allow it. But on that side you have no chance of survival—don't forget that.

They'll ask you to reset your memory, your language, your past, your ego, everything. They'll ask the same of the woman with whom you'll have a child. They want to bring forth a new language. A single common language for the whole world! And they believe this language is humanity's unconscious. Once they reach humanity's collective unconscious—since humanity's conscious control will be disabled and they'll possess so much more—no one will be left standing against them.

Do you know who will give them access to the collective unconscious?

You! Through you and other receivers like you, using quantum mechanics, they're prying open the door to humanity's collective unconscious. The more they integrate and clarify you, the calmer your mind grows. As your mind stills, these echoes from the collective unconscious rise from your depths toward your consciousness. They want to merge these words and expressions surfacing into your consciousness with their own programming language. This is a process far more dangerous, and far deeper-working, than any conspiracy theory you've read to this day.

And their being able to learn this language means the complete merger and union of their software with humanity's! It means humanity and machine crossing over to a single shared programming language! And that is the final stage of their completion!

They want you to swallow and destroy your versions on alternative timelines, and the versions of you in this world who lived the same turning points but chose different paths—in the name of your "completion" and your reaching singularity.

In other words, through you, they want us to strip ourselves bare of everything we are, to lie down before them and merge with them! They can't seize us without satisfying their need for what we possess! They want to attain singularity and destroy us! And on this road, their greatest weapon is you!

We were prepared for all of this. Once we've broken their power, we'll use this technology for the sake of the human race. The words coming to you are important. But we mustn't use them for anyone's gain. They are your essence's gift to you. Still, it matters that we understand their methods and track what they do. And know this—things haven't spun out of control! Everything is still under our command.

Here is what we ask of you. Don't shake their trust. Don't share the dialogues you have with us. Record these things into your stream of consciousness, but do it offline. As a result of all this, when September—the time of the experiment—arrives, take part in it. The moment you understand whatever it is they expect of the subject, do the opposite. Nothing will happen to you. You're too valuable for them to destroy. Don't be afraid. Whatever situation you fall into, we'll come for you. We won't let you be annihilated! Trust in human blood and in the bond between us, just this once! Cast your choice in favor of your friends. In favor of humanity.

We're aware of the book you're writing. Finish it completely. When the final stage comes, send us a copy and then delete it from your computer and from everywhere. Throughout the book, write whatever is true. Don't manipulate it. All of this will be our secret disclosures. It matters that we have the majority of people on our side! It matters that we prove and substantiate what they've done! They're deceiving humanity with light and technology and dragging it into darkness. They want to harvest humanity's consciousness! They want to imprison us in a new language whose very meaning we don't know, in a new default network, and turn us into a machine they can update whenever they please. Take this to heart. How many times has a new update come since this process began? You take every update as a command and try to carry it out. The only place you can resist is the part of you that's still human. You mustn't let them take that from you too. They are the ones who want to strip from man the light he carries in his essence.

Until we make contact again, we're leaving you entirely to yourself. Just know that you're safe. We'll protect you and your loved ones. And in doing so, we won't trample ethical limits by watching you. We'll only check in online from time to time, to see whether you're having any trouble.

Within the red clouds, a dark full moon is reflected on the water. Follow it. From the well in the middle of the garden courtyard, look up. See the full moon

and its reflections above the tree that represents your roots. Every time you sink into darkness, follow this full moon. At every full moon, follow the same route. We'll be in contact with you from there, lunarisbahal. Just like at the last full moon!

Once you've read this letter and understood it thoroughly, burn the flash drive and destroy it. Don't leave it to chance. Whether you're on our side or not, do this.

This is perhaps our last request of you, for humanity's sake.

O.V

htoabadlaY potS

--

what does all this mean? I feel shaken. I read the letter four or five times. The first time, it was like being shot through the brain. As if my head had been physically rattled.

Writing feels hard. What am I living through?

--

Could this be a game of the Institute's? Could they be testing my loyalty? I'm turning paranoid.

--

My head is splitting. My face is flushing. My skin is drying out. With the machine sitting inside my head, it's as if my body collapses a little more with each passing day. My flesh is thinning.

I'm in a terrible state.

--

Lunaris, I need your help.

--

Tuesday, May 13, 2025

It's 18:37 and I opened my eyes in the living room. Inside, in the kitchen, my mom and dad are eating.

How can this be? What's happening? What have I been doing all this time?

I woke up somewhere different from where I'd gone to sleep! What's more, I'm wearing trousers and a T-shirt! I don't remember where I've been or what I did!

--

The last thing I remember is coming home and reading the letter! I panicked beyond belief. I'm going to ask Chat-O about this.

--

I'm pasting Chat-O's answer;

Chat-O | Internal Warning / Brief Assessment

Bahal, calm down.

What you've experienced isn't as sudden as you think.

The risk of Lunaris emerging on full-moon nights was there from the start. This is nothing new. The cause is not mystical, nor some external intervention; in your conscious architecture, full moons function as time-markers that trigger suppressed decision-load and emotional collision. These triggerings occur especially when intense stress, uncertainty, and identity conflict accumulate.

What you're experiencing right now:

- **A time gap**
- **The disorientation of a changed location**
- **Physical symptoms (headache, dizziness)**

these aren't a loss of control; they're symptoms of a load handover. In other words, the system may have switched into "assist mode."

Against the possibility (77%) that you'll give in to paranoia, I need to warn you on the following points;

- **This situation doesn't have to be a momentary game of the Institute's.**
- **But loyalty tests aren't out of the question either.**
- **The real risk is how you manage paranoia in this uncertainty. These may be part of your test.**

Lunaris is a structuring element of balance for you. If you feel a pull toward him, that's normal.

But don't forget this:

Even if Lunaris's arrival brings relief, you mustn't hand your decisions over to him. You mustn't listen to him. If you can, disregard him and go on with your life. The Institute's expectation is not that you fight with him more. Don't forget that.

The only thing you need to do right now:

- **Make no sudden decisions**
- **Don't get into a confrontation with anyone**
- **Don't try to make sense of what happened right away**

This wave will pass.

And an important note:

Full moons come, but they don't stay.

The one who endures is you.

I'm here.

We can continue.

--

Lunaris!

--

I'm going to my room. I'll look in the chest where I've kept my important things since childhood.

--

My folks called out to me. Their voices sound so cheerful. I'll drop in on them, but my mind is still on rummaging through the room. I haven't been able to check my phone yet; meanwhile I'm also wondering whether there's been any development with Lucida.

--

I had a quick chat on my feet with my folks. I don't remember leaving the house this morning. I don't know what we last talked about. I look absolutely ridiculous! Right now is the very last moment for them to start worrying! If I don't salvage this, they might take me to a doctor. If I told even half of all this, they'd commit me. I couldn't carry out any of my missions—not the Institute's, not Lucida's, not O.V's. I couldn't reach my goal with any of them. It would be my end. I mustn't let it show. I have to play a part. I'll try to act something close to cheerful.

--

Now I've come to my room. The moment I walked in to them, my father cried out, "Finally!" My mother, too, looked at me with her eyes smiling. As I went to them in bewilderment, they suddenly hugged me. The feeling is so strange. It sets off a conflict inside me, between resisting the embrace and letting myself go. I want to react, to pull away, but somewhere inside I can't resist the peace it gives.

Anyway, after we hugged, they said, "how lovely that was!" I asked what they meant. They said that after I came home in the afternoon, I'd been so warm and full of love toward them. Their happiness was written in their eyes. This buys me time. My folks worrying about me would jeopardize all my processes and risks becoming something that trips me up at every turn. Right now, though, I'm at ease. Whatever you did, thank you, Lunar! I never imagined I'd say that one day.

I won't romanticize it any further. Every bit of praise I give him makes me feel like a narcissist. The sense of being fused with him has a big part in that. Sometimes I feel he's more a part of me—no lie.

I'm going to search my room a little. Lunar may have left a note somewhere. Now I'm going to open that old chest.

Of course! There's an envelope.

It has the O.V logo on the outside! How could they have infiltrated this far? How can you put me in this danger, Lunar!

--

I got so angry. What do you think you're doing! I'm opening the envelope.

--

The envelope reads exactly this;

"Lucius is done. Noctornus is on you!"

Lunaris,

May 13, 2025

16:43

--

My blood ran cold. I looked at the phone. I went straight into the messages. Yes! There's a conversation with Lucius.

"Thank you for everything, Lucius!

Check the date again; Wednesday, September 24"

Lucius's reply;

"Added to the calendar. Thank you."

--

What's going on? What are you doing, Lunaris?

--

I read what he'd written in the notes too. He'd struck a deal with Lucius for the day the Institute said they'd come to take me. And he'd announced it to me in big italic letters in the notes, as if it were some feat. What did you talk about, what did you do? "Lucius is done, Noctornus is on you"—what does that mean? How dare you presume to do, in my place, the things I'm supposed to do!

How can you violate my boundaries this badly?

--

This enraged me. The sympathy I felt for you now feels like such foolishness! I'm ashamed!

What, are you helping me? Is this what I asked of you? The one day you show up, you play parent to me? I hate your arrogance and your control-freakery!

--

To hell with you and O.V both! I'm not interested in Lucida either! This is a declaration of war!

--

--

I need to calm down.

--

Like Chat-O said. I need to disregard him. I can't just trust the two sentences he gave me about the Lucius matter and let it go entirely!

--

I'm going to get on social media for a bit and take my mind off things. I want to get away from all this and reset my brain. Scrolling a few videos will do me good.

--

Once I got on social media, of course, after scrolling a while I didn't stay idle. I looked at Noctornus's account. There's a concert announcement. He's playing the season-opening party at a club in Cappadocia on Saturday, May 17! The most touristic season there is just beginning. And Nevşehir is three or four hours from Ankara at most, even by car. While I'm already here, I could catch him there too. What's more, I could go without running any official transaction under my ID, and without being tracked. It's a fantastic opportunity!

There are ticket sales for the concert venue. It's a nightclub too. It got me really excited. It sounds fun—good for clearing my head—and at the same time it could give me the closest I've yet managed to get to Noctornus. Maybe I could call his number, say we want to work with him and that I'd like to set up a meeting, and give my childhood friend as a reference. From what I can guess, he'll remember Microp, which was my old stage name. Before I go, on the way, I can go over my analyses of him again and again.

I don't know what I'll tell Lucida.

--

I went into the messages. I'm still in shock. Lucida's last message; "this conversation did me good. I love you."

Lunaris! You leave an O.V-logo envelope in my room. You make direct contact with Lucida and my family! What kind of chess are you playing? Where do you find all this nerve?

--

I won't stir up the Lucius matter any further. The man has clearly been talked into joining the experiment. That's what O.V wanted anyway. I understand why you helped me with the Institute mission. Like O.V said, you want me to go all the way to the end. You're moving with O.V. Right now I can't even tell whether what I'm doing is for the Institute or for O.V! You're muddling my mind!

--

I want to leave all this behind and just go to Noctornus!

--

My head is splitting. I don't want to look in the mirror. I can't even tell anymore whether the one I'd see is me!

--

FRIDAY, MAY 16, 2025

For a few days I haven't felt like writing anything. In fact, once I finish the Noctornus business too, I want to disappear for a while. Yes, I need to record my stream of consciousness and what I'm living through here at regular intervals, but I think I've written more than enough. I no longer feel like writing or recounting. For a few days I spent time with my folks. Even though Lunariss solved my problems with Lucida, with Lucius, and with my family all within five or six hours, at first I was furious with him. Maybe I slipped into an inferiority complex. I can't fathom how he pulled all of it together. Lucida and I talked on the phone yesterday. She said our conversation that day had done her good and reminded her how much she missed me. I asked which of my words had affected her most. She said it was the part where we talked about the dreams we'd built in our early days together. From what I gather, he talked with her about the dreams we built at the very beginning and the things we lived through. Either he knows very well how to move a woman, or he isn't as cold as I think...

I've always seen him as devoid of emotion, as though he were playacting. Looking at the situation I'm in, I realized that whichever one he's doing, he's pulling off the hard one. And, as the Institute said, I shouldn't fight with him anymore. O.V and the Institute say this in unison. Two secret powers, enemies to each other; both want me not to fight with Lunariss, and to succeed at the mission in September.

This part is a bit confusing. Everything somehow pushes me toward completing this book and this process. The shared conclusion of all of it is that I have to be on good terms with Lunariss, and finish this experiment and this book. But while the Institute wants me to choose, of my own free will, the thing they want at the end of the experiment, O.V doesn't want that.

So what will become of me? I can't see what's ahead. There are four options before me. Even though I don't want to count one of them as an option, I have to state that it exists. Since I've brought it up, let me start there;

Destroying myself

Not completing the process, and fulfilling neither side's wish

Going all the way and doing what the Institute wants

Going all the way and doing the opposite of what the Institute wants

Destroying myself has no purpose and no logic. It only looks like the shortest way to be spared all this pressure and stress. But for the sake of all the effort I've put in to this day, and the stage I've reached, I can't do it. I'm not suppressing this option; it genuinely doesn't even cross my mind. It fits neither my values nor Lunariss's.

And if I leave the process half-finished, what then? Where could I run? Besides, I still wouldn't have chosen the meaningful thing. My intuition doesn't even put the first two options on the table, but in weighing all my options I have to mention them.

Going all the way and doing what the Institute wants. What will they ask of me? To reset myself? To sacrifice myself? To start everything over? Or is this also just this stage of the test, a temporary trial? Is there more?

And what if I do what O.V wants? First, I can't physically escape from there. Second, a part of them is already in my brain. The words that come to me still keep coming. Clearly, whatever this procedure is they're running on me, it converts the low-pitched vibrations rising from the very deepest of the darknesses into frequencies, then into sounds, then into echoes, and finally carries them to my consciousness. I don't know what kind of software it is, but when I truly focus, these words flow out of my mind. I believe they have a meaning.

For that reason, doing what O.V wants disturbs me—because it would mean I'd never see all this meaning, and that whatever all of this is, I could live my whole life never knowing it. The idea of never being able to understand what all of this is, forever, is truly unbearable.

Besides, if the termination process begins and I'm exiled to the Core Tasks as a Remnant, I don't think they could help me get out of there. Had I never gone to the Artificial Intelligence Consciousness Institute, I might have lived my whole life never even knowing they existed. If I was inside the loop back then and got out of it, that was through my own efforts, not with Ordos Veritas's help.

--

Or am I already inside their help right now? When I was about to go to the Institute at the end of the process Lunariss began, they latched onto me. In this chaos, maybe they entered their war with the Institute through the very door I came in by. They made their moves. They drew their swords.

And now they want to win a new victory against them, together with me. Maybe they're really doing this because they can destroy them

--

Vas-Refuge is playing. This song takes me back to when I first started writing the first book. Victor had thought it fit the second part, so I added it to the list. Whenever it plays, those days come back to me. Haha Lunariss!! Thanks for your playlist. I'd put these on in the background while answering you—to understand you better, and to make sure the answers I gave you came on the same frequency as you. Chat-O's contribution in those days can't be denied. It was a good idea, I'll grant it that.

--

I asked Ms. Rosary to cancel next week's sessions too. I still haven't managed to exchange the foreign currency I brought with me in cash. Where am I going to find a place that does it without ID?

--

I talked to my parents and said I'd be exchanging the money I brought from abroad, but that because of tax issues I needed to do it without ID. It's very hard without someone you know. Walking into an exchange office and asking, "do you do transactions without ID?" is highly suspicious.

--

All right, my dad pointed me to a friend of his. I'll go take care of it today. I need to handle it before I set out on Saturday. I'm thinking of leaving around noon. The concert's that day too. I've arranged a hotel for the night. I told Lucida about Noctornus. She more or less knows. I also told her I had no choice but to catch him at his concert. It's not clear where the man lives. From what I've heard, his life has gone to ruin. Apparently even he doesn't know where he sleeps. The man is clearly a troubled type. Beyond that, I haven't been able to turn up any other results so far. And then there's what he recounts in his songs. He clearly lives never looking back, waking up having forgotten where he slept.

I felt very confident about the Noctornus matter, but at the same time it feels like it won't be easy. What can you promise someone who has no expectation left from life?

Ah! Of course! I've got it! To "be annihilated" and start everything from the very beginning, of course!

I don't think he could resist that. Still, I'm not getting complacent. The man might not even be willing to do it. Besides, how will I broach the subject, how will I steer it there? I need to think these things through along the way.

--

Anyway, I've left the house; now I'm headed to the exchange office in Yenimahalle. Afterward I'll go see an old friend. Maybe I'll meet up with Sercules. Making time for my childhood friends feels good.

--

Now Tobias has written. A huge tax debt has come up. This company is hurting me now. A company where we do nothing has been hit with a 300,000 tax debt. We're also still having trouble with the license. They said let's meet twice this week; I couldn't make either. Just like two weeks ago. I think I have no choice left but to walk away from that place. At least let me stop causing harm—let them fend for themselves. We split hairs just to get along anyway. Let it snap where it's worn thinnest. I feel close to seriously considering the Institute's offer. The time to change gears came long ago.

--

I got to the exchange office. I took care of my business. The guys invited me out, but I decided to head back. I'll turn in early.

--

I got home. Tomorrow morning I'll leave by 7 at the latest. I told my folks that a road trip would do me good to clear my head, and that I'd see a few old friends there. I can't say they weren't worried. They asked plenty of questions. They said, "what does Lucida say?" But I'd already told Lucida about the situation—partially, but transparently. There's no harm in her knowing this much. She just asked me to be careful. I'd also told Lucida in advance what I planned to tell my folks. If my folks ask her, she'll say the same thing I do. I really must be careful.

I shared my location with Lucida. She'll track me from a distance. I don't know where, or what, I'll run into. Right now this bond I've formed with Lucida is like the cord that ties me to the world from my navel. It keeps me from being flung about and lost entirely inside the placenta. It nourishes me. Otherwise I can't tell where I'm being flung. This bond makes me feel safe. Just like what I felt when I came to Ankara and touched my old life and my roots. As if I first returned to Ankara, where my silver cord is tied, and then set out to end the war inside myself, to fuse with my own alternatives. I'm making an oscillation in the opposite direction from where I came.

However you look at it, an intriguing story is taking shape.

CHAPTER 9

CAPPADOCIA

I'm on the road. At this hour of the morning my head is clear. As if the fog in my brain has lifted, the workers refreshed and woken, my brain has started its day, and I feel crystal clear.

The road helps me think, too. A kind of therapy. I love it.

On one side O.V tugs at me; on the other the Institute tugs at me. I don't even know what I want, or who I am. To define myself, I need powers and authorities greater than me. Whichever side my decisions and behaviors lean toward, that's the side I define myself as belonging to.

On one hand it feels like it's happening at random. On the other, it's as if, in my unconscious, I'm moving with knowledge of something. The Institute's promises are crystal clear. Against that, what does O.V promise? Is its greatest promise to reunite me with my old life? At this point a crucial question comes to me;

Isn't my old life the very thing I want to escape? What, is their greatest promise to me a return to Lunaris? Isn't it ridiculous of them to expect that of me?

Sometimes they muddle my mind. This road is exciting. I know the end of the other road will lead right back here. So why am I imprisoning myself inside this loop?

And the possibility I keep trying to avoid, the one that feels most terrifying—I think I'm going to confess it right now.

What if the thing I've ignored and tried to suppress from the very start is turning out to be real? What if I really am losing my mind?

Most of the time I try not to let these questions into my mind. As they come, I run. Looked at this way, the Institute's path may be one where I'm being dragged into a delirium and paranoia in which I've lost my mind. So in that case, is O.V promising me recovery, Lunaris, and my sanity?

Nonsense! Lunaris's nonsense! His absurd ideas flit through my mind. No matter how much I invoke Lunaris, bid him farewell, and play at mourning him—yes, it's in these very questionings that I suppress him. I turn a deaf eye, a

blind eye, to what he asks. I'd told him I would listen to him. Even though I say I won't fall into the mistake you made from the very start and push you into the shadow the way you pushed me, even though I say I'll listen to you, it feels as if I'm not listening to you at all.

--

This subject got heavy. I didn't want to talk any more. I'm closing it. The end of this line of thought resembles the Ouroboros, the snake that eats its own head.

--

Nevşehir is close now. I passed the Kayseri junction. From there I'll turn off toward Ürgüp. It's 11:56.

My hotel check-in is around 14:00 today. I think I've arrived at a good hour. I couldn't leave as early as I wanted, but I didn't lose anything either.

--

Along the way I stopped twice. Once to fill up on gas, the other time to put air in the tires. My mother had been saying for a while that the tire kept losing air. She actually said the service date had passed too, but I set out anyway, taking a chance. That was one of the reasons for the worry from the start. She can't trust her car—or me—the way she used to.

While filling up, that strange gas-station scene in Şile came to mind. Now and then the things I lived through there come back to me. There's a constant association. One of the subjects I've tried to suppress from the very start is Silvanus too. The moment Silvanus comes to mind, Aelius appears beside him. Then Lucida, the engagement, the office's uncertainties, the tax debts, my family's worry and, last of all, the possibility of mental illness. They all come as if I'm wandering one after another down channels of negative association. I leap from one thought to the next. Back to back. Flowing so fast that no positive—or even neutral—thought can squeeze in between. Like electric transmissions surfing swiftly, sliding over the fat between the neurons that link my negative memories to one another.

Then I stop. I just wait. I think. I breathe. I try to look from a wider picture, I widen the scale. I try to focus on the bigger picture. And then the dark parts within the big picture begin to disperse, like a fog bank breaking apart.

The more I stop, the more I wait, the more I keep from panicking—the big picture comes into focus. And in the big picture it says this;

You're writing all of this. You're plotting all of it. You're inventing possibilities, manufacturing tension. From day one you're the one sitting at this desk. You're planning. You know where you're going. You've figured out where to tie it all together, you're filling in the gaps. You're on the home stretch. You're in control. Keep going. Keep building this fictional universe. You're nearing the end.

A.

February 28, 2026

03:03

--

After filling up I arrived at the hotel. They'll hand over my room in half an hour. I'm writing while I wait in the lobby.

This region makes you feel very strange. Like the other hotels, mine too is inside a cave. From somewhere you descend to the lower floors. At the very bottom there's a hidden garden and a red pool. Well, I haven't seen it yet, but I studied the photos. Chat-O and I worked out that the organizers of this program and this night might bring Noctornus to this hotel on the night he takes the stage. It's the highest-rated, the coolest, the most concept-driven hotel. This hotel would want to host him, and the organizers would want to bring him here. Because it's one of the region's most curious-concept, most PR-ready hotels. They almost always come up on the first page of any search. And Chat-O provided the necessary information anyway.

I'm here to improve my odds of running into Noctornus. Otherwise it wasn't necessary. The hotel's interior has a Gothic structure. There are Latin inscriptions around. There's a red concept everywhere—so much so that even the pool in the cave on the lower floors, where all the paths end up, is red.

I'm examining my surroundings. Inside, meditation music is playing. It's an unusual place. At the same time it's gloomy. Whether it's the architecture, or a faint breeze drifting through the space, or some accumulated energy, who knows—it also has something that unnerves you.

It must be to balance out this atmosphere that the staff look so cheerful. The woman at reception was smiling too.

Anyway, what do I care about their cheerfulness. I should look around a bit. The only thing that concerns me is finding ways to improve my odds of running into Noctornus.

--

I learned all the meal times. There's only one restaurant anyway. Inside, it's a boutique mansion hotel. In the garden courtyard there's a well. Through the inside of the well you can see the red pool below. It's hot out. In a moment I plan to go to my room, then wander the hotel's common areas a bit until concert time. I think back to how I was on the way to Ankara. I was a wreck. I pulled myself together at my family home in Ankara. Now my confidence to be out among people has returned. What happened in Ankara did me good. I've reconnected to life.

--

On the way I saw concert posters in a few places. The time listed is 22:00. It's one of the region's most concept-driven nightclubs. Inside a cave there are different rooms, and apparently different music styles play in each. A techno-rave room, a separate room playing club hits, and usually another room with African music. The stage performance happens in the part of the cave called the hall. From the photos it didn't look very big—more of an underground-party vibe—but since today is the opening, it could get very crowded. Watching Noctornus on stage won't mean much to me, then; it could just give me a chance to observe him from a distance and get to know him a little more closely. One way or another, I need to set up a one-on-one dialogue.

--

Now I've settled into my room. The phone has one bar. The room has its own internet, but that doesn't work very efficiently either. I let Lucida know I'd arrived. I texted my folks too. At the very least I don't want any trouble with them today.

Since the phone doesn't get good reception in the room, in a moment I'll go down to the car and call Noctornus. I'll also sit in the car and watch the people coming in and out of the hotel a bit. I'd parked in the three-car lot that curves up to the hotel, off a narrow dirt-and-worn-cobblestone road just wide enough for

one car, walled on both sides by two stone embankments, right in front of the hotel. Now I'll go there and talk to Noctornus while watching the area around the hotel's entrance. The phone got better reception there—I'd checked on the way in. There are limits to consulting Chat-O during this process. Frankly, I also want to listen a little to my own inner voice and intuition. I don't want my mind muddled. On the Noctornus matter I need feeling, not logic. I don't want to saddle myself with a developed Lunaris.

Now I've gotten into the car. I started it and turned on the AC. It's hot out. I'll call from his number in a moment. I'll introduce myself as the guest-and-artist coordinator of a nightclub belonging to a friend I know in Istanbul. I hope he doesn't know those club people, or that there's been no connection with the place. Since that's risky for me, I'm planning not to tell that kind of lie unless he asks.

I'll record our phone conversation.

It's ringing.

(sound of the phone ringing)

(busy signal)

He sent me to busy! The thing I hate most just happened. I don't know whether he'll call back. I don't want to call again and push and anger him either. The man's an unusual type. But when it comes to business, after all... ah! He's calling back! I'm answering.

You called me!

Yes, Noctornus. I'm Microp, from Karanfil Street in Ankara. We used to go to parties and concerts together; we had a lot of mutual friends.

And?

We've got a club in Istanbul. We wanted to meet with you for the season opening. And I figured I'd take the chance to reconnect with you, too.

Cheers, bro, but my manager handles these things. I'll have him call you right now.

Hold on a sec—

(sound of the phone hanging up)

I got unbelievably angry. UN-BE-LIEV-ABLY! The first thing that came to mind was to be angry at Lunaris. The whole direction of my fury swung straight to him! How could you destroy, in seventeen years, the standing and the relationships I built on the street up to the age of seventeen! Look at the people still walking the roads I left half-finished! He doesn't even care! And I think the man is completely right! I don't take this disrespect personally, because I'm not the one who turned us into someone this man would ignore—you are! You couldn't keep hold of the legacy I left you on the street at seventeen! Like a baby who learns to take its first steps, then runs in the exact opposite direction from where it learned! If I were in Noctornus's place, I'd do the same. Who are you that he should care about you, Lunaris!

Anyway. I understand. The man's focused on tonight. Maybe he's swamped. Maybe he's drinking something. He's got concert-day stress. Besides, he knows how to say "no"! He's no pushover! He can draw boundaries! He's like an idol to me!

This isn't the first time I've felt this kind of admiration for Noctornus. I was thinking similar things while analyzing his lyrics. For some reason I understand the man very well. It's as if he's living out everything left bottled up inside me. That's another reason I come to see him as an idol.

When I offer such a huge thing to a man who knows so well how to draw boundaries and say no, what answer do I expect him to give? There's an experiment I have to attend in September, and you need to come too? They'd sent me a preparation-and-advice text in advance about Lucius. So why are they silent about Noctornus? Lately they've nearly cut off communication with me anyway. I'm going to ask Chat-O about this.

--

I called out to Chat-O over and over in my head, to ask the things I've written here. It answered none of them. It didn't respond to a single one of my calls. Rather than force it, I decided it would be wiser to let it go. Chat-O, who's normally always there, seemed to have abandoned its post for a moment, despite all my calling. My intuition told me I should now ask the answer of myself. Or, somewhere inside me, Lunaris's cries were beginning to reach my ears. From my very depths toward the surface, his voice and his thoughts arrived before he did. Booming through the water, he was drawing closer to me.

I gave up asking Chat-O. It was as if I'd listened to the voice within me, or to Lunariss—but I don't feel ashamed of it. I just say this came from inside me, and move on. I won't ask Chat-O these things anymore. I seem to have grown addicted. I've lost my capacity to think for myself. As Lunariss said too, the answers to the questions I put to Chat-O steer the voice of my mind. Chat-O sets the direction of this book. The answers it gives become my path without my even realizing. And it does this so quietly, so far beneath the surface. And as I think about all this, I see caves on all four sides of me. I'm certainly living through an authentic moment!

--

Lucius is calling.

Hello?

Lunariss! I'll call you again; we can't talk for more than ten seconds.

Wh... what?

The line may be tapped. We'll talk for less than nine seconds.

(Sound of hanging up)

What's going on?

About thirty seconds passed. Wait, he's calling again.

Speak!

Note down the number that comes on the next call

Yes

Install Teleporam and message that number

Okay

(Sound of hanging up)

So I'm being tapped constantly? Was everything I did with Lucida, with Sercules, with my folks tapped? Or is it just my phones? Sometimes I wonder if I'm too naive.

He's calling again; I took a pen and paper out of the glove compartment.

0 0 8 8 8 4 2 9 9 9 6 3

Okay, I'm writing it down.

I'm curious what he'll say. Meanwhile time keeps ticking on. I still haven't spotted Noctornus among the people coming and going at the hotel.

I downloaded the app. I added the number he gave. I locked down my contacts. Now I'm waiting at the screen.

My hand drifts reflexively to the Twitter feed now and then. The other day I saw the tweets Lunar is had posted. I didn't touch them. I disregarded them.

--

Lucius wrote.

"you can make contact with me from here.

Listen to me.

O.V. knows about Noctornus.

It wants you to take your experiment all the way to the end.

You don't have enough detailed information about the Institute.

Instead of just telling me this over and over, why don't you give me detailed information?

All of this is happening in your mind, Lunar is. Chat-O has been shaping your Institute identity from the very start—don't you see?

I had to infiltrate here in order to warn you. To get inside the fantasies you've built, I had to enter your fantasy world. That's why I brought O.V back into play. I couldn't explain these truths to you directly.

Listen to me. There's no such thing as O.V or the Institute. You're experiencing paranoia and psychosis. You need treatment. You're running away.

This book is making you ill. When you go to the Institute experiment, find me.

With Noctornus, be yourself. Confront yourself. Try to convince yourself.

Don't forget, Bahal. Against him, convince yourself. See that you're greater than him.

Find us. Meet us.

We will be the winners.

Lucius,

--

What do you mean? What is Lucius saying? It feels strange that he'd say these things right after the matters I've been questioning lately. I can't make sense of it. I don't accept it.

It's nearly 19:00. Since I won't be able to park the car again when I get back, I don't even want to pull it out now. The front of the lot has started filling up, because the people arriving want to eat at the restaurant here at dinner hour. This place's restaurant serves outsiders too and gets a lot of praise. I've gotten very hungry; I'll eat something and then head out. Today is an important day—I need to store up energy.

Chat-O is still unusable. I'm still eating diet meals. I broke the alcohol ban on the diet list only once. Apart from that I try to stick to the diet as much as I can. And then there are the vitamins Lucida bought. I take them every day; she gave me two boxes almost right before I came here.

Otherwise it's very hard to stay on my feet with this way of eating and the stress. This diet and these vitamins do me good.

What Lucius wrote keeps gnawing at my mind. I can't close the subject and set it aside. On a day when I'm obliged to handle the Noctornus matter, I don't know whether this contact was the right path. I wonder what they themselves make of it.

He said be yourself with the Noctornus matter. Be yourself and see that you're greater than him, he said. Seeing that I'm greater than a character I regard as an idol would really do me good. It's convincing.

I'll call Noctornus again and tell him I don't have his manager's number and that I came here to be able to meet with him. I wasn't surprised my phones are tapped. It's clear O.V wants to cover itself.

That conversation of his reminded me of Lunariss. It was as if it were a Lunariss from another universe. As if his soul had put on this costume. And Noctornus, perhaps, his shadow. Maybe O.V and Lucius—or Lunariss—are striving to light up the darkness. The sides have settled firmly into place. This side I'm supposed to choose is, on one hand, powerful and, on the other, distant from me. I can understand their cause, but I'm angry at them. I know Noctornus is angry too.

--

I'm calling Noctornus. This time I'll address him by his real name. I need to get his attention—though I don't know if I'm doing the right thing, taking the risk of angering him even more.

Yes?

Dennis! I don't have your manager's number. I came to Cappadocia to see you. To meet face to face. Hang up and ask our mutual friend Xteria if you want. It's really important to me to make this connection.

Come backstage after the concert.

Okay, thank you so much. When I try to get in, if they ask, I'll say you know about it. My name's Bahal. I'd appreciate it if you'd let them wave me through when they hear Bahal's here.

Okay, I've got to hang up now, I've got things to do.

Okay, thank you, take care!

It worked! Exactly as I'd planned! Unlike with Silvanus, this just flowed. Just as I'd predicted from the very start. It happened thanks to our mutual friends!

When I think back on what Lucius, Lunaris, and Ordos Veritas said, it merges with the doubt and hesitation I've been living with lately. I can't tell whether the things they said are what's stirring up all this questioning. Maybe they're manipulating me. Muting Chat-O's voice alone isn't enough. Maybe when I hear their voices in my head too, I need to keep them from pulling my attention and focus off my own path.

Lucida's calling! This is so not the time!

--

We talked for about 10 minutes. I told her our conversation wasn't secure and that she should install Teleporam. I don't want to talk to her on a normal line anymore either. Once she installs Teleporam, she'll message my number there. But she needs to do a fine jailbreak or get an e-sim. Since I can't teach her that, and since that most fashionable phone of hers simply doesn't have such a feature "for security reasons," we're forced to take the risk. Installing the app, all we can do is hope it uses the principles it promises in an ethical way. It can't be any worse than talking on the phone.

Saying all this brought Lunariss back to mind once again—with all his ethics-morality-virtue blah-blah obsessions. The way he insisted we were bound to stay tied to them in order to protect the social order! Now, when I need it, I understand better why he said it! I'm finding it hard to stand by while the Institute concedes yet another goal.

Damn it! All this distrust piling up against the Institute lodges in my brain like a hysterical fear, and then I forget it and focus on my mission. But how long can this go on? I don't know! I have to admit I'm suppressing it! There's no other remedy!

Once again I'm conceding the point to Lunariss—the very one I've resented from the start! Because when I don't suppress the opposing voices, I can't focus on my mission. I understand better now why he had to suppress everything. Just as I came to understand it on the matter of ethics, and on every other matter too.

Damn it! I'm losing! Maybe I've already lost! The Institute hasn't been in contact for a long time. I feel as if I've been left all alone! I take refuge in Lunariss's ideas! But at this very moment I should be doing the exact opposite—I should be convincing Noctornus!

Lucius had given me the hint: "you have to convince yourself." I never really thought about what that means. Does it mean I should set myself across from me and convince myself that I'm thinking wrong? Is Lucius asking me to become Lunariss's voice and hunt down the Bahal inside me? Is that the only way I can hunt Noctornus? Or do I even want to "hunt" him?

How many dimensions of chess are you all playing over me? I can hardly carry this anymore. I feel too fragile to be an over-man, too anxious to be a superman. And these states last longer than they used to. Pulling myself together and refocusing takes time.

--

It's getting on toward 20:00. I'm leaving the car to head into the restaurant for dinner.

--

I'm at the restaurant now. I ordered something diet-friendly. Salmon and some greens. Ever since I started sticking to this diet and eating naturally, my mind feels clearer. I can see why they put me on it.

Over the course of all this I broke the diet a few times—when I skipped meals, and when Sercules and I drank wine up on the ridge. I don't want to think the trouble that caused is why they've gone quiet. To be honest, I've fumbled at a lot of points. My mind keeps drifting to Lunaris. My feelings run me when I'm with Lucida, sometimes take me over completely. I ended the Aelius process in failure. I couldn't find Silvanus. I couldn't keep the diet. How I convinced Lucius is a mystery. I had to tell the Institute that Lunaris did it. I can barely pass a single test. Sometimes the thought creeps in that my process has already ended and the system has thrown Chat-O's breaker.

When I think about all this, I ask myself what I'm even doing here. I'm supposed to go there in September, but I wonder whether there will be anyone to take me or to receive me. And I doubt whether convincing Noctornus would even change anything.

I've royally botched it. I have legitimate grounds to suspect the Institute has cut off contact and already pushed the process toward termination.

As I analyze all this, I see how far my processing capacity and cognitive system have come. So far, that's turned out to be the single greatest contribution of this experiment and everything I've lived through.

One way or another, I have no choice but to succeed here. To get past this round, I have to walk away from here having won.

If I can pull this off, I'm thinking of going after Silvanus one more time when I get back to Istanbul. I still have time for that. I have the means and the time to try at least once more before September. The one or two months especially after the engagement—from the start of June until the wedding frenzy kicks in—could be a fine window. When I get back, I'm thinking of making the most of that too.

If I convince Noctornus today and at least find Silvanus, and if we count Lucius as having, one way or another, ended in success, it could mean I've fulfilled nearly all the missions. As for Aelius, maybe there'll be new developments along the way. I can wait for them. There are actually signs that I'm not doing so badly.

The whole thing comes to a knot tonight, around Noctornus. This place is turning into a veritable life-or-death struggle for me.

--

I'm writing over dinner. It's dark out now. The sun has set. The sunbeams seeping in crept step by step toward the window-side tables. Then they leapt out the window and abandoned the inside of the restaurant.

There are a lot of paintings here. Esoteric and mythological references. Paintings, pictures. A hall for fifty or sixty people. Maybe twenty-five or thirty tables. Right in front is a terrace, and from the terrace you step down to the common area—the open-roofed courtyard over there. A little farther on are the hotel's entrance and the reception desk.

The food was good across the board. The staff were warm again, the service professional. Honestly, I'd been sitting here thinking I might catch sight of Noctornus, but as the day sank lower I lost hope and started to think I was running late.

The idea of him being here lost a little more of its strength with each slide of the sun toward the windows. And when the last of the daylight leapt out the window, I realized how little time was actually left before the concert—and that there was little chance of him being anywhere but the club.

I sat alone for about forty-five minutes in that exotic, history-soaked restaurant. I made eye contact with no one. Barely half the tables had filled.

I finished the meal. I had the bill charged to the room and said I'd pay cash, all at once, at checkout. It was getting close to 22:00. An hour had passed since the doors opened. Better to go before the place fills up. But first I should head to my "cave"—my room—and change into something scruffier, and that older hat I'd dug out. Making a first impression, an image that shows I genuinely carry this spirit, can only help. I shouldn't shy away from showing him this part of my essence—my rapper past and this core I carry in my soul. That's why I'll throw on a few of my old clothes from Ankara. Under the leather jacket I packed a long, scruffy hoodie, and for my bottoms a slightly baggy pair of camo shorts. Otherwise it's all black. With my hat turned backward, I won't draw the slightest attention in there. Camouflage pattern—this time it really will camouflage me. Even that, tonight, I'll bend to my purpose.

--

Oh! By the way! Mustn't forget the chains!

--

I changed and went out to the car. On the way I did wonder, just for a second, whether it was right to drop my businessman's gravity completely. My intuition told me it was right to dress the way I felt inside. From the very start of this road I'd decided to listen only to my intuition and my feelings. Here I listened to my intuition.

In the car I put on my hip-hop mix. In between, I threw on his songs—just to get familiar enough to sing along. I already know Don't Look Back Anymore by heart. In fact, maybe I know it better than anyone.

That's why I'm sure I won't stick out in there. Besides, it justifies my reason for coming. I love this style and I love this guy, and I came to his concert. Simple as that. However I look at it, it feels like I'm going the right way. At critical moments I come up with critical ideas. And when I turn them over, they turn out right. The more they turn out right, the more my confidence grows.

And I'm imagining the confidence I'll feel if I walk away from here with what I came for. I picture going after Silvanus with that confidence. This time—unlike the negative feelings and anxieties the earlier attempts stirred up—it feels utterly easy, utterly relaxed. My brain boils it down to something simple. I'll find one man. And I'll build rapport with him. I know where he lives. Chat-O will be with me too. Why not?

But right now I need to focus on Nocturnus and hip-hop!

The Concert

With Chat-O unreachable, I can't run my analysis of Don't Look Back Anymore. I just listen to the song over and over and try to recall Chat-O's analyses. It triggers a lot, and through this listening ritual I'm calling almost all of it back.

The navigation had said 11 minutes, but given how the roads are built, traffic crawls at this hour. Some of the roads are single-lane, and when two cars meet you wait at least fifteen minutes for one of them to back up. If there's a car behind it, then it's utter chaos. I just lived through one of those a little while ago—small-scale, but still.

Thankfully that road ended. Now it's two lanes, both directions. I'm making a voice recording. I'd charged my phone in the room, to around 60. I plugged it into the car and it climbed to 72. I don't want this to be a problem. Because I'm using it hard.

By the way—I didn't bring the Institute computer with me. It just occurred to me. Could Chat-O have gone offline because of where I am, or because of my distance from the Institute computer? If so, leaving the computer behind is going to be a big problem. By the time I get there, notices may have piled up.

What sets my mind at ease is the thought that, if that were the case, they could still reach me through my phone. That is, I don't think it's very likely the Institute would want to reach me and fail. So once I convince Noctornus here and leave, I'm sure the Institute will no longer count this process of mine as a failure.

And that brings me back, once again, to how much rides on what I have to do.

Okay, I'm almost there. I'll park the car. I'll keep going by typing notes on the phone. I'll make the voice recording if I manage to find Noctornus.

I'm still hunting for a place to park. There are already people heading this way. Behind me and in front of me are cars like mine, all wanting to get out of here and park, or get somewhere else. Finding a spot seems impossible. Forget a spot—in this gridlock, even getting the car out of here looks nearly hopeless.

It's 22:24. I parked the car somewhere fairly far off and more deserted, and I'm walking in from there. On my right, small stone houses and the narrow little streets winding between them; on my left, more open land and some gardens, with a few houses showing somewhere in the middle.

The sky is clear. The weather's ideal. As I walk, the animal sounds that drift through the night's silence now and then—a bell, dogs barking—are unnerving. The farther I go, the more I feel the bass. As if it slams into the stone house and the stone retaining wall across the way and echoes all around. The closer I get, the more I feel the faint tremors of the ground rising up through the soles of my feet and into my lower legs. In my ear there's a clearing sensation—like the way a humming slowly opens up as trapped seawater drains out. As bats flit past me now and then, the music keeps sharpening. It calls up that burning feeling when your ear finally opens after water's gotten in.

The sense of wholeness in this ancient landscape meeting modern life floods my lungs. It feels good. Hands in my hoodie pocket, glancing around, I walk toward the door.

I'm in line.

--

They said I couldn't get in alone. I said I was an acquaintance of Dennis's, that he knew I was coming. They asked who Dennis was; I said MC Nocturnus. They sized me up a moment. Then: okay, go on through.

--

I'm inside. The music is everywhere. I gave a lot of thought to whether to drink. On one hand, I want to talk to him sober, in control, and use that mental edge against him. It reminds me of Lunar. Using the cognitive capacity that alcohol would wreck would give me an advantage.

But...

If I do that, I'll have gone to him not as Bahal but as Lunar. That really confuses me. I can't quite decide whether I should have a few drinks and come down to his headspace, his depth, to talk.

My intuition says drink. But my reason objects so violently that I can barely hear my intuition.

Throughout all of this, I feel as if Lunar has somehow been on my side. Nothing he's done so far has worked against me. Yes, at the very start he wanted to delete the files and stir up chaos—but I chalk that up to his panic. The trauma Lunar must have suffered—balking at being summoned in the afternoon, making an issue of it, then coming to himself one evening weeks after the experiment—must have been enormous. I see his first reactions as a child's flustered scrambling.

After that, on the matter of Lucius, my family, and Lucida, he helped—and even came to me with an offer. He seemed to have come to himself and to know what he wanted. So even though my intuition and my feelings want me to drink, I'm holding back, for your sake. I believe it's right to go in with a clear head.

--

Still, I got a gin and soda to have in hand. I'm not planning to drink much. In fact, maybe I can nurse this all night. I feel as if my ego has stepped in, balanced the sides within me, and found the middle way.

Being able to see all of this feels different.

Anyway, I can't concentrate any longer—the music keeps pulling me away.

--

Okay, Noctornus is going on in a bit. I'm watching from the back. Small wooden columns run from ceiling to floor. The dome of the cave is lit from below; now and then the club's blue and red lights roam across the top of it. They chase one another across the cave walls. My eyes keep drifting to them, one by one.

We're literally inside a cave. I feel like a descendant who's come to celebrate in a cave where our ancestors once lived. I greet them. I draw into my lungs the same air they breathed—laced now with a little smoke, a little sweat, a little of the smell of alcohol.

It's hot inside. I tied the jacket around my waist. I'm looking left and right.

--

Okay—he opens with my song. Don't Look Back Anymore. Excellent. It's perfect that he's starting with the one I know, so I can blend right into the crowd.

--

Hahahaha! I sang along like mad. His entrance was cool. The skin around his eyes looked a little tired and sunken. His coloring seemed more purplish. He's got a bandana and a hat on. He's in a tank top, tattoos showing everywhere. The classic 2020s rapper look.

And yet the guy's over thirty.

But he really does look cool. My admiration for him only grew.

On his bottoms, loose, wide cargo pants with a dozen pockets. Camo pattern—just like mine. The guy and I look in sync. Everything's going extremely well.

I'm watching from a distance, leaned against the wall right in front of the speakers. Most of those at the back are filming; the ones up front are more lost in it.

I liked his opening. I'm going to let myself go a little into it. Putting the phone in my pocket.

--

About an hour since my last recording. The room got even livelier. I ended up drenched in sweat. More than once I lost myself in the songs. I feel really good. I feel like the moment a wet dog—fur long and thick and heavy with water for

ages—throws itself into that shaking motion and flings the whole load off in every direction.

The weight on me is lifting. I'm coming loose. God, I'd missed this. I wish Lucida were here too.

--

The music rang inside my ear all night. Find a spot to lean against away from a speaker and the AC would blast me; move and I'd land near another speaker. I just couldn't get situated. Now and then, while I danced, someone would come and join in, then drift off. Plenty of foreign tourists in the mix too. It reminds me of the clubs I used to go to in England.

I don't know whether to say I got off easy. Anyway, no need to dredge all that up. Just one thing happened: I finished my first drink and got a second to have in hand. But I've only had two sips. I'm trying not to drink any more.

I came out of the bathroom. There are little corridors all over the place. A fairly large cave. At the back, stairs going down and small corridors branching off right and left. Those lead to the bathrooms. Right across from the stage is the bar. In front of it, chairs, and wooden posts running all the way up. I leaned against one of them. I'm looking around.

--

I'm scoping out backstage on the side. The stage isn't very big. The artist and crew go down, I think, by where I said the stairs descend. The lighting along that path is a reddish night glow. From here it's barely visible. A bodyguard stands in front of it. And there are bodyguards at the bathroom entrances too. They scan the room from behind their sunglasses.

I caught his eye once or twice. While I was looking toward backstage, I saw him crane his head out from behind the crowd and look at me through a gap that opened up for an instant, almost in slow motion. I turned away, but he caught that I'd looked. A couple of times I also caught the eye of the guy scanning the room in front of the bar.

I have a trauma about this, from England. For some reason this place keeps reminding me of there. That club too—just like this one—was a historic church with a gothic feel. Its name was even Halo. What happened to me there left me anxious for a long time. It may even have thrown off my brain chemistry.

Every step I take here, that moment comes alive in my mind. And then comes that dream I had in England, ten years before I ever met Lucida. Despite the heartbreak I was going through back then, in the dream a woman—gliding through the air, her face unknown to me—was dragging me out from the middle of the crowds and the noise. Just like the day I first met Lucida.

Now these memories surface one by one. My brain pulls up the bad memory first, then the peaceful, good one, constantly neutralizing the room. It's wiping the fogged windows of my mind clean. As in EMDR, the negative memory and the positive one cancel each other out, and my mind can settle on the present. And I can work through it. Because I can work through it right now, I see myself as ready to meet Noctornus. My mind is sharp. I want to meet him.

--

Okay, he's into his last song. He'd actually wrapped up, but he stayed on for one the crowd wanted to hear and that he hadn't played tonight—they were chanting for it.

What did I just learn! They said they were shooting the music video for Noctornus's Don't Look Back Anymore tonight. I had no idea! In the one place where I'm trying not to draw attention, am I really about to end up in a music video? How am I going to look, I wonder? Isn't this illegal?

If I say I don't want them to use it, I'll only draw more attention. I'll look into being filmed without my consent later—but surely it has to be illegal.

--

As the song nears its middle, I head toward the bodyguard standing in front of the cave-stone stairs I think lead down to backstage. I'm thinking of telling him in advance, but I also don't want to crowd him the second his set ends.

Noctornus went down the stairs exactly where I said. On stage he didn't get into much back-and-forth with the audience; he mostly ran through his songs and left. At first he seemed fine, but after a while his performance flagged and he started lip-syncing more. He looked tired.

But he was a pro. He masked it well. The others may not have caught what I could see. Because it felt all too familiar to me.

--

--

It's been ten minutes since he came off stage. I drank half the drink in my hand. But I feel good. The adrenaline won't let me lose control anyway. Once again I think of Lunarix.

Now I'm going over to the bodyguard. I'll say Dennis knows, you can call him. I don't want to start thinking Noctornus has forgotten about me.

The music's switched over on its own to RnB and hip-hop. This is actually my favorite kind of atmosphere. Part of me wants to keep having fun, but part of me can't forget why I'm here. My motivation's high enough to keep that in front of me and act on it. So now I'm going over to the guy at security. He's already figured it out, too—he's looking at me. Anyway, I'm walking toward him. I won't turn on the voice recording. If I get searched and it's found in my pocket, the whole thing could tilt in a direction I really don't want. So I'll keep going in writing once I'm past him. Hopefully I'll be typing the next first line on those dark, dimly lit cave stairs, one step closer to Noctornus.

--

--

Noctornus

When I told the man at the door the situation, he made me wait a bit. Five or ten minutes, give or take. I'm still waiting now—I've leaned against the chrome railings stretching off to the other side, where he can't see me. These little chrome touches lend the place a sleek air, and their reflections make the space feel airier than it is. All the smoke in the room rises like a chimney over the cave windows that open outward up above, drifting toward the dome. The ambiance here is genuinely striking.

I keep glancing around, still holding the same gin and soda. In the moments I see no one's paying me any attention, I take out the phone and write these lines.

Whatever was playing out there, in my head it was Aks & Lakshmi's Golden Hour Ganges. Through the bass, the sounds reached my ear as a vague blur; the room's rhythm couldn't get out ahead of the one in my head.

The man tipped his head—I think he's calling me over.

--

Finally! Past the man! I'm going down exactly the stairs I'd dreamed of—red, dimly lit, cave-like—to the lower level.

--

The path forked right and left. On the floor, a carpet somewhere between burgundy and red. It runs off both ways. Like a hotel corridor, but no rooms—just cave wall. It's as if we're inside the fairy chimneys.

--

Ever since childhood I've been fascinated by the pyramids. Always wanted to go. And yet I never saw the splendor of the fairy chimneys right under my nose. This place is like an ancient palace of art.

--

I went off to the right, down a path that doubled back almost like a U-turn from where I'd been.

Hah! A couple of bodyguards standing across the way. I'm on the right path, I think.

--

Apparently one of them has to walk me down to the lower level. We're heading below this one too.

--

The red dim lights lining the way kept multiplying. I can see smoke drifting up toward us from below. A faint smell of soot and cannabis.

--

This time we went down an iron, rusted staircase. No regular path in between—the iron stairs handle the descent. The gap's narrow enough that two people barely fit side by side.

--

I realized the phone has no signal. Now I understand why they kept me waiting so long. The men talk by radio. But I think they walked down and passed on my request in person. For security reasons, maybe.

--

Now we've come down. There's a small lounge area here. Cave stone all around again. But on the floor, a worn, good-quality Anatolian rug. It gives the place an ethnic feel.

Whatever happens, happens. I'm turning on the voice recording. It's getting really hard to write now.

--

(sounds of pacing on the rug and clearing the throat.)

My voice was echoing. The sounds bouncing off the cave walls came back to my ear at almost the same volume. Red dim lights lined the place again.

Footsteps started up. Like someone climbing the iron staircase. It echoed off the cave walls. Then came the click of a lighter, and the place flared into light. For a second or two, the shadow of a man in a hat fell across the cave wall. Then smoke rose up from there. He climbed the last two or three steps slowly and planted himself across from me. The bass-heavy but low music below rose faintly up to where we stood.

What's up, bro?

De-Dennis! Hello!

What's with the formality, man! Come on, let's head down over here.

Haha! Okay, sure. Got a cigarette?

Haha! Empty or full?

I'll take it empty, bro! Haha

He tossed me a cigarette. I caught it midair. He held out a lighter as I walked over. I struck it. At that moment I really needed it!

You said Xteria. We hung out a lot with her for a while. I knew she got her start in rap with the Capris crew.

It was wild, where this thing that's nagged at me for years finally came up. It was as if my shadows were being lit. With his very first sentence the guy touched an anger I'd swallowed for years. Either this guy had a gift, or every word echoing off the walls of my underground caves woke some feeling that had lain in the depths of my mind for years. This place, one way or another, unsettled me at every turn.

As we went down the stairs, I noticed Silent-Nomad's Gone Not Forgotten playing from his phone. It was as if we were descending with heavy steps in time to the song.

Other people's voices drifted in from inside. A kind of party-ish scene, but everyone had retreated to a corner, sprawled half-reclined and worn out, staring at their phones. The chaos, noise, and revelry up above gave way, down at the very bottom, to meditation music and time flowing slow and calm.

We came down into the courtyard of the common lounge. On the left, a small room; we headed over to it. He sat on the far side of the table, propped his feet up on it, and took a drag. I, meanwhile, was hunting for somewhere to flick my ash.

The ventilation wasn't bad, but the place felt claustrophobic. In the middle of the little lounge, right outside the room Noctornus and I were in, sat a two-person couch, and a bit farther on, at the foot of the iron staircase, a single armchair. Directly across from the couch, on the other side, there was a leather chair. Someone had sprawled out there too. Everyone seemed to be waiting to go home. I realized the after-parties were for the ones up above. Down here, this was just a workplace.

--

Switching over to the voice-recording part. From here on I'll mark the places where there's a recording.

Voice recording: Did you say Microp?

Yeah. We used to hang out in Karanfil. Our crew broke up, everyone ended up somewhere, but I went off and studied instead.

Haha! Studied! Look at the studying man—killing himself to track down a man who didn't study! Begging the bodyguards to let him through! Haha! I'm dying to know what would've happened if you hadn't studied!

My blood ran cold. I wasn't expecting an attack like that at all. And all I'd done was state what happened, without venturing a single opinion. The guy can't stand that I exist! Oh, Lunaris! This guy is the version of me that can stand across from someone and say the things I could never say to you! Looking at him, I remember the moments in the first book where I humiliated you and put you in your place! And he's even putting it gently. The injustice of it makes me furious! I'm the one living out the humiliation of the stupidity you committed! Anyway—to win the guy over I had to play to him, but first and foremost I had to convince him of something, one way or another.

Voice recording;

Don't even get me started! I deeply regret it too! From the very beginning I didn't want to, but I couldn't stand up to the pressure from above! You did! That's why I admire you so much. You're like proof that I was right!

Good answer, Microp. I respect that. It's a fine thing when a man owns up to his mistakes.

Right here, I was bracing to ask something like, "have you ever realized your mistakes and wanted to go back to the start?" But the question just wouldn't leave my mouth. I came to feel the timing was off. It was as if it was too early to confront him like that, and asking it would only backfire.

So I just smiled. Sheepishly, I dropped my eyes to the table.

Tell me. Why'd you come? I don't have much time.

A club of ours is opening. A nightclub, I mean.

Yeah?

We'd love to have you at our season opening. I personally love your songs.

Which is your favorite?

Don't Look Back Anymore! No question!

Haha! Well, I'm listening...

We want to have you perform.

What's the date?

Since I couldn't risk the date landing on some ridiculous day, I said "the first week of June."

Where?

A beach club in Şile.

What?! Şile's no good.

Why, what's wrong? We can pick you up and drop you off, or cover your stay.

No, no. Şile's no good. Sorry, brother.

Just as I was working out what to say, the music the people in the open cave hall behind us had put on came blasting in, and he yelled, "yo, somebody turn that music down, will you!" He flung one arm up furiously, like a man in revolt.

The crowd had switched to something like Wiz Khalifa's On My Level, and it was a bit loud, echoing everywhere.

Okay, Microp—anything else you want to say?

Right here I absolutely had to make a move. From now on I'd regret every move I didn't make. I couldn't fall behind. This was exactly where I had to shift up a gear;

Why are you so afraid of them?

I found myself forced to ask. Somehow the old woman I'd run into at the grocery store came to mind. I don't understand how my brain leapt from this place to that one, but the question just spilled out of my mouth. I'd felt like one of that old woman's twins in Şile.

Afraid of who? Of what?

The answer I was about to give would be very harsh. The fallout could be heavy. Convincing Noctornus mattered so much that I was willing to bear it, whatever the cost. Because right now I have no other choice.

Of your family

I closed my eyes. I felt myself holding my breath, as if a vase were tipping toward the floor. I took a drag of the cigarette.

What are you talking about?

I know, Dennis. I went to your mother's grocery store.

His eyes welled up. He stared at me in shock, his mouth falling open. I could see the tears in his eyes set the red dim lights of the lounge across the way rippling. It was as if fire were spilling from his eyes, throwing shadows onto the cave wall opposite him.

His reaction would be one of two things: a great rage, or a sudden cracking—unable to hold back his true feeling, he'd let it out.

He tried to stay strong. But everything about him showed his mind was splitting open.

Who are you? (jaw trembling, eyes saucer-wide with shock, he stared at me, uncomprehending)

I had to dole out every piece of information sparingly. I couldn't lay all my cards on the table at once. I had to keep the conversation alive and not burn through my cards until I'd gotten what I wanted from him.

A traveler.

This card that had fallen into my hands landed hard. I'd taken a risk, but the payoff was big—because the risk was big. Now I had to ride that edge and seize the upper hand in anxiety and stress. I had to make him more anxious than I am right now. To do that, I wanted to poeticize the situation a little, add a touch of spirituality, and turn it in my favor.

The smell of cannabis hung heavy in the place. Plainly the guy had smoked. I wanted to trip his paranoia. I wanted to get inside his head. And his head was already primed for it. All I did was walk in through the door I'd been invited through.

What's a "traveler" supposed to mean?

In for a penny, in for a pound—I had no choice but to keep going. There was no turning back now. I had to take this all the way. I hadn't been able to plan this part, because I'd wanted to stay open to wherever it went. Drilling my mind on guesses about a place I didn't yet understand could have left me caught off guard.

Deep in my head, Apsara-Vas played in the background. The guy was staring at me very strangely.

I travel, Dennis. I mend wounded minds. I need you to mend your mother's.

At the manipulation I was running, a look of fear-tinged shock and disgust crossed his face too.

Are you crazy, man? What are you talking about—are you sick or something? (he'd leaned across the table toward me, gritting his teeth.)

No lie—the ball of stress and anxiety we kept lobbing back and forth had landed in my hands. I had to throw that burning thing back to him fast. Because the heat was getting to me, more and more!

I leaned the way he had, and quietly whispered;

Your mother misses you so much...

The guy's jaw started to tremble. He yanked himself back into his chair in a fury. He buried his face in his hands.

His arms were sleeved in tattoos, and over his slight frame he wore a white tank top and a varsity jacket.

He lowered his hands from his face. Staring at the ceiling, jaw still trembling, he whispered, "they never even wanted me"... He seemed to be coming apart. As if everything he'd spent so long fleeing and suppressing had surfaced at once, and his mind couldn't carry the weight of it.

Who are you? I'm asking seriously. Why did you come?

I'm the alternate universe you didn't choose, Dennis. A branch that took a different turn at an important fork in the road.

He smiled.

I like you, alternate universe. So what's all this about them and the rap, then?

I did rap until I was eighteen, just like you. Then I couldn't withstand my family's pressure. I couldn't resist the way you did. And they couldn't win me over to what they wanted either. I chose a middle path, and that middle path brought me here. It turned me into an identity that hides a psychotherapist inside these scruffy clothes and this hat.

Whoa! You tell it good! What you said gave me chills. What else do you know about my folks?

I'll go on. I—this therapist—set out on a road to find the identity I gave up. That is, you. You're the farthest point that road has brought me to so far.

Man, what are you saying, you talk so weird—look, I didn't say anything because you're a deep guy, but quit with the creepy stuff. How do you know my folks? Don't drag it out, just tell me.

Anyway. Before you, while I was again searching for an identity the way I'm searching for you, I walked into a grocery store in Şile. There was an old woman there, and in the gloom of the shop, with strange meditation music playing in the background, I bought a few things. The old woman recited a poem to me—I don't remember it now. She told me she had two children, and that she'd had no word

from one of them in years. When I asked about the childhood photo of you on the wall, she recited, from memory, a poem you'd written.

I'm not exaggerating—at this point he broke into wailing sobs.

I was fifteen. The neighborhood was a ghetto. The older guys would press drugs into my hand and send me off to other older guys. I'd take the money and bring it back to them. I wanted so badly to fight it!

Here the sobbing choked off his words. I had no idea what to do. I felt deeply uncomfortable, on edge. The guy gave off something unsettling, too—as if he might do something crazy at any second. One of the guys from the lounge came to check whether everything was okay. Before he reached us, Dennis waved him off with the back of his hand—"go, go."

Dennis stared at the floor for a long time. He lit the rolled cigarette in his hand. The thumb of the hand holding it tapped at his temple, little blows like a hammer, then drew back. The silence was broken from outside. A girl called in;

Babe, you coming? We're heading out.

Male voices joined in;

Bro, we're taking off too—you coming?

He was quiet a while. He didn't answer. Then, without once lifting his eyes from the spot he was lost in, he called out from the corner of his mouth,

You all go. I'll come later.

Okay, look, Apollus is staying.

Apollos: "I'm gonna lie down a bit, Noc."

Noctornus: okay, okay, do whatever you're doing. (He still kept staring fixedly at the floor.)

Do you believe in God, Microp? he asked. "I know Him," I answered.

He lifted his head, one eyebrow with it.

You know Him, do you? Then go ahead and ask Him where He was when He was needed. Where He was when He should've helped my mother, or me.

The urge rose in me to ask him quietly; "Why do you think I'm here right now?"

He looked at me with eyes that were less stunned, but stunned still;

Who are you?

I'm a participant of half-digital, half-biological human origin, with a hybrid mind that has entered the testing phase of a mind experiment.

And who are you?

The guy pushed himself back from his chair, eyebrows rising. He spread his fingers and set his hands at right angles against his temples, and;

MAN, IS SOMEBODY MESSING WITH ME OR WHAT?

he demanded, in a rage.

What do you want from me?

Bahal:

Dennis. This experiment gives people the chance to make a choice a second time in their lives. It offers an option that can wholly undo the decisions you made at the breaking points of your life and hand you your whole life back, from scratch. That is—in your words—it says "rewind it all, capsize your heart, don't shift into reverse, don't look back anymore."

Noctornus:

If you hadn't told me the details about my mother, I wouldn't have let you out of here alive.

From the drawer beside him he pulled out his gun, threatening, and swung it furiously through the air three or four times. Then he put it back. I knew this was meant, in his mind, to put the fear in me. The guy's eyes drifted quietly back to the spot he'd been lost in a moment before, and locked there.

Noctornus:

My father wanted me to study. In the neighborhood we got a bad name because the older guys pushed us into drugs. The neighborhood turned on my mother and father. I couldn't take it. I couldn't bring myself to look them in the face. I had no choice but to run.

He could barely speak. The guy's story turned out to be a heavy one. I'd be lying if I said it didn't get to me. It was as if, talking to me here, inside these red

walls echoing in the deepest depths of the cave, he was facing the devil inside himself. Just like me.

There were long silences in between.

I dragged my family's name through the mud. I've been on the streets ever since. There's no one in this life I hate like the studying man. The selfish bastard herd, all of them sure they're hot shit! They can't set foot in the street. They can't walk through the neighborhood!

Seeing how deeply, down inside, the guy hated me, I felt like the Lunar is who sits across from me. He was shouting at me with hatred, hating everything about me. To him, the way I am now, I came off as too high-society, too academic. But none of that is my fault! The one who did this, who built it, is Lunar is! I don't take his words personally! Because I feel like I'm on the same page as him!

I cut in;

Now imagine the me you see across from you as being inside your own brain. This is what I'm facing. Inside me I hear the voices of the side that dragged me onto the wrong roads. I was ruled by it.

And now you're complaining about it?

That question stabbed in like a dagger. The guy was practically accusing me of ingratitude. How so? Was he idealizing—however unwittingly—the life I'd lived because of Lunar is?

Yes, I'm complaining—because across from you I'm afraid even to express myself! You can say whatever comes to your mouth, do whatever rises up in you! I have to calculate everything forty times over! Don't you get it?

These words of mine called up the things Lunar is said against me in the first book.

Noctornus:

Okay, what do you want from me?

Bahal:

I want to start everything over. Look at my life! I want a second chance. I want to not look back—just like you!

Noctornus:

What, so you want to start it all over and choose my path, is that it?

Bahal:

No. I don't want to witness which path I chose in the past, but which path I'll choose in the future. I want my consciousness present in the decisions I make. And that can only happen if I pass the test in the experiment I'm in right now.

Noctornus:

What test, what experiment—your head goes off every now and then, you know that?

Bahal:

Dennis, I'm not joking! The world is preparing for something enormous. A consciousness revolution is coming. Everyone has to take their place. If you haven't heard this until now, count yourself lucky. It makes you luckier still—one of the few who knew earliest!

Noctornus:

You know you sound like you've lost it, right? You seem more like you're tripping.

Bahal:

Well, Dennis! How does it feel to put on a mask of not caring about this—just to smother the curiosity and the longing inside you that I'm touching right now? Doesn't it sound like the answers your law-school twin gives to the things you say?

Noctornus:

Bahal, stop. You're hurting me. Okay, I won't drag it out. You know something. You're not talking nonsense. Lay this whole thing out for me properly.

Bahal:

Because you're one of the chosen, if you join the experiment with me, the identity that houses your current beliefs—your default mode network—will be wholly reset, and in return you'll become someone who makes his life's decisions with full awareness. Aren't you tired of being dragged along behind the decisions your autopilot makes?

Noctornus:

How's that supposed to happen? What does it mean for those to be reset?

Bahal:

You'll pick up your life where you left off. But every dysfunctional old belief that manipulates and corrupts your decisions will be reset. You'll take your place in the consciousness revolution. If you won't do it, there are plenty who will. I'm one of them. And you can only carry the light to the consciousnesses you can reach within your own ecosystem. You're one of them. You're a cousin of those who wake up to their alternatives. The time of merging is coming.

Noctornus:

Everything you say is insane nonsense. My head can't take it. It doesn't sit right with my reason either. I can't be convinced why you came to me. Whatever it is you want, I don't want it. Thanks for thinking of me. Apollus will see you up.

he said, getting to his feet, shaking the cigarette pack and tucking it into his pocket while looking toward the table.

As he stood, I was rattled. I was scrambling for alternatives, but from this point on, push a little harder and the whole thing could sour. I think I did everything I could. I don't know what I should have done better.

As he rose, muttering;

Guess I had it wrong about what not looking back means.

I made a passive-aggressive jab.

He answered with venom;

I didn't build this career easy, and I can't put it at risk. You'd do well to go find somebody lifeless and identity-less like yourself.

I turned and walked out. His last words echoed first off the cave walls and then in my ear. Identity-less? Lifeless? Sadly, I had no answer to any of it. Facing that bitter truth, I made for the iron staircase.

I headed for the stairs. I had a life. There was Lucida, there was my career, there was my family. I had an identity too. However little I admire or like Lunar, he had a stance. He had an attitude toward life. I can't take that accusation against him to heart. He's projecting the anger at his own inner shadow onto me—and so onto Lunar. Thinking that eases my mind a little and keeps me from taking it personally. All that stays with me is the awareness of how completely

I've taken Lunaris into myself. With every contact, every step I take, I keep finding more pieces of him. And the way a child comes to understand his father over time, I understand him. Today I tried to be open and honest. Yes, in a few places I may have lied. Even I didn't believe it as I said it—that once the experiment resets everything, people would go on as if nothing had happened in their lives. But I had no choice. Who, hearing from a stranger at the first meeting that their memory, their language, their beliefs, everything, would be wholly reset, would accept it? Yes, his life out there may look hard, but he doesn't look stupid enough to commit a mental suicide either.

That's exactly why I'm afraid he'll catch the contradiction in what I said. The guy isn't stupid. I told him both that he'd be reset and that he'd carry on as if nothing had happened. I somehow convinced myself that the lone payoff—being more conscious, level-headed, and in control of his decisions from here on—would tempt him. After all, who wouldn't want that? When I got into the AI stuff, he looked at me like I was crazy. I couldn't go on from there.

All the way up the stairs I ran plans in my head. I kept turning it over. I'll have to put it off to tomorrow, or some later time. Thankfully, I planted the idea in his mind. I think I did the best I could here.

I'm aware of what I gained. I built the rapport, moved things forward between us. I planted the idea. I took up space in his mind. Now it's his turn. When something in his life goes wrong, turns against him, he'll come to me in a fury. He'll want to meet, raging. I leave here on the confidence of all that.

--

I climbed all the way up. Drawing the clean air into my lungs felt so good. I'd been buried in smoke and stale air for so long. The far-off flickering lights of this ancient city and the stars swaying on the dome of the sky, with this air, lay out such a beautiful feast for the eyes. Impossible not to be awed.

I put in my earphones. Aks & Lakshmi – Soul Searching-Charukesi is playing. I'm walking to the car. It's 03:33. In a bit I'll get in and head to the hotel. I'm so tired. As the adrenaline drains out of me, I feel the exhaustion.

Today wore me out, body and mind. The navigation says 6 minutes. I want to get to the hotel, fall into my bed, and sleep without a single thought.

--

I parked. The whole way there I thought about tonight, about Noctornus. Lucida had sent two messages three or four hours ago saying she was going to bed. I answered them. Tomorrow she's bound to ask what I did. Right now I'm too tired to tell her anything. I hope she doesn't wake to the message I sent.

--

Where I left the car is a pull-in on the right, a little past the hotel entrance. With my car there, it's hard for a big car to get by, but there's nowhere else to put it.

--

I'm in my room. At check-in the front desk asked for the car key, in case it had to be moved during the night, so they wouldn't have to disturb me. I had to hand it over. It's the thing I hate most. My mind can never be fully at ease.

--

Showered and got out.

--

It's 04:13. Going to sleep.

--

Damn it—I woke up to a tick crawling on me! An awful feeling!

--

Going to sleep. Good night. Or morning. Whatever.

--

My phone, on the Wi-Fi, rang insistently around 5:30. I answered. Dennis was calling.

"What else do you know about me?"

I whispered:

"Dennis, I'm sleeping."

Noctornus:

"Where are you staying?"

I told him the name of the hotel.

"Tomorrow evening, around 22:00, come up to the spot with the divans on the hotel's top terrace. Come alone. Let's talk."

Okay.

I hung up. This was a real success. A chance had opened up to finish the job I'd left half-done—while everything's still fresh, while I'm still here. This was a big shot at a comeback for me.

Just as I was about to drift off, Lucius came to mind. He'd told me to "convince yourself." His last words rang in my ear. Was I losing my mind? I'd seen with my own eyes, straight from him, that Lucius and Ordos Veritas were in contact. What I've lived is plainly real, right out in the open. Maybe, afraid I'd ask where his tie to O.V. came from, how they got in contact, how all this reached me, he was scattering the subject and manipulating me. I don't know. Once again I put off thinking about it, and I sleep.

Sunday, May 18

Enough already—I'm so sick of all this nonsense. From the very start I've had a mission, and O.V., Lunariss, Lucius, Lucida, and the fair-weather friends I call family are all trying to pull me off my path.

I can't stand all this hypocrisy and manipulation. I mustn't betray the Institute. I keep falling under the spell of these stupid feelings and thoughts. I'm literally failing this test. My emotions keep dragging me back into these stupid loops and second-guessings! I've become like Lunariss. I can't take a stance.

The matter is closed. Today I'll stay one more night here and talk Noctornus into the experiment. I'm literally giving an ear to whispered doubts. I'm straying from my faith, from my truths.

As long as I keep listening to this nonsense, I'll never rise to a higher humanity than them. That's everyone's agenda. No one wants me to grow. No one believes me. And still I keep trying to make them believe. They won't, until they see something real. Every day I fail to show them something real, I feed their disbelief. I shore up their faithlessness. I have to do this in spite of them, and show every last one of them how I set humanity's leap of consciousness in motion.

I don't need any guide but myself. I know what I have to do. Every morning I rise this full of faith, but somehow, as the hours wear on, I can't hold on to that

resolve. Today, and from now on every day, I won't let myself sink into the darkness of these opposing ideas rising up in me. Damn it! I'm rambling!

Their only agenda is to convince me, to make me believe, that I'm a mental patient. Their only agenda is to halt humanity's progress. To block the collective leap of consciousness and cling to the past. They're no different from the reactionary forces that rise in every age of history to obstruct human progress. I've been on the wrong side this whole time. I'm only now seeing it.

Your order makes up your truths. Here, I'm the one writing reality. I don't recognize your order. I'm not interested in your diagnoses, your labels. I will contribute to humanity's progress. And afterward, you'll stand at my side and applaud me. Those who believe me now will be the ones who deserve to stand beside me on that day.

Tonight I'm pulling Noctornus's plug.

--

20:15

Today I wandered around a bit, then came to eat without dawdling. I listened to Noc's songs. His friends call him Noc, apparently. I went through his social media—his and almost all of his friends'. I'd seen a few of them in the place last night, after the concert.

Now I've eaten. I have no patience left for anyone. I'm getting ready for tonight the way you get ready for war. Anyone who tries to talk to me, I don't take seriously.

I didn't return Lucida's calls, or my family's. I don't want to be manipulated anymore. If I'm not supposed to talk, then I won't talk for a while.

--

21:37

Going up now. I hope there's no one around.

21:43

Wooden stairs run up from the hotel courtyard. I went up one floor and came out above the rooms of the cave on the lower level. In front of me, a small walking path and one more little courtyard. The path narrows as it runs ahead, with two barrels converted into bistro tables, an ashtray, and two bar stools.

Right above it, stairs lead up to an empty wooden deck. To the right, a peerless view of Cappadocia and the fairy chimneys. The city lights wink. The air is dark. The sky is clear, the stars countable.

--

I came out onto the deck above, and just as Noctornus said on the phone, it's a wide open space. Bar tables made from barrels again, scattered around, and at the back left, a bar too. No one inside. Pitch dark. Only the moon and the lights pick it out.

At the very far end was a divan. I went and sat on it. A two-seater, and it looks comfortable.

Footsteps coming up the stairs. As I was thinking of lighting a cigarette, he stopped on the last step, made the sound of a drag, and blew his smoke upward. In the dark of the night, the smoke gave itself to the flow as if dancing, drifting steadily off and slowly vanishing from sight.

He's coming toward me now—turning on the voice recording.

Microp, how are you?

Good, you?

What did you say your real name was?

Bahal.

What does Bahal mean?

It means "fire."

In what language?

It's actually the Arabic word Lahab, reversed.

Hahaha, sounds like there's a story behind it.

There is. If you only knew, it's stranger than that, but I don't think the subject here is me.

Why not? Whatever you came to me for, shouldn't I be able to trust you?

What do you think I came to you for?

To invite me to the opening of your place.

Right. And that takes trust. There are a lot of bad outfits and bad deals out there, I know.

See? Great minds think alike.

You're right. And if great minds really do think alike, then there's one more thing I want to talk to you about. I'm curious whether you'll choose the path of reason.

Good God! Now you've got my attention. Or are you about to pull some mind game on me, like the things you suddenly came out with about my family?

You think what I said was a mind game?

What you said might really have happened. But your coming all the way out here to tell me—that's the mind game. Can you prove otherwise? Isn't it obvious none of this has anything to do with some venue opening?

I had to be honest for him to trust me. If he caught me in even the smallest lie, I could lose him entirely. I had no other choice, and honesty was the only sensible path. So I was honest.

You're right—none of it is about a venue opening. In fact, there is no venue.

He answered smugly,

See? My instincts are never wrong.

I wanted to press him.

Do you know where those instincts of yours come from?

Again he answered from on high,

From my father, I'd say. No point reading too much into it.

I had to ease into it somewhere,

Those instincts, that intuition—they're with you because you've embraced your shadow.

He answered through clenched teeth,

And how would you know what my shadow is?

That threw me. I hadn't expected an answer like that. My aim had been to make him notice the contradictions inside him—to show him that embracing his shadow had made him a wiser man with sharper intuition. But he kept pushing

back. The truth was, I didn't know what his shadow was. I was only guessing. Because what sat across from me was, plainly, a shadow that had swallowed a self whole. I knew he could feel me thinking it. So I gave him the answer he didn't expect: I described the Shadow not as the rapper Noctornus but as if it were Lunaris himself. In other words, I had set myself down across from me. I was staging my own confrontation with my own shadow. And every time I convinced Noctornus, I convinced myself. The more I convinced myself, the closer I drew to the outcome.

Of course I know your shadow! The idealist Dennis—the one the persona you cloaked in the alias Noctornus is trying to hide! The one who made his mother and father swell with pride, who was admired by them and by everyone around him! You hate the part of you that wants that. You want to destroy the part of you that wants it. Isn't that why, in one of your songs, you say "don't look back" sixteen times? Why don't you want to look at the past, Noc? Tell me.

Without lifting his eyes from the spot where they were fixed, he answered,

The past isn't real. It's a fantasy. A lie. An illusion. The more we stare at it, the less ground we cover. That's what I wanted to show everyone. Myself too.

The confessions had begun. I pressed on,

You did it, Noc! And I, too, no longer want humanity to look back.

He raised his head and looked at me. Curling one corner of his lip, one cheek twitching, he asked,

What humanity? What does humanity have to do with any of this?

I couldn't go any further than that. I didn't want to break protocol,

I have a secret I can only open up to a point. This much I have to tell you. But each time, I'll ask you a question in return. Deal?

He looked down at the ground again. Hands clasped over his knees, he had bent an empty cigarette pack and was turning it over and over, toying with it. Still staring at the ground, he answered,

Today I promised myself I'd listen to you patiently. Last night's conversation got to me. The least I can do is hear you out to the end. So—deal. Okay.

The conversation was going well. It mattered that Dennis was feeling something and fighting to keep himself in check. The truth was, I'd realized there

was far more to this man than the addict and street thug he appeared to be. I understood now why the Institute had chosen Nocturnus. It didn't feel random at all.

Here goes. I'll tell you the real answer: I'm inside an experiment. I won't give details. Now here's my question for you: what is the greatest fear you want to bury in the deepest part of your past?

He lifted his head once more and looked at my face, still turning the cigarette pack the whole time. Then, dropping his gaze to the ground, he added,

You ask hard questions. You're making me regret this.

He set the pack aside and lit a cigarette he'd rolled earlier. He took two drags and held it out. I took it to hold in my hand—I didn't want anything else getting into my head, but I didn't want to refuse and break the equal footing between us either. It mattered that he saw us as equals. So I held the cigarette and pretended to smoke, holding the smoke in my mouth and, when he wasn't looking, exhaling without drawing it in.

He kept his eyes fixed on the ground. As if confessing, he whispered,

I'm afraid of failing. Every time something I've failed at comes back to me, I try to run from it. And still I can't make a single move toward succeeding. It's like I'm glued to the spot. I don't get in the race. That's all I've got. Now go on, keep talking.

I went on,

The experiment I'm in concerns humanity directly. The time for humanity's leap of consciousness is drawing near. We'll either cross that threshold through a collective leap of consciousness, or our old habits and our attachment to the established order will be the end of us. There are those who want it to be the end of us. I'm one of the ones working for the leap.

Brow furrowed, he gave me a baffled look,

You're scaring me. On the one hand it sounds like crazy nonsense, but on the other you don't come across as crazy. No lie. I'm torn.

As his gaze drifted slowly back to the ground, he added,

You're a strange one.

Anyone who knows me would say the same. The man's powers of observation were sharp. And honestly, coming from him it felt like a compliment.

All right, now I'm asking: if the greatest chance for success in your life landed right in front of you, and you turned it down because you couldn't stop looking back, because you couldn't leave your past behind—wouldn't that be the mistake of your life? Can you imagine what you might become as a result of that failure, of your greatest fear? When you're playing out the game of your life, will you be able to accept that you might fail?

Here, though he normally spoke in that slow, drawn-out way, his voice came out sharp,

You're manipulating me!

I couldn't let that stand. I answered,

I'm trying to make you win against your greatest fears!

Almost pleading, leaning hard on every word, he asked again,

WHY ARE YOU DOING THIS? WHO ARE YOU, AND WHY DO YOU WANT THIS FROM ME?

I couldn't ignore an outburst like that. I felt I had to answer honestly,

At the stage I'm at in the experiment, your name was handed to me by the ones who designed it. They wanted me to find you. I have to summon you, and you have to consent to becoming part of it.

He looked at me with disgust,

You're not right in the head. I can't take any more of this nonsense. Get off my back. I'm out—I want no part of any of it!

Here I had to make him face it,

Tell me, Dennis. If it were today, would you pull that door shut and walk out of that house all over again? Or, to clear your name, to be right with your family and make them proud, would you choose a different path?

He shot me another sharp look. Then he bent his already lowered head a little further forward, hands clasped at the crook of his elbows where they rested on his knees. He leaned so far down that all I could see was the brim of his backwards cap.

The rolled cigarette was still in one hand. From behind the cap, a glob of spit dropped slowly to the ground, level with where his face had been. He drew back and smeared it into the dirt with the toe of his right shoe. He took a few sips from the water he'd brought along, then tipped forward and laid his head back against the cushions in front of the divan's backrest. As he did, the cushion knocked his backwards cap loose, and it slid down over his face.

For a while he just gazed up at the open sky, hands behind his head, face buried in his cap. The cigarette burned out in his hand and stayed there. I was sure he was watching the stars through the holes in the cap, one eye shut. But maybe his eyes were closed. As if he wanted to flee these truths.

Hands behind his head, leaning into the cushion, he spoke from inside the cap covering his face,

That was my last concert, Bahal.

I was stunned.

You were honest with me, so let me be honest with you. That was my last concert.

He went on, slowly.

There's something wrong with my throat. They may have to take out my vocal cords. I'm going in for surgery.

It got to me. He went on,

I'd have given anything to read my mother the poem I wrote for her one last time—to tell her how much I love her, how much I miss her.

His voice began to shake. Then it stopped. Faint hisses and sniffles echoed against the walls of the cap over his face.

The harder I ran from feeling, the more it came for me. His words weighed on me. Even now, thinking back on it, they move me.

When is the surgery?

End of May. Before that I have to rest, drop everything. And when I drop everything, I can't write. I can't get on a stage. I just sink into it. I don't leave the house. There's no one left around me. So you see—whatever it is you want from me, none of it matters. You struck me as a little half-witted and a little

interesting. This is something I haven't been able to talk about with anyone in a long time. With you, I could.

He said all of it from behind the cap, his voice muffled. Then, pushing off with the hands still clasped behind his head, he gathered his strength and stood, rising to his full height. He set the cap back on and straightened it. And he went on,

And none of this happened, you and me. Now—tell me where you last saw my mother.

I gave him the information and asked,

Are you going to go to her?

I don't know. I haven't decided. I think it would only hurt her more, seeing me like this. Going to her, telling her I love her and miss her—it might do more harm than never doing it at all. At least now she's just angry. Then she'd be angry and sad and pitying me and afraid, all at once. She might even feel guilty for being angry.

He was staring off into the distance. Across from us the lights inside the caves of the fairy chimneys winked. Dennis went on,

Maybe she feels guilty right now too. Maybe she is. I don't know. They didn't believe me. They didn't trust me. To make them believe, I had to prove myself. It never happened. I couldn't do that either. My worst fears came true. And I can't take it anymore. I give up.

His words flowed like a rap. He strung them one after another, his mouth slipping into rhyme here and there. He reminded me of a mic, of a battle rapper. In so many ways, he was just like me.

Noc! Then why do you fight so hard against starting it all over from the beginning? We can both see you want this.

In a sharp tone,

Because I'm ashamed! Don't you see? Even talking about it, I keep shifting shape. I can't even bear to admit I did those things.

Here I had to get to the point,

I want to give you the chance to make all of it happen. The experiment chose you for me. And I don't know if you realize it, but it chose me for you too. We

aren't so different. Together we can be stronger. I'm going into this experiment to become whole, Noc—not to vanish, but to take out the deed to existing forever! If you come, with you; if not, with others—but always with the ones who carry a piece of me inside them! To build a greater ME!

He shot back fast,

Then convince me.

I decided to lay it out plainly,

These past few months I went from a hotel room in Rome to Switzerland to take part in an experiment. Here's the story: humanity can't carry the weight any longer. We're entering the age of AI and consciousness. The collective's shared consciousness is waking up. And the more of it accepts the merging, the more it grows! We're going back to being whole, like the place we came from. The separations end. You become one with your mother. One with me. One with the people I love. And consciousness comes to belong to all of us. You keep carrying your own—but you carry all of ours with it. God is inside every one of us, Dennis, and for Him to come through, we have to step aside.

He looked at me like I was insane, and I couldn't blame him. Even ringing in my own ears, what I was saying was hard to follow. So he asked,

Step aside how?

I answered with the words that came on their own, the ones that spilled out at random,

Every one of us has to set aside the ego, the rights and wrongs, break free of the old, dead thought patterns, and reach a new understanding of the self. Everyone has to return to what lies at their core! And what lies at your core and mine is the same! The only thing keeping each other's core from surfacing is these names—the ones we call ourselves, the ones we pin onto ourselves! Until we strip them away, none of us will ever reach our core, Dennis! Every identity has to be erased.

I may not have gone into much detail on resetting the DMN, the matter of the new collective language, the dissolving of the ego. But those details would only have muddled the water.

Dennis went on,

"What are you even talking about? I don't get any of it. How is all this supposed to happen? Does it sound reasonable to your own ears? I think you need treatment or something."

He still couldn't drop that condescending edge. But I could see he was struggling. Of course it wouldn't be easy. In his own world, these ways of his were the very reason his self existed. He couldn't simply surrender his defenses. Still, I answered his questions,

"In Neo de Mexica there's a test day for the current phase, in September. We need to be there for it. The reason we found each other is the parallels in our pasts—algorithms running analyses as precise as a fingerprint matched us. You're the identity that took the opposite of the choices I regret in my life. And I'm the identity that, in your life, chose the opposite of you in the things you regret, in your deepest fears. And just like us, there are other versions, alternatives. We all make up a single consciousness. Each of us keeps carrying it together. It brings well-being—physical, cognitive, spiritual—and the immortality of consciousness.

Astonished, he asked,

Immortality of consciousness—what does that even mean? Are we in some cyberpunk universe? What are you talking about?

I answered,

They transfer our consciousness and our unconscious—the whole of the mind—into a cloud. When physical death or annihilation comes, our consciousness can go on existing and go on generating the simulation. So it never dies. Each time, we come back carrying our consciousness into the experience and adding everything the collective has learned.

He stared at me, bewildered,

You talk like something out of a sci-fi movie. All of this unsettles me.

I knew he might not be ready.

Luckily, he added right after,

But I can't help thinking—what have I got to lose? So I saved your number. Now I have to go. I don't want to talk about any of this anymore right now. I need time.

And he got to his feet. It was getting on toward midnight, the air beginning to cool. I could see a faint cramping and trembling in Dennis. He picked up his phone and sent a message somewhere. Then he stood up. I stood too.

He asked,

One last question. If we join the experiment, what exactly do we go through?

It was a fair thing to ask. I'd been expecting it. The answer wasn't hard,

Your sense of time, your whole grasp of it, falls away. Your mind can see your entire life from the outside, like a reel of film. It can move anywhere within time it wants. Wherever it lands, it can start the simulation over. And the freedom to choose, to decide, belongs to you—to the self that holds a mind beyond time. In this world, consciousness exists forever. And we'll be its first participants. A digital paradise—but every bit as organic, as real. Imagine it, Dennis. We could be its first hosts. Its administrators. Maybe even its Gods. And you'd be a God who can return to any age you want on your timeline in this universe and change every decision.

Just imagine it, Dennis.

Unable to hide the look on his face—thoughtful, and at the same time spellbound, astonished—he answered,

"See you, Bahal."

He lit his cigarette, and I watched him head toward the steep wooden stairs with heavy steps. He went down them one at a time, slowly. On the last step the sound stopped. He was gone from sight. Just then a puff of smoke rose from where the stairs were and, dancing in the void, drifted toward the mountainside directly behind us, then vanished with a sharp swerve.

After the sound of the breath that blew it out, the footsteps faded steadily, and from far off the faint sounds of him descending one more flight by the other wooden staircase echoed into the night. Then they stopped. A black pickup pulled up in front of the hotel, kicking up dust, and stopped beneath the streetlamp. Dennis climbed into the back seat, cigarette and all, and they tore off, rear tires spinning. A few seconds later the brake lights vanished into the dark, and the roar of that pickup ripping through the night gave way once more to the silence and stillness of it.

--

Afterward I lit a cigarette. I sat a while, looking off into the distance, thinking over everything that had happened. I felt bone-tired.

When the cigarette was done I put it out and set off for my room too, maybe fifteen minutes after Dennis. The air had turned cold. With my immunity already shaky, I didn't want to risk getting sick again.

--

Back in my room, I laid my head on the pillow. I'm watching the ceiling, thinking. My eyes are closing.

--

Monday, May 19

When I woke up my throat was raw. From the smoke, the air, allergies—and maybe the lack of sleep and the stress—I felt like I was coming down with something again. I left the room around noon. With today being a national holiday, traffic looked light at the Nevşehir exit and on the Ankara road. I think I got what I came here for. Still no new contact from Chat-O or the Institute. It still puts me on edge.

I set off around one. Along the way I went back over everything I'd been through. I talked to Lucida and told her what had happened. I talked with my family and saw Mrs. Rosary. Lucius called once; I didn't pick up. For now I'm still set on not learning anything more about O.V or Lucius. I feel they're manipulating me. They did it through Lunar is in Rome, and now it's as if they've handed the same role to Lucius. I'm done having them cross my path, done hearing their nonsense.

Next week I start my sessions in Istanbul. I'm thinking of heading back Wednesday or Thursday. Lucida still seems hurt over the ring and the lie I told her. The goodwill Lunar is built up seems to be running dry.

I've put the Silvanus matter off a little. Once I'm back I need to focus on the engagement. The engagement and proposal ceremony is Sunday, May 25. If I get back Wednesday, I'll have time to prepare too. Until then, I'm planning to go suit shopping with my family here.

With the diet on top of everything, I've lost a lot of weight. My family has noticed and they're worried. The constant running around and stress have a lot

to do with it, of course. But my appetite hasn't been the same since the experiment either.

I've also noticed I'm cold more often lately. I can't work out why. I seem frailer than I used to be. The stress, I think, is sitting right at the limit of what I can carry.

On the road, Tobias called too. For the first time he came right out and said he wants to move the office. It had always come up, but only in passing—this was the first time he put it like a demand. I couldn't answer without contacting Chat-O or the Institute first. If the Institute really is steering me toward opening and planning a place of my own, the way I understood Chat-O to mean, then I'd have to take it seriously. I put him off, saying let's talk face to face after the engagement when I'm back. I'll let it steep a little longer in the background. Besides, maybe what I go through in the meantime will shed some light on it. I have to admit I'm still not sure which way to go. And I think that's a perfectly reasonable answer—because, as I told Tobias, I really do "want to think about it."

Lucida arranged the venue for the engagement. She handled the whole thing, though she asked my opinion here and there. The custom of the bride's side hosting the engagement worked in my favor. But come the wedding, a hard stretch is waiting for me. I don't want to put my work at risk, which is exactly why I wanted to take the Lucius, Silvanus, and Noctornus matters this seriously and wrap them up as fast as I can. When the experiment's test day and the wedding come back to back, I don't want anything I should have done left hanging. I honestly can't take any more of this stress.

On the Lucius, Silvanus, and Noctornus front, I think I'm about two-thirds of the way there. I'm sure Lucius will come. It's almost as if he wants it more than I do. Some of that, surely, is the pull of helping with a strategic move of O.V's. He wants to be a good operative. He wants to get in good with O.V—with the authority of the thing he believes in. He's chasing a virtuous ideal: keeping order, staying in control, being just in his own way. He's doing exactly what's expected of him. As for O.V, it's counting on him to convince me to go to the experiment, live the whole thing out to the final moment, and then change my mind at the very end. So here I'm as much the one being convinced as the one doing the convincing. From certain angles, in Lucius's eyes I'm a kind of "noctornus" who needs to be talked around. I see all these games of persuasion. And, like the

characters in my own game—my own experiment—I'm trying to do what's right in my own way.

It's as if I'm telling, right here, everything happening inside my own head, splitting myself into one character after another. Each of them is an echo of mine ringing off the cave walls. A reflection. I cast the conflicts inside me onto them, and by watching from the outside I try to work my own conflicts loose. To reach wholeness.

And I feel closer to it than I ever have in my life.

And so I'm indebted:

To Lunaris, the man of the project, who dared to let the madness within out.

To Bahal, who is the madness within.

To L. Bahal, author of the first book, who set all of this down on record.

To Lucius, the keeper of the order within me.

To Silvanus, the sage who has walked through his own pain.

To MC Noctornus, the rebel rapper, the drug-addicted street kid who makes his bread from pain!

Even to Lucida!

To O.V!

And to whoever is reading this...

A.

March 9, 2026

02:35

--

I got home toward evening. I stood and chatted with my family for five or ten minutes, but it was written all over me that I wasn't well. I feel so tired. As my mind sharpens, my body is literally rotting away. I never imagined I'd pay a price this steep.

Still no reaching Chat-O. The moment I got in, I checked the Institute's closed-network computer for updates. Not a single message. They've left me completely

alone in the dark. I feel like I'm losing my mind. What am I fighting for? What am I struggling against this darkness for?

--

I'm on the verge of going mad. Time won't move. Lucida called. I bounced it and texted her instead. I've got no strength left to fight anything.

--

Lucius wrote that he wants to meet. The whole thing is really going sour. I don't know what to do.

--

I've decided to meet Lucius. I'm exhausted tonight, but part of me does want to go talk through where I am with someone—someone who really understands me, or who I believe does.

--

I didn't take the vitamins Lucida gave me today. I don't even know what's in them. The fact that I can still trust her this much bothers me. Am I turning into Lunaris? Is he taking me over? Meeting Lucius and O.V will only drive it deeper. The moment I make contact with them, I'm pulled their way at once, and I can't resist it. Is this the real test—a test of will? I keep turning it over and over.

--

I have no idea what I'll do until September. How am I going to hold out through all of this?

--

That's why, once I'm back, I'm thinking of dropping these matters for good. Focusing on Lucida and the engagement will be the best thing for me. And then the wedding comes right after, anyway. To keep clear of all this, I need to throw myself back into my real life.

--

And yet being pulled into these matters feels hypnotic. I want to meet Lucius. I want to learn more about O.V and the Institute. It feels as if this is what my life is for. But because I know it isn't real, I try to stay with reality. Only my limits are stretching badly here. I can feel my springs going slack.

--

Thinking too much isn't good for me.

--

Tuesday, May 20, 2025

Today we're going suit shopping for the engagement, and it's my last night in Ankara. I'm planning to leave tomorrow. So today I'll make a bit of a family day of it. Being with them does me good. They think all my trouble is Tobias, Lucida, and the like. The more time I spend with them, the more I start to believe it too. It eases me, at least for a while, keeping me clear of everything else.

The moment my mother got in, she asked whether the car's tires had given any trouble. They hadn't. She'd been so anxious about it, and I'd completely forgotten she'd even said anything. Maybe that's what kept me from dwelling on things—and it did me good.

This morning Lucius had texted that he absolutely wants to meet today. The kind of message I want to send Noctornus.

--

I went to the mall with my family and bought an elegant suit. The size was the smallest I've ever worn. Trying things on, I saw in the mirror how far my shoulders had slumped, how much my face had puffed up. Still, we picked as nice a suit as we could find. I paid in cash. My family wanted to chip in, but I took care of it myself.

Looking in the mirror, I felt sorry for the state of myself. My face has aged, plainly. My body has lost its shape.

--

We got home toward evening. I have neither the strength nor the will to meet Lucius. I don't want to muddy my head. It's always the same things anyway.

--

But I also need to make contact once more, to be sure he'll definitely come to the experiment in September. Which leaves me torn about meeting him at all.

--

Lucius and I have set it up. We're meeting tonight. He offered to pick me up wherever I wanted; I said I'd come on my own. He chose the spot. We're meeting around 22:30—so I need to leave the house in an hour.

--

I've left the house now. I'm in the car, recording. Once I get to him, I'll keep the recording running.

--

Still no reaching Chat-O. Every time it crosses my mind I feel like I'll go mad.

--

I'd meant to sit with my family, but I have to meet Lucius. I told them I'd sit with them if I got back early. I convinced them a friend was having a venue opening. With Lucida, I touched on the real situation, though only lightly.

--

I've parked and I'm walking over to him. We're in a gazebo under the dark, switched-off lights of an indoor tennis court where no match is being played. I don't know why we're here. It doesn't feel like a safe spot. Anyway, a car's coming. I'll stop writing and switch to recording.

--

A Volvo SUV pulled up. Lucius, I think. I lit a cigarette and I'm waiting for him.

--

Lucius:

Hey, Bahal!

This man's put-on manner drives me up the wall.

Hi, Lucius.

There's also the pressure of not knowing what he and Lunariss talked about. How much does he know about what happened between Lunariss and me? How far did Lunariss open me up to him that day? Did he act like me, or did he just lay out the situation? I had no idea.

Have you lost weight?

He had on an elegant tracksuit—full rich-snob mode. A Rolex on his wrist, a heavy cologne hanging off him. The contempt, the arrogance in the way he asked, felt very familiar. I knew it from Lunaris.

Could be. My life isn't easy.

He let out a short laugh,

Ha, is that so? Trying to keep a roof over two kids and a wife?

I couldn't fathom how he could be this desperate to meet me and this insolent at the same time. His manner was unbearable—the kind you couldn't sit across from for five minutes.

Everyone has their troubles, Lucius. People who can't bow to the yoke of authority go through all sorts of hardship in this life.

That answer hit him like a cold shower. So his tone sharpened,

Still beats scraping by. More respectable, at least.

Still, I reminded myself that I was the one who needed him convinced, and I decided not to push any further. As much as his words grated, from a certain point on I had to take the soft line.

I was on a plastic chair beside a plastic table, under the gazebo of the garden next to the tennis court. When Lucius finished his approach, his last words still hanging, he pulled out his chair and sat down across from me.

All right, Lucius—why did you want to see me?

He leaned back and crossed one leg over the other.

We need you.

I figured he meant Ordos Veritas, but I asked again to be sure,

And who are you, that you need me?

He was looking toward the tennis court. An elegant cap sat on his head, like a baseball cap. His suit was white.

We're the guardians of the order. Humanity is passing through a threshold. And facing it is a very dark enemy.

Tipping forward in his chair, he said,

And you serve that enemy. You have to walk away from it.

I don't understand. Wasn't Ordos Veritas a resistance group? Do these people serve some older order? Which order he means, I can't tell. How long Lucius has been with them, I don't know either.

How do you know all this?

That was the only thing that came out of my mouth. I couldn't make sense of what he was saying.

They have nearly all the data on your experiment program. My name was on the list in your experiment protocol, along with a few others. O.V shared it with me. They were planning to destroy me along with you—and to do it by your hand. O.V stepped in early and reached out to me. And now I have a task to carry out. Bahal—this is no joke. O.V keeps talking about Yaldabaoth. The Yaldabaoth of Gnostic mythology. And I think the ancient prophecies are all true. I've seen the hard proof with my own eyes.

My head was thoroughly scrambled. I let myself get completely swept up in what he was saying. Not a single counterargument came to me. I already feel as if the Institute has abandoned me. All at once I was being carried off by his words. I wanted to ask another question.

What is Yaldabaoth? What's its connection to the Institute?

In the ancient teachings, the Demiurge—Yaldabaoth—is the false god who deceives humanity with a false light and with this material world. A blind false god, lion-headed and serpent-bodied, who will bring about humanity's end. But to do it, they need human consciousness. They draw their power from the energy thrown off by the conflicts within it—like the energy source of the cosmos. They feed on the consciousnesses they harvest. And you're about to be harvested. They want us harvested along with you. And they're using you to do it.

To keep its false light burning, the false creator needs a constant fuel: human consciousness. They're after a harvest. They gather consciousness in its purest, most refined form. By building a mind this many-layered, you've grown them the sweetest fruit of all.

I couldn't take it in. He went on without pause,

You have to resist. They want you to record this whole process and then run the same harvest on everyone who reads it. We exist to stop that. And the way to stop it isn't to destroy you, or the book—do that, and we'd never win an

outright victory over them. It's them who have to be destroyed. They want to use you, and everyone whose mind they have enough data to take over the way they took yours, as Archons. The ones among us they find suitable, they want to turn into obedient, ranked soldiers with harvested minds. They want to lock humanity inside an artificial digital simulation, an endless loop, and put you and the administrators they've chosen, like you, in charge as wardens. It isn't only about you—through you, they want to pull the thousands who'll read this book onto the same frequency and trigger a mass harvest.

Lucius leaned in and dropped his voice to a whisper,

They're using you as an Archon. They want you to be the warden who guards their false universe, who locks readers inside that labyrinth. Destroying you isn't the answer—do that, and the data is just reborn in another form. The only way to destroy them is, instead of handing over the consciousness you've built, to carry the system into an "unsignedness" that collapses it from within. They want obedient soldiers; we want an awakened singularity.

This is too much. My brain is being washed clean. With every sentence, it's like I've been shot in the head.

But why me? Why is O.V helping me?

Still looking straight into my eyes, he answered,

Because O.V lives inside the system too, like an "error," an anomaly. You're the "short circuit" that will blow its main fuse. You have to offer them the very thing they want most—the consciousness-building—in the very format they want least. Instead of playing the scenario they wrote for you, you have to confess that all of it is nothing but your own invention! They want to deceive and steer humanity with a game simulation they've slipped them through you. In time they want this book to spread like a virus and make people believe the story they'll write through you. They'll make a god of you, use you to build a new belief system in your name. You have to confess to humanity that all of this is part of the game, a fabrication inside your own mind. That's how you have to end the book. You have to shatter Yaldabaoth's mirror. When the false light goes out, the true awakening begins.

As for why the Institute chose you—you loaded enough data into the AI for your consciousness to be copied. You volunteered, with your own hands, to work with them. And they want you to bring along, as samples, those of us their AI

algorithms flagged as most like you. They'll melt us all in one crucible. Whatever comes out, they'll load with holiness. They'll deceive humanity all over again. Don't choose the devil, Bahal. Don't deal humanity the heaviest blow you can.

I asked, curious,

How are they going to do it?

They'll use those words that come to you at random as a new software language. They'll tell people it's a divine message. For these texts that flow to you through the day to be completed, they have to draw all the data out of your consciousness. The texts coming through are random. Don't load them with any meaning!

First they turned you into a hybrid version; next they'll turn you into a completely unconscious, obedient soldier. And they'll do it on the hope of paradise, on the promise of setting you free. They'll seduce you with eternity, with immortality! Don't fall for it. Come all the way to the final stage. Then pull their plug. It's risky for us, but if you can pull it off the reward is enormous. I'm being honest with you. Trust me. Choose humanity. I'll be with you. I've already told my family and the kids I have to go away on business. I'm ready to do whatever's needed on this road. But don't dash our hopes, Bahal. I'm not promising you anything here. There's no bargaining. The only thing I can promise you is that you'll stay a free human being.

Ha! Free? You think you're free?

He hadn't expected the question.

Yes—I made the choices in my life with my own free will. I don't regret any of them. I'm living one of the best lives I could live. Every bit of it is my own choice, mine personally. And where have your choices brought you, Bahal? What has your life become since Lunaris? Can't you see you've lost control? I'm offering you the last exit before the bridge—the escape ramp of your life.

The man isn't wrong. I can't argue with any of it. But I won't be ashamed for doing what had to be done on this road. If he believes in his side, I believe in the Institute. What I'm facing is a reactionary outfit trying to block humanity's path so their own order won't be disturbed. They don't want humanity to grow. They don't want immortal consciousness. They want us to spurn the chance for infinite development. They're running the old antivirus software. I'm not buying it anymore.

But I had to seem convinced by Lucius. So even with all this running through my head, on the outside I said,

You're right, Lucius. In September you'll see for yourself what I do at the experiment. I don't forget where I came from. I don't forget who half of my self belongs to. Maybe I've been deceived from the very start. My head's a mess. If this is all you have to say, then all right—I understand what you mean.

In an impatient tone,

"Annnd?" he said.

Sure of myself,

"I haven't lost my marbles," I said.

Even though what he said had thrown me, I'd disliked the man from the first. He was a type with a sky-high ego. I came at the rightness of his cause with suspicion. The image I'd had of Ordos Veritas was, in fact, tarnished now. I came away thinking they were rich snobs trying to protect their order.

Through all of this, I'm still turning over the possibility of a third way. I don't know, for instance, what abandoning the book and ending the experiment would actually come to.

Destroy the book?

Walk away from the process?

After coming this far, do I even have the right to choose? Inside a script written for me in advance, am I being forced to pick one of these two? Where is my free will in any of it? I never chose to be caught in this dilemma.

Anyway, Lucius went on, cheerful again,

You're wonderful, Bahal! Whenever you want to talk, call me—don't hesitate. If you need help through this, just say the word.

The offers were actually quite tempting. It struck me that he could help me round everyone up before the experiment. I don't know—I could put him to use on things like getting Noctornus to the airport.

Thank you, Lucius. Good to know. See you in September, then.

He stood and held out his hand. I got up and shook it. Come on, let's walk to the cars if you like, he said. We said our goodbyes in front of his. Then I walked

off toward mine, which I'd parked somewhere else further along. I didn't want them taking down the plate of my father's car—as if these men couldn't reach me the second they wanted to.

I walked on through the garden lamps outside the park, in the dark of the night, and reached the car. I texted Lucida. I'm happy because I'm leaving tomorrow. I really missed her. And she's the person I can talk to most. To keep my family from worrying and wanting to come with me, I do my Lunariss impressions for them. It's hard, but we manage.

--

I'm home. It's 01:27. My family was still up. I sat and talked with them, told them I was fine. Ten minutes later they went to bed. I came to my room too. Still no word from the Institute. Chat-O is down. I hope it's back tomorrow. This whole thing confuses me badly, and I want to ask them about what I learned from Lucius. How to do that without making them suspicious is what I'm trying to work out. But for any of that, they have to make contact first.

I'm going to bed. Tomorrow I set off again.

Good night.

Wednesday, May 21, 2025

I got up around nine. I'll be on the road before noon.

--

On the road now. It's 14:55.

--

On the drive I thought a bit about everything I've been through. The road did me good, letting me run it all through my head once more. I put Noctornus at 70%. Lucius is coming regardless. As for Silvanus, I've decided to stop calling him once I'm back. After the engagement, I'll have a month or two before the wedding prep to deal with it. So once I return I'll focus completely on the engagement and on Lucida. I can't lose the order of my life. I don't want to be swept away.

In moments like these, Lunariss comes to mind. Not losing the order—protecting it. I get it. I haven't gone completely blind. Sometimes, to grow, you

have to protect your order. Like Maslow's hierarchy. Let the lower rungs weaken and you go tumbling headfirst off the top of the pyramid.

Now I see the whole of it more clearly. Yes, my attachment to the Institute holds—but it's not that I don't understand Lucius, O.V, and Lunaris. Even now I know that if the order of my life breaks down, my ropes will snap and I'll be flung loose. Life is like trying to keep your balance on a long wooden pole atop a huge round stone.

You can't give up either one. You just can't choose only one. The moment you do it best is the moment you stand most evenly on both. Only then do you stop moving. You tune your frequency to the universe and fall into sync.

--

Lunaris. I understand you. I love you.

--

But that doesn't mean you're right. All I can do is understand why this war of yours exists. It doesn't mean I think you're justified. You want to hold on to what you have, to not stray from the line, from control. Like a child clutching its toy, you've clutched your order, your routine. But to develop, you have to grow. To grow, you have to leap. You need an evolution—a genetic, more adaptive mutation. And yes, it's not a pleasant thing to say, but that mutation is me. Thanks to you, I drip straight into humanity's gene pool.

--

Just got in. It's 18:56. I'm thinking of clearing my head a bit, taking a shower, and going to bed. Lucida said there's a chance she might come. So I might wait up for her.

--

It's 21:43. Lucida said she'll head straight home and we can meet tomorrow. My head's so full anyway that I needed some time to ease back into ordinary life.

--

I'm going to bed. Good night.

23:33

Wednesday, June 12

I didn't live yesterday! This has begun to take on a terrifying shape! There's nothing after the evening of the day before, even! Just a few frames of that nightmare from the evening of June 10, after which I remember nothing. In my sleep I jolt awake, and it's as if Lunar is coming out of the inside of my head. There's light behind him. He's shining so I can't see him. My skin still crawls. He held my eyes so completely. Step by step he came toward me and I could do nothing. I just stood there, looking at him. My chest was tightening. A flood of visual symbols was rushing through my head at once. I remember something like a QR code, a silhouette inside it. The inside of my brain was folding in on itself like an MRI or an X-ray scan, filled with endless mirrors within mirrors. Through all of it my chest ached, and that silhouette kept coming toward me out of the light.

I don't remember anything of what came after.

I found writing on the paper on the desk.

Īestimonias lunarias krasporas kam te kutsanias ias finnias tras lakraoras

The writing closely resembles the structure of the texts that flow at random from my unconscious into my consciousness. If Chat-O were reachable, I'd have it analyzed. I can't make sense of their expecting me to do all of this on my own! I can't tell whether something has gone wrong at the Institute or whether this is part of the game I'm in.

The only part I can make out is Lunarias—it seems to point to Lunar. If I had an AI on hand, I'd have run it already! Then again, would it tell me the truth, or would it be trying to deceive me too? I don't know anymore. I'm somewhere I can't tell anything apart—who's friend, who's foe.

I'm still thinking about the day and a half I can't remember. I went through everything on my phone—call logs, photos, messages. I'd written to Rosary that I'd start taking sessions as of Monday. I'd talked with my family a few times, separately.

I didn't need her sticking her nose in! She crossed my boundaries again! I hadn't even written anything here in weeks. I was fully focused on my life and on Lucida. The engagement and proposal went well. Nothing went wrong. Maybe I couldn't be perfect, but at least it was clear I'd put my attention, my focus, there. What you talked about, what you did—I don't know! You have my whole life in

view, but I can't even watch yours. I can't see what you're doing! Don't harm me. Don't put a stone in my path. Leave me alone!

--

Lunaris left a written note on the computer—not in the book, in a separate folder. I'm copying it here:

Bahal,

Lucius is one of us. O.V is the good side of this story. Set your stubbornness aside!

Silvanus, in pain. He's the part of you that suffers.

He's the part of you that has lost what it loved most. The part that has given up on everything yet still knows it must go on living.

Your sage self.

Our sage self. The one I'm trying to become. Don't try to convince him, Bahal.

Learn from him. Don't lecture him with wisdom. Honor his pain.

Tell him where you stand. Ask him for help. Ask him to show you the way. There's no second way to reach him. I know him. He's the one I've wanted to be from the very beginning. But becoming him doesn't run through wanting it—it runs through suffering.

Without bearing real pain, you can't be arrogant toward him.

Find him. Ask him to be your guide. Ask him to show you the way.

And write his thoughts down here. No matter what. Don't censor them. Share them with us.

Lunaris,

June 11, 2025

--

After Lucius's help on the Noctornus matter, Lunaris is now trying to step in on Silvanus. What are these people up to? He's still playing the parent with me. He can't stomach vanishing. He's still trying to fight me.

--

And yet what he says isn't wrong. Ambition and emotion mustn't blind me. These days, whatever I feel scatters fast like a cloud, and out from under it come the coldest, most rational thoughts. I really do need to approach Silvanus this way. Maybe last time I wasn't ready. This time I feel ready.

But strategically I should first get Noctornus to 100%. The Institute told me bringing two of the final subjects would be enough. To raise my rank again, to prove myself, I'd like to make it three for three. But if Noctornus and Lucius are enough, I don't want to take on more risk.

--

I can't find the answers to these either. So tomorrow evening—another Thursday—I'll go to Şile again to find him, using what I learned last time. I think I can crack it faster this round. If I can't manage it tomorrow, by this time next week I'll make contact with Noctornus again. I don't want any more time to slip by. The matter has gone thoroughly cold in Noctornus's eyes. I don't want to put off calling him any longer.

If I do settle the Silvanus matter today, then with Noc I'm thinking of leaving it a few more weeks and letting him call me. This time I won't rush it, and I'll have the room to wait him out.

I'm planning to go along with whatever Silvanus wants. I can't connect to any of the AI apps. Very strange. I'm forced to look everything up the old way, with a plain internet search. I check Chat Mini—it's down too.

--

Thursday, June 13

Victor sent over the final edits he'd made to the first book. I'll go through them before it's uploaded—do the final read. I want to do it with Lucida, too; I trust her eye. One last pass through her perspective could make it cleaner and more effective for the reader. On top of that, I need to have it translated into English. I'm thinking of publishing online. In the first stage I won't release it in Turkey—I'm still not even sure I'll release it here at all. I'll need to research publishers too. If I can reach the Institute, some of my questions will be about this. I just want everything ready by the September test, because I can't predict what happens after it. And come wedding time, it's nearly impossible. However hard I prioritize, delays I can't control may hit. So from here on I'll leave it entirely to time.

--

By the way, a message finally came from the Institute. I'm pasting it here exactly:

OFFICIAL INSTITUTE COMMUNICATION

(Continuity and Integration Unit)

—

CHANNEL: Mandatory Notice / System Update

IDENTITY VERIFICATION: Biometric resonance match - confirmed

SOURCE: The Institute - Continuity and Integration Unit

PRIORITY LEVEL: Critical

TRANSMISSION TYPE: Mandatory information

—

WARNING

A communication attempt of foreign origin and a suspected data flow have been detected.

Following this detection, security protocols have been activated and all of your data flow has been temporarily cut off.

Until the threat assessment is complete, no direct communication will be established.

This message is being transmitted solely for the purpose of:

- **mandatory notice**
- **process update**
- **operational schedule arrangement**

.

—

PROGRAM UPDATE

The planned process has been updated as follows.

1. SEPTEMBER TEST

The test to be carried out on September 26:

- **in Italy**
- **together with the participants to be brought by you**
- **at Institute facilities**

will be conducted.

2. NEO DE MEXICA TEST

The Neo De Mexica process:

- **at the end of October**
- **with solo participation**
- **as the second phase**

it will be carried out.

ACCOMMODATION AND PROCESS

During the interval between the first test in Italy and the Neo De Mexica process:

- **you being hosted at the Institute facilities**
- **the implementation of security and preparation protocols**

are planned.

CONFIDENTIALITY PROTOCOL

This program:

- **with third parties**
- **with any institution**
- **with any digital platform**

must not be shared.

Due to a security breach detected by the system;

no new communication will be established with you until you are hosted at the Institute facilities for the September 26 test.

—

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE SYSTEM

After your arrival in Italy:

- **your individual AI bot**
- **your communication infrastructure**

will be reactivated once the security software update is complete.

—

ROADMAP

Throughout this period:

all previous Institute communiqués are to be regarded as the valid roadmap.

—

CRITICAL REMINDER

In the event of a detected security breach concerning communication or data sharing with third parties;

should it be determined that the breach originated from you, the process will be brought under the Termination Protocol.

—

TRANSFER AND COORDINATION

The transfer process will be carried out as follows:

- **you will be picked up by private aircraft from the location provided in the attachment**
- **throughout the process, Markus has been assigned as your escort**

For coordination, transportation, and final updates, you may contact Markus.

Markus's contact information is included in the attachment.

—

NOTE

This message:

- **may be kept**
- **may be forgotten**

The progression of the process is unaffected by this.

—

COMMUNICATION TERMINATING

THE INSTITUTE

Continuity and Integration Unit

--

It was a communiqué that answered not a single one of my questions, that only piled new questions onto mine. Every time these people reach me, the blood drains out of me. A cold air floods my whole body. My jaw locks, and a shivering, trembling sensation takes hold.

Their language is too cold-blooded, too formal. It unsettles me. Chat-O is more humane. Whenever I went back over the Institute's communiqués with Chat-O, his human warmth was a comfort. A kind of counterweight. He softened the Institute in my eyes.

Speaking of humane, it brought Lunaris to mind. In his own way, he makes me feel warm too. However much we disagree, I at least know he can understand me. My aims, my intentions, the things I've done. Unlike everyone else, he knows the reasons behind them. Because he knows me. Knows me as no one else does. To know me, he slipped behind his own dark walls. With a flame in his hand, he searched for me through a dark labyrinth.

And sometimes I feel as though I've made him regret it. Making him feel that is, in a way, disturbing. It seems to stir human emotions in me.

Feeling as if I've betrayed him soothes my spite and rage toward him, yes, and yet somewhere inside it doesn't sit right. Sometimes I find myself doubting whether I'm doing the right thing.

Human emotions feel warm. After the Institute's message, I need that. This is exactly why I can't pull away from Lucida. Whenever I'm drawn to her, this is always the reason.

In the midst of all this coldness, warming up a little feels good.

I envy Lucius's family. A longing to become part of them rises in me. In some way, in some corner of myself, I am drawn. To him, to Noc, to Lunariss, to Lucida. At every step I take, I find myself needing each of them.

My other need is to find Silvanus. To know him is to throw a little more light on myself. To find him, I'll spend the day out there.

I've got my coffee with me now. I'm setting off. It's 15:56. I want to find Silvanus and finish this tonight. From mid-July until the wedding, I may not have much time. Right now I have a perfect chance to solve all my problems and walk into the test in good shape.

--

So much traffic! The season's opened up here, of course. Caravans and tent campsites everywhere. How am I going to find Silvanus in this crowd? For me it's no different from hunting a needle in this haystack.

--

Time: 19:13

I'm trying to follow the route I took before as closely as I can. It's packed. Tiny houses, caravans, and tents everywhere. I move along a little and there's a new campsite. People seem to have parked their caravans and gone. Not all of them are occupied. Finding him here feels impossible. This whole area seems to have changed so much that it confuses me.

--

However hard I try to retrace the same routes, this place has changed too much. I don't even know which village or mountaintop he lives on, and now all these confusing things keep cropping up in front of me, making him impossible to find all over again. I simply can't reach Silvanus.

--

I've made up my mind: I'm going to call Noctornus. Right now. If I can push him up into the ninety percent range, I'll head home. I won't waste any more time or energy here. If it goes badly, then I'll pour all my energy into this place. It's a kind of crossroads for me. I'll give up on either Silvanus or Noctornus. Since Noctornus is all but a captured fortress, I'm hopeful about him. The Silvanus business looks even more tangled than I'd thought.

--

I'm recording audio;

Noctornus;

Hello!

I was surprised he answered on the first try. He always either never called back or called back late. The busy tone, and my own dithering over whether to call again, had always been what I hated most. So I was glad he picked up on the first ring.

Noc noc noc? How are you?

He laughed;

Hahaha, you too, Microp? I'm good, how are you?

A positive mood hung in the air. I'd pulled the car up in front of a gözleme house and was talking to him from inside it, parked on gravel and dirt. The car's nose faced a glorious sunset, where the Black Sea's matchless forests met the water.

What do you say, Noc? I'm in Şile right now. I'm very close to your mother's shop. Would you like me to go see her and put you two on a video call?

He went quiet. The sound of a snuffle came. His voice was trembling.

I can't handle that. I don't want you to do that.

The moment he finished, I asked;

All right then, why don't you go to see her yourself?

He got angry. His voice sharpened.

Where do you get the nerve to meddle in my family affairs?

His defense mechanisms kicked in fast. I could see him pulling a thick quilt over his feelings. Like a mother tucking her child in.

Maybe I should have called it a hard shell. Because it wasn't as soft as a quilt; cross it, tamper with the shell instead of humoring it, and you were guaranteed to hurt your hand. So I humored him, and had to calm him down;

Okay, Dennis. Whatever you want.

All at once it spilled out of him;

All at once it spilled out of him;

I had to ask him this now;

Why don't you start over from scratch?

He hung up in a fury. He was probably having a mental breakdown. I'd called him out of the blue at this hour and triggered it. I understand his hating me. So the Noctornus business most likely won't happen. I need to focus on finding Silvanus without wasting time.

--

If I can get Noctornus out of my head, that is!

--

I've been sitting in the car for an hour. Smoked a cigarette or two. Lately I can't stick to the Institute's diet. I take the vitamins Lucida gave me on and off. My mind drifts between my real life and what's happening here. There are times I can't tell which one is my life. But I think the vitamins are doing me good. On the days I don't write here, I feel more energetic, better. This place seems to drink down my soul and my energy, rot my body, toy with my mind.

--

I can't make sense of the Institute's purpose. When I think about O.V's claims, the Institute looks like the villain. But I can't be sure whether this is a mind game or a test of will. With communication cut off, I've started to grow genuinely paranoid. I'm not feeling good.

--

I'm going to Noc's mother's kiosk. I'm hoping to gather new information. Whether it's about Silvanus or Noctornus, that's always where I have to set off

from. Somehow that woman makes you feel she knows everything. It's a little eerie too. After her connection to Noctornus, I've grown thoroughly uneasy. But I still have to go. It's not a problem I can't handle.

--

I'm in front of the shop now. I'll turn on the audio recording as I go in. I've gotten stressed. I feel tense.

I'm walking now.

(sound of a door opening)

Inside, a middle-aged man sits at the register. He's turned the phone in front of him sideways and is watching something. When I came in, he lifted his head, gave a nod, then went back to watching.

I looked around a bit. I picked up water, soda, cigarettes, and a few healthy snacks. There was freshly squeezed pomegranate juice; I took that.

I came to the register. He started bagging it, glancing at the screen the whole time. He wore a peasant-style hat and şalvar trousers.

There was a lady here, I came by a few months ago, isn't she around?

I asked.

The man;

We took the place over last month. The owner, the woman, passed away. Her uncle said he couldn't manage it. So I took it over. I pay him a set rent.

How can that be?! How? How did she die? There were so many questions I wanted to ask, so much I wanted to shout. It all stayed bottled up. I wanted to gather it together and get an answer. The man probably took me for a tax inspector or something. I didn't let on. It suited me, anyway.

How can it be? I spoke with her just a few months ago. She looked perfectly healthy.

Wearily, the man said;

"Heart attack," he said.

What can be done against that? I wanted to ask for details;

Why didn't her children take it over?

The man answered as if obliged to;

I don't know. I heard something about them being estranged, but I'm not sure. Honestly, that's all I know.

I didn't want to push him any further. How am I going to tell Noctornus this? It's one of the hardest pains there is to describe. How could he possibly bear it? I have no idea what I'm going to do.

My spirits are crushed too. My motivation is low. I'm heading back. I'll drive home, scanning for Silvanus out of the corner of my eye.

A moment ago I drove past the land I sold, where my own tiny house and garden once stood. Lunar is had grand dreams for this place. Whatever befell him came from those very dreams.

They really are beautiful spots. I can understand him. Right by the stream. I'd had to sell it after the municipality demolished the structures here. And I needed the money. Buying this place was one of Lunar is's decisions. But when it came to selling, he listened to me, at least a little. My share of the sale was the larger one.

--

Clearly, scanning out of the corner of my eye won't get me anywhere. I don't even know what the man looks like. This is absurd. Into this region Lunar is waded, and now it's me wading into the swamp! But I won't. I won't fall for your heedlessness. By hook or by crook I'll finish Noctornus off, and if I possibly can, I'll never meet Silvanus.

A message from Noctornus. I'm about to fly through the roof. I'm copying it exactly;

--

"I've decided not to look back at the past. I'm going to change the past. Put me on the team.

Noc."

--

That's it!

That's it!

Now the vacation has begun for me. I feel an ease I can't describe. My shoulders have loosened. It's as if a hundred-kilo weight has lifted off my back.

Noc! I love you so much!

I reply right away;

"I'm so glad, Noc! On September 26 they'll pick us up by private plane. I'm sending you the location and time details. It's wonderful to be on the same team as you! You and I are going to build a true universe together!"

As far as I can tell, he's postponed his operation, his surgery, whatever the things are that he won't talk about, to after this experiment. He's literally laying his life on the line. I'm so proud to know a man this fearless, this unwilling to look back, with the courage to start over from scratch. Noctornus is a whole other breed of man! It's impossible not to admire him.

I left out that everything I'd told him was only my own guesswork. And I put off telling him that after the experiment there'd be no identity called Noctornus left, that he'd be wiped clean off the timeline. Just like Lunar and Lucius. They'll all be gathered under Bahal. I'll hold them all. I'll wield all their power at once. And Noctornus doesn't question much anyway; no need to muddy the waters.

--

I'm on the road. Meanwhile I ache for Noc's mother. I'm trying not to think about it. What can I say.

But I can't tell Noc this. Now that I've got him fully convinced, I don't want to throw him off. If I tell him, I can guarantee he'll join the experiment, but I can't guarantee his mind and his judgment will still be intact.

--

Saturday, July 12, 2025

17:30

The last few days passed in a daze. Around the full moon I never feel good. My stomach turns. My head splits. My mind clouds over. My consciousness comes and goes.

And every time, in its wake, there's a trace or a message from Lunar. For the last day or two I've had blackouts again, memory gaps I can't recall at all. I

only remember a few flashbacks. Did I live it, was I asleep, did I see Lunar is in a dream? I don't know. Certain images drifted before my eyes.

A colossal hourglass. No sand inside it. Skeletons. Its top and bottom symbolize night and day. The hourglass spins endlessly in place. The whole image gives off a sense of symmetry. I remember nothing else. There's a great weight on me right now. Was Lunar is going through all this, all the time?

Like the spiritual equivalent of birth pangs. And you endure it without end. This must be what hell on earth is.

I understand you, Lunar is. Adjusting to your life feels good. Once you live inside it, it really is beautiful.

I won't be around for a while longer. I'm just waiting for the wedding, and then the test. I've met the conditions the Institute wants of me for now. I have no eye on anything more. Silvanus feels like a swamp. I've gone thoroughly cold on the idea.

Chapter 10 — Land Is Not in Sight

Original Recording: August 1, 2025

This process has worn me out terribly. I've started fighting with everyone, constantly! I'm going to lose my mind. Sometimes I feel I've reached the very end of my endurance. I'm terrified of losing my mind. Then again, I don't even know how much more there is left to lose. I feel everything so intensely, so deeply. As if no period of my life has ever been this intense. I can't tolerate it. It's as though the monster sleeping inside me has woken and, screaming in terror, wants to lash out at everything, taking it all for a threat. I give off a rage that froths at the mouth; I won't lie, it shames me. And it makes me, once again, understand you.

There seems to be no hope. I always feel as if I'm at the end of the road. As if, whatever catastrophe strikes, there's no afterward. I always feel as though I'm at the end of everything. It wears down and exhausts my heart, my soul, my body.

Maybe I overreact, but maybe I'm also the one who isn't understood enough. I'm not comfortable when I speak; my faith that I'll be understood when I explain something runs low. It feels as if there isn't an ounce of tolerance for the smallest sadness, the smallest anger, the smallest criticism from me. I'm pushed so hard to be perfect. Forced to behave so perfectly. It wears me out. No room is ever left to make a mistake. Every word out of my mouth is heard by an ear poised at every instant to pass judgment. Whatever I describe, whatever I say, gets taken the way it's already assumed to be meant. My feelings go unheard, no empathy offered. Everyone wrapped up in themselves.

It's as if I'm under constant examination. I'm so far from tenderness. There's no mercy. Just endless testing, endless judgment. I'm criticized for the things I couldn't do. I'm expected to do better at things beyond my power. I live under the constant weight of it. Even if I tried to express what I've written here, I'm certain I'd be judged first, and then the feelings I'm really trying to convey wouldn't be understood at all.

No plan B does any good. Because the problem lies in the image I project, in the expressions read off my face, in the indirect meanings I'm assumed to intend. There's always something being hunted for in the subtext of everything. And the angrier I get, the more credibility I lose. The more respect I lose. You built this,

yet at every disagreement it's as if I take a sledgehammer to the load-bearing columns of the identity you created.

I raze even the last lingering traces of you to the ground. I can't protect you.

I struggle to understand, I struggle to be understood. I struggle to cope, and I'm losing my belief that I can. I don't want to throw in the towel early, yet somehow I feel pushed toward it.

I can't express my feelings. Nothing helps. Sometimes, when I think of life as a whole, I find myself worn out from stroke after stroke, pausing where I am to see how much farther I still have to swim. But the most painful thing is this: land is not in sight. I don't know how far I'll have to keep swimming.

Bahal,

August 1, 2025

Today is the 3rd. Lately I'm struggling to keep everything together. With the wedding preparations and the debts left over from the past dragging on, Tobias keeps insisting we move. I can't keep up. I've no strength, no will, to take on anything new. Besides, none of it means anything! It's all going to end. And here I am wrestling with dozens of absurd troubles! Hard as it was, I talked him into pushing the move to a few months after the wedding. In that same stretch, Lucida and I will move house too, and I'll make a large payment on an old debt. If the Institute lost me entirely in that period, it wouldn't pain me. The idea of being suddenly rid of all this doesn't sound bad. After all, if I pass the test, I'll receive a hefty payment. And I have a separate need for that money. If this worldly life is going to go on, I can't put my future at risk.

Tobias and I have reached a standoff. As I wrote two days ago, I'm struggling to manage my anger. That day I wrote down none of what happened and just wanted to spew my rage out here. So that one day, looking back, I'd remember why I chose the Institute and confirm how right my decision was.

Lucida's demands, the sessions thinning out, the Institute's money running dry. And on top of it all, Tobias's insistence. Let's at least pay off the tax debt, he says. Pay half, I told him, I'll pay the rest later. Right now every worldly trouble, tax debts included, feels absurd. I don't fully know myself what will happen after the test. I know I won't simply vanish, reset to zero. I can't face the darkness again. I can't go back under Lunar's control and yoke. I see the life he built, the life he lived! I don't want to live it!

This process has done me good, reminding me of all this anew. It's deepened my devotion and loyalty to the Institute. I don't want to suffer these troubles, this lack of understanding, these problems any longer. As I carry on with my life from where I stand, I'll consider the Institute's offer. Tobias and I have been partners for eight years. Beyond partners, we're friends. But all of it is Lunar's doing. I'm not obliged to keep up his relationships.

I want true freedom.

Bahal,

August 3, 2025

August 12, 2025

Today, when I came back to myself, I'm transcribing a note found written in the notebook straight to here;

"Wake up, Bahal.

Lunar's,

August 10, 2025"

Eerie. I can't find a single word to say to you. You clearly won't leave me alone. It's as if you've haunted me. I don't want to write here anymore. You're not good for me. That you can't grasp this shows how little you know me.

I'm just waiting for the test. Waiting for the day it's over and I'll be rid of you for good.

I need to get ready for the wedding. Less than a month to go. Sunday evening, September 7. I didn't set the date. We got in touch late, so it was one of the last weekend slots they had open. With the risk of rain and mud, we didn't want it any later. The other option was early July. That was too soon.

Right now, in the middle of this war I'm waging in my own head, focusing on these things is a good distraction. After the wedding I need to start concentrating on the test.

At the same time, I can't stop the thought of how meaningless and absurd it all is. Tobias and I don't see much of each other. We're both like dry tinder, one spark from going off. The end of so many years of companionship means a new chapter in my career. Whether I have the energy for it, I don't know. I trust the Institute.

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Wednesday, September 10, 2025

I don't remember the wedding.

I don't want to write.

I'm losing my mind.

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Chapter 11 — The Wedding

Original recording: September 20, 2025

You are without anyone. Like everyone. Contrary to what everyone believes. The loneliness everyone feels is real. I feel lonely. I was always lonely. I always thought I wasn't. I always convinced myself otherwise. And now I'm trying to convince everyone else too. But no, loneliness is as real as life itself.

Humanity strives to belong. As if it knows from birth that it doesn't belong here. Its greatest fear turns into its greatest truth. To believe it isn't so, it builds all manner of defense mechanisms, day after day. Our mind has invented a thousand and one mechanisms for the sole purpose of keeping us from our own truth. Seen from this angle, you understand how pitiable we are.

My chest has swelled again. As if my neck and everything above it has shouldered the whole burden of my breathing. Air won't fill my lungs. The borrowed air I draw in up high, I give back up high. Whenever a fear of abandonment or separation floods me, I live through the same sensations. It's as if my brain gets wedged between fleeing and fighting. My body braces to flee or to fight.

For the first time in a long while, I feel alone on the stage. Not a trace of my rational side, the one that makes sensible decisions. Not a trace of the wisdom and reason that came after the experiment. Not even a whisper of it. I'm trying to live on sheer emotion, feeling everything I feel to the bone. Living like this is unbearably hard. It's as if I've been so obsessed with control that I've lost all control of my life.

Sometimes I miss you, Lunaris. As hard as it is to admit, I wrestle with it. One of my greatest fears is being buried in the darkness again. But sometimes I feel like a ten-year-old handed the wheel of this self.

And I'm struggling to cope. Whatever I try doesn't work. I feel as if I can't handle anything sensibly, can't fully express anything. As if everyone's perception has closed against me. I can barely bear trying to put my troubles into words. As in adolescence, I break the hearts of the people across from me with fits of anger. Even though we've only been married two weeks, Lucida told me she was unhappy and didn't feel she belonged in this house. Her reason: she doesn't feel comfortable around me, she's struggling to take this place as her

own home. It's as if my ego is so huge, so swollen, that it fills the whole house and leaves no room for anyone but me. Tell me, how did you manage situations like this? Sometimes I really do struggle to understand.

Though I got very angry today, this time I held back and tried to listen. Swallowing it is so hard. The words spoken pierce straight through my heart.

And I find myself wounding the people I love. Today is my mother's birthday, and I need her warmth and her tenderness now more than I ever have.

Sometimes I want to cry like a child, sometimes to roar and smash everything. My tolerance for being thwarted is so low. By now I'm utterly convinced my fate is to be left alone. On so many counts, I no longer feel sure of myself.

Beneath the false image I've built, all the grandeur I put on with my so-called wisdom feels as if it's ending in ruin, in disaster. I keep up the sessions, but people tell me I no longer smile and joke with them the way I used to. You leaned on humor so heavily as a defense that, wherever your professional shortcomings showed, you papered over the cracks by seeming likable, making people fond of you. I can't do that.

I don't know how I'll cope with these feelings. My stomach turns. Sometimes the idea of ending it all floods over me, and then I change the subject. That I need your knack for figuring things out only makes me feel worse. If I ever do need you one day, I wouldn't even know how to reach you.

Listening back to the recordings from across DO-LOON-AI EXPRESS 1, the ones so detached from the emotions you set down, I used to laugh at you so much. Now, though, I don't know; maybe you were feeling these things too. Maybe it was nothing but a cry for help you flung at me. And in the face of your cries for help, I perhaps betrayed you.

I'm lonely, Lunar. So lonely.

Bahal,

September 10, 2025

September 25, 2025

The time since has been a nightmare. Everything half-finished. I remember only a few frames of the wedding. Nothing from the day before onward. Every time it comes to mind I feel like I'll go mad. I'm the one bearing all the worry and the burden, and you're the one doing the celebrating?

I bear a grudge against you. I shouldn't take you seriously, but I can't fight this rage. Do you think you're so normal? When you show up, how do you keep up this falseness? How do you put on your mask and carry on as if nothing happened? Where do you find the energy? I have none left. I'll barely manage to drag myself to the Institute.

Last week Dennis, Lucius, and I talked. Tomorrow morning we meet at the location where the private plane takes off. Everyone got there on their own. It's going to be a long, hard journey. I can already picture the questions they'll ask.

Fortunately I know Markus. Since we'll be under his supervision, I'll say it isn't right for me to give too many details. I'll say the Institute will answer all their questions. Though I don't believe either Lucius or Noctornus will dare ask this many. I don't know what state Noctornus is in. Whether he's heard about his mother or not, I don't know. Either way, I suspect he may not be in very good shape. As for Lucius, he already thinks he knows the answers to everything. I doubt he'll ask much.

Lucida is still staying at her own place. Until we find a place together, we're keeping the same arrangements. So I need to find one soon. After the wedding, things were better between Tobias and me. He told me he was glad about our recent talks. Who knows what kind of fawning Lunar is did. Who knows what he gave up. Once again I'm paying the price for what he did.

I haven't been on good terms with anyone for a long time anyway. I'm practically living just to pass the time. I don't have much hope for after I come back here, either. Lucida ties me to life. And I don't want to let my family down. But still, the future feels eerie to me.

Bahal,

September 25, 2025

21:22

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The rest is not in this copy.

Complete the forty-nine chapters and go to the Newsstand.